

Sea Of Dreams

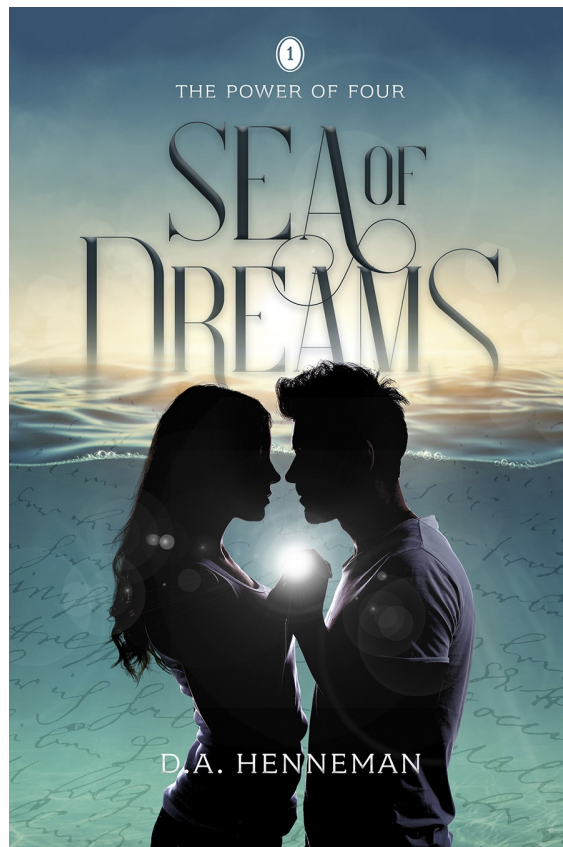
The Power Of Four Series

D.A. Henneman



Saray Books LLC

Blurb



In a land that parallels ours, a great evil lies in wait. To defeat it, Brooke must face her worst nightmare.

Just when Brooke Fisher thought she had a handle on her anxiety, strange things start to happen. In addition to her hair turning green, she has had nothing but cold showers and iced coffee for weeks. When the man starring in her nightmares walks into her reality, she struggles to make sense of her undeniable attraction to him.

The beautiful woman Will Engel has met is complicated in a way that speaks to him. As he helps her unravel the clues in a mysterious journal, he finds that their pasts are intertwined in a way that defies all logic. As an illusionist, he struggles to make sense of the magick that surrounds him.

The threat of the Shadowman from Brooke's dreams grows stronger, and their journey takes them to a magical land that parallels their own. What they find confirms Brooke's destiny as the element of Water, and cements Will's role in a land he never knew existed. The fate of both worlds is now tied to their choices, but the universe has plans of its own.



Tropes: Soulmates, Destined, Found Family, Vacation

Spice Rating: 3 Peppers (out of 5)

Genre/Elements: Fantasy Romance, Paranormal Elements, Elements, Magick, Diver, Illusionist

Setting: Maui

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Dedication

To my Husband Kurt, who is by far the most patient man on the planet. You have seen me at my best and absolute worst, and in every storm I've had to weather, you've been there to anchor me. You will never know just how much that means to me, you are truly my rock and I love you.

Prologue



The dusk was alive with the soft rustle and chirps of faceless creatures heralding the night. Brooke moved toward the banister, shivering against the damp chill that seeped through the gauze-like material of her gown. She barely registered the tickle of bright green fabric across the tops of her bare feet as she stepped forward on the balcony.

He was in the yard below watching her, and it pulled on her awareness. Her eyes searched the darkness to find him. She knew he was there, knew he had come for her, and her heart fluttered nervously in anticipation of seeing him again.

He was difficult to see, even after her eyes adjusted to the dark. His black silhouette was framed by the ghostly rows of pale, white birch trees that grew along her property's edge. He wore thick shadows like a shroud, and only when he took a step forward, was she able to distinguish his features.

The man lifted his face. As the gaze from his glowing eyes met hers, she felt as though she would drown in their crystalline depths. Brooke's heart raced as he lifted his hand toward her, beckoning, and she raised her arm in response.

The man stood motionless for a moment. Then, without a sound, he curled his fingers toward the center of his hand and released a spark of dark blue fire.

At first, there was shock. It wasn't the man she expected, the one that had captured her heart. Panic pushed the breath from her lungs. Her chest tightened as though gripped in a vise. She stood above him, paralyzed, and powerless to look anywhere but the hollow, dead eyes of her destiny. She allowed the inevitable. There was no other choice.

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Chapter One



B rooke awoke with a gasp, her heart fluttered against her ribs as she gulped in breaths to fill her screaming lungs. Her eyes darted around the room as she allowed her mind to catch up and recognize her surroundings. It was okay. She was safe at home.

Keyed up from the reoccurring dream, she flopped back down and counted her breaths, slowing her pulse like her therapist had taught her. She repeated the mantra, learned when the horror of her parents' death tore through her young mind. Sleep didn't always offer an escape. Years ago, she had learned it sometimes brought something worse. She had spent well over two decades running from it – from him.

She chanted softly, willing the words with each deep breath to cover her in a blanket of tranquility. *I find peace, love, and happiness in myself and those around me. I find peace, love, and happiness in myself and those around me.*

The sound of her cell phone playing *California Girls* by The Beach Boys jolted her. She blindly felt around the covers for it, smiling softly at her choice in ringtones. Her brother, James, never understood her fascination with the American rock band from the '60s, especially since they grew up in Britain in

the '90s. She enjoyed pointing out he had no right to talk since he knew the words to every song by the *Steve Miller Band*. His tone-deaf rendition of *Abracadabra* was the worst.

The boys started singing about the Midwest farmer's daughters when she found the phone under the pillow next to her. She slid her hand beneath, trying her hardest not to disturb the pile of fluff that rested on top. With great skill, she simultaneously nabbed her phone and hit snooze.

Misty looked up with sleep-filled eyes and cried out before plopping her head back down.

"So sorry to disturb you, love." Brooke murmured softly as she scratched behind the cat's ears. She felt the tension from the dream slip away with Misty's vibrating purr. Just a few minutes more and she could get ready for the day.

Brooke had used her dreams when she was younger as an escape from her fears and was kept safe under the watchful eyes of the motherly figure her mind had conjured. Although there was an ominous presence in those dreams as well, it never approached her when the woman was around.

The dreams became a way to avoid life in general as she got older. The woman's presence faded, and a young man filled Brooke's adolescence with adventure. He was full of life and mischief and could get Brooke to try things she would never have done otherwise.

The nightmares came later, at a time when she was vulnerable, and the young man no longer shared her dreams. Evil sliced into her safe place like a knife and affected her reality. The gaping hole it left in her soul bled panic. Brooke realized her obsession had taken over her life when she started searching in every used bookstore for the journal that the dark presence in her dreams insisted she had.

As she lay relaxing, fingers absently rubbing Misty's soft fur, she saw them again in her mind...the eyes. They were brilliant blue, the color of the sea on a

cloudless day, and just as fathomless. In her dreams, they peered into her soul, unlocking her every weakness.

Blurred like a distant memory, the man's features faded like smoke. But his eyes were something she couldn't forget, even in the clarifying light of day. Their glowing image frightened, yet intrigued her, and as crazy as it seemed, she had always felt as if she were dreaming of two different men. But two different men with the same features? The same eyes? Through therapy, she found comfort in the understanding that dreams were a way for the mind to sort things out. She had stopped trying to rationalize them long ago.

Brooke forced herself into her morning routine. It was the best way for her to tamp down her stress. Still somewhat groggy from sleep, she stumbled up the hall, past the room with her diving equipment, and into the bathroom. The blinding florescent shocked her eyes as she leaned against the sink to pull her lonesome toothbrush from its stand. A quick glance in the mirror turned into a startled and longer second look. "Must be tired," she said, rubbing her eyes. "Why does my hair... Well, that's brilliant! Green again!"

Several long blinks didn't change a thing. Sure enough, her long blonde hair, which had just been brightened, included strands with a bright green tinge to them. Some were even what she would consider turquoise blue.

Staring at her reflection, she hoped she was still dreaming. Another blink... Nope, not dreaming. "Fat lot of good it did me to have Tara treat my hair out of a box," she muttered. "This is the worst it's ever been."

She shook her head, unable to stop the partial smile that crept across her face as she resigned herself to her fate. Was it odd she found humor in the fact that not only did she swim for a living, but now she looked the part? She groaned as she ran her fingers through her colored tresses. "Looks like seaweed. What a lovely way to start the day."

As she dithered over how to wear her hair in a way that would attract the least attention, the doorbell rang followed by four short knocks.

“Boy, you’re in for it,” she laughed to prevent herself from crying and ran to the door to let Tara in.

“Come on, Brooke, these bags are heavy,” Tara blurted out as Brooke swung open the door. She walked right past Brooke without a glance, putting the bags down in the kitchen with a dramatic huff, which was entirely out of character for her even-tempered friend.

Brooke followed Tara into the kitchen and stood quietly in the doorway as her friend unloaded the groceries. A pent-up fury was released that, in Brooke’s observation, must have been brewing for some time.

“He is unbelievable!” Tara slammed the cereal box down on the counter as she vented. “He says I’m smothering him, and he needs time to think. I haven’t seen him in three weeks! How can I possibly smother someone I never see! We don’t go out, never spend time together, and when he comes over, he’s gone within an hour! And the sex! Don’t even get me started on the... Oh Lord, Brooke...what the hell happened to your hair?”

Arms crossed as she leaned on the doorjamb, she responded with a smirk. “I wondered if you were going to notice. I think you and a box of color is what happened to my hair.”

Brooke watched with a sinking heart as Tara closed her eyes and leaned her head back. She realized her attempt to make light of the situation hadn’t worked when Tara looked up at the ceiling, blinked her eyes as though there was an eyelash in one, and then totally lost it. Glistening tears turned into soft crying, and after another look at her hair, morphed into uncontrollable sobs. When Tara flopped down on the kitchen floor, leaning her back against the cupboard doors, Brooke moved quickly to sit by her side.

“Come on, Tara, it really isn’t bad. I kind of like it,” Brooke joked. “I have the rock star thing going on, and you know how I love everything ’80s.” Tara stopped sobbing long enough to take another look at Brooke’s hair and proceeded to cry even harder. “Well, I know you aren’t that upset about my hair, so it has to be Greg. What has he botched up now?”

Tara took a deep, shuttering breath, pausing slightly before she found her voice. “I think it’s over,” she said simply. “I’m not sure if I’m sad because I’ll miss him, or sad because I’ve spent the past year of my life with a man I won’t miss.” Brooke put her arm around her friend, rubbing the top of Tara’s back, and the sobs kept coming. “Honestly, love, he was a bit of a wanker,” Brooke said softly. “I never really liked Greg anyway.”

Tara’s slender shoulders shook, slightly at first then with a steadier rhythm, and Brooke knew her friend was laughing before she heard it. Tara looked up, smiling through her tears, “You know, you’re right, and I don’t think I ever did either.” Brooke watched as Tara tipped her head, a crinkle between her eyebrows, as she questioned her with a grin, “A wanker is a bad thing, right?” They took one look at each other and burst out into simultaneous, tear-soaked laughter. When the giggles faded, they paused for a few minutes in contented silence.

Tara took a deep breath, picked herself up off the floor, and pulled Brooke up by the hands. “Now, what are we going to do with that hair Miss Lauper?”

Brooke laughed merrily as she ran back to the bathroom, yelling over her shoulder, “Oh no, you’re not touching it again!”

While she didn’t normally shower before going to work at the pool, Brooke wanted to see if she could get some of the green to wash out or at the very least to fade a bit. As she scrubbed, Brooke prayed the clarifying shampoo would work a minor miracle. Being a part-time swim instructor was hell on her hair. It was too bad Mr. McGregor couldn’t hire her full-time at the bookstore.

Brooke got out of the shower and wrapped her head in a towel before putting in her contacts. Since her eyesight was perfect, she didn't need them to see well but used them more to avoid the stares. The contacts changed the natural color of her eyes, one emerald green and the other sky blue, to a beautiful turquoise for both. Tara was the only one who had ever seen Brooke without contacts, and she never commented on the two-tone oddity that topped Brooke's list of insecurities. It was one of many reasons they became such fast friends.

Brooke joined Tara in the kitchen, who seemed more at ease after her vent session. She was putting away the last of the groceries and talking to the cat. Misty was feigning disinterest in what was brought but clearly curious to see what was happening. Brooke couldn't help but laugh at her antics as Tara caught her out of the corner of her eye, wriggling her way into one of the paper bags and noisily turning herself around to peek out like a lion in a cave.

"You better get your fluffy butt off your mom's English muffins, or there'll be the devil to pay," Tara berated the cat with a laugh over her shoulder as she put the milk in the fridge.

Misty proceeded to do what any other cat would do under the circumstances. She stayed exactly where she was, shifting slightly to adjust her comfort level, and prepared to stay for the long haul.

Tara shook her head, her mouth wide with disbelief and mirth. "Can you believe her?" Brooke grinned as her friend turned to address Misty. "I see how it is! Well, I'll show you, stinker. I have a secret weapon!"

Grabbing a can of tuna out of the cupboard, she pushed down on the electric opener. That was all Misty needed to decide she had enough of the bag, and she was wasting away to nothing from her intense and uncontrollable hunger.

"You're nothing, if not predictable," Tara chuckled as she spooned the treat into Misty's bowl and scooped up the last of the groceries.

Tara had cooked breakfast while Brooke was in the shower, evidenced by the food she carried out to the table. She didn't have the heart to remind Tara that she hardly ate first thing in the morning. Brooke decided to force something down since Tara had gone through the trouble.

Lifting an English muffin and opening it on the small plate in front of her, Brooke's first thought was that it was slightly overdone. She glanced up at Tara, whose wide smile dimpled her face. That was all Brooke needed to see to finish creating her sandwich with a rubbery egg and a cold cheese slice.

"Tara, why don't you just move in here with me for the time being, until Greg moves out, and you can get yourself settled? I have plenty of space, and you'd only have to share your room with Misty." Brooke crunched into her sandwich before adding, "Oh, and a bit of my diving equipment."

She scrunched her face at the thought of having to straighten the room quicker than she intended, or perhaps because the inedible breakfast sandwich was chipping her teeth.

"I wouldn't want to impose and..."

"It is not imposing. I'd love it if you were here!" Brooke reached over and squeezed Tara's hand, glad to have an excuse to put down her sandwich. "You're always a big help to me, and I'd adore the company. Besides, you're practically living here anyway since you've been doing my shopping."

"I don't mind. It keeps me busy while I'm looking for a job," Tara said with a smile. "Besides, if I didn't shop for you, you'd never have any groceries!"

"Just so," Brooke agreed with a nod. "Please think about it. I'd really like to help you out."

Tara seemed to mull it over as she nibbled on her muffin, answering after a few seconds with a big smile. "Ok, I'll stay for a few weeks under one condition. You let me cook for you a couple of times a week!"

Brooke agreed, knowing full well she would do whatever it took to deter her from cooking. As great as Tara was at everything else, she was a horrible cook!

“I’m going to run home and pack a bag. I can meet you here later tonight.”

“Sounds perfect.” Brooke put her plate in the sink and gave Misty a scratch behind the ears. “Spare key is under the mat, so you can let yourself in. I should be home around eight or so.” Brooke walked back toward the living room, removing the towel from her head and shaking her hair loose.

“I see the green and blue didn’t come out,” Tara said as she wrinkled her nose. “I feel horrible about messing up your hair.”

“No worries. It’ll grow on me,” Brooke joked as she put on her jacket. “There are all kinds of people that pay top dollar for this kind of look. Besides, I’m in the water half the time anyway. I bet no one will even notice.”



Chapter Two



Wisp of smoke filled the stage. It pooled on the floor as the orchestra set the mood by playing deep, haunting strains of music to die by. The lights were hazy, creating shadows in the corners of the room. It supported the illusion the walls didn't exist, and the space was somehow connected to infinite darkness. The whispers of light and dark crept over the frozen faces of mystical creatures carved into the pillars edging the stage, giving them life and movement.

The audience collectively held its breath, as it had off and on for nearly two hours. They were nervous and edgy in their dark surroundings. Compelled to concentrate on a single point of light in the room, the contagious energy quickly gave way to excitement as the man in black walked back on stage.

His lean build was visible through the fit of his tee shirt, and while he was not heavily muscled, there was no denying his strength. He moved across the stage with a glide in his step, almost as though he were performing on ice. The speed and grace in which he moved was magical, like the illusions he performed.

"And now for my last trick, ladies and gentlemen, I will cut my lovely assistant, Trina, in half!" Will Engel crossed over to center stage, announcing his

intentions with a dramatic wave of his arm and a brilliant smile. “After which, we will put her back together...if everything goes as planned,” he finished with a wink.

Trina was already getting into position in the coffin-like box on stage, moving quickly for someone in four-inch heels and a sequined bathing suit.

Once his assistant was in place and the lid was secure, he lowered the gleaming saw from the ceiling and lined it up with the top of the container, banging on the large round blade with a hammer for dramatic effect. He touched his finger to the blade, quickly pulling it back as though he had nicked himself.

“I should probably mention this is the first time we’ve done this trick,” he muttered softly, yet his voice was heard easily enough by the transfixed crowd.

He took the feather boa Trina dropped by the side of the box and rubbed it along the blade’s edge, demonstrating in one swipe what the sharpened steel could do.

With a wave of his hand, he let the severed boa flutter to the floor.

The audience stared with greedy anticipation as he fired up the saw. The jagged disk spun faster until the edge was all but a blur. As the blade reached the top of the box, splinters flew forward, pulling screams from some young ladies in the front row as they were surprised with small chunks of wood.

Will guided the blade lower still, until it paused, seemingly stuck on the body of the assistant inside. Her screams went from terror to agony.

The shocked audience was mesmerized as he pushed hard on the spinning blade with such force that Trina’s head and feet rose simultaneously. Her screams stopped abruptly as the blade went straight through the center of the box.

Blood sprayed out from the crack, horrifying the ladies in the front row. They stared, wide-eyed, hands covering their mouths and muffling their shrieks.

Trina was silent, blood dripping from her mouth and eyes open in a vacant stare.

With a tearing wrench, Will split the box open, pushed the parts of the box apart

at the cut, and sent them to opposite sides of the stage. Trina's soft hair flapped quietly as the box half with her head in it rolled to the left wing.

Collectively holding their breath, the crowd watched as stagehands brought the box pieces back to the center of the stage. They pushed them together while Will shook open a red piece of silk the size of a large tablecloth. Handing the fabric to one of the stagehands, he slid on top of the reconstructed box and crossed his arms over his chest. With a nod of his head, Will directed his helper to cover him completely, draping the fabric around his prone body and down the sides of the box.

Will lie still for a moment, his trim, muscular frame shrouded by the soft fabric, then slowly moved beneath the silk as though he were propping himself up on his side. Within seconds, the fabric was torn away by one of the stagehands, revealing the beautiful Trina, in her shiny silver bathing suit, posing on her side in Will's place.

The crowd began to clap as she was helped down. With a swipe of her hand, she released the sides of the box which revealed the magician who had taken her place inside.

Will climbed from the cramped space, and the audience went wild, the roar of the applause deafening as he straightened then took his bow. He winked and waved with a two-fingered salute to the ladies in the front row before turning to Trina. He gestured his arm toward her, indicating to the crowd that they should clap for her as well. As the curtain came down, he gave one last wink to the front-row ladies for good measure. It never hurt to flirt with the audience.

Trina kicked off her heels and put her fingers through the straps to carry them toward the dressing rooms. As she rubbed her back with her other hand, it was apparent to Will that she was tired and probably needed the upcoming break too.

"It's a good thing this was our last show. I'm not sure how much longer I'm going to be able to fit in that box with a baby coming!"

“Not to mention your outfit won’t look so hot with a big old belly,” Will laughed as she gave him a good-natured swat on the arm.

“I’ll look awesome in this outfit with my belly out to here!” She gestured a foot past her slightly rounded waist with a grin.

“You certainly will, gorgeous! You’re going to be the hottest mother-to-be on the Vegas Strip,” Will bantered with a lift of his eyebrows and a dimpled grin.

She laughed, calling his bluff. “You’re always full of shit! And don’t you dare give me that same look you just gave those chicks in the front row, ‘cause it won’t work on me! You’re such a horrible flirt!”

He laughed heartily. She always knew how to put him in his place. “I was taking one for the team, you know. A bit of audience interaction helps with ticket sales.”

“Oh, is that what you’re calling it now? Audience interaction? Looks like a bit of fishing for company, if you ask me.”

“Trina, we’ve known each other way too long! With you around, I can’t get away with anything, which is exactly why I stopped fishing long ago. But that doesn’t mean I can’t look at the aquarium.”

She smiled and gave him a large wet smack, leaving a smear of her fire engine red lipstick on his stubbled cheek. He groaned as he used his sleeve to wipe the greasy makeup from his face. She nabbed her robe from a nearby peg before they went upstairs to change.

Will followed Trina up to the tiny dressing room which adjoined his. The place wasn’t so bad, but he wanted to get to the point where he wasn’t living week-to-week and having to convince the larger venues to take on his show. Hell, he wouldn’t mind being able to convince his parents either. They didn’t agree with his choice of careers any more than some of the casinos did.

Now that he was creeping up on thirty and a successful career in magic was less obtainable in their eyes, his parents had started pressuring him again to take over

the family business. He knew his dad wanted to ease into retirement, and they would be happier with him earning a more responsible income. But Will didn't believe he was built for corporate life.

He realized how it looked to them, especially in the early years when he had lived entirely off the trust fund his grandfather left him. His grandfather, Henry, believed with hard work and dedication anything was possible which was what inspired him to work his way through law school and start his firm all those years ago. He also believed that Will, his only grandson, was going to follow in his footsteps. In a way he had, just not the way his grandfather had envisioned.

Grandpa Henry inspired him to follow his own dreams, and he honored his memory by dedicating himself completely to his craft and becoming the best illusionist he could. He had stopped tapping into the trust fund years ago, living simply from the income he earned with his magic shows. Because he paid his own way, he hoped his parents would have one less thing to hang over his head.

It was easy for him to live on the frugal side – he caught his meals at the casinos or ate at Trina's – and with his schedule, there never was enough time to go out anyway. Rent was typically covered by the venue where he was performing, and his belongings were limited to what he could fit in a set of luggage. It was just one more reason in a long list not to get involved with anyone. He couldn't grow a set of roots even if he were a tree.

As much as Will didn't want to take a sabbatical, he didn't really have much of a choice, since soon Trina would look like she swallowed a basketball. Besides, he was tired, and a vacation was looking pretty good.

Trina assured him she would be ready to get back to work by the end of the year which gave Will a little less than eight months to decide on his future. His parents wanted him to buckle down and earn a serious living. Will felt if he committed to researching and developing new material for the show he could break into the mainstream. While his parents held firm to the belief that he was

too old to be wasting time chasing dreams of becoming the next hot act, he knew the only difference between him and anyone who was a success was that he hadn't been seen by the right people - or at least not yet.

To keep the family peace and to ensure that he had somewhere to stay during his vacation, Will made an arrangement with his folks that they would get their answer after his break. That seemed to appease them enough to agree to give him access to their time-share.

Will snatched his worn leather coat from the back of his dressing room door and slid it on.

"Hey, have you seen my keys?" He scanned the room, half-heartedly lifting a few things out of the way.

Trina was sitting at the vanity in her room, removing the stage make-up from her face. She answered him through the open door that adjoined their rooms.

"Sorry, no. Did you check the jeans you had on earlier? Tony always does that - totally drives me crazy on laundry day!"

He swept up the jeans laying on the floor of his dressing room and patted them down, finding a stick of gum, fifty cents, and a book of matches, but still no keys.

"Simply amazing," he muttered to himself, "I can make shit disappear like nobody's business, but when I need to find something, it's a different story!"

Trina giggled, "That's because you're such a slob!"

"Who asked you anyway? And I'm not a slob, I'm domestically challenged!"

Trina chuckled, "Yeah, you and Tony both. Seems to be an epidemic for people with a Y chromosome. So, where did you end up deciding to go on your vacation? Somewhere with sandy beaches and teeny bikinis?"

Will smiled at the thought. "Not a hundred percent sure yet. Really just thinking about getting away and doing some research. Need to add some new tricks to the

show. I'm not planning on it being much of what you would consider a vacation."

"Well, if it were me, I would go somewhere tropical with blue ocean as far as the eye could see. You can do research pretty much anywhere! And I'm not planning on my time off being much of a vacation either," Trina said with a laugh.

"Yeah, better you than me," he responded with a smirk as he continued to rummage for his keys. "My folks have a time-share in Florida, so I'll probably end up there. Might give me the opportunity to go out to the streets and see if some of the newer stuff will work up close and personal. I need to go home also. You know – to touch base."

"That sounds great. Your parents would love to see you! You'll have to let them know I send my love."

He tried not to let the hesitation he felt sound in his voice. "I do every time I talk to them." He knew his mom would be excited to see him, but he wasn't quite sure he would leave without a lecture from his dad. Trina adored his parents, and at one time, they had high hopes for her becoming more than a work partner to him. It turned out to be another disappointment in a long line of disappointments for them.

"Aha!" he exclaimed as he found his keys under a towel on his changing table. He lifted his duffel bag, tossed the balance of his belongings in it, and walked through the door into Trina's dressing room. He leaned over to give her a quick kiss on the cheek she had just wiped clean and wished her luck.

"Be sure to call if you need anything and text to let me know how you're doing." Trina looked up with a smile, "I'll keep you posted. And Will, try to relax while you're off. It is supposed to be a vacation, you know... Time to chill."

"Yeah, yeah, I get it. I'll see what I can do," he answered with a wink, smile, and his two-fingered salute, leaving Trina grinning and shaking her head.

He stepped into the hallway, smiling and interacting with the stagehands on his way to the backstage door. They were breaking the set down, preparing for the next show, and he wondered if he would see them again. He hoped he would. They were a great group of people, but he had a decision to make, one that could very well change the course of his life. He knew his father, so the stage might be the last place he'd end up when all was said and done.

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Chapter Three



The Witch's Brew was by far Brooke's favorite local coffee shop. After her morning swim classes, she popped in on her way to the book shop. Her latest potion of choice was the pumpkin spice java, topped with a vanilla whip and served with a gingersnap cookie. She had visions of the concoction dancing through her head all morning and instantly relaxed when she walked in the door, and the smell of fresh brewed coffee hit her full force.

She loved the Brew, with its year 'round Halloween décor. She supposed it was because it reminded her of a cool, crisp autumn, which she didn't get to see much now that she lived in Florida. Even though the area was a great place for someone who liked to scuba dive, she missed the fall.

The Brew also happened to be the only place that served a real English style tea, which brought back fond memories of Devonshire. She didn't get back home often enough. When she missed her brother, she would pop into the small coffee house, order an entire pot of tea, and ensconce herself in the corner to video chat with him.

Although Brooke was raised in England, her voice didn't generally hint at her heritage. Since moving to America, her crisp, cultured tones had been quickly

replaced with a lazier and less formal American dialect. Hints of her accent came back after talking to James or having a few cocktails. It was also prominent when she was really worked up – she couldn't help it.

She had about an hour before starting her shift at the bookstore, which wasn't far from the Witch's Brew and located just a stone's throw from her flat. There was just enough time to do a bit of research.

Brooke parked herself at a corner booth and fired up her laptop. There were dive destinations she was researching, and she was anxious to narrow her choice down. She had finally saved enough to book her trip.

Absently, she stirred the coffee she had been cooling. The first sip caused her to scrunch her brow since it wasn't what she expected at all.

"Damn this coffee is cold as ice," she muttered to herself. "Really unlike this place."

She walked back to the counter and asked the barista for a new cup, thinking perhaps the burner had been shut off, and the coffee allowed to cool. The woman apologized for the inconvenience, handed Brooke a new steaming cup, and tossed in a streusel pumpkin muffin at no charge. Brooke thanked her with a smile and walked back to her table, looking forward to munching on the muffin as she researched her trip.

Paying more attention to what was on her laptop than the drink she held in her hand, she absently blew on the liquid to cool it before attempting a swallow. She took a sip and almost spit it out on her laptop. Cold! Ice Cold! She was confused. She knew for a fact she had seen the barista pour steaming coffee into the cup right out of the pot. Yet here she was, with a drink that might as well be frozen.

Baffled, she stood and shook her head. "When life gives you lemons," she said under her breath as she wandered up to the counter to ask for a cup of ice. There was no way she was asking for another cup of hot coffee at this point. She paid

no attention to the strange look on the barista's face, merely thanked her and pulled a straw and lid from the basket on the self-serve counter.

Back at the table, she poured her coffee over the ice, put on the lid, and popped in the straw. Picking up where she left off on the travel site for Hawaii, she gave a swish to the drink in her cup.

Out of the corner of her eye, she noticed it was getting darker. A glance outside told her a storm was coming, confirmed by the black clouds rolling in off the coast. They looked like laundry tumbling in a dryer. She was glad she remembered her umbrella, although she didn't have far to go. While mulling over the best dive sites in Maui, she took her first sip of drink number three.

The warmth of the coffee that came through the straw shocked her tongue, a tongue that proceeded to blat out a very colorful expression as she lowered the cup to the table. The barista glanced over at Brooke. Confusion wrinkled her brows as she wiped the counter and shook her head. Brooke was stunned as she watched the steam rise through the straw like a tiny chimney.

She was aware of the fear and irritation creeping into her mind, increasing her pulse. The other mishaps from the week bled into that moment, affecting her mood. Her hair was tolerable, she accepted that, and she could even accept her new leather jacket being dowsed last week by the sprinkler system in the hallway outside her flat. Accidents happened. But cold showers for the last couple of days, and now coffee that changed from hot to cold for no reason?

Much as she tried to make light of the situation in her mind, she couldn't. She wanted to believe they were all coincidences, but she didn't.

Inevitably, her overactive imagination started making connections between what was happening and the dreams she'd been having. Her worries splintered her mind, fracturing the thin wall she had built years ago to separate dreams from reality. What if the frequent nightmares and the strange things happening to her were related? What if they were real?

The fear that she would once again become obsessed took root. Panic threatened to overwhelm her, and her heart fluttered in her chest like a bird in a cage. She decided immediately and without question that she had to leave. It wasn't a thought as much as it was an overwhelming urge. While she packed her laptop, her managed irritation quickly changed to uncontrolled edginess when she felt the temperature in the room drop. A thick blanket of menace covered the typically quaint atmosphere.

Her hands shook, and a chill crept up her spine as she picked up the coffee, which only moments before had been steaming, and watched in confusion and fear as it froze solid. Tears brimmed in her eyes as she looked around the room, her mind frantically trying to make sense of what was happening. In a split second, she processed that she was the only person seeing what she was seeing. Quickly gathering her things, she moved toward the door. She was on the verge of a major panic attack or delusional meltdown; they were the only explanations that made sense.

As she walked out, every patron she hurried past was in their own world, chatting to friends, texting on phones, and surfing the web. None of them gave the impression they heard or felt anything strange.

It must be me. These sleepless nights are taking their toll. That must be it. Or is it caffeine deprivation? Lord, maybe I do need to make an appointment with Dr. Matthews.

She stepped onto Main Street, pushed the button of her umbrella, and opened it with a whoosh against the darkened skies. With each step, she repeated her mantra, taking deep cleansing breaths as she willed the words to slow her racing heart.

Even though the weather was less than stellar, overcast and drizzly in the sunshine state, she didn't mind the short walk to her second job, especially since she knew the fresh air would help calm her nerves. By the time she rounded the

corner, she was well on her way to rationalizing the strange things that were happening to her.

She had always had a wild imagination, anyone who read as incessantly as she did would. And she knew sleep deprivation took its toll on people in all sorts of bizarre ways. She made a conscious decision to treat what was happening to her like a puzzle she needed to work through – logically and methodically. That decision calmed her more effectively than any drug could. She had found it was control, or at the very least having a plan, that allowed her to squelch her panic when it reared its ugly head.

The wind picked up, pulling and tugging at the edges of the umbrella during her brief walk. Everything was secured in her backpack, so she was able to hang on to it with both hands, keeping herself tucked up under and away from the increasingly steady drizzle.

She was feeling more herself the further away she got from the coffee shop and the closer she got to her destination. To keep her mind occupied, she ran through a mental list of things she needed to get done before the day was through.

The temperature dropped again noticeably. A major storm was brewing, and she pulled up the collar on her fleece jacket to keep the wind from blowing down her neck. The streets were void of people, all of whom had likely gone inside to weather the storm. Storms were common this time of year, typically blowing in and out within a thirty-minute window. But this one felt more ominous.

As she walked, a tingling started on the back of her neck that graduated to a creeping, spider-like sensation, moving its way down her spine. *Not again*, she thought to herself, as she prepared for the next wave of panic and dread to fill her body.

Even with her earlier thoughts of control, she couldn't shake the feeling she had. It reverberated in her back, crept around her sides, and tangled in her stomach in a quivering mass of nerves. Brooke described it to her therapist once as the "wet

blanket,” a suffocating feeling of dread that triggered a full-blown panic attack. In addition to this phenomenon, she had the unmistakable feeling of being watched. But when she looked up the street and down the alleyways, there was no one to be seen.

She breathed through it, once again telling herself it was all in her mind. Picking up the pace, her hurried footsteps sounded on the pavement like the steady beat of a drum. She made it to the Book Nook, just in time for the clouds to let loose, and shut the door firmly behind her, taking a moment to breathe deeply. Brooke knew she needed to get a handle on her nerves. The dream the night before must have affected her more than she realized.



The tall dark figure had been following the beautiful woman with the green hair and bewitching eyes. He had been close enough to touch her, close enough to smell the perfume on her skin, to see the soft curve of her neck, and it pleased him. He had made much progress and was gaining more control each day. Soon, he would be able to take back what belonged to him, take back the item that would find its way to her. Her ignorance would be her undoing.

He watched her with greedy eyes from his vantage point. She ducked into a shop and spoke to a young lady inside. He could see the power that surrounded her, a bright blue and green aura, and sensed he did not have much time before she understood the changes she was undergoing.

She was much more perceptive than he had counted on and had missed seeing his presence by mere seconds as he followed her from the café. While he had been quick, hiding in the alleyways or fading into the shadows, he wasn't quick enough. She seemed to know he was there and that she was being followed.

The thought excited him, this game of cat and mouse as it were. But at the same time, he was fearful. She was already showing signs of her abilities, which might

prove to be more of a challenge than he anticipated.

With her growing powers and his talisman nearby, he knew he was running out of time. The journal had not yet made its way to her, but it would happen soon. He felt the book's waves of energy calling like a siren's song, and he ached to answer it himself.

As much as it pained him, he refrained from reaching toward the power the book expelled - afraid that if he grasped it, it might disappear again. He was especially fearful of reaching for it in his current fractured state. He knew she was his key to getting it back, to making himself whole. His patience would soon be rewarded.

As he watched her through the window of the store, he considered for a moment what he might do with her once the book was in his possession and the way was unbound. She had the potential to be an immensely powerful sorceress, and there could be many benefits to converting her. He allowed himself to consider all the possibilities, smiling as he made his plans to capture her... and the journal.



Brooke tucked her backpack into the employee area and looked longingly at the half-full coffee pot that was there. The coffee debacle at the Brew was still fresh in her mind, and after careful consideration, she decided it wasn't worth the attempt. Normally, she loved the fact that The Book Nook was a small, family-owned store. Alfred McGregor, the store's owner, was rarely in, which normally suited her fine, but tonight had her frazzled. She wasn't looking forward to the closing shift alone.

She threw some change into the vending machine instead, pushing for a diet soda and hoping it would at least be cold. She knew the boss didn't like drinks out by the books, but she was thirsty and really needed some caffeine - her

nerves were shot. After a quick reasoning session with herself, she went out to the front counter, greeting Nita who was finishing up her shift.

After commenting that she liked Brooke's hair, Nita looked at her with concern.

"Are you alright? You look a bit pale."

Brooke shook her head and put on a smile. "I'm fine, Nita, thanks. Just edgy today. Didn't sleep well last night. So, what's pending?"

Nita accepted Brooke's explanation and filled her in on the orders she had taken, which didn't take long as they hadn't been terribly busy. Brooke explained why her hair was a bit on the funky side, and they both had a good laugh.

"I actually like it. I think it's adorable the kids thought you would sprout a mermaid tail."

"Wouldn't that be a sight," Brooke chuckled as Nita pulled her purse out from under the counter.

"I'd better go. Looks like it's getting really nasty out there."

"It is, so be careful driving home. Maybe give me a double-ring when you get in, just so I know you're okay?"

"Sure will. Two rings then hang-up like usual," Nita agreed. She waved at Brooke while simultaneously pushing her way out the front door and opening her bright yellow umbrella against the storm. It looked like a small bit of sunshine against the darkened skies. Since she was still edgy from her earlier walk to work, Brooke stood in the front window and kept an eye on her co-worker until she made it to her car and drove off.

The building was old, weathered like most buildings in coastal towns. The creaks and groans always left her a bit on the uneasy side. The storefront was quiet, and Brooke reached under the counter to turn on the radio as she often did when alone. The oldies station played songs that reminded her of her parents and soothed her. Then she started on the stack of new arrivals Nita had been working on when she first arrived.

Most of the books she needed to price were on the Top Ten Bestsellers list. She flipped a few of them over, quickly skimming the back to see if they were something she'd be interested in reading. The latest novel by a hot new author caught her eye, and she set it aside to take home.

The books on the bottom of the stack were older, which wasn't surprising, since the store specialized in hard-to-find, unique, and used books. Interested in seeing what Alfred found this time, she slid the paperbacks from the top to get a better look. She was so absorbed in peeking through the stack, she hadn't noticed the bell on the door go off until the person who had come through it was standing right in front of her.

A dark shadow crept over the counter toward her, which startled her completely, her arm arching of its own accord from her cringing shoulders. With a small scream and bounce, she knocked the books from the pile she had been working on and watched helplessly as they sprayed outward, scattering haphazardly across the lobby floor.

The dripping figure turned, the hollow clunk of his leather shoes vibrating from the old wooden floor as he took two steps into the lobby and hunched over the books that had fallen.

Completely embarrassed for letting her earlier imaginings get the best of her, Brooke came around the service desk and addressed the stranger before he felt obligated to pick up the mess for her.

She apologized without looking at him, her words sounding more like nervous rambling. The man straightened and turned toward her, the shadows falling from his face. As she lifted her head to thank him, their eyes connected, and in a single heartbeat, the queasy feeling she had shaken earlier returned to the pit of her stomach. *It can't be. He can't be real!*

Her hands shook, and her breathing quickened to match her already racing heart. His eyes...the eyes she had seen in her dreams practically her entire life were

staring back at her with an intensity that looked right into her soul – and it crippled her.

Fear clawed at her mind, threatening to tear it to shreds as she stared back into his clear, compelling gaze. Paralyzed, her mind raced to fit all the pieces of the mystery together.

Her terror was all-consuming as though someone pushed a pillow down over her face but still expected her to breathe. She tried to catch her breath, to fill her lungs and slow her heart rate, but she couldn't calm herself down. The panic was suffocating her.

Her mind instantly made connections that were impossible, that defied all logic, and she was tired of trying to rationalize it away. The part of her that she had squelched all those years came forward – the part that believed in magic – the part that recognized the man standing before her. “It’s you,” she whispered.

She realized with dismay she was starting to lose consciousness, and through the glittering sparkles, she saw the stranger’s hands reach out. When he touched her, Brooke did something she had never done before, something her controlling personality would never allow. She blacked out.



Chapter Four



Will wasn't quite sure what had happened. One minute, he was walking in from the rain, and the next, he was holding a beautiful woman in his arms. Not that he would normally consider that all bad, but she was out like a light. Call him crazy, but generally, he liked them more lucid.

When he walked into the bookstore and saw her from the doorway, he felt something inside him click, like a light being turned on in the corner of a dark room. His feet propelled him forward, while his mind battled opposing feelings – wanting her to acknowledge him and needing to disappear.

But he startled her, like a doe in the woods, and caused her to knock a stack of books into the lobby. In an effort to help, he walked over to gather them and felt her radiating warmth as she came up alongside him.

She apologized, the melodic tone of her voice sweeping over him in waves. When he turned and their eyes met, one word came immediately to his mind. *Magic.*

In that split second, he felt as though she recognized him for who he was. Like two souls speaking without words. Awareness, like a blinding flash in his mind, urged him to find out who she was since nothing else could possibly matter

more. He knew it was impossible, but he felt as though he knew her. From what she whispered to him before blacking out, it was as though she knew him too.

Before he could spit anything out from the tangled mess of his thoughts, her eyes rolled up in her head, and her knees buckled, which took all of the romance out of introducing himself and sweeping her off her feet. Ok, well maybe a bad metaphor since she was already off her feet. Fortunately for him, Trina had fainted more than once during her first trimester, and he recognized the signs.

In a flash, he stepped forward to catch her as she slid into his arms. He couldn't help his immediate thought, that she felt all kinds of right. *Magic*, his mind whispered again. Her breathing was slow and deep as he gently lowered her to the floor. Removing his coat, he shook off the last of the rain and turned it inside out before wadding it behind her head like a pillow.

He checked her pulse, knowing before he did that it would be strong and steady. He hadn't let her drop, so knew she hadn't bumped or bruised anything, but it was always better to be on the safe side. She seemed to be fine, and he waited like he always had with Trina, seeing only to her comfort and letting her regain consciousness on her own.

He knelt on the floor beside her and gently wiped the hair from her face. Ok... so not just beautiful, but gorgeous, he thought as he took in her features.

She was average in height, he would guess five foot seven, with a very toned physique that looked like she worked out. Perhaps like him, she was a runner. Her hair was bright blonde and a bit on the funky side, with thick streaks of blue and green running through it randomly, similar to some of the hairstyles he had seen back home on the Strip. She had it pulled up in a clip, which looked uncomfortable, so he removed it. His breath paused as the thick, wavy mass pooled around her face and shoulders. The colorful tresses framed a delicate oval face that boasted high cheekbones, a slim nose, and the most important feature to his mind – the fullest set of naturally pink lips he had ever seen.

As she started to come to, the lines on her forehead crinkled between her eyes, and her lips pursed together as though she were trying to solve a riddle. He watched the expressions as they danced across her face, mesmerized by the soft moans that accompanied them. A pleasant scent of vanilla musk hit his nose, and when he felt a soft smile creep uncontrollably across his face, he realized he might be in trouble.

The woman's lashes fluttered and her eyes peeked open. He was careful to let her move on her own, not wanting to startle her again. As she turned her face toward him and glanced into his eyes, he got a feeling in the pit of his stomach like he had dropped twenty flights in an elevator. There was no denying the feeling of familiarity that warmed him, urging him to pull her into his arms and never let go. The only thing stopping him from doing that was the fact that they had never met.

He sat quietly as she adjusted to the light and focused on his face, gracing him with a nervous smile as she lifted her hand to her head. He felt his pulse quicken and a tingling along his spine very much like the feeling he got when he nailed an illusion for the first time. He had never been one to believe in fate, but whatever this was, he knew he was at the right place at the right time.

In that moment, Will knew this woman was special, important to him in a way only time would reveal. He realized deep in the recesses of his soul his life would never be the same. Strangely enough, for the first time in his life as a confirmed bachelor...he was okay with that.



Brooke liked this dream, vacationing on the sandy beaches, her own personal attendant to wipe the sand from her cheek as his gaze warmed her face like the sun. His eyes were beautiful and had the piercing blue intensity of the ocean.

Tufts of black hair rustled against his forehead, moved by a breeze she couldn't feel. Wait, not a breeze... Moved by her breath?

Oh my God. She wasn't dreaming! Her head spun, whirling as nausea gripped her. Holy shit, she was on the floor. How did she get there, and who was this man? Was he smiling at her?

While the deeply feminine side of her didn't mind the attention or the fact that her head was practically in his lap, she was horribly embarrassed that the only reason she seemed to be getting his attention was that she had collapsed in the middle of the store lobby. This meant, presumably, he was too much of a gentleman to let her crash in an unladylike heap to the floor. Lucky that.

As her eyes adjusted on his features, her heart started to race again when recognition triggered her fight or flight response.

Oh God, I know him. I've seen him before. Her heart raced as the memories came back to her in full force, and she looked at him warily, allowing her lifelong dreams to influence her demeanor.

The deep, rich tones of his voice were soothing, and it took a minute to register that he was asking if she was all right. She nodded, glancing away from his hypnotic gaze, and proceeded to pick herself up from the floor as gracefully as humanly possible, at least considering the circumstances.

He was beside her immediately, holding her elbow steady and helping her to her feet. His touch unnerved her, but she was grateful for the support since she was still feeling a bit light-headed. His voice came over her shoulder, warm and inviting like a cup of cocoa with extra marshmallows.

"Are you alright? You look a little pale."

He was a double threat: gorgeous and a voice to match. He made her nervous, and she tried not to shake as she answered. "I'm fine, really. Just a bit scattered."

"Maybe you should sit down or something. Is there someone I can call?"

“No really, I’m good.” She turned away from him, slipping her arm from his grasp and stumbling over the spilled books as she backed away.

She needed to pull herself together. The man of her dreams was literally standing in front of her, but she didn’t need to lose her mind. *It’s a coincidence*, the logical part of her brain chanted, but the rest of her body sang a different tune. She was definitely going to have to have a word with herself later about the horrible timing of her hormone-infused lady choir.

There was an odd tightness in the pit of her stomach, a familiar tingle and warmth she hadn’t felt in years. She fought the compulsion to circle her arms around his neck and lean her body into his since at the same time she feared he might harm her as he had in her dreams. How could he possibly be the man she dreamed of? She was beyond confused. Brooke stepped behind the counter, in part to give herself something to lean against, but also in the hopes it would provide a barrier between her and Mr. Blue Eyes.

She turned back toward the lobby just in time to see his well-formed body bend over to scoop up the books, his coat, and something small from the floor. It was then she realized he was grabbing her hair clip, and she self-consciously smoothed her hair, which she was positive was down in a wild mess around her face.

This is getting better and better, her inner self snarked, as she attempted to shake the jitters by taking a deep breath.

As she watched him from the counter, she knew she was right about there being something familiar about him, and considering the direction half her dreams took, she could even understand her racing heartbeat. It wasn’t that “Dreamguy” she was worried about, however, it was the other one – the one she had named “Shadowman” in her youth.

For years, the Shadowman had chased her through her dreams, a faceless being that drained her resistance, left her powerless, and forced her to face each

morning with a sense of foreboding. He was the one that had been showing up lately in her dreams. She definitely didn't want to meet that guy, and while she had always assumed she was dreaming about two different men, she wasn't altogether sure anymore. It was the eyes. In both types of dreams, while the men had personalities as different as oil and water, they had the same eyes.

The stranger sauntered up to the counter, smooth as silk, moving with the lithe grace of a dancer. His black, spiky hair damp from the rain that he had come in from, and a slight bit of scruff gave him a sexy yet edgy look. The classic angles of his features were softened by a brilliant smile and creased with a slight dimple to the right of his full lips. She noticed he practically dwarfed her, and taking this all in, she tried to calm the butterflies spiraling around tornado-style in her stomach.

She cringed internally as her voice squeaked out. "Thanks for your help, I don't know what came over me. It really was kind of you."

Brooke took the books he handed her, shuffling through busy work on the desk and avoiding eye contact with him. He was close enough to her that she could smell the gum he chewed, which barely covered the musky scent of his cologne. It wove a powerful web around her senses.

"Are you sure you're okay?" he asked as he handed her the hairclip. She looked up and caught the concern in his eyes – *his beautiful...crystal clear...bluer than blue eyes*. "Are you sure you don't want me to call an ambulance? A boyfriend?" Brooke felt her face flush. He made her shaky, but not in the same way she had first thought, especially since he was way too concerned about her well-being to be the scary, going-to-kill-you-in-your-sleep Shadowman from her dreams.

"Or maybe something to eat?" He continued, "Do you have low blood sugar?"

Brooke giggled nervously. "No really, I'm fine. You just startled me."

He looked at her disbelievingly.

“Honestly, I was going through the new arrivals and wasn’t expecting anyone to be out in this weather.”

He hesitated, and before he could ask another question about her well-being, she pushed aside the books topped with her clip and gave him her professional can-I-help-you smile. Time to change the subject.

“So, what brings you in today?”

He paused, giving her a quick once-over as if to determine if she was being honest about how she felt, then answered her question.

“Actually, I’m staying in the area for a bit and was checking out the town when the storm came in. I was just stepping in out of the rain.”

There was truth to what he was saying and honesty in his approach. Her gut told her he wasn’t there to harm her. The panic drained away, and she relaxed slightly.

“Well lucky for me you stopped by when you did. I really appreciate your help.” A grin split his handsome face, crinkling the corners of his eyes and warming the room by ten degrees. There was no denying the moment of déjà vu – he seemed so familiar to her. It was strange, but he reminded her so much of the boy her mind had created all those years ago, the boy who had shared her secrets and stolen her heart.

“Anytime. You know it may be a good idea for me to stick around a while...just to be sure you will be all right. You seem a little distracted.”

Brooke laughed out loud at that, not able to help herself. Lord if he only knew.

“Honestly, I’m good. I just have a lot on my mind, and it has been a strange day to say the very least. You can stay as long as you like. It doesn’t look like the rain is going to let up anytime soon.”

He had a really nice smile. He had a really nice everything. Was it a wonder she was having a hard time thinking straight? She couldn’t remember the last time her emotions were all over the place like this. Well, maybe she could. Brooke

puzzled over her recent dreams and wondered why her mind was trying to desperately make a connection to this man – a connection that scared and confused her, but at the same time felt right.

She decided she really needed to get out more often and again thought about seeing her therapist, especially considering everything that had happened recently.

“Ok, while I hang here a bit, what types of books might you have on magic or illusion?”

Ah finally, something she could do to keep her mind off all of her confused and chanting lady parts. With a deep breath, she answered.

“We have a pretty extensive selection. Magic happens to be one of the owner’s favorite subjects. Mine too, actually.” Still a bit dizzy from her faint, Brooke took a small sip from her diet soda before continuing. “We keep all those types of books upstairs. Come on, I’ll show you.”

Brooke started toward the stairs, motioning for him to follow. “We can also order special texts if you can’t find what you’re looking for.”

“Sounds great, lead away,” he said with a dramatic wave of his hand.

Self-consciously she led him up the stairs, fully aware that he was eye level with her rear for most of the trip. She couldn’t help but think he was looking at her ass and tried not to stiffen as she climbed the stairs. She made quick work of getting to the top and walked toward the center aisle where he joined her. The upper floor of the store wasn’t large, more a loft than anything else. It was filled from floor to ceiling with books in all shapes and sizes, lined up like tiny soldiers in narrow wooden cases.

“The Occult section starts here and ends the third row down on the right. We don’t have illusion separated from the other books on magic, so you will have to filter through them. Let me know if you need anything.”

She had to get back downstairs. He made her body tingle with feelings she thought were long dead. She moved past him toward the stairs, and the sound of his voice made her toes curl. The longer she was near him, the more he seemed to affect her.

“And what name should I call if I need anything?”

Brooke turned to look at him and couldn't help her slight blush or her soft smile. He was extremely handsome, and any other time, under any other circumstances, she would be flirting shamelessly with him.

“It's Brooke. Brooke Fisher,” she answered quietly.

“Nice to meet you, Brooke. Mine's Will. Will Engel.” She didn't realize she was standing there staring at him like an idiot until he said with a smile, “Just in case I can help you with something.”

What was it about him that caused her to lose her thoughts? *Pull it together, Brooke, Pretend he is just like any other guy.* The problem was he didn't make her feel like any other guy would, especially when he grinned after her bantered response.

“I will keep that in mind.”

Before her crazy thoughts got her into some real trouble, Brooke hurried down the stairs, leaving him to peruse the shelves at his leisure.

Downstairs, Brooke got back to business, trying to squelch the feeling in her stomach that made her want to toss her cookies. The man upstairs made her more anxious than she wanted to admit. After the disastrous relationship with her ex-boyfriend, Rob, her luck with men hadn't been the best, so she had kept her distance as of late.

She tried to no avail to sever the connection her brain was making to her dreams – to ignore the thoughts screaming in her head that forced her to accept her dream world as reality. She wasn't having any luck. He looked so much like the man she had dreamed of her whole life. However, she spent way too long in

therapy for her mind to go down that path again. No one, not even Dr. Matthews, knew the frightening depth of her visions, and she was going to keep it that way. If she didn't, she feared she could very well end up in a psych ward.

After putting some inventory on the shelves, Brooke decided that Will was being awfully quiet.

A few of the books in the recent shipment needed to be filed away on the second floor. She took one last glance out the front door for incoming customers then scooped up the new arrivals and headed for the stairs.

Will was engrossed in an older book detailing some of Houdini's more famous illusions when Brooke came up behind him.

"How's it going? Are you finding everything all right?"

"I found a few things I'm interested in," the response rippled warmly over her. The double innuendo didn't escape her notice, nor did the heat in his eyes when he glanced up at her. Clearing his throat and pointing toward her arms, he said, "What have you got there?"

She looked down at the small stack she had brought with her and pulled out the book he was pointing to. It was dark brown, leather-bound, older, and seemed to have no title, although she supposed it could have worn off. The cover was dulled by the passage of time with nothing else visible, except a gold embossing of a large figure 8 turned on its side. It was a book her boss would typically have chosen for his private collection but had included in the shipment of books to sell.

"Not sure, looks like an old journal of sorts," she said as she set the rest of the stack down on a nearby shelf. Will stood up to join her and looked over her shoulder as she opened it.

Her first impression was correct. Various handwriting styles filled the journal page after page along with detailed drawings of spells or enchantments. She fought the urge to connect the book she held to the one she had dreamed of – the

one she had searched for in her youth. That book was a figment of her imagination. It wasn't real like the one she held in her hands.

"Looks like you're right. I wonder how old it is."

"Has to be centuries old. Most of these words are a mix of Old English and something else I can't quite make out. Perhaps a bit of French?"

"Impressive. Beautiful and brains to boot," he quipped. She didn't have time to blush before he reached his hand out and said, "Wait, flip back a page. What was that?"

The prior page showed a figure standing near a portal. There was a handwritten scrawl under the drawing that seemed to be a chant or verse, though the words were hard to make out. She'd taken a Latin class in college, one that was finally coming in handy as she scanned each word. But the harder she tried to decipher the passage, the stranger she felt.

A slight tingling sensation moved from her shoulders, down her arms, and toward her hands where the book rested. When the words started to shift and change, fear tickled the edge of her mind, and she snapped the book shut. She had no desire to revisit the panic attack that had struck her earlier in the day. She was glad Will didn't seem to notice her jitters.

"How much for that book?" he asked as he took the journal from her hand and gathered the rest of the books he was interested in. He followed her down the stairs with the small stack.

The book was strange, she would be happy to see it go. Struggling to steady her shaking voice, she said, "Anything in the historical section of the store is usually a hundred unless otherwise priced by the owner. Since I don't see a sticker on the binding, it's yours if the price is acceptable."

"It looks like a cool book," Will replied. "I'm a collector of sorts. I'll take these too."

Brooke flipped through his selections and was impressed by the mystic range they covered. She held up a book on finding balance using the power of the elements that she herself had just read. “This is a great book. I was amazed at just how a few changes in your attitude or surroundings can make such a huge impact.”

“That is what I am hoping. At this point, I’ll try anything.”

His statement obviously touched on something he was struggling with. Not wanting to get too personal and needing to send him on his way to calm her frazzled nerves, she quickly changed the subject.

“These books are great also. Houdini’s passion for illusion was inspiring, although tragic as well.” They walked to the counter and took their respective places. Doing something as simple as ringing up the order made her feel more in control.

He tipped his head as he examined her across the counter. “You’re sure interested in this subject. Hasn’t anyone ever told you there is no such thing as magic?”

She laughed and nodded. She got that comment a lot. “Ah, a skeptic I see. And what makes you think there isn’t? That will be one hundred sixty-five dollars and forty-two cents please.” She bagged up his purchase and was feeling better now that the journal was tucked out of sight.

“Logic and common-sense,” Will said with a grin as he pulled out his wallet.

“Seems to me, someone willing to spend this kind of money on books about magic should actually believe in magic. Are you sure you want to buy these?”

He laughed out loud, and the rumble of it was contagious. “Ah well, I work with illusion, which by my definition is magic with an explanation.”

“Interesting occupation,” she murmured as she swiped his credit card. She was somewhat disappointed that someone as interested in magic as he seemed to not

believe in a mystical presence. What did she care though? It wasn't like she was ever going to see him again.

His rich voice interrupted her thought process. "I have a relatively open mind and could perhaps be persuaded of the benefits of believing in magic. Maybe over dinner?"

Oh crap, she wasn't expecting that. She was immediately torn. He was so charming. Yes, Yes, YES! Her neglected body parts screamed, but her practical, levelheaded, panicked nature won out. "Sorry, I don't go on dates with customers."

"So, if I don't buy these books, and I come in a few more times to get to know you, then it's a date?"

He was persistent. She had to give him that at least. "I'm not sure I would go that far," she laughed. "Was it a no on the books?"

"No, it is a yes on the books, and it's imperative I stay here until you change your mind on the dinner invitation."

"I'm not necessarily sure about that."

"Oh, but it is. I'm not from around here, and I'd like someone to show me around town, so I can get my bearings. We could start tonight if you'd like."

Brooke knew she was dangerously close to running out of excuses but wasn't sure if that was necessarily a bad thing. "Actually, tonight won't be good for me. I have plans with a friend of mine. Sorry."

Before he had a chance to express his disappointment beyond a brief frown, he asked, "Okay, so how about tomorrow? You have to work?"

Brooke looked into his eyes, and her connection to him was undeniable. She needed to find out why, even if he did make her slightly nervous. She was dreaming about him, or at least someone who looked like him. The only way she was going to get to the bottom of it was to spend more time with him. Against her better judgment, she made her choice.

“My shift ends tomorrow at six. I suppose dinner would be acceptable.”

His grin was a mile wide. “Sounds great. I will pick you up here then? Six-thirty?”

“Sounds good,” she said shyly.

She completed the sale, feeling the heat of a blush once again. He shrugged on his coat, patting it down like he was searching for his keys, which he found in his right pocket. He gave her a quick wink before grabbing his bag. He whistled something unrecognizable as he sauntered toward the doorway. Before stepping out into the street, he turned with a boyish grin and a two-fingered salute wave.

She waved back from where she stood, laughing and shaking her head. “*Oh lord. What am I getting myself into?*” *Men like him should come with surgeon general’s warnings tattooed on their foreheads.*



Chapter Five



Will managed to make it home just in time for the second wave of storm clouds to let loose with a vengeance. “Hell, I would’ve stayed in Vegas, if I’d known the weather was going to be this crappy,” he muttered as he peeled off his coat and plunked his bag on the counter.

He was glad to be back at his folk’s time-share, out of the rain and ready to kick back and relax for the evening. He was looking forward to flipping through the books he bought. A new age twist on the age-old sleight of hand with which he earned a living was desperately needed.

Pulling them out of the plastic bag from the Book Nook, he smiled as he thought about the storekeeper who had sold them to him. *Brooke*. He could tell he flustered her, which made her even more attractive to him. It was apparent that she had no idea just how beautiful she was. He liked that about her.

He was glad she said yes to the date, even if it meant he would be purchasing more books than he could possibly use as he got to know her. He was on an extended vacation, and there was no reason why he couldn’t share some of his time with someone who had similar interests. Okay, so he didn’t know if he and the shop girl had similar interests, but he was intrigued enough to find out.

If he were honest with himself, he probably didn't need to be thinking of women and dinner invitations right now. If he was going to convince his folks his choice in occupations was the right path for him, he had a lot of work to do. The new show had to be drafted out and staged, and most of the tricks he performed needed to be revamped. He also wanted to add a couple of new illusions, which took a lot of time to plan. He would be running short on time for rehearsals with Trina if he was going to have to wait until after the baby was born. Yeah, dating a local was probably the last thing he should be doing.

But since when had he listened to reason?

On his way to the bedroom to change, he built a small fire to fight off the unseasonably damp and chilly weather. Once the flames were crackling, he changed into his sweatpants and a tee-shirt, tossing his clothes on the floor near the closet door. Before settling on the couch with his new books and the deck of cards he kept nearby, he grabbed a beer from the fridge along with a bag of pretzels.

He didn't have enough energy to study a new illusion, or even read for that matter, so he set the books down on the table and broke out his cards. He always made time for a bit of sleight of hand in the evenings since it took a great deal of practice to have the manipulation of the cards come off as magic. He took a few swigs from his beer before setting it down on the coffee table and shuffled the deck.

The feel of the cards in his hand soothed him like an old friend as he set the deck up for one of his favorite tricks, the Rising Lady. He had been doing card tricks since he was a kid, and when he was stressed or needed to solve an issue, working with the deck helped him unwind and gain focus.

He gave the cards one last shuffle, preparing to levitate the Queen of Hearts as he had done hundreds of times before, but the cards slipped through his fingers

and fluttered into his lap. He tried again, confused as to why the Queen was stubbornly staying in the deck.

“Strange,” he mumbled as he attempted the trick one more time. As he shuffled the cards, he felt a tingling sensation form in his shoulders and radiate down his arms. Before he could blink, the deck sprayed out of his hand like 52 card pick-up.

“What the fuck,” he blatted out, his mouth wide as he stared at the mess of cards. Never in his career had anything like that happened, and he tried to squelch the small voice in his head that whispered, *maybe you are losing your touch*.

“Not losing my touch,” he argued with himself as he looked down in his lap at the Queen of Hearts.

He scooped up the queen, along with the other cards within arm’s length, and then got to his feet to get the rest from the floor.

“Must be tired,” he grumbled, deciding reading might be the best thing to do after all. He put the cards on the table, took another drink from his beer, and picked the journal from the top of the pile.

For an older book, the binding was still in really good shape. Worn over time by the touch of countless hands, the leather was rubbed smooth, but showed no other visible signs of damage. Other than the golden infinity sign etched into the cover, there was nothing else visible. No title or author to clue the reader in on what might be inside of the pages.

When he had peeked over Brooke’s shoulder in the shop earlier, he saw pages that looked a lot like something he would draw when planning out an illusion. The pictures had been detailed with writing below, which looked like a description of the how to. Just as he was starting to get a better look, Brooke had snapped the book shut, and he had no other recourse but to purchase it.

He wasn’t worried about being able to decipher the language. If he couldn’t make heads or tails of it, Brooke seemed able to follow a large portion of the

text, and he had a feeling she would be interested in helping him out. A common interest would be a great way for them to get to know one another.

He opened the book slowly, careful not to tear the ancient pages, and was surprised to find the first few completely blank. As he flipped through the book, he couldn't believe his eyes! Page after page was empty, blank as though it were a brand-new journal.

He worked day in and day out with magic, spent hours bending minds to his will to make them believe they were seeing the impossible, yet he could not explain what was happening right in front of him.

He flipped through each page, from the front cover to the back, and knew it hadn't been that way when he looked at it with Brooke. He wracked his brain to calculate a solution, and a smile creased his face.

She must have, mistakenly or possibly on purpose, put a different book in his bag when he made his purchase. Even if she hadn't agreed to the date while he was there, she had ensured that they would see each other again. He smiled as he finished his beer and wondered how the girl with the funky hair and gorgeous smile was spending her night.



Brooke pulled on her green, silk nightie and checked that the windows were locked before settling into bed. The soft glow of her bedside lamp soothed her as she picked up her latest read. The book had just come into the store and wasn't due to go out on the shelves yet, so she brought it home to get a sneak peek. She really liked the plot so far. It was smart and sassy with just enough sex to make it interesting.

It had been a long day, and the weird stuff that had happened was confusing at best. The logical part of her brain couldn't quite grasp the incident at the Witches

Brew or why she would have passed out at the store, especially into the arms of a stranger.

She was irritated with herself, actually. She was determined to be in more control of her senses during her date with Will. Her mind flashed visions of his captivating eyes, and she had to force herself to concentrate on her book. She escaped her thoughts the only way she knew how by reading about a werewolf and halfling getting it on.

She decided as she read through the first pages of the chapter, that it might not be the best book to read after meeting Mr. Blue Eyes and agreeing to dinner. The book was steamy enough to make Nora Roberts blush and had her wiggling in bed, her body responding to the things the characters were doing to each other.

After ramping up to the torrid sex scene, things seemed to calm down in the story, and the next chapter was relatively uneventful. She found herself nodding off, and finally, setting her book aside, she allowed her eyes to drift closed. The peacefulness of the night covered her like a down comforter, and the last few images that flashed in her mind were of Will's sexy smile.



The moon's soft glow reflected in the crystal pool a small distance from where she stood. She walked to the water's edge, through the velvet grass that dampened her feet, toward a flat rock jutting out over the pond. She breathed deeply the essence of the night, her heartbeat slowing as the trill of crickets soothed her.

Upon reaching the water's edge, she made her way over to the ridge, which gave her a perfect view of the pond. She looked beyond to the lush valley that sloped and dipped into waves of heather and lavender flooding the hillside like a sea of dreams.

She had come here after every breakup, lost job, and death of a loved one, and each time filled herself with a power that made her whole again. This place had always managed to balance the thoughts in her head and remove pain from her heart.

Perched on the rocky platform, she dipped her feet in the cool water and enjoyed the moment of solitude. She closed her eyes, leaning back on her arms, and allowed herself to fully relax in the hushed sounds of the night.

“The moon is beautiful tonight,” she heard a deep voice say as she jolted up from her leaning position and turned to face the man.

“You startled me,” she said. “I wasn’t expecting anyone.”

Her heart raced as the man stepped closer to her apologizing, “I’m sorry. I didn’t mean to scare you. I was just out for a walk and noticed you sitting here. Are you alone?”

She sensed right away that she could trust him, his aura reflecting optimism as it radiated pale yellow. She wasn’t aware of how she knew that, but she realized it meant he wasn’t the one who wanted to do her harm. Would he remember her this time? So far, it didn’t seem so.

She relaxed her tensed shoulders and let out her held breath in a sigh before answering, “Yes, I’m quite often alone in this place. I usually come here to think.”

“Mind if I join you?”

She looked up into his eyes, gazing into their piercing blue depths, and felt her heart race. As quickly as the feeling came, it was gone again as she recognized him on a deeper level than even she understood. She motioned for him to sit down beside her as she scooted over to the right to make room.

They sat in companionable silence for a few minutes, and she could have easily have forgotten he was there, except for the dampness of her palms. Each time he came to her, she prayed it would be the time he would remember her. She wanted

him to recall their past conversations, and the journeys they had shared, recognizing once and for all that she was his soul mate.

Silly really, that she was in love with a dream. But she supposed every relationship had its issues.

His voice broke through the peace of the night, bringing her out of her own head.

“I can see why you come here to think. It quiets my soul.” He hesitated before continuing quietly. “Do you mind if I ask you something?”

“I guess not, but I’m not altogether sure I will answer.”

“Fair enough,” he chuckled, his rumbling laugh curling her dream toes. “I was just wondering if you had found the secret yet to unlocking your powers.”

“My powers?” she said, puzzled by his question. “Sorry, I don’t really follow you.”

“You are meant for great things, and there is a power inside of you waiting to come out. I don’t understand it, but I feel it’s true.”

She stared dumfounded into his eyes and shook her head. Since when did he believe this? Was this the same guy she had hot dream sex with in the past? She was confused by the direction this conversation was heading. Maybe he wasn’t who she thought he was.

“You have the wrong girl. There is nothing special going on here.”

“There is something special about you, and the power meant for you is there. Look at the water’s surface, you can see the magic.”

She looked toward the center of the pond where he pointed and saw a slight glow beneath the ripples that formed. The glow became brighter as she focused her attention, and her arms rose of their own accord.

“You’re sure about this?” she asked with a trembling voice as she felt a buzzing sensation radiate from the center of her shoulder blades down the entire length of both arms.

“It feels right. You’re meant to unlock this power, and I’m meant to help you. Together, we’ll stand against your fate.”

“I really don’t like the sound of that,” she said as she lowered her arms and turned to look at him.

He smiled, placing his hand under her chin and dipping his head down as he lifted hers. “I promise it will be fine. Don’t ask me how I know, I just do. I was meant to be at this place, at this time, and I can’t shake the feeling that you’ll soon be in danger.”

Time stood still as she waited for him to recognize her. She had dreamed of him for years, and his memories of her had been erased each time they met. Please God, please let him remember me this time.

She noticed a brief flicker in his eyes before they crinkled, and a smile softened his features. The recognition shined in his eyes, and her heart sang as he whispered. “Has anyone ever told you that you have the most stunning eyes?”

“You have,” she whispered. Her heart raced as his head dipped lower. Before she could say another word, his lips were on hers. He was tender and sweet, worshiping her mouth with a gentle kiss as he cupped both sides of her face.

Their contact was brief but full of promise of the passion they had shared in their dreams. It tasted of hope for a future she had looked for in every person she dated but had only found in his arms. How could any other man ever compete with utter perfection...with this man who had stolen her heart? How would she ever be able to live a normal life while in love with a vision?

He pulled back and put his forehead to hers. “I need you to remember everything I’m about to tell you. First, I need you to believe I will do everything within my power to come to you. I promise it won’t be much longer. Do you believe me?”

“Yes, I believe you,” she heard herself say as his voice became muffled, and he started to fade.

“Second, you must find the key to unlocking your power. I believe he is coming for you, and you need to be prepared to fight if I’m not able to get to you. Do you understand?”

“Not really. Can’t we just go back to kissing?”

She felt the vibrations of his chuckle as he answered with a wink. “I love your sense of humor and always have. As for the kissing, we’ll be doing that soon enough. Promise me you’ll look for the signs that release his hold on me.”

“Hey, did you say you remember my sense of humor?”

He was barely visible, and all she could make out was his eyes, “I remember you now, Angel, and I promise we will be together soon.”

“Wait! Don’t go....”



Brooke woke up sitting on the edge of her bed with her arm reaching to the left, as if she were trying to hold on to something or someone. She had been dreaming again, she knew that, but this time, it was different because her dream guy finally had a name – Will Engel.

She shook her head unbelievably, not quite sure how she felt about this latest discovery. Somehow, the fog in her mind had lifted, and she instantly knew the man she had felt an undeniable connection to all of these years, the one she grew up with in her dreams, was the very same man that had asked her out to dinner.

She was baffled as to how she could have dreamed about someone her whole life that she had only just met and in such detail. Could it be her mind playing tricks on her and replacing the dream guy image with a flesh and blood person? That had to be it. It was the only logical explanation.

No matter who the guy was in the dream, there was obviously some message her subconscious mind was trying to get through to her, and she found herself wanting to believe what “dream” Will told her. Maybe the romance part was

coming her way, and she was right to accept the dinner invitation. Or perhaps she should just stick with her gut and let this one pass, especially since he wasn't from around here. No matter how she felt about him in her dreams, she needed to make her life decisions based on reality.

It was still dark, so she straightened the blankets and closed her eyes in an attempt to get back to sleep. She smiled as she remembered her dream man's eyes. Pools of brilliance shining bright just for her, like two distant stars growing closer with each relaxing breath. The feel of his lips against hers, the warmth of his breath, and the comfortable familiarity of his body.... With dreams like that, why would she ever want to wake up? She nodded back off with a soft smile on her face, more and more at peace with her decision to say yes to their date.



Will wasn't sure what woke him, but he had a feeling it might have something to do with the woman in his dreams. He rolled on his side since lying on his stomach was out of the question in his morning state and closed his eyes against the sun's rays peeking through his blinds.

He saw them in his mind – clear, shining eyes, unique like the soul they belonged to, in two of his favorite shades of green and blue. Although he hadn't dreamed of this woman before, he felt as though he knew her, like there had been an instant connection that went far beyond the physical. He supposed his mind was making up a version of the perfect woman and found it ironic that her imperfections were what he found so attractive.

His mind wandered to his meeting with Brooke, and he found himself making comparisons. There were so many similarities, but the eyes didn't quite match, since Brooke's were a lovely shade of turquoise. He wondered what other sorts of things would be similar between the two women. For the first time in a long time, he was interested enough to find out.

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Chapter Six



The next day, Brooke got in a full two hours of reading before she heard the bell on the door. When she looked up, she was surprised to see Will carrying the bag with his prior purchase. As he made his way up to the counter, she marked her place in the book and carried it with her to greet him.

“Hi. You’re a bit early for our date, aren’t you?”

He laughed at the thought. “I am, but I had an issue with this book I purchased yesterday. It doesn’t seem to be the right one. Maybe it was switched?”

She walked up closer to him as he pulled the journal from the bag, her voice clearly sounding like she was feeling... Perplexed. “I don’t know how that could have happened. This is the only book like it in stock. What’s wrong with it?”

“When I looked through it last night the pages were completely blank. I figured maybe it got mixed up with something similar when you rang me up.”

They stood together their heads bowed over the book as he flipped it opened.

She made a swap with him to free up her hands, not even thinking about the book she was handing him to hold.

“Seems fine to me,” Brooke murmured curiously. The book didn’t seem to have the same impact on her senses as it did before.

Completely engrossed in flipping through the pages of the journal, she almost didn't register he was chuckling under his breath.

"Good thing you didn't switch it with this one, although I'm sure *Wolf of my Heart* is a very compelling read."

She looked up into his eyes and tugged the book from his hands, her face flushing with embarrassment.

"I will have you know it is! The characters have personalities that you can connect to, and the plots are beautifully written and creative."

"If you say so but seems to me from the cover it's about some werewolf getting it on with a hot elf chick."

Her cheeks were on fire, and she thought about all the other books she had read that would have been just as bad, if not worse for him to see. Trying not to sound too defensive about her guilty pleasure, she walked to the sales counter and tucked her book out of view.

"Well, I suppose it is a good thing I don't always judge a book by its cover."

He laughed at that, agreeing with her. "I suppose it is."

She couldn't help but smile and reopened the journal to inspect the pages, changing the subject to allow time for her cheeks to cool.

"Seems like the book is fine. Everything looks like it did yesterday when I sold it to you. I'm not seeing any blank or damaged pages, and the binding seems to be in really good condition."

Will looked over Brooke's shoulder as she flipped through the pages. Shaking his head, he muttered, "I can't believe it. I could have sworn they were blank last night. Must have been tired."

"That could have been. I know how I get," she said as she handed the book back to him. "It's been slow. Why don't I close the shop early? It will just take me a minute."

"Sounds great."

As Brooke did her end of the night routine, she worried that she wouldn't be able to successfully avoid thinking about the dream kiss they shared while having polite dinner conversation. Even though he rattled her, she was not one to back out on a plan. Besides, she liked the fact he was punctual, early in fact, which gave him ten points toward her 100-point perfect date score right off the bat.

She was relieved he had dressed on the casual side since she opted to wear her favorite pair of light blue jeans, jazzed up with a sheer aqua blouse over a shimmery tank. The thick silver necklace she wore high on her neck was almost in direct contrast to the loosely moving bangles that hung on her wrist. She liked the sound of the bracelets clinking against one another with its hollow tinkling tones like an outdoor wind chime. The sound soothed her in times of stress and this first date in a long time warranted wearing them.

She decided to embrace the colored streaks in her hair, especially since the green tinge showed through no matter what she did. It just seemed so strange that this time the streaks were so drastic, but the look was growing on her. Besides, it obviously wasn't deterring Will from taking her out. Another ten points.

After checking the lock on the back door, she went back into the lobby and got a better look at her date. Will's black leather jacket fit him like a second skin, covering a royal blue dress shirt which brought out the color in his eyes. The jeans he wore hugged his lean build, not showing signs of wear, but looking as comfortable as an old friend. He didn't wear them too baggy or hanging low off his backside. Another twenty points.

Scanning her way back up his well-built frame, she noted he had a "mussed" thing going on with his hair, which would have given him a scruffy look had he not shaved. He got another ten points, and a mental note that he cleaned up extremely well. Fifty points and the date hadn't even started! She couldn't help but wonder if she was in over her head.

Will's eyes sparkled with amusement as she walked toward him. Her face warmed at the realization that he probably knew she was checking him out. She smiled as he broke the silence.

"I meant to do this earlier."

Curious, she watched as he raised his hands in a gesture of surrender then crossed his hands in front of him and held them up again, making a white rose appear. He bowed slightly as he handed it to her. She had to admit, it was the coolest thing any date had ever done for her. Putting it to her nose, she breathed in the sweet fragrance.

There was a bit of his cologne on the petals, and she assumed he had it tucked in his jacket to pull off the trick. Sandalwood was her all-time favorite, and mixed with musk, it was going to be hard to keep her nose away from him. She had always associated that scent with relaxation.

She looked up with her eyes, her nose still buried in the rose. "Quite the trick," she said. "Have anything else up your sleeve?"

"The night is young – only time will tell I suppose," he said. "Something else I should have done earlier was letting you know how great you look by the way."

"Thank you, Will. And thanks for the rose. That was very sweet."

"You're most welcome. So, are you ready to show me the town?"

"I am."

"Do you have any idea where you want to start? I've heard good things about a few places, but you know the area better. Ladies choice might be a better plan for tonight."

"I actually love the place around the corner. It's a little hole in the wall really, but they have great food if you're game."

"Sounds great. Let's do it," he grinned, his dimple coming out to play.

Shit! Such a sucker for dimples! Another ten points... she was definitely in trouble!

After Brooke locked the store, Will walked beside her and fought a compulsion to hold her hand. He was glad the restaurant took them less than five minutes to get to as he wasn't sure how much longer he could control himself. Her pace slowed, and he took the cue that they were at their destination and stepped over to open the door.

Will knew immediately why Brooke loved the place. She was greeted with a hug and a smile by the owner and tucked into what had to be the best seat in the house. She certainly hadn't been lying when she told him it was a hole in the wall, since the place probably couldn't hold more than thirty people at a time.

The chairs were oversized and padded, giving the secluded feeling of sitting at a booth even though they were in the center of the room. They were seated at a small café-style table placed right in front of one of the largest saltwater fish tanks Will had ever seen. Used as the restaurant's focal point, the tank was nearly as wide as the room itself, stretching practically to the ceiling.

Her face lit up in a warm smile as the owner's wife came from the back room to greet her. She introduced Will as a friend of hers, and he was welcomed like a part of the family. After a few minutes, the owners left them alone to chat as they filled their drink orders.

"This is probably one of the coolest places I've ever been," said Will. "I can see why you like it so much."

"I love it here. The owners are great, and the booths in the back are perfect for when I have some research to sneak in on my lunch hour."

"What kind of research, if you don't mind me asking?"

"Not at all. Typically, I research dive sites. I'm always looking for somewhere new to go."

"You're a diver? Impressive," he said with a nod. "The restaurant with the fish tank makes way more sense now. So where is the next place you have lined up?"

“One site I’m researching is Maui. There is an amazing crater there I would love to see. Honestly, I’m always game for diving pretty much anywhere. What about you – ever dive?”

Will chuckled, “Who me? No, never have. Although it would be cool to learn. You give lessons?”

“Maybe, depends on who is asking for them,” she replied with a sly smile.

“I’ll keep that in mind,” he shot back.

Two hours had gone by before Will realized it. Brooke was not only extremely bright, but also witty and genuine. He couldn’t remember a time he had connected with someone so quickly on a date. There hadn’t been a topic she wasn’t able to chime in on, which delighted him, and their discussion ranged from Monet to the best fishing spots in the area. When the conversation turned to what he did for a living, he found it intriguing that someone as intellectual as she was could be so interested in magic.

They touched on his show, the types of tricks he did, and what he hoped to accomplish on his extended vacation. An hour into the conversation, he found himself opening up to her about growing up as an only child, and the isolation he felt. Magic had been his outlet and constant companion when he was younger, and he often used it to connect to people. Her eyes sparkled as he recalled how he used to put on magic shows for the grounds staff as a boy. He wondered how he could stretch out the evening without seeming like he was coming on too strong.

As the plates were being cleared and the bill was delivered, Brooke’s phone went off.

She fumbled with it, shut off the sound, and switched it to vibrate, “I’m so sorry. I didn’t even realize it was on.”

“It’s all good, really. Did you need to get that?”

“I can call back later. It’s my friend, Tara.” She laughed, shaking her head and rolling her eyes upward. “She probably wonders how my date with you went.” He liked the way her cheeks turned pink after she looked him in the eye.

Will couldn’t help the smile that crept across his face. “Really, so what will you be telling her?”

“Ah I...,” Brooke’s phone vibrated, saving her from answering the question. She reached down to switch it off without looking, her hands fiddled as if she was flustered.

“Are you sure you don’t need to get that? I really wouldn’t mind, besides then I would get to hear how our date went,” he joked with her.

Brooke shook her head no. “It’s fine. She can wait until....,” Just then her phone went off again. “I’m so sorry,” she said with exasperation. “If you don’t mind, I’m going to take this. It’s Tara again.”

Brooke was horrified that she was being so rude. She hoped it wasn’t going to make a bad impression, since she was having a great time with Will. He had a lot more going for him than just being yummy eye-candy. He was entertaining, smart, and had a semi-dry sense of humor that she could totally get into. She thought it was cool that they both loved Benny Hill and Monty Python, and she found herself promising to bring her DVDs over one night soon for a movie night. The insinuation they would be having a second date didn’t faze him in the slightest.

The phone vibrating the third time saved her from sharing with him what a great time she was having.

“Tara, I am in the middle of.....”

“Omigod, Brooke, where are you? I just got here, and it is an unbelievable mess...and the cat is missing. She could be anywhere....”

Brooke felt her heart clench as she tried to organize her thoughts. “Tara, slow down... You’re talking way too fast, I can’t...”

“Is everything okay?” Will whispered with concern. She listened to Tara ramble, holding up a finger to indicate she would get to him in a minute.

“Brooke the apartment... I was so worried about you...” Tara started to cry, and Brooke struggled to keep it together long enough to concentrate on the garbled message she was getting over the phone.

“Tara, sweetie, you have to calm down. I can hardly understand you.”

Brooke glanced up at Will who was preparing to leave, gathering the check from the owners and waiting for her to share what was happening. She was sure he could tell from her body language that it was something serious. He reached across the table to cover her hand and gave it a gentle squeeze.

“Your apartment, Brooke, it’s been broken into. The place is trashed.” Tara’s voice started to fade as Brooke tried to absorb what she was telling her, the muffled sounds of their conversation stretching her emotions thin. She knew the color had drained from her face by the chill on her cheeks.

The sound of Will’s voice whispering her name, and the feel of his hand grasping hers pulled her from the panic that threatened to overtake her.

“Oh my God, Tara, where are you?”

“I am at Heather’s. I went over....”

“Listen to me, Tara, you need to stay at Heather’s and don’t leave until I get there.”

“Ok, but the cat...”

“Tara, don’t worry about Misty. She’ll be fine. You have to promise me you won’t go anywhere near my flat until the police get there. You called them, right?”

“Not yet, I was going to do that next.”

“Police?” Will finished paying the bill and tossed a tip on the table as Brooke pulled her purse from the floor. She appreciated that even though he didn’t know what was going on, he instinctively knew what to do to calm her. His hand was

warm on her back as she paused long enough for him to snag his jacket from the back of the chair. They crossed the room to the front door and stepped out into the crisp night.

Brooke finished her call as they walked toward the Book Nook. “I’ll see you in five minutes and stay at Heather’s.”

She stopped and looked up at Will who was waiting patiently to hear what was going on. Her hands shook as her nerves got the best of her.

“Tell me how I can help.” He rubbed his hands down the sides of her arms.

Will’s comforting gesture did her in, and her voice shook as she answered him.

“Someone broke into my flat. Tara let herself in and noticed the mess. I need to get home, I’m so sorry...”

“Don’t apologize, and don’t even think I’m letting you go home alone,” Will said with a tone that clearly wasn’t taking no for an answer. “I’ll take you. My car is parked around the corner.”

elle

Chapter Seven



Brooke let Will lead her to his car and gave him the directions to her complex. He drove with one hand covering hers. Within minutes, they arrived. As he followed Brooke up the sidewalk to her flat, she was surprised to find her hand gravitating back toward his and how natural it felt when he closed his fingers around hers.

Each unit in Brooke's complex had a separate entrance, like a duplex, so it wasn't surprising to her that no one had noticed anything strange going on. No one was out, and there were no lights spilling through the cracks of the curtain-filled windows that faced the courtyard. Had anyone heard a disturbance, Brooke was sure the yard would have been filled with curious bystanders.

Heather was Brooke's neighbor to the right, who was helpful when she needed a cup of flour to finish a recipe, but otherwise kept to herself. Heather was peeking out of her doorway when Brooke walked toward her door and called back to Tara that she had arrived. Her neighbor gave a small wave, telling Brooke to let her know if she needed anything. She moved aside as Tara bolted through the doorway and pounced on her friend with a full-body hug.

“I was so worried when I couldn’t get a hold of you! I thought maybe something happened to you. I had totally forgotten about your date. It’s such a mess in there,” Tara rambled on as the tears welled up in her eyes, “I’m really worried about Misty.”

Brooke trembled as she held her friend tight. “Misty’s probably just hiding. You know how she is. Come on, Tara, deep breaths, right?”

Tara took a deep breath in and wiped her tears. “You’re right, I’ve got this...”

“Good, lovey, cause the only one allowed to lose it is me,” Brooke joked as tears welled up in her eyes again. She made quick introductions between Will and Tara then started toward her flat.

“Wait a minute,” Will said as he pulled on Brooke’s hand, causing her to take a few steps back. He directed his question to Tara. “How long were you in there?”

“Long enough to see it was a mess. I called for the cat from the living room, and when she didn’t come out, I called Brooke then the police. I just got off the phone with them when you pulled up.”

Will directed his next comment to Brooke. “You’re not going in there first. You can come in after I take a look around. I’ll come get you when the coast is clear. You might want to avoid touching anything just in case the police want to take prints.”

Brooke took one look at Will’s face and knew there was no sense in arguing with him. He squeezed her hand one more time, and with a soft smile meant to comfort her, disappeared through the doorway.

He was gone only seconds before she heard sirens in the distance, and she was relieved when she saw his face poke back through the door to give her the all clear. The look on his face told her it was going to be bad, but not even that prepared her for the horrible mess that awaited her. Will stood aside to let her through the door, staying close behind. Brooke welcomed his presence as she walked into her home and was almost brought to her knees by crippling waves of

violation. Knowing nothing had been sacred, that everything had been touched, sent fingers of revulsion down her spine.

“Oh, sweet Jesus,” she blurted as her hands came up to her mouth. She closed her eyes to pull herself together. Her panic rose from the soles of her feet and hit her full force before she knew what was happening.

Her heart raced. Her lungs couldn’t take in any air. The stabs in her chest made it hard for her to remain standing. The overwhelming need to escape consumed her. Her body shook uncontrollably, and her knees gave out beneath her. Through the heart-wrenching fog, she felt Will’s warmth behind her, offering his support and strength with his presence.

He pulled her to him and wrapped his body behind hers. His hands supported her elbows, and he rested his chin on her shoulder. His breath was warm on the side of her neck, the mint he had grabbed from the restaurant soothed her senses. His deep hypnotic voice calmed her frazzled nerves as he murmured, “Breathe, Angel.”

Brooke closed her eyes, forcing herself to take deep, cleansing breaths. She relaxed, floating in the sound of his voice, filling her lungs with breaths that he took with her. She realized in that instant that he had done this before, that he was as familiar to her as her own mind. She welcomed his embrace like a favorite blanket, allowing it to cover her as it had when she lost her parents. He had been there for her then just as he was now, calming her in the very same way. She remembered, but would he?

As the strength returned to her legs, she nodded to him that she was okay. He rubbed up and down her arms with his hands, much as he had done earlier, much as he had done in the past. Almost as though it was second-nature for him to do so. She glanced over her shoulder, giving him a timid smile as he gave her arms a soft hug before taking a step back. She wasn’t sure how she felt about her realization. She needed some space.

She looked around her living room, a feeling of disgust crawling over her as she looked at everything that had been touched. Her thoughts strayed to the Shadowman, and she wondered if it had been him. Strangely, she hoped it was, considering he probably tossed stuff about with his magic instead of fingering it. Oddly enough, she'd be much more comfortable with that.

Over her initial shock, her next thought was that she wasn't sure how it was possible she had so much stuff. She supposed it looked worse than it was, considering everything was pulled forward from the bedrooms as well.

Practically every piece of furniture in the room was overturned: drawers opened, cushions and pillows tossed, every book, magazine and nick-knack off the shelves. It looked as though a tornado had gone through, stirred around for a few minutes, and then sprinkled her lingerie around like candy on a frosted cupcake.

Disbelief slowed her reactions. *Seriously? What the hell did he hope to find in my underwear drawer?*

Although the front door was open, they heard a knock behind them, and Tara turned to greet the officers who had answered the call. They got down to business, asking Brooke what she had been up to earlier in order to determine a timeline for when the incident occurred.

After taking her statement, the police followed her from room to room. Will gave her some space and stayed in the living room. All of the rooms were equally as messy, and it wasn't until she got to the guest room that her helplessness turned to anger.

Her Goddamn diving equipment! Really?

Her equipment was dotted among Tara's tossed belongings, and when she spied her tanks, she raced into the room to check for damage. The tank itself could take a beating, but it was the gages and valves she worried about.

The officers stepped back into the living room while she made her inspection. It was more than likely due to the size of the room, but Brooke imagined it might

have to do with the overwhelming amount of stuff that was littered about. One young officer had stayed behind, leaning disinterestedly in the hallway and looking very much like he wanted to be somewhere else. She could relate.

Brooke gave a sigh of relief when she realized the tank seemed to be holding air and lifted the mask from the floor to check the lens for cracks.

A small voice came from the doorway behind her. "How's your diving stuff?"

Tara spoke softly as if not to startle her.

Brooke rose to a standing position and turned around to answer her. "Seems fine, but I'll want to take the tank in to have it inspected. Just to be sure. It doesn't look like anything was taken. Why would anyone do this?"

"Not sure. Looks like they were searching for something," Tara squeaked.

Brooke felt a tickle at the back of her neck, which she squelched to examine at a later time. She was 99 percent positive she knew who did this, and she was out of her mind to think it. "Yeah, they probably were, but what? It isn't like I have anything of value."

In true form, Tara snorted and grabbed Brooke's arm, moving her further into the room, so their conversation wouldn't be overheard by the officer in the hallway. Lowering her speaking voice to a whisper she said, "Oh, I don't know, some people would kill to have that much underwear from Victoria's Secret." Tara giggled nervously, relieving some of the pressure that had built up.

"Leave my underwear out of this," Brooke whispered with a smirk and a laugh. *Leave it to Tara to crack a joke at a time like this.*

The police were busy securing the scene in the living room when the girls decided to check out Brooke's bedroom. The bored rookie followed the girls to the bedroom, perching himself outside the doorway to wait for them. It seemed he was dead set on doing as little as possible. The bedroom was much of the same, more clothing than anything, except for the presence of underwear, of course, which was scattered decoratively across her couch and love seat.

Brooke whispered, so her conversation wouldn't be overheard by mixed company. "Why couldn't the underwear mess stay in here exactly?" She didn't want to think what kinds of "statements" were being made about her lace bras and satin nighties out in the living room. Oh Lord, was that a thong she was remembering dangling from her lamp? She groaned as Tara's question snapped her out of a prayer to the goddess of women's foundations that no one would notice it hanging there.

Tara laughed and whispered in her ear, "Don't worry about it, Brooke. It isn't as if we aren't all adults. I am sure all the men here have seen women's underwear before."

They both shot a look back to the rookie cop, who was busily digging for gold – as they say in the states. Back in England, he would be searching for a crusty dragon. They quickly turned their heads, trying not to laugh as Tara whispered her comment. "Well, maybe not that guy."

Brooke snorted and shot her friend a raised eyebrow which must have been enough of a clue for Tara to change the subject.

"So, how was the date with Mr. Dreamy?" she said with a twinkle in her eye, and an angelic look on her face.

Brooke cringed and found herself wishing she hadn't changed their topic from her lacey nothings. "Tara, don't call him that," she whispered, nervously glancing out the door behind her. "His name is Will, and the date went fine."

Tara peeked up the hallway behind her before whispering her next thought. "Fine? Looks to me like he is way better than fine! He is fine with a capital H-O-T!"

"Will you stop it," Brooke said in a hushed voice while simultaneously squelching a laugh. "You're so bad! I think you're the one that needs to be dating."

"FINE by me...."

“Oh, my lord...can we just talk about this later?”

“Oh, believe me... we will.”

A deep voice, rich as mocha, sounded from the hallway directly behind Tara. “Is everything okay back here?”

Brooke sent a warning squint with her eyes that Tara had better watch what she said, and Tara grinned with a silent message that Brooke would owe her big time. With a raised eyebrow, Tara answered Will’s question, dragging out the last word for effect. “Everything is FINE.”

Brooke swallowed a laugh and rolled her eyes. Tara looked up with innocent eyes at Will, who explained that the officers were ready for Tara’s statement. He looked from Brooke to Tara and back, as if he knew there was a joke but hadn’t heard the punch line right. Brooke was just glad he didn’t seem to have heard any of the conversation. He would probably wonder what was wrong with them. No one in their right mind would be carrying on about how someone’s date looked when they were in the middle of a crime investigation. Thank God, Tara wasn’t in her right mind. It kept Brooke sane.

Before heading up the hallway with the nose-picking officer, Tara peeked over Will’s shoulder, flashing a devious grin, her eyes wicked with mirth. It was nearly impossible for Brooke not to laugh. Tara mumbled something to the officer who nodded in happy agreement and followed her up the hallway like a lost puppy.

Brooke took one last look around the room, shaking her head at her friend’s blatant shenanigans. She tucked her head down to hide the grin that threatened to creep across her face, especially since Will was still in the doorway. She agreed with her friend. He was nice looking, but she still wasn’t quite sure what she was going to do about it, especially since this trouble hadn’t started until he had showed up in her life.

After composing herself, she turned to leave the room and was startled by a thudding crash behind her. Her eyes met Will's as he began to move toward the closet.

"Will, maybe you should get the police..." Brooke started to say as he pulled his sleeves over his hands.

"It will be FINE," he said with a wink. Brooke felt her cheeks flush. From his comment and the look on his face, she guessed he heard every word of her conversation with Tara.

Nice! Not only has this guy seen all of my underwear, but to top it off, he overheard us describing how hot he is. I think I'll just die now.

He raised his hands to the door, gently pulling it open, and let out a yell as a giant ball of fluff came screeching out of the closet and attached itself like a giant leech onto his chest. The shock of the force pushed him back as he put one hand behind him for balance and the other on the crazed beast to prevent it from moving around.

"Omigod...Misty! Are you okay, baby?"

"Is she okay? What about me?" Will groaned. "I think she's permanently attached to my chest."

The cat was breathing heavily, eyes wide and frightened. Will regained his balance and stroked its fur, managing to calm Misty down enough for Brooke to peel her from his jacket. The cat's claws made a slight popping sound as they came loose from the leather.

She crooned to the cat, softly stroking her fur, as she put her face down in her neck. "I'm so glad you're alright, fuzz-face."

She watched Will as he straightened up from his crouched position and gave him a smile as he inspected his jacket for holes. "Sorry about your jacket, Will, did she do a whole lot of damage?"

“No, seems to be good. How’s your cat?” he said as he came up to her and scratched the top of Misty’s head.

Misty purred as Will stroked the cat between her eyes, “I guess that’s your answer.”

elle

Chapter Eight



Brooke and Will walked back into the living room just as the police were finishing up with Tara. She pulled the cat from Brooke's arms and cooed to her lovingly.

"Do you have somewhere to stay tonight, Miss Fisher?" one of the officers questioned as Brooke looked at him with confusion. "You know, because of the front door." She nodded as he continued, "It will need to be replaced, and I would suggest installing a deadbolt while you're at it. In the meantime, I think it would be best for you to have it secured and stay somewhere else while we finish up the investigation. We need to be sure they aren't coming back."

Brooke glanced over to Tara, who answered her unasked question with an apologetic tone. "Sorry, Brooke, since our plans have changed, and I can't stay here, I'll have to go to my folks."

Tara must have sensed Brooke's confusion as she clarified with a quick glance to Will. "You know, because I can't go back to my apartment just yet?"

In a blinding flash, Brooke remembered that Tara's ex was in the process of moving out. How could she have forgotten? "No worries, Tara, I can find a place to go for a few days."

“You can stay with me,” Will said without hesitation. “I have plenty of room.”

“I really appreciate that Will, but it might be best if I get a hotel for a few nights.” Brooke glanced at Tara holding Misty in her arms, the question about what she was going to do with her must have been evident on her face.

“I feel like a terrible friend. I’m so sorry, I can’t take Misty for you. You remember my dad has...”

“Allergies,” Brooke finished, nodding her head. She wasn’t sure what she was going to do, since the hotel up the street didn’t allow pets, and she dreaded taking Misty to a cattery.

Brooke watched Will nod as he addressed the Detective, “We’ll get this sorted out.”

Will’s comment satisfied the detective’s need to ensure Brooke wasn’t going to try to stay in the apartment, and he packed his things. On his way out to join the rest of the squad, he gave Brooke his contact information. After he left the apartment, Brooke turned to address Will.

“I really appreciate the gesture, but I am sure I can find somewhere to—”

Will’s resolved expression stopped her mid-sentence. “Don’t be ridiculous, I want to help. I’m renting a house, and you and Misty stay as long as you need to.”

Brooke looked at Tara, who was smiling innocently as she watched Brooke’s interaction with Will. The awkward pause must have snapped her out of her musings since she mumbled a clarifying statement to Will.

“Thanks for giving them a place to stay. I would take Misty, but I’m in the process of clearing out some vermin from my apartment.” Tara looked at Brooke with a satisfied smile. “Much as my Dad loves animals, he can’t be within feet of them before sneezing up a storm. Otherwise, I’d take Misty in a heartbeat.”

Brooke couldn’t disagree that Tara’s ex-boyfriend was definitely in the vermin category and thought her friend might be prompted to put a fire under his fanny

to get his things out in light of this new situation. In the meantime, she was intrigued by the idea of getting to know Will better.

“You sure you don’t mind, Will? I can always find a hotel to stay at.”

“I’m sure, and it will be nice to have some company. Besides, most places don’t allow pets.”

“True,” Brooke mused. The Shadowman’s return to her dreams had her reconsidering. She needed to figure out why Will had the leading role in her dreams and the connection he had with the Shadowman if any. This would be the perfect opportunity.

“I just need to pack a few things,” she said quietly.

“Take all the time you need.”

As she walked back to her room to pack, she heard Tara whisper from the guest room, “Don’t forget to pack your lingerie. It’s out in the living room.”

Brooke poked her head in and whispered back, pointing her finger at Tara with a smile. “You are not helpful! Leave my underwear out of this.”

“Considering how hot it was out there with the sparks flying, you might want to consider taking some is all. Isn’t that right, baby?” Tara crooned to the cat, who was all packed up and ready to go. Misty meowed from the carrier and tilted her head in response before curling up in preparation for her trip.

Brooke shook her head. “I don’t know what it is about you, but Misty is never comfortable being in that thing. You have the magic touch for sure.”

Tara laughed, “I just have a way with animals I guess, although it never worked on old-whatshisface.”

“I think calling him an animal is demeaning to animals,” Brooke joked tenderly. She gave Tara a thoughtful once over, her tone coming out more subdued. “Are you sure you’re going to be okay? I mean, being at your folks and processing the breakup with Greg?”

“Don’t worry about me,” Tara said with a flick of her hand. “Besides, you should be concentrating on packing some cute outfits for your future dates. I think this guy has a lot of potential, and he really seems to be into you. Honestly, what man offers to take care of you and your cat?”

“I know, right?” Brooke laughed. “Rob couldn’t stand Misty! I guess that should have been a sign.”

“One of many,” Tara muttered with a grin.

“Precisely!” Brooke paused as Tara stood up and placed Misty’s carrier on the bed. “Thanks for everything, sweetie,” Brooke said as she gave Tara a hug.

“I wish I could do more, Brooke. I feel awful that I have to bail on you like this.”

“Don’t worry about it. I completely understand. Besides, I have to admit I’m curious, and this will give me a good opportunity to figure him out. There’s something about him I can’t quite put my finger on.”

“Well, if you need help figuring out where to put your fin....”

“Ok going now,” Brooke laughed as she bolted from the room. She could hear her friend’s giggles clear up the hallway and made quick work of packing a bag. After she finished packing her toiletries from the bathroom, she headed out into the living room where Will was chatting up Tara. If Brooke didn’t know any better, Tara was up to something, looking much like the cat that swallowed the canary, and Will was no help, egging her on with his boyish charm.

Tara handed Will the tote bag filled with Misty’s supplies, gave Brooke a quick hug asking her to call her in the morning, then made her way out the front door.

Brooke looked at Will, who had a not-so-innocent look on his face, and decided she wasn’t even going to worry about what they had been talking about. Not that she shouldn’t worry, since Tara knew way too much about her to be safe from verbal leakage, but because she feared she would have bigger fish to fry if her assumptions were correct. It was only a matter of time before the Shadowman

realized that Will had the journal and would be paying him a similar visit. The thought that they seemed to be two separate people made her feel better.

Taking her bags from her, he nodded toward the cat carrier. "Might be better for Misty if you carry her. It won't take long to get to my time-share."

After placing Misty's crate in the back seat, Brooke glanced up at her kitchen window, immediately wishing she hadn't. There was no denying who she saw outlined there. She watched as he faded away, just like the shadows he was made from. Her mind grasped at the significance of his return to her life as Will stepped into it. *Is there a connection?* She slid into the passenger seat and closed the door, but by the time they had turned the corner at Main and Fifth, the pleasant conversation had all but taken her worries away.



He was physically exhausted from controlling his essence in their dimension and frustrated that his journey had been fruitless. It wasn't in her home, he didn't find it, and his hunger for it grew. He had forced his shade to travel back mere hours after the initial search, materializing in her kitchen.

Through the window, he saw Brooke leaving with her man and found he was unable to do a thing about it. Within seconds, he lost control and snapped back to his physical form, like a stretched rubber band that had been let go. The gaping hole left by his essence disappearing from his psyche caused his physical form to ache. It was a painful process, trying to merge the two halves of his being. His shade was growing stronger. What he feared the most was that soon he wouldn't be able to control it at all. If that happened, what would he become?

He needed to find the journal before Brooke realized its power, before she traveled through the portal without him and doomed him to this half-life forever. He was running out of time.



Chapter Nine



Will motioned toward the couch where Brooke sat thankfully. She lay her head back on the cushion behind her, feeling the stress seep from her body.

“Would you like a glass of wine?”

“Actually, yes. That would be lovely, thank you. I’ve already decided I’m calling in sick tomorrow.”

Brooke cracked her eyes open as she heard the clink of wine glasses on the table and felt the couch cushions sink beside her. Through hooded eyes, she looked at Will’s profile and smiled at the unguarded moment she glimpsed. She watched quietly as he took a sip of his wine and rubbed his fingers along the back of his neck. The stress of the day had affected him too, she realized, and it warmed her to think he hadn’t let it show. That he had been there for her in her time of need. So much like the boy in her dreams.

He emptied his pockets, tossing his cell phone and wallet on the table, before scooping up three white opaque balls centered on it. They clinked in his hands and her curious nature won out over drifting off to sleep.

“What are those things anyway?”

“What – these? They are Baoding Balls. Some people call them Chinese exercise balls. I use them to keep my hands limber – old habit from the days when I did a lot of sleight of hand. Sometimes I use them when I’m stressed. They tend to relax me.”

“Really? They’re pretty. They almost look like crystals.” Brooke leaned up toward him, taking a sip of her wine as she looked at his hands. “So, how do they work?”

“They are crystal actually, white quartz. You hold them like this in one hand, and then use your fingers to rotate the balls clockwise for a few minutes then back counter-clockwise like this.”

Will spun two of the balls in his hands and then added the third, clinking them together as they rotated in his palm. Brooke gasped at the speed at which he had them spinning, grinning with childlike pleasure.

“Hey, David Bowie did that in *Labyrinth*!” she squeaked in delight. Her enthusiasm was contagious, and Will laughed as he shook his head and shrugged.

“Yeah well, I haven’t quite gotten the floating part down yet but pretty similar for sure. Although, I think I’m better at it than he was.”

“Hmmm, not sure about that quite yet. Only time will tell, I suppose.”

“Ah, now who is tossing lines back,” Will chuckled, “Touché, Mademoiselle.”

They both laughed and fell into a comfortable silence as they drank their wine. Brooke’s eyes were getting heavy, and she could hardly keep her head from leaning on the back of the couch. She must have nodded off since the next minute Will was clearing the glasses and heading to the kitchen.

“I’m sure you’re exhausted. It’s been a rough night. I’ll show you your room if you’d like.”

Brooke looked at him with grateful eyes, “Thanks, Will, you’ve been awesome. I really appreciate you letting me stay. Misty, too.”

“It’s really no trouble. Selfishly, I have to admit I like the company. Besides, it will give us a chance to get to know one another.”

As Will walked to the kitchen to put the glasses in the sink, the vibrating of his cell phone drew Brooke’s glance. The phone, just a few inches away from her, glowed with insistence that begged to be investigated. Her curious nature won out, and she leaned over to peek at the bright screen showing an animated envelope with the words “New Txt Message” above, and “Trina” below. She couldn’t help the conclusions she jumped to. Who the heck was Trina? Was it possible he had a girlfriend? Brooke hadn’t really gotten the girlfriend vibe from Will, but then she thought she knew her ex-boyfriend pretty well too.

She guiltily scooted back to the couch and waited for Will to return to the room. He sauntered in with a sexy smile and stopped in front of the couch with his hand extended, like a knight reaching for his lady. She smiled timidly as she put her hand in his, allowing him to help pull her from the couch.

She stood in front of him, their bodies barely a breath apart, the electricity of the connection sparking between them. She slowly looked up and noticed his smile had softened. His eyes were hooded and smoky.

Her mind was racing. She couldn’t make sense of what she was feeling, and everything was happening so quickly. It was overwhelming. She was conflicted, knowing she couldn’t deny the attraction but simultaneously needing to understand its purpose. It was entirely possible that Will wasn’t the person her heart wished he was. She would almost bet money on it since that man was a figment of her imagination. He had to be. But then how could she explain the Shadowman, who was turning out to be more than something her mind conjured up.

She looked into Will’s eyes – so captivating, so familiar – and realized she needed more answers. She needed to find out why Will reminded her so much of the Shadowman, what it meant, and if there was a connection to all of the crazy

stuff that was happening to her. Was it a coincidence that it started the day Will walked into the bookstore?

Her body tensed, allowing the memory of her dreams to steal the moment. He must have sensed the change in her, the hesitation, since with a slight clearing of his throat and a gentle squeeze of her hand, he took a step back.

He gestured for Brooke to precede him up the hallway, almost boyish in his behavior as he shifted from foot to foot. He seemed nervous, and she couldn't help the train of thought where her fluttering pulse was leading her. *He looks so much like...him. Could it be that they are one in the same?* The Shadowman had never harmed her physically until she met Will. The direction of her thoughts came to a screeching halt as they stopped in the hallway.

"Your room is the one here on the right," he explained as he flicked on the bedroom light. "Sheets are clean. I use the room up the hall on the left. You have your own bathroom and there are fresh towels in the closet inside. It's through the door to the left. You can't miss it."

Brooke decided cutting the night short was probably best for both of them since she really needed to get a handle on her feelings, which was impossible with him around.

"Thanks again. Goodnight."

Will gave her a brief nod and turned to head back out to the living room when Brooke's voice stopped him, "Hey, Will?"

"Yes?" he answered as he looked back to her.

"I had a really nice time tonight, all things considered."

"I did too, Brooke," he said with a warm smile. "Sweet dreams."

Let's hope so, Brooke thought to herself as she shut her door quietly.



Brooke woke up the next morning to a note on the kitchen table and a full pot of coffee. She was glad Will had gone for a run since it gave her some time to be alone with her thoughts and take a look around. It wasn't snooping really. She just wanted to get to know Will as a person. At least, that was what she told herself.

The wine glasses and a few dishes he had from earlier were in the sink, and she made quick work of getting them scrubbed and lined up in the dishwasher. With the kitchen tidy, she toasted an English muffin and poured a cup of coffee, watching the steam disappear. When she felt the side of the cup, it confirmed her suspicion. The coffee was cold. She decided she would drink it on ice since she desperately needed the caffeine.

On the way out to the patio, she grabbed a banana and scooped the journal from the coffee table. Her dream the night before had been vivid, focusing on the journal and the pages she needed to pay particular attention to. The path seemed so clear in her dream state but so unobtainable in the light of day. Other dreams had included Will, which was only natural since they were spending time together.

The pages were cryptic and hard to read, with spidery drawings of wavy figures on a number of pages. The figures looked to her like ripples on the ocean, and the longer she mused over the pages in the book, and with the things Will had said in her dream, it seemed that her issues all related to water. Along with her ongoing shower issues, the coffee was something she couldn't wrap her head around. She remembered back to the incident at the Witch's Brew and tried to tie it all together. There just didn't seem to be any common threads, other than her, and she didn't want to think about what that meant.

Sitting on the patio, Brooke took a sip of her iced coffee, thinking *it actually wasn't bad when you got used to it*, and looked at her watch. She wondered how

long Will would be on his run and if he would like the other half of the English muffin she usually left on her plate.

She looked down at the journal she had opened, taking a bite of her banana. Nothing so far made any sense, and most of the pages were faded, making it hard to translate. It had been a few years since she had been a freshman in college, and her Latin was a bit rusty. But it looked as though the journal was filled with pages of descriptions, places and things, along with detailed drawings of the same. She flipped through the pages and started some notes.

Will ran up to the table just as she put down the book in frustration. Her quick glance up turned into a longer linger. The man was seriously gorgeous. *He's even amazing all stinky and sweaty, and lord, he needs to put a shirt on! Okay, well maybe not...*

"How was your run?"

"Pretty uneventful, unless you count my interaction with the flock of seagulls that thought I was a loaf of bread."

Brooke laughed, "Yeah, they're pushy around here. They get fed pretty well on the beach."

Will grabbed the other half of her English muffin and slathered on some grape jelly she had left on the table. "Speaking of being fed, you're done with this, right?" He bit into it with a grin.

"I certainly hope so. You know, I don't just let anyone finish my breakfast."

He smiled at her and gave her a quick wink, "You know...I like the sound of that. What's on the agenda for today? You have any plans tonight? I was thinking I could rent a movie, maybe bring Chinese home for dinner."

"Sorry, Will, but I really need to get back into my place. I was going to call the detective later to see how the investigation stands and then meet Tara to do some straightening up. I'd still like to stay here if that's okay, I'm just not sure how late I'll be. What about a rain check?"

Brooke noticed the flicker in his eyes and the subtle pout before he answered jovially, “Rain check sounds great. You going to need any help?”

“Thanks, but I think we’ve got it. I’ve had about all I can handle of my personal belongings being on full display for all to see.”

“Well, now that you mention it, that was a pretty nice shade you had on that lamp.”

“Exactly my point!” she said with a flushed laugh. “If it’s all the same to you, I’m going to straighten up without any help from the testosterone-laden peanut gallery. I should be back no later than nine o’clock.”

He hit her with his devil-may-care grin, flashing his dimple shamelessly at her. It was enough to make a girl change her mind. “Fair enough, and if you’re up to a movie when you get back, you can let me know.”

“Fair enough,” she answered with a laugh.

Will helped her clear the patio table and followed her inside. Brooke watched from the kitchen as he made his way up the hallway with a bounce in his step and whistling a tune off key. Randomly, she wondered if the water in his shower would stay hot if she joined him, and in the next second decided she had better get her flat to rights quickly. Thoughts like that were going to get her in trouble. The more time she spent with Will, the less likely it would be that she would ever want to leave. She needed to keep her distance – for both of their sakes.

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Chapter Ten



Later in the week, Brooke spent the hour before closing looking through the shelves upstairs to see if she could find anything remotely close to the journal she sold Will. Although she hadn't received the same tingling sensation that she had before, something about the book bothered her. Brooke couldn't shake the nagging feeling that the issues weren't imaginary. She felt as though she was missing something important about the book's presence. It seemed like too much of a coincidence for a journal and the man she had been dreaming of to both show up in her reality.

She wasn't having any luck in the occult section – most of the books were newer and related to things such as Tarot, the Wiccan culture, and homeopathic remedies. As she scanned the shelves, her eyes landed on a colorful book wedged at the end of the lower shelf. Drawn to it, she pulled it out to get a better look.

The book on auras was thin, describing in detail what they were and the meaning behind their colors. Remembering her dream from before and the glow that surrounded her dream guy, she flipped to the pages that described the color yellow. It confirmed what she had known in her dream. The yellow aura related

to life energy and was the color of awakening, intelligence, and creative inspiration. It also included tendencies like being playful and easy-going. *She* decided to take the book with her, wanting to read up on what it meant if veins of pink blended in with the yellow. She had seen that coloring around Will toward the end of her dream.

Brooke started down the stairs to the lower level, noticing a shadowy figure in the lobby. She thought it was Will at first, but this man had much longer hair.

“Sorry, I didn’t hear the door ring. Is there something I can help you with?” There was something off about him. The figure looked up into her eyes, and his piercing, blue orbs hypnotized her on the spot. She was unable to move a muscle, her arms and legs weighted as though they were held in place by layers of duct tape.

She stood frozen on the stairs, staring into the eyes of the being that had haunted her dreams for a lifetime. He was transparent, edged by a complete absence of light, a thick coat of midnight black. A lighter gray haze haloed the black, menacing in its presence. Even without the book on auras she knew it meant she was in big trouble.

As she stood on the steps, powerless to move, a disembodied voice surrounded her.

“I’m sorry for not being here in a more conventional state.” His greasy voice crawled over her as she tried to piece together the meanings of her dreams and hoped this was merely another one. Maybe she had fallen asleep on the bench upstairs.

“Who are you? What do you want?” His energy repulsed her, like feeling a tickle and looking down to see a beefy spider making its way up her arm. She swallowed her panic, internally chanting to herself that it was only a dream. Her heartbeat ramped up, the wild flutters making their way into the pit of her

stomach. A quiet thought tip-toed through her mind that the vision could very well be real.

“You know who I am.” His force slithered closer as he spoke. “Events have been put into motion, forcing me to come sooner than originally anticipated.” His eyes swirled, keeping her paralyzed, and she wondered how she could ever have mistaken them for her dream guy’s. They were so cold.

“Until now, it was easier keeping you two apart by erasing his memory. But he will soon remember all you shared in your dreams. I can’t risk that.” The next phrase was spoken softly, as if he were talking to himself. “It’s time to put myself back together.”

“Who? What are you talking about? I don’t understand.”

Ignoring her questions entirely, he raised his arms toward the nearest bookshelf, and a stream of lightning came out of his fingers, sweeping the books from the shelves. The energy was dark blue, almost black, and bolted from his fingers with a loud crackling that sounded like lightening hitting a tree. She smelled burning, even though none of the books seemed to be on fire.

Another crack of energy caused the books to float in a circular pattern from floor to ceiling, gaining momentum like looking down on the top of a tornado. The sound of the pages flapped like dark wings as the books whirled and spiraled toward the center of the darkness. The void was no longer transparent – in fact, it was pitch black, similar to the aura that surrounded him. The chill in the air caused goose bumps to ripple along her arms.

“Together, we will unlock the secrets of the journal.”

“You mean the one Will has? I don’t even have that anymore. Is that what this is all about?” As she spoke to him, she found that although he had her paralyzed, she was able to wiggle her fingers.

He continued to hold the portal open, its dark center like a black hole in space. As he shot energy from one arm to the opening, he pointed the other one toward

Brooke, and she closed her eyes. She prepared herself for the lightning to fry her to a crisp.

He blasted a pulse in her direction, and unlike what she expected, it wasn't painful. In fact, it felt as though every nerve ending in her entire body was twitching. It was mildly uncomfortable but didn't hurt. She opened her eyes and saw the dark blue electricity crackle against the soft green glow that surrounded her. Brooke was lifted with the light that encapsulated her and was forced to float the rest of the way down the stairs toward the hole he had opened.

He inched her toward the portal. Hundreds of books were spinning dizzily around the outer edge and flying closely around her at a blinding rate.

The hole was getting smaller. The books were crowding toward her, and she was pushed forward by his force. Her last coherent thought was how typical it was. She had the worst luck with men in reality, so why should her dreams be any different?



“Brooke, Brooke, wake up. Oh, please wake up.”

Brooke felt warm hands on her shoulders and someone shaking her gently as the muffled sound of a voice became clearer in her mind. Her eyes snapped open, and she took in a quick breath, her mind focusing on Tara's concerned face.

“Are you alright?” Tara looked around the room with her mouth wide open.

“And what the hell happened in here? Should I be calling the police?”

Brooke allowed Tara to help her to a sitting position and shook the fog from her head as she took quick inventory of the room. The Shadowman was gone, as was the portal. The only evidence of their interaction was the huge heap of books that had been swept from the shelves. She closed her eyes and took a deep breath, willing her heart to slow its pace from her abrupt awakening. Had it really happened? Had she been dreaming, or had her mind splintered?

Her legs felt like cooked noodles. They were almost not strong enough to stand on, and she was glad for Tara's support. She raised her hand to her hair, rubbing a large knot on the side of her head and answered her friend hesitantly.

"I'm not sure. I must have fainted and bumped my head. When did you get here? You didn't see anything when you came in?"

"No, nothing, girly. Just you in the center of the lobby and these books everywhere."

"And the guy?"

"What guy?" Tara looked at Brooke like she had sprouted a third eye. "The one that asked you out to dinner? Mr. Dreamy?"

"No, the other one," she answered as Tara walked her away from the pile of books beneath her.

Tara laughed nervously, "You had someone else ask you to dinner? And then what happened? You threw a bunch of books at him?"

Brooke smiled at her friend's attempt to lighten the stress. Tara dealt with crisis the same way that she did. "You seriously didn't see anybody?"

"I seriously didn't, Brooke. What the heck is going on? You're starting to scare me."

"I'm actually starting to scare myself." She looked in the corners of the room for the Shadowman, but the only sign he'd ever been there was the mess he'd left behind. Her head was throbbing. She must have gotten whacked pretty good with a book when he tried to stuff her through that portal, but it didn't make sense to her why it stopped so suddenly, and he disappeared.

It couldn't have been a dream – the place was too much of a mess. Nope, that guy was definitely real. To make matters worse, her mind had made a connection to Will in her dreams, she realized that now, and she wasn't sure how she felt about that. She knew one thing for sure – she needed to find some answers, and her best bet was going through the journal again.

“Earth to Brooke,” Tara said as she waved her hands in front of Brooke’s face.

“Are you sure you’re okay? You need to go to Urgent Care or something?”

“No, I’ll be fine, just a little lightheaded still. Let’s get this place cleaned up. I’ll close up for the night, and we can get a bite to eat. I’m sure it’s just low blood sugar or something. I haven’t eaten much today.”

Tara sounded unsure as she walked to the piles of books on the floor. “Doesn’t seem right, but if you’re sure.”

“I’m positive. I’ll be right as rain soon, you’ll see.” She just wished she could convince herself of the same.



Chapter Eleven



He didn't know what happened. One minute, he had the portal open with Brooke on her way through, and the next, his essence was shot back to his dimension. Unable to return, as he had lost control of his shade, his path was now blocked, and it angered him. *Could it be she released her powers without his knowledge?* He didn't think so, but since the past couple of nights, he had been unable to manipulate her dreams. He was beginning to wonder.

When she was younger, he was forced to watch her from afar as the mentor was too powerful. Then later, a man came into her dreams – first as a boy and then as a young man, sharing adventures with her. Through the years, their bond grew, and eventually, they fell in love. He knew early on the boy was a threat to his plans, the young man had powers of his own. As the boy matured, the Shadowman realized he was not unlike himself in looks. He used that to his advantage, tricking Brooke at times by taking the young man's form in her dreams.

Through the years, he did what he could to keep them apart. Without the proper control over his essence to travel to their dimension, he waited patiently for them to meet in her dreams, doing the best he could to prevent them from meeting in

reality. For as powerful as he had once been, it irritated him that the only spell he could use was something as simple as a memory spell. Each and every time the two met in her dreams, he erased the man's memories, which had kept them separated until now.

The Shadowman's control was slipping. Something had changed. The man met Brooke in reality, and he could no longer merge with his shade at will. Once Brooke and her man learned to combine their energies, he would have a hard time overpowering them. He needed to find a way to bring her over, or he would be stuck forever in the hell his life had become – in the place between dreams and reality.

An idea formed in his mind as he pulled forward the scrying bowl to look in on Brooke. The simple stone bowl held a powerful potion he used to reflect on things to come, or paths he should take. It was one of the few magical tools he had left, one of the few Zilla had been willing to show him. The plan unwound in his head, like a serpent uncoiling from its slumber, and it became clear to him what had to be done.

It was a simple plan, really, one that could be implemented in a few days after he had rested. He was amazed he hadn't thought of it sooner. A smile crept across his face that never once reached his eyes, eyes he closed as he visualized the next stage of his journey.



Chapter Twelve



The police had finally given Brooke the okay to clean, and Tara was already at Brooke's flat when she arrived. The hug did Brooke in, causing the tears that were trapped in her eyes to overflow. Tara leaned back and looked into Brooke's face, smiling softly as she took a deep breath.

"You good after what happened the other day?"

Brooke nodded, taking her own cleansing breath before answering. "I'm good."

"Okay," she responded simply, "Where do you want to start?"

Brooke decided the living room was as good of place as any and appreciated her friend getting down to business. Their conversation was light, primarily focused on Tara's ex and updates on his slow progress extracting himself from her apartment. Soon, they were joking and bantering about as if nothing had happened, and Tara lost no time asking how Brooke's stay with Mr. Dreamy had been.

"Tara, you've really got to get your head out of the gutter, not everything revolves around sex."

"Says the person with all of the sexy underwear," Tara smirked as she waved toward the basket of laundry they had just gathered.

“I can’t help it. They send me coupons for free panties, and when I redeem them, I have to get a bra to match!”

“Brooke, I think you’re the one that needs help, not me.” Tara giggled, as she tossed the red thong from the lampshade into the basket.

“I’m starting to agree with you,” Brooke mumbled, ducking up the hallway before Tara could banter back.

They spent the first few hours putting the bedrooms and bathroom back together, which didn’t take as long as Brooke thought it would. Brooke put the last of her clothes in the hamper, anxious to get it washed.

Brooke was glad they had made so much progress, but at the same time was bummed that her time with Will would be coming to an end. After tomorrow, there wouldn’t be an excuse to stay with him, which honestly, was probably better considering how confused she was.

Tara broke the silence, “So, what’s going on? You’ve been kind of quiet tonight. Does it have to do with Will? Are you guys okay?”

Brooke took a deep breath and let out a wistful sigh before answering. “There is no ‘us’ to be okay. He is just being helpful and giving me a place to stay.”

“If you say so. But from what you’ve told me and what I’ve seen, you guys have some major sparks going on. You might be second-guessing it for some reason.”

Damn, she knows me so well. “You might be right,” Brooke looked at Tara, who gave her the raised eyebrow look she was famous for and laughed as she finished her comment. “Okay, you’re definitely right, I’m hesitating, but I think I have a very good reason!”

“And what would that be? With the things you have told me about him, he seems perfect for you!”

“I know, I know, but there’s no sense in getting attached. He doesn’t live here, and besides, he’s getting texts from some chick named Trina, and I don’t want to

get hurt again. Honestly, I would rather be alone than go through another heartbreak like Rob.”

“There has to be some logical explanation for the messages. Maybe it’s his sister?

Leave it to Tara to look at the bright side.

“Look, Brooke, I know you have a bad taste in your mouth with that kind of thing. Rob wasn’t the most faithful guy, but you don’t want to be alone. You have too much to give. If Will isn’t able to see it and won’t work to have you in his life, then I guess he isn’t worth it. But are you willing to let that chance pass you by without even trying?”

“I’m scared, Tara. He makes me feel things I have only ever dreamed about – things I never for the life of me thought could be real. What scares me the most is if he’s real, the other things can be too.”

Tara tipped her head, squinting her eyes as she processed what Brooke had said. “Is this about the Shadowman?

Brooke lowered her head. She couldn’t look her friend in the eye and not blab absolutely everything that had happened so far. Needing more time to sort it out, she let Tara jump to her own conclusions.

“Brooke, those are only nightmares! He isn’t real, and you can’t let your fears cripple you like this.” She bent her head down to look Brooke in the eye. “Have you talked about this with Dr. Matthews?”

Brooke shook her head and answered in a small voice, “No, I haven’t.”

“Brooke, you’re one of the strongest people I know. You have dealt with way more than anyone should have to, but you have to find a way to get this dark dude, or shadow or whatever he is, out of your head. Otherwise, you will never be able to move on...with anyone.”

Brooke nodded her head in agreement, and though Tara was speaking more from a relationship standpoint, she knew she was right. She needed to find a way to

get out of the Shadowman's grip, but she was afraid her issues with these nightmares were only beginning.

"Thanks, Tara, you're right. I know there are changes I need to make, and I'm working on it. Maybe an appointment wouldn't hurt."

"I worry about you, Brooke. I just want you to be happy."

Tara's sincere look made her eyes sting. She shared everything with her and hated feeling like she was holding back from her now. "I know, Tara. I hope you know I want the very same for you."

The hug warmed her, and Brooke held on as if her life depended on it. She sucked back the tears that threatened to fall. Thankfully, after a final squeeze, Tara attempted to lighten the mood.

"I know what you need," Tara said, smiling as she grabbed the remote for the T.V. and flicked on Pandora. She filed down the stations until she found just the right mix, and as the music started, Brooke cracked a smile. *Leave it to Tara to know the Beach Boys could fix just about anything.*

Brooke ended up staying much later than originally planned and had called Will a few hours earlier to let him know she was going to be late. He sounded bummed when they discussed not spending any time together that evening. She was too, but at the same time, she was glad she had gotten so much done at her flat.

Will's place was dark when she walked in, except for the small light above the kitchen sink he had left on for her. He must have gone to bed since it was well past eleven. As she hung her jacket on the peg by the door, she noticed a note on the kitchen table. Will's masculine scrawl let her know there was dinner in the fridge if she was interested. Even though she had a bite with Tara, she smiled at his thoughtfulness.

"You're going to make someone very happy one day," she whispered to no one. Her thoughts strayed to the name on his cell phone, glowing as brightly in her

mind as it had on his screen. With a sad smile, she made her way up the hall to the guest room.

She threw on her favorite blue nightie, brushed out the snarls from her hair, and slid between the sheets with a deep sigh. The sounds from the ocean came in through the crack in the window, which Will had left open. It was soothing, listening to the waves crashing upon the shore. Her eyes were lulled closed by the sound, and in no less than five minutes, she was fast asleep.



Back at her favorite pond, Brooke's heart raced in hopeful anticipation that she would see Will again. She made her way to the stone platform, her feet slick with dew as she stepped through the ankle-deep grass along the water's edge.

The moon's glow shimmered on the pond like diamonds and reflected on the ripples created by fish that grabbed at tiny insects. Small circles radiated from the center of each splash, growing wider until they faded into the edges of the pond and gently wet the stones that circled it.

She sat on the rock jutting over the water's edge and looked to the valley, curious to know if he would come, and if he did, if he'd remember her. She couldn't deny there was an attraction both in and out of her dreams, and the benefit to meeting him here is that she wouldn't have to share him with Trina – whoever she was.

Above the soft sounds of the night that surrounded her, she could hear the rustling of the grass behind her. Face flushed, she turned to greet him with a smile when his boots hit the stone's surface behind her. "I was wondering if I would see you tonight."

He stopped abruptly, instead of taking his usual place beside her. He skipped the playful banter she had become used to, and his voice sounded mechanical. "I came to check on your progress."

She looked up at him with a puzzled expression. The moon was shining in her eyes, throwing shadows on his face, and she was having a hard time making out his features. "Sorry, I don't follow you."

"The journal, have you made any progress?"

Brooke tried to ignore the sinking feeling in her stomach as he took another step, and she focused on the aura that surrounded him. He looked and sounded like Will, but according to his aura, he most definitely was not Will. She tried not to let her voice shake as she answered him, needing desperately to keep the conversation going so she could figure a way out or force herself to wake up.

"No...no progress. Why do you ask?"

"Pity, I was hoping you would have unlocked its secrets by now. I'm running out of time and patience."

"What kind of secrets were you hoping for?" she asked as she tucked her feet up underneath her and pulled herself into a crouched position.

"Secrets of time and space, of power and control," he said with a shark-like smile. "It is a diary of the Elements, and I need some information from it that is only present when you are around."

"So, if you held it, you'd only see blank pages?"

"Brilliant and beautiful," he said as he closed the space between them. "There is someone I need you to meet. I am tired of being two halves of a whole."

Before she could sprint, he took the final steps forward and grabbed her under her arms, lifting her as if she were a feather. She felt a tingling of energy radiate from his hands, like plugging something into a bad socket, and found she was powerless to move because of it. His soulless eyes bored into her, and she wondered how she could have ever mistaken him for Will, even though they were identical right down to the small dimple near his devastatingly handsome smile. What did he mean he was two halves of a whole? Was that why she was so conflicted? Maybe he was like a Dr. Jekyll and Mr. Hyde.

“I have some plans for you,” he chuckled as the energy from his hands lifted her a few inches off the ground. With his power, he propelled her in a half-circle, edging her toward the darkened tree line. There was a swirling dark mass there just beyond the outer edge of the forest, similar to what he had created in the bookstore. She felt her panic rise, threatening to choke her as she struggled.

“Let go!” she screamed, thrashing her head from side to side, which was the only thing she could move. Through the covering of hair that landed in disarray on her face, she could see a shadow move behind the tree trunks near the portal and felt a huge wave of relief as she recognized Will entering the clearing. While she didn’t have time to think things through completely, she was aware that she finally had her answer... They were two different men.

As glad as she was to see Will, she was simultaneously frightened out of her mind, knowing full well what the Shadowman was capable of. She screeched to him as he moved toward her, “Will! Watch out!”

Will shouted as he raised his hands to his sides and continued to move forward. He pushed his raised palms forward, releasing a white ball of light from his hands, “Let her go!”

Will threw another energy ball just as the first one hit the Shadowman’s shoulder, pushing him back and causing him to release Brooke. She fell forward, tripping on the tall grass where they had been standing and falling to her knees. Will took full advantage of having stunned the Shadowman and threw another lightning mass out as he closed the distance.

Brooke pulled herself up from her crouched position, stumbling a few steps away from the Shadowman and out of the line of fire. Will kept his eyes on his target, never once looking her way, and she was fascinated by this fierce new side of him and the abilities that came with it. Brooke glanced at the Shadowman, noticing the effects of the light balls that seemed to limit his movement with

crackling white static. In the end, it wasn't enough as he broke the static's hold and shot a huge ball of fire straight toward Will.

Will slowed his run toward the stranger, closed his eyes, and crossed his arms in front of his face to prepare for the flame to hit him. He heard the woman scream, and turning his head in her direction, saw something amazing.

She was standing near the pond, wearing a paper-thin, blue gown that billowed around her ankles. Her long, wavy hair framed her face, the strands lifted by an invisible force, giving the illusion of a halo. Her arms were stretched in front of her, reaching toward him as her exquisite eyes reflected concern for him. They glowed brightly, one brilliant blue, the other emerald, and something clicked inside him in that instant. He remembered those eyes. They were eyes as unique as the woman that captured his interest so long ago. The woman he had always dreamed of... His Angel.

Brooke's movement drew his attention from her eyes, and he watched as she raised her arms, beckoning a large wall of water from behind her, which sprayed up on all sides toward him. He closed his eyes just as the impact of the fireball hit his chest, pushing him off his feet and onto his back while he simultaneously felt the cool water douse him from above.

"Will, are you alright? Oh my God. Are you burned?" Brooke rambled as she ran over to where he lay.

He looked around. The Shadowman had disappeared. "I'm fine, Angel," he answered with a smile as he propped himself up on his elbows and looked into her anxious face.

"Well, it doesn't look like it to me – your shirt has a huge hole in it, and your chest is smoking."

"Nice of you to notice," he said with a grin and a slight wince as his chuckle pulled on the tender skin.

She knelt down next to him, her expression unamused, and her head shaking as she answered him. "I meant literally smoking, as in on fire." She reached toward his chest, gently touching the area where the fireball had hit, and her lip trembled.

Will took her hand and looked into her eyes, "I know what you meant, babe. I'm sure it looks worse than it really is. Did you see where he went?"

Brooke shook her head as she looked toward the tree line, "No, he disappeared right after he threw the fire ball at you, but he was near the dark hole. It's gone now. I think it's some kind of doorway."

Will stood up and put his hand out to Brooke to help her up. After she was standing, he put his arms around her, not caring that he was soaked to the bone or that he had 2nd degree burns on his chest. He just needed to hold her – to feel her arms around him again. He felt as though they had been apart a lifetime.

Brooke sank into his embrace and shivered uncontrollably. "I was scared, Will. He was always spooky in the past, but this time he actually hurt one of us. He's getting stronger."

Will cupped both sides of her face and looked into her eyes, "I promise you we will figure this out. I'll always do what I can to protect you."

Will kissed her on her forehead, and she nodded in agreement as she looked down, frowning at the blisters that formed a six-inch diameter around his heart.

"We really need to find something to put on that. I think I know of a place where we can go."

Brooke took hold of Will's hand, leading him out toward the hillside that dipped into the lush valley below. He slowed his pace, causing her to turn after feeling the slight resistance from him. He tugged her to him, careful to tuck her into his side to avoid the burn on his chest, as he lifted her chin to look into her eyes.

"I have a much better idea. Why don't we just stay here and enjoy each other's company? I'm not sure we will have much longer tonight, and I don't want to

waste it trying to hunt down Neosporin in an empty countryside.”

Brooke had wanted to argue that it wouldn't matter what they did, since he never remembered her by the next dream anyway. But like other times they had been together, the attraction overwhelmed her, and she lost herself in his kiss. She couldn't think, almost couldn't breathe, her heart pounding frantically as she held him tight, answering every sweep of his tongue with hers. She tilted her head allowing it to deepen as he kept one hand in her hair and lowered the other hand to her side, sliding it around to the small of her back.

He broke the kiss slowly, and Brooke felt him shift his attention to her neck, lowering his head to the tender spot where it met her shoulder. He murmured something she didn't quite catch, and he lowered his lips to her neckline, nibbling his way up her neck to nuzzle her ear. His breath on the side of her neck sent chills down her spine, and she relished the warmth of his touch. He raised his head slowly and smiled as he looked into her eyes, giving her one last tender kiss full of promise for a future of which, up until now, she had only dreamed of.



Chapter Thirteen



Brooke was still smiling when she woke up at Will's the next morning, feeling like a pan of brownies that had just come out of the oven – all warm, gooey and yummy. It was still early, but she heard Will knocking around out in the kitchen.

She dressed quickly, brushing her teeth and running a comb through her hair before heading into the kitchen for her morning caffeine fix. Her assumption was right, Will had the coffee going and was putting on his shoes as she walked into the living room. Her face warmed as she remembered the things they had done in her dream.

“Got the coffee going for you. Did you get everything done you needed to at your apartment?” He was looking down, concentrating on tying his laces.

She made her way up to the kitchen counter and pulled a mug out of the cupboard above the coffee pot. “We did get a lot done actually. I think we should be able to finish the rest of it tonight, and then I can be out of your hair.”

She laughed at the comment as she poured her coffee, excited to see steam remain and immediately distracted by him coming up behind her as she put in

some sugar. For some crazy reason, she found herself holding her breath as she waited for him to answer her.

“What if I like you in my hair?” he said softly.

She turned, putting her back against the counter, and saw he had his trademark grin in place.

Brooke’s heart was pounding so loudly she was amazed he couldn’t hear it. With a shaking hand, she placed her coffee cup down on the counter beside her as he stepped forward to corral her with his arms on either side. Her gaze moved along his shoulders and up to his face as a thought flitted through her mind that she liked him in blue.

His eyes were looking back into hers but didn’t have quite the same look in them as they did in her dream this morning. Oh the look was making her heart race all right, and she felt as though she was going to pass out... In a good way of course, but the quizzical look on his face made her realize she had made a horrible mistake.

How could I have been so stupid? As she internally berated herself for neglecting to put on her contacts, she glanced downward in both directions, calculating the odds of her getting back to her room without him saying anything about her eyes. The odds were 10,000 to one, and she wasn’t a betting girl. Sandwiched between Will and the counter and unable to make a graceful exit, she had no choice but to look into his gorgeous, baby blues now crinkled with mirth.

“Well, that explains a ton,” Will said aloud, not necessarily to her as he continued to mumble. “I thought I was going crazy.”

Brooke nudged him back as she moved away from the counter and started toward the guest room. “I forgot something in my room,” she said. “I’ll be right back.”

Will grabbed her hand and pulled her back in front of him, blocking her from escaping with his stance.

She lowered her eyes to the center of his well-formed chest and shifted nervously on her feet. She had always hated her eyes, especially when growing up and hearing the other children whisper behind her back. While she hadn't planned on letting anyone else in on the secret, she sighed knowing she didn't have much of a choice in the matter now.

"Look at me, Brooke," he said to her softly as he lifted her chin. Scenes from last night's dream replayed in her mind.

She held her breath as she waited for the questions, the comments that had fed her insecurities since childhood, but she heard none of those from Will. The corners of his eyes creased as she heard the words she had waited to hear in reality her entire adult life. "Has anyone ever told you that your eyes are stunning?"

Brooke's eyes welled as she moved her head aside to avoid embarrassment. *You have but only in my dreams.*

He paused a moment with his hand still cradling her chin as her face turned in his palm. "They're my two favorite colors," he said softly, "They always have been."

Looking like he sensed her embarrassment, he slid his hand from her chin and took a step back, allowing her some space. She picked up her coffee mug, resigned to the fact the damage was done, and stepped over to the kitchen table to have a seat.

Will paced back and forth a few times before he sat across from her, outwardly nervous and agitated. She didn't have long to wait to learn why. He took a deep breath, ran his hands through his hair, and rubbed his early morning stubble as he blurted out, "I dreamt about you last night."

She paused before answering, "Well, we have been spending a lot of time..."

“I don’t think that’s it.”

Brooke set her cup down with a bump on the table as she tried to hide the quiver in her voice and the shaking of her hands. It was strange they had both dreamt of each other last night, and she tried to keep her voice conversational as she responded. “That’s odd. What exactly were we doing in this dream?” She took a sip of her warm coffee, taking note of Will’s devil-may-care grin over the lip of her cup and lift of his eyebrow as he answered her.

“I’m pretty sure you already know the answer to that since you were there too.”

“Yeah right,” Brooke responded with a lift of her eyebrow, realizing quickly he was dead serious.

Brooke placed her coffee on the table and got up to pace the room. She couldn’t believe it! How could he know? Could they have shared the same images? It was impossible, right? She didn’t want to consider any possibility that might point to the realization that they shared the same dream, especially since she was very much aware of what they had been doing in that dream. From the smoky look in Will’s eyes, she was pretty sure he was aware of what they had been doing in the dream as well.

She looked at him incredulously. “What are you telling me, Will? We were both in the same dream and shared the same experiences? Do you know how unbelievably barmy that sounds?”

“Barmy? You’re adorable when you get worked up, have I ever told you that?”

Brooke looked at him, the confusion on her face must have been apparent.

“Your accent,” he said with a smirk. “It really comes out when you’re worked up.” She barely caught the next statement that he muttered under his breath.

“Always has.”

Brooke groaned in frustration and slapped her hands to her sides. “Can you focus please?” His response was a belly laugh that was highly contagious. She turned her back to him to hide the smile that threatened to crack across her face. Was he

just messing with her? Or did he really think they shared a dream? She peeked over her shoulder. He was sitting there smugly waiting for her to make the next move.

Will stayed in his seat and waited for the gears in Brooke's head to stop spinning as she calculated the possibilities. Her reaction to his statement was answer enough for him. She was definitely the woman in his dreams, and he had the feeling she knew it.

Images had been coming to him all morning, flickers of past visions he didn't remember having but felt in his gut he must have. They all included the same girl, the woman there with him now, and they had shared lifetimes of experiences together. While he wasn't sure how he felt about the rabbit hole he was being dropped into, he was glad he wouldn't be making the trip alone. In his dreams, they shared adventures and whispered secrets and were connected in a way that frightened him. He had to find out what it meant, why he felt whole with her around.

Brooke grabbed her cup from the table and walked toward the sink looking out the window as he got up from his chair, scraping it against the floor. He moved up behind her, touching her shoulder gently with one hand as he moved her hair to the side with the other.

"I know it sounds crazy, but that is exactly what happened. I don't know how, I don't know why, I just know now we have a connection – one that we've had for some time. I wouldn't mind figuring out what it means."

Brooke's hands shook as she bent to put her cup in the dishwasher, partially because of what he was saying and partially because he had been running his finger up and down the side of her neck as he spoke to her, and she was starting to get that "warm brownie" feeling again.

She straightened up and turned to face him. "Listen, Will, I'm not sure what you think you dreamt, but I can assure you it is impossible we shared the same

dream. It's crazy."

Will's grin softened his smart-ass comment, "I thought you said it was barmy?"

She took a deep breath. He wasn't making this easy. He was so close it was making her head spin. "It is!" Besides, I have had the same dreams since I was little. I would know if you had been in them." *Great, now who sounds barmy?*

Will looked at her as though he were putting that little tidbit in the back of his mind for future reference, "Ok, so what is it going to take to convince you this is really happening? What if I could give you hard evidence?"

She flushed at his comment, looking into his face as he attempted an innocent look and utterly failed at it. *How much did he know? How long could he remember back? How could he be thinking about sex this early in the morning? Okay, she knew how he could be thinking about it since she was too, but there was no way he was there last night in any way, shape, or form other than in her imagination.*

"This is unbelievable," she murmured as she shook her head. "It can't be possible."

"Oh, it's possible, trust me. I know."

"Ok. Say for argument's sake I believed you, and we shared a dream. What could you possibly have in the way of evidence?"

He grabbed his shirt behind his neck and swept it over his head in one motion, letting it drop from his chest and hang from one arm. Her eyes naturally went to the naked chest he bared for her, and she gasped, realizing he had a burn mark on it in exactly the same spot where the Shadowman had hit him in her dream. His voice came to her over the fog that formed in her mind. "If the burn mark from the fireball isn't proof enough, you could always use that hickey I put on your neck during our make-out session."



Chapter Fourteen



Will was sitting patiently on the couch and caught the antibiotic cream that Brooke tossed to him before taking a seat across from him on the recliner. After the last comment he made to her in the kitchen, she had raced to her room, more than likely to look into a mirror to determine if he was telling the truth about the love bite on her neck.

He watched her pull her knees up and cross her arms over them, resting each of her hands on opposite shoulders. Her demeanor was making him nervous. The silence almost worse than her being upset.

She stared at the floor, her chin resting in the crook of her arms as if she were deep in thought, or at least that was what he hoped it was. It bothered him to think she might be shaken enough to close herself off to him and the possibility of something amazing, especially since he had finally figured out who she was to him. He had been dreaming of her almost his whole life, he remembered now. It was as if a fog had been lifted and seeing her multicolored eyes had confirmed it for him.

Okay, so maybe he could have handled this morning a bit better. It was entirely possible he shouldn't have come on so strong or treated his injury so lightly, but

he had been coming off the high he was on from the dream the night before. It was almost as though the morning was an extension of it.

He realized now Brooke might not have been comfortable with things that had happened in their dream, still attempting to keep him at arm's length for reasons that she only knew. Realistically, it made sense – he was almost a complete stranger. But the feeling they were linked couldn't be denied.

His past dreams were pushing into his head like a mass of people crowding to make it onto a subway. He realized while they might feel real to him, that she might not have experienced them the same way – or at all. He needed to slow down, needed to figure out what this all meant, especially since what happened in their dream was somehow pulled into their reality. He finished rubbing on the ointment, the angry red burn stinging as he touched it. It didn't hurt nearly as bad as the realization that if he could be hurt by the dreamjerk, so could Brooke.

"You have any theories on what is going on here? What this guy might be after?" He tried not to let any hint of jealousy sneak into his voice, "Or is he maybe an ex-boyfriend bent on revenge?"

Brooke lifted her head from her knees, startled from her thoughts. "Yes... I mean... No... of course not." Her voice was strained, and Will decided his sense of humor was once again ill-timed.

"I was just kidding, Brooke, you know...trying to lighten the mood? Listen, we have to figure this out, and we have obviously shared this particular experience, so I think it will help if we put our heads together."

Brooke sighed, and he imagined she was mentally fighting herself over admitting the truth and avoiding the entire conversation. The truth won out.

"How much do you remember?"

"Of the dreams?"

"Yes. I mean how far back can you remember, and what do you recall?"

Will gave it some serious thought for a few seconds before responding, “I remember you, your eyes especially...which really are beautiful by the way.” Brooke blushed at the compliment as he continued. “And it’s the strangest thing, but it seems as though I have been dreaming of you forever and have only just realized it – like a lifetime of dreams have been fed to me in flashes throughout the morning.”

Brooke shifted to tuck her legs beneath her. “I’ve dreamed of you too – my whole life, as a matter of fact,” she glanced up in his eyes, looking a bit unsure if she should continue. “The difference is when I woke up, I remembered you and everything we shared. That day you walked in the bookstore it hit me pretty hard.”

“The day you passed out?”

Brooke nodded in agreement, “Yes. Seeing you that day upset me since you look so much like the Shadowman. I’ve confused the two of you for a long time. Honestly, you could be twins, except his hair is usually a bit longer.”

“I remember you mentioning him when we were younger but don’t ever remember seeing him.”

“Generally, it was either you or him in my dreams, never both, until now. I remember a time when you stopped coming, and his visits increased.”

“I couldn’t tell you why I stopped my visits, but I feel in my gut it wasn’t by choice.”

“I think it was the Shadowman’s doing. He seems to be pretty powerful. By the time you returned to my dreams, we were older, and the Shadowman hadn’t aged. In this last dream, he looked exactly like you. I think he used a spell of some sort.”

“Since I remember our dreams now, maybe his power is weakening. I don’t ever remember fighting him like that before. It seems to me the lightening is something new.”

“I think it is. I don’t ever remember you having that ability before.” Brooke looked at him with a sad look in her eyes, “I’m so sorry he hurt you, Will.”

He pointed to his chest, “What this? I’m fine,” he said with a dismissive tone and a wave of his hand. “What’s more important is that we figure out what he’s after. Did he mention anything to you about what he wanted?”

“He mentioned the journal a couple of times, last night and the day he came to me at the bookstore.”

“Wait, hold it, he came to the bookstore? When was this?”

“Right after my place was broken into. I thought at the time I had fallen asleep and was dreaming, until I woke up in the middle of a pile of books with Tara shaking me.”

“Why didn’t you say something before?”

Brooke looked at him, her mouth wide. “Are you kidding me? Seriously?” She laughed and shook her head before she continued. “What was I supposed to say, Will? That dreaming of this Shadowman nearly ruined my life, and I spent the better part of my adolescence in therapy? That this imaginary figure had scared the shit out of me every single night of my childhood by threatening to drain every ounce of power from me and leave me to die? Or how about that he actually manifested at my work and made a tornado of books that opened a portal that he was attempting to suck me into when Tara walked in? How about that you and he look so much alike that I thought you were the same person? Is this the type of dinner conversation you were thinking we could have had? Because I think anyone I told that story to, including my best friend, would have left the room screaming! Tara doesn’t even know the half of it. The only thing I let her in on is the fact that I have the hots for Mr. Dreamy!” As she finished her rant and looked into his face, she closed her eyes and groaned, knowing she had done it again.

“You have the hots for Mr. Dreamy?” Will said, grinning ear to ear.

“Out of all of that, is that all you heard? Brilliant!” Brooke growled playfully as she started to laugh, “You’re so frustrating!”

Will got up off the couch and crouched in front of the recliner where she sat. “Sorry, my jokes are sometimes ill-timed. We definitely have a problem with this guy or thing, whatever he is, because he’s crossing over from the dreams into our reality. I want to help you figure this out.”

“Thanks, Will,” she said softly as he stood up and walked over to the coffee table where he had left the journal, “It will be nice to have someone to share these things with,” she continued. “I thought I was losing it.”

“Well, if you are, you’ll have company. So, he is after this thing huh?” he said, waving the book and shaking his head. “Not sure why – it’s full of blank pages.”

“So, that’s what you still see when you look in it? Blank pages?” Will nodded as she remembered something the Shadowman had said in the dream.

“He said he needed the journal to get some information from it that only I could see. I’ve looked through it but haven’t found much of anything.” She popped up out of her chair and held her hand out for the book.

“I wasn’t able to see anything on those pages until you were standing with me, just like right now.”

Brooke opened the book, and they were both able to see page after page of drawings and scrawling that Will hadn’t seen since the bookstore. Some of the words he could decipher looked to be Latin, with the drawings detailing various leaves, berries, and creatures of all shapes and sizes.

“You’re definitely the key to reading this book.”

“It’s strange, but that seems to be the case. It’s almost as though the journal is magic.”

“Not sure if I would go that far. There is no such thing as magic. I’m an illusionist, remember? I would know.”

Brooke rolled her eyes. “Why not? What is magic really, but power that allows people to do impossible things? You make your living tricking people’s eyes and minds into thinking they are witnessing the impossible. There is magic in that as well,” she said, thoughtfully.

“Well, that is a matter of perception. You haven’t seen one of my shows,” Will joked. “Your faith in the impossible is inspiring.”

“I like to believe magic is all around us, finding its way into everyday life one miracle at a time. What about creating life, healing from a crippling disease, or overcoming diversity? Those overwhelmed by the steps necessary to get to the end result could consider these things impossible. Yet there are people who find the strength to do it each and every day. I don’t question that there is magic... I know there is.”

He took the book from her hands, holding it up to make his point. “Well, if that is the case, we had better find a way to tap into some of that power with this book. Otherwise, I have a feeling we are going to be needing a lot more than Neosporin next time we run into you know who.”

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Chapter Fifteen



It had been a slow day in sales at work, so Brooke spent most of the afternoon researching the journal. She was working open to close, having signed up weeks ago for double shifts since the swim classes ended, and new sessions weren't starting for a couple of months.

Will had been especially sweet before she left his house, making her promise she would keep her cell phone handy just in case the Dreamcreep, as he had dubbed him, decided to show up. As odd as the entire situation was, having Will to share it with grounded her, and she tried not to let the nagging feeling that he might be involved with someone else worm its way into her mind and burst her happy bubble.

Brooke wasn't comfortable bringing Trina up to him, especially since she didn't have any kind of a hold on him. They had only gone on a few dates, and her stay with him was coming to an end soon, so the timing wasn't right for that type of conversation.

Since what they shared in their dreams had never been based in reality, she decided to take it one day at a time for now. Why there was someone after her

and how this book fit into the equation was way more important at this point than whether or not she and Will had a future.

Brooke sat on the couch in the lobby, her spiral notebook ready beside her and laptop propped on the small coffee table at her feet. She had been concentrating her efforts on transcribing the language on the page that showed the portal since that seemed to be what the Dreamcreep kept trying to push her into.

The sketched image was a dark hole with swirling masses of matter circling around the outer edge, which was exactly what it looked like as she well knew from experience. What was interesting was that this picture of the portal included four unique symbols at the top, bottom and on each side of the dark hole, similar to points on a compass. While these symbols were reflected individually throughout the book, they were only present together in this particular drawing.

Three of the symbols were variations of a triangle, and all four were drawn with simple lines without any major detail. The top symbol was a triangle drawn point down with a line running through it from left to right capped on both ends with another short line. To the right, the symbol was almost identical, except the triangle was point up, and the “double-T” line was toward the upper portion of the figure. The symbol at the bottom of the portal was nothing fancy, just a plain old triangle point up. The last symbol, the one to the left, was the most unique and probably the easiest to figure out. There were two horizontal lines, one on top of the other that bowed up and down like waves in the ocean, and she knew without a doubt she was looking at the symbol for water.



It took her a little while to realize this particular part of the book was actually not written in Latin, but in French, and with the help of some translation software, she had made huge progress by the time her shift came to an end. As she started to gather her books and shut down her laptop, the bell on the front door rang. She glanced up to see Will stroll in.

Just to be safe, she pulled her phone from her pocket and kept it in her hand until he made his way to her, and she could confirm that it was indeed him. Almost immediately, she recognized his sandalwood cologne, and the soft yellow glow of his aura. She was getting rather good at sensing them outside of her dreams, even though her ability decided if and when it would make its presence known. She bent down to collect her purse from the side of the couch and tossed her phone inside as she heard Will's voice behind her.

"Looks like you have been doing your homework. Any progress today?" he asked as he looked around at the mess she had sprawled out on the coffee table. "Did you even stop to eat today?"

"Eat? Uh, I guess not," Brooke shrugged as she continued to load up her backpack. "Now that you mention it, I'm starving!"

"I'll bet you are, considering your shift started at nine this morning, and it's past dinnertime. Come on, I'll help you pack up, and we can get a bite around the corner. Maybe you can bring me up to speed on what you have found out."

It was a quick walk to the Salty Dog Restaurant where they had their first date. After receiving their drinks and placing their orders, Will asked to see what she had uncovered.

Brooke showed him her notes side by side with the journal.

"Most of the journal seems to be written in Latin, but there are lots of other languages as well, such as Greek, Gaelic, and a bit of French. I started translating this portion here since the picture was familiar to me."

Will nodded his head, “Looks like the portal Dreamcreep was trying to drag you to.”

“Exactly,” Brooke agreed. “What I believe is this represents a doorway between worlds, very possibly between our reality and our dream world. Right now, I think it’s limited in its ability. He said he needed me to unlock the mysteries of the book. My theory is that portal has the potential of going anywhere if you have the right key.”

“And you’re the key?”

“Well, the Creeper thinks I am,” Brooke laughed nervously, tucking the books out of view as their salads were placed on the table. As soon as the waiter was gone, she pulled the notebook back up, and Will pointed to the symbols she had re-created on the page.

“What are these here? Do these triangles mean anything?”

“That actually took me a bit to figure out, but once I realized the few pages in this section about the portal were written in French, I was able to determine these are symbols for the elements.”

“You mean like Earth, Wind, and Fire?”

“Well, there is Water also... Otherwise, you would be referencing a band from the 70s,” she chuckled as she took a bite of her salad.

“Well, while I would never discount the popularity of *Boogie Wonderland*, I suppose you’re right.”

“A man who knows his 70s music... Impressive,” she said, nodding her head with her lips pursed. “You’re full of surprises.”

“No, I just grew up in a household that never evolved past the eighties. My Mom still wears bright colors and has big hair.”

Brooke laughed out loud, not missing the small frown as he changed the subject quickly.

“Okay, if we think of it from a magical standpoint, the elements make sense. The four symbols represent a full circle of power. What do you think they mean for us? And why do you think he is after you?”

Oh Boy, here it goes. “Well, so far I only have theories,” she paused nervously as he waited for her to continue and then jumped in with both feet. “According to what I have read in the past, the elements are the four purest powers of the universe. They are represented on a compass as North for Earth, East for Air, South for Fire, and West for Water.” She pointed to the drawing in the journal. “I did some research on these symbols and found that they represent those elements. There was a phrase I found in the book that insinuated that each power will require a different item to unlock its corresponding portal, allowing the traveler to cross into a different dimension.”

“What was the phrase?”

“It translated roughly to...‘The power of four, will find each key, unlocking the magic, so mote it be.’”

“Sounds a bit like Dr. Seuss,” Will chuckled.

Brooke couldn’t help but smile herself, knowing it all sounded completely ridiculous. “Many of the spells and chants used by the pagans rhymed. They were easier to remember that way.”

“No need to get defensive,” Will grinned with a twinkle brightening his eyes.

“Let’s say I’m buying into the whole opening the portal thing. Go on.” She looked up at Will and took a deep breath before finishing.

“I think this book is filled with valuable information far beyond our comprehension and is only visible to the four elements, whoever they are at any given point in time. I also think, like you, Dreamcreep isn’t able to see the pages on his own. That is what he needs me for.”

Will nodded. “So, if you’re able to read it on your own, what are you telling me... You’re one of the elements?”

“I told you it was only a theory,” Brooke laughed nervously. “But yes, if I’m able to read this when no one else can, I believe that could be a possibility. I also think that this journal could be one of the keys to travel through the portal to somewhere else.”

Brooke picked at her salad as she waited for Will to process what she had said. A small part of her hoped he would laugh it off and tell her it was all in her head, so she could get on with making an appointment with Dr. Matthews straight away. The problem was she knew for a fact that it wasn’t. The Shadowman was real, the burn on Will’s chest was real, and the portal drawn in the journal was real, which meant that life as she knew it was pretty much over.

She waited for Will’s response, knowing that if he didn’t believe her then no one would, and she would be left to face whatever this thing was on her own. That was not something she looked forward to, especially since she had really started to rely on Will and his sense of humor to help keep her from losing it completely. She loved the way he made her laugh. That, coupled with the fact that he was built like a God, her cat seemed content to tolerate his existence, and he cooked a mean pot of spaghetti, made him about the most perfect man on the planet in her eyes.

After a moment of silence, Will looked up at her with a small smile, reaching out to touch a piece of hair that had come out of her clip and rubbing it between his fingers. “So, I’m guessing you’re Water, which explains a bit.” She looked at him, her head tilted to the side, and the space between her eyes pinching as he continued. “You know how you pulled it from the pond to dowse me in the dream? It could even explain the problems you’ve had with your coffee and the shower, I suppose.”

Brooke smiled, nodding her head in agreement and taking a deep breath, relieved that he was open minded.

“Not sure how much it will explain actually, but I agree with you that there have been too many strange things happening to me related to water to ignore. So yes... If I had to pick an element, that is exactly what I think I am. So now, we just need to figure out what it means and where it takes us next. And Bob’s your uncle.”

The rest of their dinner conversation danced around the dreams they had shared, and Brooke was amazed – and a bit nervous – at just how much Will remembered. His mind was clearly made for detail. He recalled the silly things they had done as children, the tricks he used to perform for her, and she found herself wondering if he had connected to her in the same way back then.

Her face warmed thinking of it, and thankfully, he hadn’t noticed, continuing to chat about the tricks he still did in his show. She was delighted to know he was still doing the Rising Lady – it was by far her favorite card trick. He seemed pleased by that.

They kept the conversation light, without venturing into the people-you-have-dated-before territory or the wow-so-you-think-you-are-an-element discussion. Brooke decided she was fine with that for now, especially since she didn’t want to share the dirty details of her past, no matter how curious she was about his. Besides, the Will she was getting to know in reality could very well be different than the man she knew in her dreams.

Will paid the tab and helped her with her backpack, placing his hand on the small of her back as they made their way to the front of the restaurant. He held the door open for her and reached for her hand as he joined her outside on the sidewalk.

Brooke liked the way his hand felt in hers, like it belonged, and when she looked up at him, he gave it a gentle squeeze. “Now where to?”

Three little words with so much hope and potential, but at the same time, raising so many red flags for her. *Too soon, too soon!* her brain chanted. *Go for it! You*

know him! All her other parts argued. Her brain, as usual, won out, and her decision was made.

“I really need to go home tonight, Will.”

She didn’t miss the disappointment in his eyes, which she was positive reflected in her own as well, but things were getting a bit too cozy, and she needed a break to regroup. Her emotions were in a constant state of upheaval around him, and if she was going to wrap her head around what was happening in a logical way, they needed to spend time apart.

“Tara and I were going to meet at my place. We haven’t had a girls’ night in a while.” They walked slowly hand in hand around the corner toward her car as she continued, “You know, painting toenails, drinking wine, watching chick flicks.”

“Okay, okay, I get it,” he chuckled. “Girls’ night it is.” He grabbed the keys and unlocked the passenger door to load her backpack before following her over to the driver’s side. Just as she grabbed the handle of the door to open it, she felt him tug on her hand, causing her to turn around in place and face him.

He took a step forward, and she stumbled back, feeling the car up against her back as her eyes met his. His rich voice covered her like chocolate on a cherry. “I do know what else goes on during girls’ nights, you know.” He rubbed a lock of her hair between his fingers, and she nearly swooned.

Heart racing and brain turning to mush, she could hardly hear what he was saying over the *Halleluiah Chorus* being sung in her head. She managed to tone it down long enough to squeak out, “And what would that be?”

“You know...girl talk,” he said with a grin.

Lord, the damage the man could do with a smile!

Her stomach felt like she had swallowed a bowl full of goldfish, and she feared they wouldn’t be alive long as she felt the heat rise from her feet to her head in

2.2 seconds. *Is it hot in here? Wait a minute! We are standing outside! Is he doing what I think he is doing?*

As he moved in closer, his face mere fractions from hers, she heard a small voice squeak, “What are you doing?”

He hesitated slightly at her question, raised his eyebrows and grinned, never breaking eye contact as he answered her quietly. “Giving you something to talk about. Is that okay?”

“Yes,” she answered on a sigh. There was no way she was telling him no. “Yes, it’s okay.”

“I hoped you would say that.”

Time stopped as he moved in slowly, touching his lips on hers. As Will lifted his hands to cradle her face, he pulled back slightly as if to assess if he could go further – testing the waters, so to speak. It didn’t take him long to figure out the waters were fine, and he jumped in, angling his head slightly and closing his fathomless eyes as he deepened their kiss.

The humming vibe of his palms on the sides of her face was electric, sending pulses to the back of her skull as one hand slid up from her cheek to cup the back of her head. Brooke’s hands found their way to his shirt, one resting lightly on his hardened abs while the other snuck around the side to his back like it had a complete mind of its own. As he slid his other arm down, pulling her tighter against him, she couldn’t help the sense of belonging. As if she were born for his touch. *Her* hand crushed between her chest and the rock-solid wall she was being held in place by, she tried to determine if the throaty moan she had heard had really come from her. Whoever it had come from didn’t matter, since the kiss went from zero to sixty in a matter of seconds.

She lost all conscious thought as he pushed her toward the car, begging her mouth open with his tongue. She matched him stroke for stroke. His hand was

warm on her ass, turning her insides to jelly as the dream feelings she had for him flooded her reality.

He pulled her hips forward as he pushed his toward her, wedging her between the door and his hardened length. She felt him with every inch of her body. Oh Lord, she needed this... She wanted this... And every hesitation she had ever had about where they were heading went completely out of her head. She embraced him in the depths of her soul.

His urgency slowed, and he came up for air, his lips leaving hers as he nibbled down to the crook of her neck. Every single nerve ending in her body was a tingly mass of desire – she was nearly shaking with it. It had provided way more of a connection than anything she had ever experienced with him in her dreams. Brooke's hands gravitated to his neck, tangling in his hair as he kissed her tender skin. She felt the gentle tickle of his whiskers rasp against her neck as he whispered into her ears.

“You drive me crazy, you know that, right?” He didn't wait for her response, just met her lips with his for a shorter, but no less passionate kiss.

Brooke's legs were like rubber, and she was glad he didn't step back when he finally stopped. It was pretty apparent his body was the only thing holding her up, and she had no problem with that. They stood molded together, cocooned in their special moment, and there was no denying who he was to her. Brooke saw the boy she fell in love with, in the warm glow of the eyes of the man who stood before her, and she was hopeless to lose her heart once again.

Will put his forehead to hers, which was almost more intimate than the kiss they had just shared. It was a sweet gesture that tugged at her heart strings, and it was becoming more apparent that she was a goner.

He spoke softly, his deep voice rumbling against her chest as one of his hands made their way back to cup her cheek. “Have fun tonight, Angel, and be safe.” As his thumb caressed her cheekbone, he looked at her as if seeing her for the

first time. He took a noticeable break from the intimacy by kissing her nose before giving her a soft peck on the lips.

She missed his warmth almost immediately as he took a step back from her and took a wobbly step to the side.

“I will, you too.”

He opened the car door, helped her to her seat, and closing it gently, knocked on the glass for her to roll her window down. He ducked his head in, giving her one final kiss before making his way to his car. As she pulled away from the curb, she decided driving away from him was one of the hardest things she had had to do in the longest time. Tara owed her big time.

elle

Chapter Sixteen



The Shadowman watched as a rainbow of oils seeped from the broken glass that littered his room and wicked into his stone floor like water into a sponge. His anger had been palpable, his rage intense, as it took control of his arm and sent his potions flying upon entering the room. Nothing had been spared from the red haze of his fury, and after it was spent, he realized what it had cost him. He would have to get another pendulum, among other things.

Breathing heavily, he willed himself to calm his emotions. He could ill afford to lose control, knowing that it would not benefit him in the slightest. But he couldn't help himself. Things weren't going according to plan, and the frustration ate at him like a parasite. As much as he hated to admit it, he needed help, and he needed it fast.

It was becoming all too apparent that Brooke's powers were growing rapidly, even without the merging of the elemental portal. Her bond with the Mage, Will he believed she had called him, had ties that even he couldn't break. The battle they had last night made that clear. His body was still vibrating with the current Will had crippled his essence with. He hadn't felt his shade since.

He had never felt so impotent, and it irritated him that a mere novice could have that strong of a spell at his disposal. The effects of the lightning traps Will had hit him with had been powerful at first but were now weakening to the point where he could shake them. Even so, he would need to prepare a few days before attempting to see her. He would not be caught unawares again.

In order to get hold of the journal and with it, Brooke, he had to somehow, someway, ensure they all ended up in the same dimension. Since it was impossible for him to fully manifest in theirs without the secrets in the book, the only other solution was to bring her to Wisteria. Even though he himself couldn't write in the Elemental Journal, he knew someone that could. He didn't care if he had to make a deal with the devil. He needed to capture the element and get that blasted book here.

The heat of his anger warmed his face with the realization that the things he would need to do next would haunt him forever. He hadn't been prepared to ask for favors that threatened his very manhood, but he had run out of ideas. That he was desperate enough to consider this as one of his options told him he had completely lost his mind.

elle

Chapter Seventeen



Brooke's girl's night with Tara was fun, and after painting toes and watching their favorite Rom-Com, they called it a night. Tara didn't stay, she had promised to go somewhere with her folks in the morning. And although Brooke didn't really want to be alone, she thought it would be best if Misty stayed one more night at Will's. The construction workers had yet to put the final touches on the front door, and she didn't want to worry about her getting out. She had a few more things to do, and she felt it was time to start getting used to being in her flat again.

After pouring herself a glass of wine, Brooke took it to the bedroom and set it on the nightstand. She slid on one of her freshly laundered nighties and looked at herself in the mirror, admiring the way the fabric hugged her skin. She wondered if she should have worn it at Will's. Maybe Tara was right. Maybe she should start living a little and taking chances. *But what about Trina?* The little voice in her head squeaked.

She sighed, lifting the journal from her dresser and slid under her crisp sheets. Oh yes...it felt really good to be home, but her nerves were still jumpy. She took a sip of her wine to calm them and tried not to let the lonelies set in. She had

been thinking about Will off and on the entire night and couldn't even cuddle with her cat. It would be a long night.

Brooke had just started to decipher the last paragraph of the portal page when she heard her phone vibrate. She tried not to let the smile on her face crack too wide as she looked at the text on her screen from Will.

You Up Angel?

Her smile widened if that was possible. She absolutely loved it when he called her that both in and out of her dreams. Her heart raced as she answered him with a text of her own.

Yup, just got to bed doing a bit of reading...you?

Just messing with my cards...can't sleep. Can you talk?

Brooke hesitated enough to get a follow-up text from Will.

It's okay if too late, I understand.

Not too late, would love to talk :)

No sooner had she sent the message, her phone started to buzz, showing an incoming call from Will. "Hello?"

Will's rich voice sent ripples of desire straight down to her hot pink toes. "Hi, Angel, you have a good time tonight?"

"I did, it was really nice to hang out with Tara. How about you? What have you been up to?"

"Not much, been working on designing a new illusion and practicing some sleight of hand. Misty has been keeping me company on the couch. She was looking for you earlier."

"I think the construction will be done tomorrow, so I should be able to bring her home then. Thanks again for letting her stay another night."

"Not a problem. You make any more progress on the book?"

She scooted herself down to get more comfortable, a small sigh escaping as she nestled down in her pillows. "I was just getting to it when you texted."

“Hope it has some answers.” She heard his soft expulsion of breath as if he were getting comfortable as well.

“So, you and Tara talk about anything exciting?” The playful note in his voice was hard to miss, and a smile curved on her face as she answered him.

“Oh no! That’s for me to know and you to find out... I don’t kiss and tell.”

“Good to know,” he chuckled. “Since I plan to repeat what happened this afternoon a lot more.” His voice got deeper and a bit more serious, “What color did you paint them?”

“Excuse me?” She laughed at his complete change of topic, knowing exactly what he was referring to.

“Your toes... What color did you paint them? Isn’t that one of the things you were going to do with Tara?”

“Hotsie Totsie Pink,” she answered with a smile. Lord, he made her feel beautiful even over the phone.

“Can’t wait to see them.” Misty’s vibrating purr came over the phone line loud and clear.

“Didn’t know you were into toesies,” she joked as she shifted the phone to the other ear.

“Only when they are painted Hotsie Totsie Pink and attached to a certain bookstore salesclerk that just so happens to embody the element of water.” His deep voice warmed her as he posed his next question. “What time tomorrow did you want to come get Misty? Maybe we could work some more on the book.”

Brooke thought for half a second she should attempt to play hard to get, and it took another half a second to completely dismiss that idea and answer him.

“That would be great. I happen to have the day off and could come by anytime.”

“Sounds great, how about now?”

Brooke couldn’t help but laugh, and the fact that she was lying in bed and feeling all shades of gorgeous made it come out all husky and soft. She pictured

him lying there and thought about the tone of her voice and how it might affect him. If it was half of how his voice affected her, he would be in for a very long night.

“How about tomorrow at 11? I can bring lunch, and maybe we can hang out on the beach.”

“Deal,” he answered simply. “Goodnight, Angel, sweet dreams.”

After Will’s call, Brooke did manage to make some more headway with the translation, albeit the progress was slow with the buzz she had going. She found a page number referenced within the text on the portal page, and since the pages weren’t numbered, she counted each page from the front of the book until she got to what she assumed was the 60th page.

What she saw there looked vaguely familiar, even though the page was written in a completely different language than what she had transcribed earlier. The drawing caught her attention. It depicted a moon-shaped cliff of some sort, surrounded by small creatures that looked to be fish or a variety of sea animals. *Does this mean it’s beneath the water? A moon-shaped crater surrounded by water... Where have I seen that before?*

It came to her in a blinding flash, and she knew she was on to something based on the chill running up and down her spine. The picture was familiar to her because she had spent the last six months planning out the next dive that would take her there. She knew she had to be looking at the Molokini Crater just off the coast of Maui, and as she looked at the language again, it dawned on her she might be looking at a unique form of Polynesian. The script was faded and hard to read, but three words darkened before her eyes as she stared at the page... Hele Mai Wai.

She dropped the book as if it burned her, grabbing her laptop and pulling up the sights she had been researching for her trip. Sure enough, the pictures of the

crater matched the drawing on the page. Her hands shook as she searched the internet for a site that would help her decipher those three small words.

She spent the next hour reading as much as she could about the history of the Polynesian gods and goddesses and translating the words as best as she could with the limited number of resources she had found. The language was ancient, almost to the point of being completely extinct, but she managed to decode a message she knew deep down was meant for her. She looked back to the page and now saw the words for their true meaning. Simply translated, they were, “Come Water.”



Brooke woke the next morning, and although she could use the caffeine, she wasn't sure brewing a pot of coffee was worth the effort. Her head was splitting from the wine she had the night before and what she needed was an aspirin. She poured herself a glass of orange juice and set it on the counter before looking for ingredients to make a picnic lunch. She was irritated to find that she would have to run to the store. She was completely out of things to make a decent spread, and what was available looked like a science experiment gone bad. She shut the door with a huff and glanced over to her juice which bubbled merrily in her glass.

Brooke watched in fascination as the liquid churned and rippled, much like the pain in her head, and wondered for a moment if the two could be related. At this point, anything could be possible. The sides of the glass were cool to the touch, but the bubbles inside increased their movement when her hands were near. She wondered what would happen if she concentrated.

She placed her hands on either side of the glass, taking in a deep cleansing breath and closing her eyes. The vision that came to her mind was the pond she often dreamed of – not the surroundings, but the water itself. She saw the small

rippled movements on its surface and imagined the water as flat and mirror-like. When the picture in her mind was completely still, she opened her eyes and looked in the glass, confirming what she already knew. The juice was completely calm.

She sat for a minute on a nearby chair, wrapping her head around what had just happened. Had she really just controlled a liquid like she had in her dream with Will? She tried concentrating on the glass again, this time imagining the water moving, but there was no change. Brooke even went to the glass and put her hands on either side but nothing. The power seemed to be sporadic, at least for now.

Brooke made quick work of getting ready, and on the way to Will's house, stopped at the grocery to pick up ready-made items for their lunch. The containers fit easily into her picnic basket in the back seat, and within minutes, she was back on the road. Since she had been so intent on checking out the bubbling juice, she had forgotten to take any aspirin, so her headache was worse. She was second-guessing her purchase of a bottle of wine.

As the darkened skies followed behind her, she frowned at the overcast sky. "Of course, the weather would be lousy," she grouched. She had really been looking forward to a day on the beach with Will and had just made it through his front door when the flood gates opened, and the torrential rains came pouring down from the sky.

Will greeted her with a kiss on the cheek as he took the picnic basket, laughing at her pouty expression. "Come on, Brooke, it isn't all that bad. You know it could be a lot of fun having a picnic indoors."

She shook her head and laughed as he wiggled his eyebrows wolfishly before making his way to the fridge to grab some sodas. Leave it to Will to make the best of a beastly situation, she thought as she pulled the journal and notebook from her bag and headed to the couch to wait for him. If anything, the rain had

gotten worse as she watched it beat on the patio furniture through the door-wall that led outside.

She was pretty sure that unlike most of the rain in Florida, that this cloudburst was going to last a bit longer than the average 15-30 minutes, and she and Will would have to come up with a Plan “B” for the afternoon. Thankfully, her headache was getting better now that the rain had started.

Joining her on the couch, Will handed her a diet soda and sat close beside her, his firm thigh brushing up against hers. She remembered their kiss, their phone conversation from the night before, and the things he said. She hoped the tingly way he made her feel wasn’t apparent in the dusky light. She decided getting down to business was the best way to control her wayward thoughts about how Will looked without a shirt or the fact that he promised to kiss her a lot more in the future. *Nice!* Now she had something else to hide in the dusky light. She pulled her fleece jacket around her on both sides covering up her girls, who were rising up to say hello through her thin tee shirt. *Yeah, an indoor picnic is really not going to be a good idea.*

Brooke was having a hard time bringing Will up to speed on what she had found out so far while ignoring the sparks she was sure they both felt. It seemed to her that the romantic pull they had acted on the night before dissipated slightly in the light of a new day. It confused her, maybe even disappointed her, but she didn’t allow those feelings to interfere with telling him everything she had found out so far. When finished, she waited for his reaction, holding on to the smallest thread of hope that he would believe her.

“So, let me get this straight. These words that appeared on this page told you to go to Hawaii?”

“Well, not in so many words... But yes, the two words translate to ‘*Come Water.*’ Also, this page is written in a Hawaiian dialect, and the few words I was

able to translate reference a doorway, water, and a crescent moon. I believe what this is describing is the Molokini Crater just a few miles off the coast of Maui.”

She pulled out her notes and showed Will the drawing she had made of the crater. “See, it is in the shape of a crescent, and the drawing shows various fish which would indicate its placement in or around water.”

“Ok, I can see that, but this could be a drawing of anything. How can you be so sure this is sending you to Hawaii?”

“Well, there were also two names. I didn’t know at the time what they were, since I’m not real familiar with the Hawaiian culture, but here they are... ‘Namaka-o-Kaha’i and Pele-honua-mea,’ or Namaka and Pele for short.”

“Ok, those definitely sound Hawaiian,” Will chuckled. “Who are they exactly?”

“Well, that was what was so interesting. Pele was the Goddess of Volcanos, and Namaka, her sister, was the Goddess of the Ocean. They got in a heated dispute over a man, or something along that line, so Namaka was always trying to drown Pele with tidal waves, which, myth has it, ultimately created the Hawaiian Islands.”

Brooke glanced up from the book and witnessed an unguarded moment. Will was smiling softly, the look in his eyes caressing her as he scanned her face.

“You’re really getting into this aren’t you?”

“Actually, I am. I love solving puzzles,” she laughed nervously. “Weird, huh?”

He shook his head, saying, “Nope, I think it is adorable.” He continued with a smile, “Ok, so let’s say that you’re right,”

“Oh, I’m right,” she said with a laugh.

“Ok, so you’re right – you’re always right, and Hawaii is the place to go to check out this Mojo Crater.”

Brooke laughed heartily, “Will, it’s the Molokini Crater, not something Austin Powers would visit!”

“Okay, I get it, Molokini Crater. So, my question would be, why there, and once there, what happens next?”

Relieved he was with her so far, Brooke pointed out a faded symbol on the page in the journal that showed the crater. “I believe this is the area where I will find what is referenced in other pages of this book to the Alchemist Portal. These two squiggly lines here are the symbol for water and are in a location that doesn’t see a whole lot of action as far as dives go, since most of the tourists tend to limit their activities to snorkeling on the inner portion of the crater.”

Will shifted closer, staring at her with a crinkled brow as Brooke continued.

“I believe with what I have read so far, the person that encompasses the element must go through the particular portal that corresponds with that element in order to fully release the powers they have been gifted with.”

“Hold on just a minute. What are you telling me, Brooke? That you’re going to Hawaii to dive to some portal that will take you God knows where to release an unknown power that you’re not even sure of? Something doesn’t sound right. I don’t like it, and I think we should do more research...”

“No, you hold on a minute,” her voice was shaky, and her eyes were filled with resolve as she tried not to let her emotions run away with her. “I have dealt with these dreams, with this horrible being my entire life. He has haunted my very existence, which is now in shambles because he has the bollocks to come after me in broad daylight, and the power to do physical shit he never did before. If I’m going to have any chance of figuring out how to get him out of my life once and for all, I’m going to take it. If it involves going through some portal in the middle of the bloody ocean, then I’m going to do it.”

Will listened to her without saying a word because he knew deep down that she was right. She was stubborn, bull-headed, brilliant, and beautiful – but she was also right. He felt it in his bones. Taking a deep breath and wiping his hand across the scruff on his chin that he had forgotten to shave off, he said softly, “I

get it. I don't have to like it, but I get it. Besides, when you start pulling out the British slang, I know you're serious."

Her smile beamed at him as he reached over and took her hand in his. "I'm going to buy into all of this, Brooke, because as much as I don't want to admit it, I think you're on to something. I might not remember them all, but I remember enough of the dreams we shared to know he's always been after you. I also know from experience that even if he can't physically get here, he can still hurt us. If you have the chance to figure this out, I say you need to take it."

"Thanks, Will, that means a lot."

"You're welcome. What do we do next?"

She paused for a moment, obviously taken aback by the "we" in his sentence.

"Well, it looks like I have a trip to plan. And I have to locate someone on the island that can help translate..."

Will shook his head as he interrupted her, "Oh no... nu huh... wait just a minute. There is no way you're going alone... I'm going with you."

Brooke looked floored. "What are you talking about? You can't just drop everything and go to Hawaii, and who said you were invited anyway?" she said with a nervous half-laugh.

"I'm inviting myself, considering we don't know if and when Dreamcreep is going to show up next, and I think our chances are better at fighting him off if we are together."

Brooke opened her mouth to argue, shutting it about three seconds later when she realized he was right – they would probably be safer together. While she wasn't looking forward to the havoc it would cause her heart, she would have to be crazy to admit she wasn't looking forward to seeing Will run around half-naked in a tropical paradise. Lord, what was she thinking?

Will got up from the couch, just as the thought she needed more space flicked through Brooke's head. While he seemed dead set on going with her no matter

what, he also seemed smart enough to give her some breathing room to calculate him into the equation.

He busied himself in the kitchen, giving her time to mull things over. After a few minutes, he came back into the living room with the lunch Brooke had brought with her and set it on the coffee table. He pulled a couple of blankets from the couch and laid them out on the floor, creating a picnic area. He swept the basket from the table, placing it on the blanket, and plunked next to it as he opened the lid and rummaged around to see what she had packed. He looked up with a wink, pulling out the food containers and spreading out the feast as he waited for her to join him.

A quick glance out the window told Brooke what she already knew – the rain was here to stay. Resigned to the fact that they would be eating indoors, she stood up and took a few steps forward to join Will on the floor. He held out his hand and tugged her gently to the place beside him where she could sit with her back up against the recliner. He found the bottle of wine and was looking for the corkscrew, which she pulled from the elastic strap on the inside of the picnic basket's lid.

“You thought of everything,” he said with awe as he took the corkscrew she offered, brushing her hand with his and sending a quick jolt of awareness to her core. It was impossible to imagine, but his eyes were bluer than she had ever seen them. She felt the heat of his stare, her body reacting as if he was undressing her with his mind. As quick as the moment began, it was gone again as he lowered his eyes to work on opening the bottle of wine.

Disappointment rang in her voice for more than one reason, “Yeah, well, too bad the weather isn't cooperating.”

“Well, why don't you do something about it, Aquagirl?”

He switched gears flawlessly from the I-want-to-take-your-clothes-off-Will to the easy going and good-natured Will, and she felt that talent was somewhat of

an art form. She got into the mood quickly, her voice taking on a playful tone.

“Oh, so it is going to be like that now is it? Well just you wait, ‘cause your nickname is coming next, and it is going to be a doozy.”

“Doozy? Is that a technical term?” he laughed as he handed her a glass of Shiraz.

“As a matter of fact, it was one of the names I was considering for you,” she responded with just the right amount of sass.

As they ate lunch, they chatted about the trip and the things they would need to do in the next few weeks to prepare Will for the dive. While she could share the basics with him, she was not a qualified dive instructor yet so needed to arrange for him to take some online as well as some one-on-one training. She knew he would be in good hands with Ray, who was a Master Scuba Diver. He was certified with the Professional Association of Diving Instructors and had been a PADI instructor for more than fifteen years.

She had gotten to know Ray pretty well during her certification process and had made all her purchases through him ever since for any supplies or equipment she needed. He was also a great resource for information on a multitude of dive sites since he had practically been to them all. Over the years, they had become really good friends. Will would be in good hands.

Will seemed excited to learn all about scuba and peppered her with questions about her past dives, which she was glad to share. They spent the next few hours talking about the things she had seen during her travels and the places she had been. She promised to bring her album the next time she came over since she had some great photos, and he seemed genuinely interested in seeing them.

She had never really known anyone to share that particular interest with, other than Ray, so had always planned her vacations around diving with tourist groups. Since the buddy system was extremely important in diving, she could be easily coupled with another person if she traveled that way.

She thought it would be interesting, not only having her own “buddy” with her but also going to a less populated area in search of the portal. To be with just one person in a quiet ocean full of fish was going to be very different from diving in a group.

As much as the experience intrigued her, the thought of wandering off with a newly certified diver made her nervous, especially considering the area they needed to check out was called “*Edge of the World.*” She wasn’t sure what they would find going over the edge, or if what they were looking for would even be there, but she was comforted to know that no matter what happened, Will would be with her every step of the way.



Chapter Eighteen



After signing Will up for diving lessons, the next several days worked into somewhat of a pattern for Brooke. She would work in the mornings, fitting in research in the journal, then spent most afternoons with Will, going over what he had learned in class and helping him study for his upcoming tests. While she was away, Will had ample time to work on the online curriculum the class required, and she was tickled over his enthusiasm. In the meantime, she had been attempting to recreate what had happened with her juice in her kitchen but hadn't had any luck.

Ray had her tag along on the days that Will was doing his confined water dives, so she could get in the pool with him and practice emergency techniques they hoped they'd never have to use. Ray felt it was important for them to do as many dives together as possible before they left, so they would be familiar with each other's body language and be able to communicate easily if something went wrong.

For as much of a practical joker and ceaseless flirt that Will tended to be, he was extremely dedicated and serious when it came to honing his diving skills. He made sure to pay the utmost attention during the lesson and was a quick learner.

He was an engaged student and asked a lot of questions, which allowed Brooke the opportunity to see a more humble and sweet side of him. As much as she wouldn't mind getting to know him in the biblical sense, she had to admit the gentlemanly side of him was a huge turn on as well.

The more time she spent with Will, the more she found herself impressed by who he was as a person. Most men she had known in the past would have acted like know-it-alls and never asked for her opinion. But he never acted as though he was intimidated by her knowing more. She felt like his equal, and that was something that spoke to her heart.

Will completed as much of the schooling that he could on-line and had finished up the last of the confined water dives. One of the final things for him to complete were the open water dives with the instructor. They were starting those the next morning.

Brooke had gone over to Will's after class, and while he ordered pizza, she double-checked his gear to make sure it was ready for his big day. Satisfied that everything was in its place, she made her way to the couch and tucked her feet under her as she waited for him to join her.

He startled her as he hopped over from the backside of the couch to land right next to her. "They said they would be here in about 20 minutes, and I hope you're hungry 'cause I couldn't decide on Pineapple and Ham or Supreme, so I got one of each."

"One of each works for me," she answered. "I'm starving!"

"Perfect," he said in a tone that almost sounded as if he were talking about something else. Then he visibly shifted gears, snatching the Baoding Balls from the coffee table and twirling them in his right hand.

"Since we have our flight and the hotel booked, I thought we could talk about other things you might want to see while we're there," said Brooke. "We should have time for site-seeing."

Will shrugged while keeping the balls balanced in his hands. "I'll pretty much do anything. Is there something you want to see? Other than the crater that is."

"I had a few ideas," she answered. "There's a great botanical garden I would like to tour, but the lavender farm looked interesting as well."

"Let's do both," he said with a shrug. "I'm honestly just pumped to be spending time with you."

Brooke flushed at his nonchalant comment and glanced his way. He was so focused on his hand exercises it seemed as though he didn't realize what he had said. She was looking forward to spending time with him as well but kept the thought to herself.

"It amazes me how you can keep them all going without dropping them."

"It's easy. You want to give it a try?" Without waiting for an answer, Will stopped twirling the balls and reached over to pull Brooke into the space between his legs on the couch. He snuggled up behind her, raising her arms with his and placed the smooth crystals in her right hand.

"Your hands are a bit smaller." She felt the tickle of his breath on the side of her neck as he took one of the balls back. "Maybe we should start you with two."

He placed his right hand, palm up under hers and started to wave his fingers one by one as if to give her a massage, moving the balls in a rotating pattern in her palm. His face was close, just over her shoulder near the side of her head, making it hard for her to concentrate. His left hand snaked its way around her waist comfortably, like it had every right to be there, and would have been fine, except for the gentle circles he was lazily rubbing on her stomach.

She was glad he was helping support the crystals in her hand since she was having a hard time holding them steady with Will cocooning her against his rock-hard body. Brooke closed her eyes and leaned back to enjoy their combined heat, melting into his chest and letting out a whispered sigh.

She felt him tighten his grip around her waist, pulling her closer, and relished the warm, soft feel of his lips on the back of her neck. She smiled with her eyes closed, allowing the glow of feeling special to infuse her, and her next comment came out husky and soft.

“You do realize it is impossible to concentrate with you doing that?”

She felt the rumble of Will’s chuckle on her back, “A good magician needs to be prepared for any distraction, you know. The show must go on.”

“I highly doubt this is the type of training magicians get, Will,” Brooke said with a smile and glance over her shoulder, stopping the rotation of the crystals. His eyes warmed her, and she felt his smile on the back of her shoulder. She had never seen anyone more wickedly handsome in all her life.

He answered with a quick lift of his eyebrow, “We magicians are trained in all sorts of things. I have a lot of tricks I could show you.”

Brooke laughed aloud. “I just bet you do!”

They laughed, diffusing the moment and not addressing the attraction they both felt. She was torn between two feelings, one of wanting to stay wrapped in his arms forever, and the other to hold him at arm’s length. A few seconds later, the doorbell rang, which took the decision from both of them, prompting Will to shift Brooke off of his lap to go take care of the pizza delivery.

While Will was arranging their meal in the kitchen, Brooke tried spinning the two balls in her right hand and was pleasantly surprised to see she could do it on her own. Feeling a bit sure of herself, she switched them over to her left and found out very quickly it wasn’t nearly as easy as he made it look. After placing the balls back in their bowl on the table, she made her way to the kitchen to see if there was anything she could help with. By the time she got in there, he had already set the table and had the pizza opened up to grab buffet style.

After dinner, they decided on a movie. Brooke needed a break from attempting to unlock the secrets of the Elemental Journal, which had been one of the

phrases she found within the pages recently. She picked out what Will deemed a “chick flick,” which he agreed to watch only after she promised that she would snuggle on the couch with him. He, in turn, promised to be on his best behavior. He lay behind her on the couch, and she cuddled her backside against his warmth with a light blanket over the both of them. Her head rested on a pillow, and she leaned into his chest, so he could see the television over her. She remembered a time years ago, during a dream they shared, lying in much the same way on a soft mound of grass at the edge of a waterfall. She had told him about her parents and then crumbled into his open arms, rushing toward the comfort he offered. After the tears were spent, and he had lowered them gently to the grass, there was no conversation, no adventures or Shadowman. At that moment, it was just the two of them with no sounds between them, but the rush of the water.

She remembered a feeling of peace wash over her that only he seemed able to give her and wondered, after all this time, what he had been thinking as she lay there in his arms. Her mind shifted back to the present, and she couldn’t help the chant in her head, repeating with every stress-free breath that she exhaled...*I wish I could stay like this forever.* His husky voice broke the silence and stopped the thoughts in her head.

“I’m sorry about your parents, Angel.”

His statement surprised her, and she twisted to look up into his sincere eyes. “It was so long ago, Will, but thank you. If you don’t mind me asking, what brought that up?”

“Lying like this brought it back to me. I remember holding you near the water, watching a waterfall. You told me you had lost them, and I remember feeling helpless as you fell apart. It was so hard for you, and I just didn’t know what to say then. Your heart was breaking, and I didn’t know what to do.” Will’s voice cracked a bit as he finished his thought. “I remember it just about killed me.”

Brooke felt her eyes brim and touched her lips to his in a soft kiss to ward off the tears. That he remembered, touched her heart – that he shared how he felt about it, filled it. “You were there for me when I needed you most, Will, and I have never forgotten that.”

Thankfully, he tugged her closer to him and rested his head against the side of her face. She wasn’t sure what to do with all the emotions stirring around in her chest. “It’s important you know that I’m here for you now.”

She rubbed the arms holding her, giving them a gentle squeeze before answering softly. “Thank you, Will, that means the world to me.”

The decision was made. Her mind, soul, and heart were his.



Chapter Nineteen



The next day, Will stood at the end of the pier breathing in the salt air, listening to the soft lull of the waves as they hit the pilings and lapped against the side of the boat. The morning sun reflected on the small ripples making their way toward shore and sparkled like her eyes when she laughed at one of his jokes.

He understood her affinity to the water, inspiring as it was beautiful, and soothing to the soul. Standing there that morning, he realized he would never be able to look at the ocean again without thinking of her, and somehow, he was comforted by that thought.

Ray pointed toward the shore and said something Will missed as he started to untie the boat from the bollard. Will's head followed Ray's finger and couldn't help the grin that spread across his face as he watched Brooke make her way up the pier toward him. *She's so damn beautiful.*

"Good morning. Gorgeous day for a dive," she said smiling.

"Weather is great. I hate to admit it, but I think I'm a bit nervous."

"You'll do great, Will, it will be a piece of cake." She laughed, and her excitement was contagious. "You have all your gear on board?"

“Yup, should be all set,” he answered as he took her bag and handed it back to her after she got on the boat. He stepped in behind her and nodded to Ray that he was ready.

Ray released the last of the ropes and hopped in, giving Brooke a quick wink before revving the motor, backing out of the dock and taking off along the crystal clear water to one of their favorite spots for Will’s first open water dive.

Since Brooke had completed almost all the required courses to be a Certified PADI Instructor, Ray was fine with staying up top with the boat. He felt because they would be making the dive together it was more important that Brooke go through the exercises with Will below the surface.

Will caught on quickly, and they made short work of practicing the air sharing techniques and emergency protocol he had learned in earlier classes. There were four more dives that needed to be completed before their flight the following Saturday, and Ray was being really great about accommodating their tight schedule. They completed everything that was required for the first dive before their time was up, and they had to make their way back to the boat.

Brooke knew Ray was fitting them in around his regularly scheduled classes so kept her eye on the clock to be sure he got back in time, which he did – with 10 minutes to spare.

They unloaded their gear, putting the tanks into Ray’s SUV for him to refill at his shop while they each loaded their equipment into their cars and slid off their wetsuits. Since she had such a short ride home, Brooke didn’t worry too much about changing and just slid a pair of sweats on over her bathing suit.

Ray honked and waved as he pulled out, yelling that he would see them at the same time tomorrow, and took off toward town while Brooke grabbed her purse from the trunk and walked to the driver’s side of her car.

Will caught up with her just as she closed the door. She rolled the window down and looked up at him saying, “So, see you tomorrow then?” They had been

spending a ton of time together, and Brooke needed a bit of a break. Packing would give her a good excuse if he asked, but she hoped he wouldn't, since it wouldn't take much for him to change her mind.

Will frowned slightly before nodding his head and saying, "Sounds good." He took in a breath and looked into her eyes as if to say something, but to her relief, he must have thought against it and simply said, "I had fun today."

"I did too," Brooke answered awkwardly.

He smiled and gave a two-finger wave before heading off to his car.

Misty greeted her at the door and ran right to her wetsuit, which she investigated thoroughly for wayward fish.

"No sushi today, kitty," Brooke laughed as she took her wetsuit into the bathroom to give it a good scrub for the next dive.

After a quick shower, she filled the tub enough to soak her suit, checking for any tears or splits in the fabric as she turned it inside out. After the initial rinse, she worked in a bit of baby shampoo and gave it a final rinse in clean water. She was thankful Ray shared that trick quite a few years ago, saving her countless dollars by not having to buy commercial care products. When she was done, she hung it to dry on the wetsuit hanger always present in the corner of her shower and left the bathroom fan running to take care of the humidity.

As she relaxed in bed, she reviewed her recent theories. One was that they would find the portal on the dive...that it would take them through to another dimension...that the dimension was where the Shadowman was from, and the powers she had been given in her dreams just might become a reality.

She also believed it was possible that if the Shadowman was real, then Sevilla would be as well. She had dreamed of her as a child and hadn't thought about her in years, but Brooke knew if the woman was there, she would help without hesitation.

With her soft-spoken manners, Sevilla had grounded her and provided a loving home she could escape to. She was never one to pass judgment or hold her back from things she wanted to try. Sevilla had given her a perch to leap from and a net to catch her if she fell. Was it a wonder she spent her life insisting her dreams were real?

With all the theories racing around in her head, she clung to a single hope. If all of her assumptions were correct, there would be someone on the other side able to help them find the answers they needed and remove the Shadowman from her dreams forever. If Will and the Shadowman were real, it meant the place she dreamed of was real too. If the portal took her there, she hoped Sevilla would be there to greet them.

Between the dives needed to complete Will's certification, arranging to have Nita cover for her at work and packing for their trip, the rest of the week went pretty quickly for Brooke. She arranged for Tara to watch the cat while she was gone and had readied her bags for the trip. She had kept in contact with Will, mostly through text, and as the days went on, things worked their way back into a comfortable routine.

They cut it close, with Will's last dive the day before they were supposed to leave for Hawaii. Brooke arranged to pick Will up the next morning at 5:00 a.m. to give them enough time to go through security and check gear before their 8:00 a.m. flight. She arrived at his place a few minutes early and helped herself to a warm cup of coffee as he gathered the last of his bags. He had shipped a few of his things home and turned in his rental car since he would be returning home directly from Hawaii. She tried to focus on the time they would spend together, instead of the fact that this vacation represented them saying goodbye.

Brooke watched him as he moved from his bedroom to the front door with the grace of someone who was used to being on stage. His movements were like a

dance. It was going to be a long week, and avoiding sex with a man she was attracted to in her dreams and reality would require a minor miracle.

She was drawn to him – she couldn't help it, having dreamed of him just the night before. He had been attentive to her needs, so loving and warm, and she melted against him without hesitation. Thinking of it now made her heart race, just as it had last night, and she felt the familiar tingle along the back of her neck. Thoughts of him affected her in a way she couldn't deny, and she was saddened that they were only free to pursue their heart's desires in their dreams. The fact that he would be going home soon put a damper on any consideration for taking their relationship to the next step in reality.

If only they could live in the twilight of their dreams, in the tiny moment before the harsh light of reality found them, perhaps they could be happy. Brooke realized by the way he was looking at her and the smile on his face, that he must be remembering the scenes from their shared dream. It had been unbelievably intense, their frustrations exploding in passion and heat. As the scenes flickered in her mind, she couldn't stop her thoughts from wandering into Hotmanland and unwrapping him in her mind like some giant piece of saltwater taffy. She felt her face flush and turned to hide her embarrassment in the menial task of rinsing her coffee cup. It was going to be an excruciating trip.

Will couldn't wipe the stupid grin from his face. He knew by the way she was looking at him, and the intense stuff they did in their dream the night before, that she had feelings for him. Over the past few days, Will had only seen Brooke during his practice dives, and their conversations had been limited. He hadn't been sure where he stood with her, but now he was.

Not being around her on a regular basis had been hell, and he had decided almost the first night that he was being an idiot by not jumping in with both feet. It wasn't as though he could avoid getting hurt – she already had his heart in her hands. He also couldn't imagine spending the rest of his life without her in it, so

he had some decisions to make. Did he want to include her in his nomadic lifestyle and continue with magic, or did he want to provide her something more stable and listen to his parents? He still wasn't sure. All he could do was make a plan and hope to hell she would want to be part of it.

"Brooke, about last night..."

She held up her hand effectively stopping his comment mid-sentence. "Will, you don't need to explain. We can't help what we dream about."

Her face flushed, and she turned to rinse the other dishes in the sink, talking to him over her shoulder. "Are you sure you still want to do this? I mean, it might be better if I go alone. You know, less complicated."

Will's heart sank. She was giving him an out. Was that what she wanted? He struggled for the right words to say, needing more time. Ending things here and now wasn't what he wanted. He hoped deep down it wasn't what she wanted either.

"Of course, I still want to do this. I care about you, Brooke, and I think it's important to see this through."

Will walked up behind her and put his hands on her arms giving them a gentle squeeze. He couldn't see her face, she kept it ducked down and hidden from his sight. "For both of us."

She allowed his touch – that was something anyway – and waited for her response. Still facing away from him, her voice was soft and muffled, "I want to see it through too, Will. I'm just a little confused."

He wished she would turn around, wanting to gather her in his arms. "I'm sorry, Brooke, I don't mean to confuse you. But it's like I've lived two separate lives, and now they're being merged into one. The lines between doing what I have to and what I want to are becoming a little blurred."

Brooke nodded her head slowly as if she understood. Her voice came over her shoulder in a wistful sigh. "I understand, I truly do."

“So, you okay with me going?” Will held his breath as he waited for her response, and after a short time, she nodded and answered.

“Of course. You’re right, we need to get to the bottom of this, and it affects us both.”

“Then let’s go figure this out.”



After sixteen hours, three planes, two layovers, and a one-hour car ride, they finally made it to their destination in Makena, located on the Southern coastline of Maui. Although the trip started out strained, by the time they were two hours into their flight, Will’s easygoing nature had lifted the mood. He spent the better part of the flight teaching her card tricks, and by the time they landed, she was able to pull cards from the bottom of the deck swiftly. He joked that if she got much better, he’d be out of a job.

The tropical resort was lush and would have been way over Brooke’s average daily budget had she not been splitting the cost with Will. Since their trip was relatively last minute and destination-specific, they had to take what they could get when making their reservations. Now that they were here, she was secretly glad they had been limited in their choices since the resort was stunning.

After being draped like royalty with leis made of pink orchids and given an armload of materials explaining the area amenities, they were escorted to their room, which was almost the size of Brooke’s entire flat.

Will took care of the bellhop’s tip as Brooke started unpacking her suitcase into the dresser closest to the bathroom. She was exhausted from their trip but knew she wouldn’t be able to sleep until all her things were put away, so she made quick work of lining stuff up.

Will plopped on the bed closest to the door with a banana from the fruit bowl and watched her with a grin. “Don’t you ever stop moving?” he said as he

finished the fruit in three quick bites and tossed the banana peel on the table beside him.

“If I stop moving, I’ll be done for the night,” Brooke replied tartly from the bathroom doorway. “I’m definitely working on fumes here.” She peeked out the door, spying Will sprawled on the bed and felt her heart skip a couple of beats before it rose up and wedged itself in her throat. Her mind might be confused, but her body sure knew what it wanted.

“You want the shower first?” she managed to squeak as she ducked back into the bathroom.

He really flustered her. It was bad enough that his leg had rubbed hers for practically every minute of the excruciatingly long flight they had taken. But to be stuck in a room with him one bed over, well she wasn’t sure she was going to be strong enough to resist that, especially after their incredible dream sex.

She thought she heard him chuckle before he answered her, which caused tingles in places she was trying to ignore. “You go ahead since you’re unpacked already. Just be sure to save me some hot water.”

She didn’t miss the joke or the belly laugh when she yelled out, “Very funny.”

She took extra time to wash off the trip, especially since the water temp was cooperating. By the time she was done, Will had unpacked as well and stacked their suitcases in the closet. After he went in the bathroom and before she got into bed, she walked over to the banana peel he had left on the table and scooped it up, dropping it in a nearby garbage can. She smiled to herself and shook her head. It was nice to know he wasn’t perfect, since he was definitely not the neatest guy on the planet.

After tidying a few more things, she crawled into bed and closed her eyes with a deep sigh, barely registering the sounds of Will in the shower as she faded off to sleep.

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Chapter Twenty



B rooke woke the next morning to the heavenly smell of fresh brewed coffee and a sexy Will, who held out a Starbucks cup in one hand and a cranberry scone in the other. *Lord, to be able to wake up like this every morning,* she mused, taking the steaming beverage from him.

She murmured a “thanks” and concentrated on drinking the coffee before it turned to ice, deciding nothing was worse than a hot man handing you breakfast when you had a major case of bed head and sweaters on your teeth. She was glad he was gentleman enough not to make a comment about how frightening she looked when she got up in the morning.

Will hesitated a moment, almost as though he were considering something, which caused her to run a hand over her hair. She looked up into his face, which had an expression so tender she considered inviting him to crawl into her bed and spoon the day away. The unguarded moment was whisked away in seconds as Will gave her a wink and made his way to the balcony.

“What’s the plan today?” he asked from the door wall, breathing in the salt air of the ocean.

Relieved that he was going to ignore the attraction between them and get down to business, Brooke answered as she got up from the bed and rummaged through her drawers for something to wear.

“We need to hook up with the contact Ray gave me and arrange for a boat. I would also like to do a re-con dive just to become familiar with the site and what to expect.”

“Sounds great. I’m all yours.”

After Brooke called the Hang Ten Dive Shop for directions, they gathered their gear, loaded it in the rental car, and made the ten-minute trip up the coast.

The retail portion of the shop was small but tidy, and Ray’s contact welcomed Brooke with a bear hug and booming “Aloha” before pumping Will’s hand like a car salesman and introducing himself.

Alan was enthusiastic and friendly – she would give him that at least. She also knew he was probably one of the most gifted and knowledgeable divers on the island since Ray wouldn’t lead her astray. She would bet her eyeteeth he knew him personally since the scuba world was relatively small. Once you made contacts, you had friends for life.

Without getting into details about the dive, Brooke let Alan know they were interested in diving the Molokini Crater and were particularly interested in the area called *Edge of the World*. Alan nodded and asked to see their C-cards, frowning when he saw the date of certification for Will.

“I see you have your AOW Brooke, but *Edge of the World* can be challenging, especially for a newbie.” He nodded toward Will, “No offense, dude.”

“None taken,” Will responded as he shifted on his feet and held his tongue. He let her do the talking.

“I know Will is newly certified, but we have made every dive together, and he’s caught on quickly. I’m really confident in his abilities, and I’m sure if you take us down the first time, we’ll be able to handle it from there.”

Alan looked up into her eyes and gave her a toothy grin. “Any friend of Ray’s a friend of mine. Ok, you got it, Diver Babe. When do you want to get wet?”

Since the jet lag had caught up to them, they made arrangements with Alan for a dive the next morning. As excited as Brooke was to see what was down there, she wanted to be sure they were well rested before they took their first dive. She thought it was humorous that she had to spend the first ten minutes of the car ride defending Alan, explaining that he wasn’t calling her a “babe” and what “getting wet” really meant.

She smiled at Will’s grumblings, saying that she considered being called a “Diver Babe” a compliment since it meant she handled all her own gear and carried her own weight on a dive. The “get wet” phrase was simply what every diver ever wanted to do.

She almost spit out the diet soda they had purchased from the dive shop when Will mumbled it was pretty much what every man on the planet wanted “babes” to do.

She hadn’t had this much fun in days, and it made her realize she had really missed Will’s snarky sense of humor. It probably didn’t hurt that he seemed almost a bit jealous of their dive host, which went a long way to bolster her self-esteem. Alan was cute, but he didn’t compare to Will in her eyes, not even remotely.

After finishing at the dive shop, they decided to take in some sites. Brooke programmed a few locations into her phone that she had come across in some brochures the resort provided. While the GPS was guiding Will to their first destination, she enjoyed the scenery with a serene smile on her face. She and Will had planned out their itinerary during breakfast, knowing full well they might not have time later in the trip to get any sightseeing in, limiting their selections to things Brooke really wanted to see.

For her, seeing a tropical garden was a must, and their travels led them to the Kula Botanical Gardens in Upcountry Maui near the slopes of Haleakala. Walking around the dense, colorful foliage, she was amazed to learn that it was once a live volcano responsible for the formation of the eastern part of the island. Since they hadn't arranged a guided tour in enough advance notice, they took advantage of the lazy pace of the self-guided tour and strolled for a few hours when Brooke heard Will's stomach growl.

"Are you getting hungry?"

He smiled self-consciously. "You heard that huh?"

"Couldn't miss it – sounded like a volcano was about to blow."

"Nice. Well, you never know, that could always happen around here too. Didn't we pass a restaurant on the way here?"

"Pretty sure it was a few miles back, but I'm sure we can find it with my phone."

The Kula Lodge was just up the road, and they were seated promptly on the terrace overlooking the emerald green hills of west Maui. Brooke thought for a moment that it was too bad they didn't come here for dinner, since the sunset would be spectacular.

"What's your theory on what we'll find down there?" asked Will.

Brooke shook her head and shrugged. "I have no idea what to expect, and that's what makes it so hard. I'm not even sure where to start."

"So, we dive and see what jumps out at us?"

"Well, when you put it that way it doesn't sound like the best plan," Brooke laughed. "There are some things you don't want popping out at you, especially when you are breathing through a mouthpiece."

"I can imagine. What's the scariest thing you've had come at you?"

"Me? Oh, I don't know. I suppose a shark."

"Shark?" Will's face turned ashen as he looked at her incredulously. "What were you doing? Did it bite you?"

“No, just startled me. I was taking pictures at the time.” She couldn’t help grinning at his reaction. “You okay, Will?”

“Hell no, I’m not okay,” he snorted. “Not sure I’m ready to see one of those up close and personal.”

“For the most part they are more afraid of you than you are of them,” she soothed. “They tend to leave you alone.”

They went over various scenarios and agreed on what they would do or how they would handle it, especially since they wouldn’t be able to speak during the dive. They were in complete agreement that if they found a portal, they would be going through it together, which relieved Brooke to no end.

“I’m glad you’re here, Will.”

“Me too,” he answered softly. “What’s next for you, after we get Dreamcreep out of your life? Have any plans?”

“I haven’t really thought about it,” Brooke mused. “It has been my focus for so long, I’m not sure what I’ll do. How about you?”

Will shrugged and looked at her solemnly. It was one of the few times Brooke had ever seen him so serious.

“I have stuff at home to take care of, family business so to speak.” He seemed nervous and picked at the food on his plate. “Decisions to make that I’ve been avoiding.”

“Anything I can do to help?” Brooke tried to keep her voice calm and even.

“Will it help to talk about it?”

Will looked up and smiled softly, reaching his hand across the table and covering hers. “I appreciate it, but no, it’s something I need to sort out myself. But thanks.” He shook off the mood and changed the subject quickly, “So, what’s next on the agenda?”

The decision he had to make seemed to be weighing heavily on him, and Brooke questioned if he would ever be able to merge his dream life with the one he lived

in reality. She ignored the thought that he wouldn't and happily changed the subject.

"I have a brochure for the Ali'i Kula Lavender Farm. I thought we could make our way there before heading back to the hotel."

"All right, it's a deal – under one condition."

"Which is?"

"That we don't stay long. It doesn't sound like a place where dudes hang out."

Brooke laughed shaking her head. "Probably not. Fair enough, I promise to make it fast."

Brooke limited the visit to shopping for Tara whose all-time favorite scent was lavender. Will had even gotten into the spirit, once he realized there were other men there, and purchased a small scented travel candle for their room.

Exhausted and deciding they had crammed enough in for one day, they got in the car to head back to the resort. Brooke kicked off her shoes and sighed deeply as she sank into the seat of the car. The satisfied smile on her face threatened to turn into a full-fledged grin when she felt Will's warm hand cover hers. *Perfect day*, she thought to herself as she squeezed Will's warm palm against hers.



The next morning, Alan and his partner were waiting at the end of the pier, coffee cups in hand. "Right on time," quipped Alan. "You need help with your gear?"

Brooke started to shake her head as she heard Will's voice from behind her. "Nope, we've got it, but thanks, man."

Alan nodded. "This here is Steve. He'll be spotting for us today."

Brooke noted that Steve looked a lot like Bradley Cooper, save the long blonde hair that seemed to be a thing with surfers. He shook their hands before dropping into the boat to start the motor while Will helped Brooke load the gear. Once

they were on board, Alan untied the last of the ropes and hopped in, signaling to Steve that they were good to go.

Brooke sat down next to Alan on the boat, leaving Will no choice but to sit across from them with the equipment. She didn't miss the sad puppy dog look on Will's face when he realized she wouldn't be sitting next to him. During their trip to the dive site, Alan explained where the safety items were on the boat and then talked about the history of the Molokini Crater.

"I read the ancient Hawaiians used the crater for fishing and harvesting eggs until World War II?" asked Brooke.

Alan nodded with a grin, seemingly pleased to share information about his culture with someone who was genuinely interested. "That's right, Brooke. When the U.S. entered the war, they used it for target practice since its slim shape was similar to a submarine or battleship. They continue to find casings to this day."

"I hate to hear that, it seems like such a beautiful place, and for it to be ruined is a shame."

"Preservation efforts have been in place since the seventies. We work pretty closely with the Department of Aquatic Resources. They are taking good care of the crater."

The *Edge of the World* was located on the backside of the crater with a much deeper drop off than the opposite side where the majority of the tourists went to snorkel. Steve slowed down to a drift as Alan reached out with a boat hook to grab the pick-up line from the nearby mooring buoy. Once the boat was secured, Will and Brooke dropped a dive flag buoy portside.

Since Steve was staying up top with the boat, Alan wasn't going to have a traditional buddy and stressed the importance of the three of them staying together while they completed their final safety check. They set their watches

and agreed the dive would total 30 minutes before coming topside, and their depth would be no more than 20 meters.

Brooke sent up a small prayer that she would find what she was looking for within 60 feet, otherwise, she wasn't sure what they were going to do. She knew she was already pushing the limit with Will being newly certified, and anything deeper than 20 meters was going to require more training for him, which they simply didn't have time for.

She sat next to Will on the starboard side of the boat and waited for Alan to give the thumbs up signal that he was out of the way. Will was next and gave her a wink as he took a hold of his facemask and leaned back off the boat with a splash. After his head bobbed up and she got the thumbs up from him, Brooke tipped in to join him.

After giving their final thumbs up to Steve, the three of them dipped below the surface and started to make their way toward the crater. The waters were serenely beautiful, filled with a rainbow of fish that slowly swam by as if they had nowhere to be anytime soon.

As they made their way to their desired depth, she glanced back to make sure she was flagged by both her buddies and signaled to them she wanted to tip a bit northeast.

They signaled back "affirmative" and then swam toward the area of the crater she had seen drawn in her journal. She hoped once they arrived there would be some sort of clue on what to do next since she was quickly running out of ideas. After twenty-five minutes of swimming along the crater's wall and finding nothing out of the ordinary, Will touched her arm, pointed at his watch, and then up toward the boat with an apologetic look in his eyes that made her want to cry.



Chapter Twenty-One



Brooke tried not to show her disappointment at dinner that night. If she was being honest with herself though, what the heck had she expected? That a mermaid would flag her over to a secret spot along the crater wall and open a secret passage to a portal that led to another dimension? The whole idea was insane.

Will was being great about it all. She knew he could sense her frustration and true to his nature, tried to cheer her. They had started dinner with a glass of wine, and while Brooke was feeling better, she was considering something a bit stronger when he broke the silence.

“I didn’t think it went all that bad today, and look at it this way, we ruled out where not to look.” She appreciated his efforts.

Brooke shrugged her shoulders before responding, “I’m really not sure what to do, Will, I’m not sure any of this is even real or if it is something I’ve made up in my own head.”

Will placed his hand over hers and gave it a gentle squeeze. “Brooke, I don’t believe for one minute that this is in your head, and I had the burn on my chest to prove it.”

She was doubtful. Much as she agreed with him, she had hit a dead end on the translations and wasn't sure they could trust anyone to help decipher them. Even if they figured out where to go and what to do, they would have to somehow convince someone to charter them a boat without the proper permits and let them take it out without a Dive Master aboard. That certainly wouldn't go over well. She didn't even want to think about what would happen if they didn't come back before nightfall...or at all for that matter. *Definitely time for a stronger drink!*

After a scrumptious dinner and two Aloha Punches, *maybe it was three but who was counting*, Will convinced Brooke to take a break from stressing about the how and why, to concentrate more on enjoying the where.

As they walked down toward the beach to join the crowd gathering for the evening entertainment, she realized he was right. They were in one of the most stunning places in the world, and if she couldn't take a few minutes to enjoy where she was and the person she was with, then she wasn't living.

They found some seats near the stage just as the show started, and she was mesmerized by the simplistic beauty of the native dances, which described everyday things, such as the formation of the islands or how food was gathered.

Brooke was feeling particularly mellow and leaned in as Will put his arm around her and pulled her tight beside him. She made the excuse he was just keeping her upright, but from the pouty looks he gave her earlier as she hugged both Alan and Steve goodbye, she thought perhaps it was more. In her inebriated state, she embraced the idea of Will's attraction to her. She would worry about the implications later.

The dancer that came out to announce the next hula was beautifully dressed in a rustling grass skirt and flowered tank top. Brooke thought the flower leis on her head, neck, wrists, and ankles looked much like piped frosting, especially against the thick, silky chocolate of her long hair. With a fluid elegance, the dancer introduced the next dance as the "*Ka Uluwehi O Ke Kai Hula*" and

explained it translated to “Plants of the Sea.” She said the song described the seaweed and algae that were harvested from the nearby reefs and spoke to the algae’s beauty and sweet fragrance. Brooke didn’t know how algae could ever be beautiful, smiling to herself at the thought.

During her inner musings, Brooke missed what the dancer said. Before she realized what was happening, she was pulled to a standing position by a shirtless man in a flowered skirt and led up on stage. Will was clapping, along with the rest of the audience, a wide grin splitting his face. He knew very well how tipsy she was, and she laughed to herself, hoping she wouldn’t give everyone too much of a show.

A crew of dancers were lined up in front of the other women pulled from the audience, who were all giggling and looked to be in the same boat as Brooke. They were all shown the first few moves from the dance, which were relatively easy since they repeated themselves, and after a few minutes of practice, the music started.

The first stanza of the song highlighted Brooke’s fumbling attempts at copying the moves of the dancer in front of her, but by the second part, she had caught on. All the motions were made with a constant swaying of their hips as they stepped side to side. It was the hand gestures that told the story, and Brooke delighted in the realization they were speaking of the beauty of the ocean.

The first movements placed their arms as if they were searching, one hand at the side of their face with the other extended. The next was describing the sea as both hands made a waving motion up and down, to the right and then the left. The final moves were like a hug, arms held wide, crossed in front of her chest, then blowing kisses as if to say the ocean was cherished and loved. By the end of the chorus, with the audience clapping for them as they made their way back to their seats, Brooke felt a connection to the song she couldn’t deny.

When she returned to her seat, Will was hooting and clapping with an enormous smile on his face.

“I’d like to see you try it, especially after two Aloha Punches!” Brooke laughed as she pushed his arm.

Will chuckled, “Hey, I thought you did great and wasn’t it three?” He lowered his voice, and his eyes softened. “I’m getting a kick out of seeing you relax, Angel. It looks good on you.”

The music starting for the real performers saved her from leaning in toward him and giving him a kiss. It was hard to fight the impulse. She watched with enthusiasm as the dancers performed the hula, hoping she had looked half as graceful as they did. She found herself dissecting each move and piecing together what it could mean. She was glad they had given her a copy of the translated song which enabled her to follow the movements and recognize the importance of the algae that was harvested all those years ago.

The show ended with fire dancers, and Brooke joked to Will that it was his turn to go up on stage. After watching the performance, they both agreed it was a good thing they didn’t call anyone up on stage.

It had been a long day, and after a leisurely stroll on the beach, they made their way back to the room. After changing into her tank top and shorts, Brooke pulled out the journal to look into something that had niggled at her mind since performing the hula. She pulled out the paper with the lyrics, comparing it to the journal, and sure enough, it was there. It was extremely faded, but a reference, none the less, to the plants the song had described.

“Will, I think I found something.”

He came over and sat near her as she pointed to the journal. “Right here, there is a reference to the plants they sang about tonight, so maybe if we find the plants, we find the portal.”

“Are the plants still around? I mean, there are a ton of tourists that come here every year. They could have been wiped out years ago.”

“I’m not sure. I think we should check the web and see if we can find some photos, maybe some research data.” Will nodded, and they quickly got to work.

Once they were able to translate the Hawaiian words into English and then into their scientific names, they were able to locate photos of the plants described in the journal. Brooke was happy to see the plants were not entirely extinct, but she was a little dissuaded that the particular types of plants typically grew in shallower waters.

She didn’t have a whole lot of hope that she and Will were going to find them on the less sheltered side of the crater, but since they had another dive scheduled, she figured she would be finding out soon enough.

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Chapter Twenty-Two



Will left Brooke upstairs packing while he went downstairs and made arrangements with the concierge. He returned their rental car and booked a ride to the dive shop for the next morning. Brooke wanted to be ready for anything on their next dive, so she had been organizing their things when he left the room. They had managed to secure a boat from Alan and would be going off alone in the morning.

Will stayed in the lobby to make a few calls. He especially wanted to check up on Trina to see how she was doing. He wasn't prepared for the crying jag the call prompted and spent the next 45 minutes on the phone piecing together, between sobs and wracking intakes of breath, what had happened over the past few weeks.

He was worried to hear she had been having some pains, and that she had been in and out of the ER over the past few weeks for check-ups. Luckily, the doctors couldn't find anything wrong with her or the baby. She was at the hospital overnight under observation and would be going home the next morning if the tests came back okay.

He managed to calm Trina down by the end of the conversation and spent an additional 15 minutes chatting with Tony, making him promise they would continue to send word.

He went to the flower shop inside the hotel and arranged to have a potted orchid sent to Trina, letting her know on the card that he was thinking of her, and he hoping all was well with the baby. He tucked his copy of the order into his wallet and browsed for a few minutes in the showroom as his thoughts wandered to their phone conversation.

He realized in that moment how precious and unpredictable life was. And although it made him somewhat uncomfortable, found great solace in knowing that he had figured it out before it was too late to take advantage of it in his own life.

After one more purchase at the flower shop, he raced up to the room. He didn't want to wait a minute more to include Brooke in his life, to really truly include her.

While it had been fun being single with no ties and no responsibilities, he knew now he had been missing out on something truly special with someone who could make his life more than he ever dreamed it could be. He had been missing out on what Trina and Tony had found – a true connection and blending of hearts. If he had to change the entire direction of his life to provide for that, he was more than willing to do it.

He knew what he wanted and knew he had found it. Now, he just needed to figure out a way to keep her in his life.

Brooke was seated near the balcony and had just finished her conversation with Tara when Will walked back into the room, looking a bit pre-occupied and somewhat out of breath. She asked him if everything was all right, and instantly, he was the easy-going, light-hearted Will with a trick up his sleeve she had come

to know and love. He pulled out a fragrant flower lei and placed it over her head, draping it across both her shoulders.

She was warmed by the gesture, breathing in the sweet, spicy fragrance of the carnations as she lifted her head to thank him and found his eyes filled with tenderness and desire. She barely registered the warmth of his hands as they cupped her face, and he put his lips to hers.

The kiss said everything neither of them could, speaking to the fears and worries each had in their minds but couldn't voice.

She was tired of fighting against her practical nature and wanted to live in the moment with him. Even if it ended up not being forever, she would rather spend a few moments in his arms than a lifetime without him. Brooke knew she wasn't being logical, that she was throwing caution to the wind, but she didn't care. Her heart was already his. She would embrace the journey and see where it led.

She pushed her body closer to his, crushing the flower lei between them. Molded against the warmth of his body, her hands tugged at the soft cotton of his shirt, pulling it from his jeans and providing a gap to slip her hands up along his spine. She felt the rumble of his moan as he lifted her off her feet and walked her toward the closest bed. The next few seconds were a blur of flying clothes, tongues, and warm skin.

When able to piece together a halfway coherent thought, she was pinned beneath him completely naked, except for the flower lei he had given her. She felt him hard against her through the soft cotton of his boxers. The cool touch of the lei's petals against her skin was in direct conflict with the heat of his touch. He brushed her breast as he lifted the flowers to his nose.

"You're so beautiful, Angel." His eyes were sincere and full of passion. "Like a dream."

His gaze drank her in as he pulled the lei over her head and set it next to her on the bed. She said nothing, afraid of breaking the spell, and chose instead to

answer him with a kiss. Pulling his head down gently toward hers and meeting his mouth halfway, she smiled internally at the catch in his breath and the deepening of his kiss. She liked that he was as caught up in the moment as she was.

Will's touch was electric, the brush of his fingertips against her flushed skin causing her pulse to race. He was murmuring incoherent words against her neck, whispering warmly in her ear as he nibbled on her lobe. Brooke couldn't wrap her brain around what he was saying, his breathy words turned her insides to jelly.

His pace was unhurried, almost reverent, as he dipped lower and lower, his head finally resting over her chest, his warm breath tightening her nipples. He cupped the underside of her breasts, holding them in place as he laved her, revering each in turn. When he finally took her breast into his mouth, Brooke was unable to control herself as her body lifted in the age-old signal of acceptance.

She couldn't breathe, just the slightest touch from him made her quiver. He hadn't shaved, and his whiskers rasped against her tender skin. It excited her to follow the feeling, knowing that where she felt his whiskers, his tongue would follow. Her hands reached to touch him, but he had other plans.

Will placed her arms at her sides and grinned. "You'll have your chance, Angel. Right now, I want this to be about you."

"Having you inside me is all I need," she moaned.

Urgently removing his boxers, he slipped on a condom. His hands were back on her in seconds, rubbing up from her ankles toward the sides of her hips.

Brooke raised her hands again, compelled to touch him, as he hovered over her. It was obvious he had plans of his own, and he lowered himself, so he was eye level with her chest. Reaching out for one of her hands, he occupied it by weaving her fingers in his. His other hand made a trail of feather, light touches down her stomach and toward the apex of her thighs. She involuntarily squeezed

his hand as he cupped her mound and slid his fingers inside. His deft fingers had no trouble finding her sweet spot, and he looked into her face to gauge her reaction.

The jolt was enough to make her feel as though she had lifted herself entirely from the bed, and his chuckle told her that she practically had.

“Mmm, you like that?” he asked, not waiting for her to answer as he lowered his head and slowly took her breast into his mouth. His fingers continued to work their magic, rubbing against her and building up a divine pressure that had her pushing herself shamelessly against his hand. She realized then the Baoding Balls served a secondary purpose for him. His fingers were magic.

“Will, please.”

“Soon, Babe. You’re almost there.”

She was about to lose control. The pressure was building, and her thoughts were jumbled. Brooke was vaguely aware that she had yet to touch him but was so enthralled by what he was doing to her, she forgot to do anything about it.

Energy was flowing to her core, her nerve endings pulsing and raising her awareness. She was so mesmerized by how he made her feel, it hardly registered when he lowered his head to replace his hand with his mouth. After a few seconds of his firm tongue lapping her core, Brooke’s uncontrolled release racked her body in waves of euphoria and forced out a breathy scream.

He must have taken that as his cue because the next thing she felt was the warmth of his body on her chest, and his length nudging her to open for him.

“Oh God, Will, now!” she urged as she pulled her legs up and locked them around his back. He plunged, re-igniting all the nerves that had just blown the top of her head off, sending her over the edge once more.

Brooke had never in her life had an orgasm that quickly in reality, let alone two back to back. Will reached his first climax on the waves of her second, and the connection she felt in that split second was nothing short of mystical.

He remained close, keeping himself inside her as long as he could while gently kissing her lips and cradling her face with his hands.

“Angel, you feel so good,” he said with a smile as he kissed her nose and then nuzzled it Eskimo style. “More amazing than in our dreams.”

“Well, I’m not sure,” she said playfully. “We have done some fantastic stuff in our dreams.”

“Really? Well, I guess we’ll need more practice to live up to your expectations in reality.”

“Will, I’m not sure I can move quite yet,” she laughed. “My body feels like jello.”

“Hmmm, I like jello,” Will whispered as he kissed her neck. “And you don’t need to move, I like you just where you are.”

It only took a few minutes of rest, and a bit of prompting from Will for Brooke to decide she could move after all. Lovemaking the second time was just as intense but slower in pace. They took their time reacquainting themselves with each other’s bodies, making love with each brush of their fingers, each passion-filled word.

After they were spent, Brooke suggested they take a quick shower, which turned out to be a bit longer since Will’s theory had been correct. The hot water did work better when he was in there. If they hadn’t needed to get up so early in the morning, Brooke would have stayed there all night.

Crawling under the covers of the second bed, Will spooned behind her, cupping his hand possessively on her breast and pulling her back toward his chest.

“Goodnight, Angel, sweet dreams,” he whispered softly as he held her tight. She relaxed against him, feeling at home in his arms and fading into a dreamless sleep.



Chapter Twenty-Three



Considering they had no idea what to expect on their next dive, they had made arrangements with Alan to keep their suitcases at the dive shop after they checked out of the hotel. They told him they were on their way to another island after their dive, so he was happy to oblige.

Having something happen, or worst case not coming back at all, was a sobering thought, but as always, Brooke's practical nature had her preparing for any possibility.

While Will was on his run that morning, Brooke had been busy deciding what they could take with them, bringing out some watertight bags she often used. They weren't going to be able to bring a lot and the items they did take would have to be limited to a single mesh bag light enough to dive with.

She had limited their packing to one light change of dry clothes for each of them, one small towel, and the journal, which went into its own waterproof bag that she could slip inside of her wetsuit. It was important that they took that with them since perhaps the portal wouldn't show itself without it. She presumed that was why they hadn't seen it the first time. She spent the next hour adjusting dive

calculations for the added weight and sending out some quick emails. With all her loose ends tied up, she was ready for their adventure.

Brooke decided they wouldn't go as deep on the next dive as they had before, especially since the plants they were looking for preferred warmer waters. Much as Alan and Steve didn't want them heading off alone, they couldn't help cave to Brooke's insistence that they would be careful. She may have told a white lie as well when she said the backside of the crater was a place they would avoid. Alan had a personal boat that wasn't part of the charter that he allowed them to use. And by late morning, she and Will had started out, anxious to search the new area of the crater.

The journal was packed in a bag within a bag, which was slid down along Brooke's thigh in the hopes it would remain dry. She didn't want to take any chances with it in case they somehow lost or misplaced their duffel. She felt it was important to keep it with her at all times moving forward.

After tossing out the dive flag and securing the boat, Will gave her a quick kiss for luck before they secured their masks and prepared to enter the water. They leaned back from the side of the boat, tipping in one after the other, then descended hand-in-hand toward the area they thought would be a good starting point.

She was happy to see coral dotted in a few of the areas that they passed but tried not to get too excited. Although there was vegetation present, there was very little of it, and they might not be in shallow enough water to find the algae.

Brooke waved to Will that she was going up a few more meters. Will swam toward her in response. She pointed to him to stay at their current level and to start searching to the right for the algae while she searched to the left. She didn't have to swim far before seeing a crag in the rock five feet high and at least that deep, surrounded by the varieties of seaweed and algae they had researched on her laptop early that morning.

Unable to get his attention by waiving, she swam to Will, and he turned just as she reached for his shoulder. Brooke signaled for him to follow and turned to swim back to the opening in the crater. As she reached the gap, she felt Will's hand on her arm and turned to look at him, seeing the caution in his eyes. She took Will's hand and kicked toward the opening, releasing it to gently move the plants aside to look for anything on the crater's surface that might be a clue.

The hole in the crater was as dark and foreboding as some of her dreams. She knew such places were the favorite hang outs of all sorts of creatures and hoped she wasn't swimming into the home of a Moray eel or octopus. Startling either one wasn't something she wanted to risk.

Will reached down to his utility belt for a flashlight as she waited at the opening for him to light the way. She held back for him to do a quick sweep of the area. After finding no one in residence, he gave her the all clear signal. Ducking her head slightly into the crag, she swam slowly from one end to the other, Will following with the flashlight.

The jagged surface of the crater allowed algae and coral to cling easily, making it difficult for Will and Brooke to see the face of the rock. The inside wall of the hole was vibrant with visible plant life moving with the same grace and beauty as the hula dancers had. The closer she swam to the center of the opening, the more she felt she was on the right track.

A sparkle along the wall caught her eye, and she motioned back to Will that she would need his light. Before he had a chance to shine it along the surface of the crater, Brooke felt a charge of electricity zap through her body. The tingling sensation from the top of her head to the tips of her toes filled her soul with excitement. She knew before Will had a chance to light the way that they were in the right spot.

Her pulse quickened as his beam moved over the crater's surface between the gentle sway of the seaweed. She swam to the place where she had seen the subtle

glow, and that's when she saw it. Faded like the pages of her journal, but there none the less, was the symbol for water.

She reached out to touch it and felt Will's hand on her leg as he tugged her back slightly. Why was he hesitating? She was mesmerized by the thought that she might get to the bottom of everything strange that was happening to her. The area was somehow more visible, almost glowing as they made their way toward it. When they were close enough to the symbol, Brooke could see it was indeed lit, glowing warmly against the rock's surface into which it was etched.

Will took Brooke's hand before she got any closer, signaling to her he wasn't letting go. They swam together toward the crater wall. As Brooke reached out to touch the symbol, waves of energy pulsed from it, and the crater's surface changed to a mercury-like substance. She glanced back at Will who nodded his support and reached out to touch the shiny silver surface of the portal.

She closed her eyes as the substance covered them completely and then pulled them into its depths. There was absence of light, cold and frightening, and she felt his hand slip from hers. She was alone in the dark...then nothingness.



Chapter Twenty-Four



He must have been knocked out. Will came to consciousness slowly as the ground firmed up beneath him, and he heard a feminine voice speaking his name. He looked to his side and noticed their tanks on the grass beside him. But where was Brooke?

“Willmot, are you able to move? The effects of the portal will dissipate. Sitting up will help.”

“No one ever calls me Willmot, except my Mother,” Will groaned as he reached his hand to his head and let the stranger help him sit up. “Who are you, and where is Brooke?”

As his head cleared, the woman came into focus, and her kind smile told him he had nothing to fear from her. “Brooklyn is doing well. She is still absorbing the effects of the portal and should be with us shortly.”

“Absorbing the effects?” Will’s heart raced, and worry gripped his throat as he looked around. “What do you mean? Where is she?”

As the woman laid her hands on his shoulders and looked into his eyes, his pulse immediately slowed, and his breath was calmed. He was feeling less anxious.

“She has more responsibility, so the adjustment takes longer. It is especially so for the first of four. Brooklyn will be fine, she is just there, in her element.”

He glanced around and recognized the location where he had gone in his dreams, the place where he and Brooke had fought against Dreamcreep. After looking around to be sure he wasn't lurking in the shadows, his eyes followed the woman's finger toward the center of the pond.

Brooke lay on top of a column of water pushing up from beneath her like a fountain, which flowed steadily back toward the surface causing ripples to the water's edge. She seemed to be asleep, held in place by the force of the wave. From what he could tell, she was unharmed.

“Who are you, and what is going on?” Will asked abruptly. “And most importantly, are you friends with the Dreamcreep?”

The woman smiled serenely as she answered. “Erebos, the Dreamcreep as you call him, is no friend of mine of late, and my name is Sevilla. I'm very pleased to meet you finally.”

Will sized her up, noting she was in her late thirties possibly early-forties and had bright-green eyes. Her thick, black hair was pulled up off her neck in a messy bun, and her dress was colorful and gauzy, like the boho style that was so popular in California. She wore very little jewelry – in fact, the only thing he noticed was a necklace containing a large, flat disk the color of her hair.

“How is it that you know my formal name, and what do you mean finally?”

“Although we have never met, I have heard of you and have watched over you in my way,” she answered cryptically, waving to the center of the pond where the water spout shifted and carried Brooke toward them. “Come, we will need to get you both somewhere safe. Even though you have weakened his power, Erebos is a formidable enemy and has allies.”

The wave carried Brooke gently to shore, dissipating slowly until she was resting on the mounded grass near the water's edge. Will immediately went to

her side, placing his hands on her neck, checking for a pulse and laying his head on her chest.

He was pleased to hear the strong steady beat of her heart and squelched the fear in his voice as he spoke to her. “Brooke, are you all right?” He had never seen anything more beautiful than when her eyes finally fluttered open. Relieved, he lowered his head for a brief kiss.

She smiled up at him and cupped his cheek with her chilled fingers. “Hey.”

“Hey yourself,” he whispered softly, giving her one more kiss. “We made it. How do you feel?”

“I feel pretty good – I’m not sure...” she began as he helped her up and raised her head. When she noticed the woman standing beside them, her recognition was undeniable. “Sevilla? Is that you?”

Sevilla’s smile beamed across her face as she pulled Brooke into a hug. “Yes, Brooklyn, it’s me – welcome home.”



Sevilla’s home, as it turned out, was located in the forest just a short walk from the pond. After Will was satisfied that Brooke could walk on her own, they headed into the tree line. He carried their bag, which had made it through with them and walked a few steps behind the ladies, chatting like old friends.

They followed a dirt path near the edge of the woods. It had been cleared over time with its frequent use by travelers and woodland creatures. The forest was dense, and trees rose majestically from the peat covered floor. They created a thick canopy that barely allowed the sun to peek through. There were several trees that had fallen over time, held up by a random boulder or the crook of a nearby log, all in various levels of decay. Some were thickly covered with mosses, mushrooms, and the like.

From the ferns that grew at the bases of the trees or holes in the rotting trunks, small animals scurried from one place to another, watching them as they passed by. Their mannerisms reminded him of a game of hide and seek that he and Brooke had played in the very same woods they were traveling through now. Brooke looked back with a grin, letting him know that she was remembering the same thing. She had always been impossible to find, able to cram herself into the smallest spots in the forest because of her size. He smiled at the newfound memory.

Sevilla led them toward a clearing where the trees thinned, allowing more sun to shine through. As they stepped into the sunlight Brooke's excitement grew, and she pulled the woman into a hug.

"Oh, Sevilla, it looks the same. It's been far too long since I've been here."

Sevilla led her up the path. "I couldn't agree with you more. Let's go inside. I'm sure Wilmot has many questions, and I have much to tell you."

"Willmot?" Brooke said with a laugh as she gave Will a playful look over Sevilla's arm.

"Family name, don't start," he answered with a grin and waved toward the path for Brooke to continue ahead of him.

It had been years since Will had seen a cobblestone house since most of the homes in Vegas were built with a Southwest flair. He was most impressed with the clean and tidy condition of the estate, especially since it looked to be hundreds of years old and similar to what one would see on an English countryside.

There was a well-tended garden sandwiched between the estate and a small stream that cut through the yard toward the back of the property. Creeping ivy in emerald green and shades of scarlet wound its way from the lower half of the building to the second floor, adding to its picturesque beauty.

The stones used in the construction of the home ranged from pale cream to a dark chocolate brown and were like the rocks he had seen dotted on the forest floor. They seemed to be the same as those used to create the stone fence surrounding the perimeter of the property.

“Oh, Will, isn’t it just beautiful?” Brooke gushed as she left Sevilla’s side and took his hand in hers, leading him through the small gateway in the fence. It warmed him to see her so happy, and he took her hand in his as they walked up the stone path toward Sevilla’s home.

Sevilla opened the front door and welcomed them inside, before taking the bag from Will and excusing herself. She went up the wooden stairway just inside the entrance with their bag. Brooke walked to the kitchen, waving for Will to follow. She lifted a small metal strainer from a hook on the wall and took a few mugs down from the cupboard.

Brooke turned to look at him, mugs in hand and relaxation in her face. It was apparent that she loved it here. “I’m going to brew some tea. Care for any?”

He pulled out a chair at the large wooden dining table and made himself comfortable. “Sounds great. Need any help?”

Brooke turned pausing for a moment. “Nope, I’ve got it.” A smile crept across her face, and she took a deep breath. “It’s amazing to be home.”

The kitchen was rustic but at the same time, cozy and neat. There was a large stone fireplace that filled the center of the room, beautifully designed with a thick wooden mantle about head level. The opening was broad, designed for cooking as evidenced by the copper pots hanging from iron hooks secured in the mortar. There were also bundles of garlic and peppers hung from pieces of twine on either side of the hearth. From his vantage point, Will could see an opening behind the flames that showed a room beyond. With the number of books visible, Will assumed it was a library or den.

He watched Brooke in comfortable silence as she filled the kettle from the pump style tap at the sink. Plucking various items from the shelves, she moved toward the fireplace with the tea kettle, hanging it from one of the hooks and using a small lever to swing it over the fire. She must have felt his stare since she turned to look at him with her eyebrow raised, silently questioning why he was staring at her ass. He grinned and shrugged as if to say he couldn't help himself. She was in a wetsuit which left little to the imagination. That look got him a tinkling laugh and a shake of her head before she went back to the counter to prepare the rest of the tea fixings.

After a few minutes, Sevilla came back down the stairs, joining Brooke in the kitchen and directing her comment to Will. "I placed your bag in a bedroom upstairs, first door on the left. Brooke can show you later when you're ready to rest."

Will nodded his head and finally let his curiosity get the best of him. "So, how is it you two know each other exactly?"

Carrying over the mugs and tray filled with tea biscuits, lemon slices, and honey, Brooke joined Sevilla and Will at the table.

"I have known Sevilla for a long time," started Brooke, "since I was a kid in fact. But I thought she only lived in my dreams, just like what I thought about you and the Shadowman. I never imagined she, or even this place, was real. We met shortly after my parents died."

Will placed his hand over Brooke's. "That was a rough time for you," he said quietly.

"It's okay, Will, it was a long time ago. Although at the time, it was extremely hard on me, especially since I was so young. I started dreaming of Sevilla, and she gave me a safe place to come, to talk about things that were happening in my life. Soon, she was so much more than a friend. She became like a mother to me."

Sevilla's eyes brimmed with tears as she smiled warmly at Brooke, "Having you in my life has been a gift. I will always consider you my daughter."

Brooke smiled warmly. "This place was like my home away from home, especially when things weren't going so great in my life, and I needed an escape."

Will nodded in agreement before posing his question. "I think I remember things we used to do and recognized some of the sites, but I don't ever remember this house or meeting Sevilla."

"That would be my doing," Sevilla answered. "Since you're someone that links her to her fate, I couldn't take the chance of us meeting or having you come to this place. When she dreamed of you, I used a spell to hide my presence. Later, when you came back into her life as a man, the spell wasn't necessary, since she didn't come to see me nearly as much."

Brooke felt her face flush. Her attraction to Will had been hard to fight, and she remembered wanting to spend every possible moment with him. She still did. Sevilla was right about her having stopped coming, and Brooke wondered if she had hurt her feelings. It was possible, although Sevilla's eyes only reflected love – just as they always had.

"In some ways, we were fortunate Erebus took such pains to erase your memory. Meeting before this time could have been dangerous for you both, and Brooke accessing her powers without you present could have been devastating for us all."

Brooke rose to get the kettle from the fireplace and walked back to the table, pouring the water over the tea leaves in the strain-lined mugs on the table. "So, what kinds of powers are we talking about and when are they going to show up? And please don't say the ability to turn my hair green and every heated beverage on the planet into an ice chunk are it. If that's the case, you can have it."

Will grinned as Sevilla said with a smile, “I actually like the color of your hair. It matches your beautiful eyes.”

Brooke passed the mugs to each of them with a smirk. “I hope you like iced tea. It won’t be hot for long.” After serving everyone, she sat back down and brought the mug to her lips.

She was surprised when she took her first sip, fully expecting it to be cold, but instead felt the steaming beverage warm her face. “Seriously, Sevilla? Why on earth would the Dreamcreep want what I have? I can’t even control it half the time!”

Sevilla smiled serenely. “Erebos knew you would eventually learn to control the powers of your Element. To gain access to them, he wanted to be present when you went through the portal. He also knew Will would be a threat to his plans, so he chose to erase his memory as a way of controlling where and when you ultimately met. He wasn’t sure if Will was destined to have powers and couldn’t take the chance that in meeting in reality you would activate them.”

Will practically choked on his tea as he responded to her with a laugh, “Powers? My only powers are tricking people into thinking they are seeing something that isn’t actually possible.”

“Illusion is an age-old skill that goes hand in hand with magick,” she said solemnly. “And while you will both learn how to use your powers over time, there are a few of them that have merged with your essence already. For instance, your past ability to balance Brooke, which will allow her to channel her powers. That is a skill that is going to be invaluable to her while she is merging with her Element.”

Brooke stared at her unbelievably, her voice rising slightly. “What exactly is going to happen to us? What other changes will take place? I mean, it’s bad enough I have technicolored hair. Am I going to sprout a tail now too? Or live in water the rest of my life?”

Will quickly got up from his seat and stood behind Brooke, placing his hands on her shoulders. He leaned his head down alongside of hers and whispered in her ear. "Let go of the mug, babe."

"What?" she responded while immediately looking at the mug to see what he was talking about. "Bloody Hell!"

The tea that remained in her cup had come up to a rapid boil, bubbling to the edge of the cup and threatening to spill over. She jerked her hands from the mug on the table and pushed her chair back slightly as Will's hands moved down from her shoulders, toward her elbows, and gave them a gentle squeeze. She was amazed to see the tea settle almost immediately, and when she put her hands on the mug, it was cool to the touch.

Both she and Will looked at Sevilla for an explanation, and true to form, she sat there with her *Mona Lisa* smile and picked up their conversation where they had left off.

"To answer your questions, no...you will not be sprouting a tail, and no...you will not need to live in water. You will, however, always be compelled to live near it, just as you always have. As for what changes will take place, we can look to the journal to find those answers. Were you able to bring it with you?"

"I did, but aren't we going to talk about what just happened?" Brooke questioned as Will pulled a chair up beside her and sat down.

"What happened is you got upset and took it out on that poor cup of tea." Sevilla answered her with a twinkle in her eye. "I'm happy to see Will knew exactly how to balance you." She got up from the table and started clearing the dishes.

"Great, so now I'm imbalanced," Brooke muttered as Will sat next to her and took her hand in his.

"I don't think that's what she meant, Angel. It does seem your issues with water seem to calm down when I'm around though – like you being able to have a hot

cup of coffee when I make it.” He leaned his head in toward her ear and lowered his voice so only she could hear, “Or a warm shower when I’m around.”

Brooke felt her face flame as she looked over her shoulder and thanked her lucky stars that Sevilla had turned her back to them and missed Will’s comment.

“You’re right, Willmot, you’re able to assist Brooke in focusing her energy when she uses her powers.”

What was I thinking? Brooke’s blush deepened, *that woman always had the best hearing. I hope to God she didn’t hear the crack about the shower.* “So, his power is focus?”

Sevilla walked to a doorway under the stairs, answering as she ducked inside briefly to gather some towels and soap. “Over time, he will develop many powers, but the one that is most helpful to you at this time is his ability to focus your elemental power. Since he traveled through the portal with you the first time you did, he is now bound to the powers of water the same as you.”

She closed the closet door and walked over to where they were seated at the table, handing the items to Will as they stood. “We can talk about it more later. Right now, I think you should get cleaned up, get into something more comfortable, and rest,” she looked at Brooke, her eyes creasing with mirth. “If you need help balancing the heat of the water in the tub, I’m sure Will can help you.”

Crap, she did hear him! Brooke turned another shade of red and quickly ran up the stairs, pulling Will behind her.

elle

Chapter Twenty-Five



Something was profoundly different. Erebos could feel it in his bones, and while he was still too weak to control his shade, he wasn't so drained that he couldn't use his scrying bowl to see what the Element was doing. He gazed into the dark liquid and was amazed to see that it reflected only a silvery fog and nothing of the dimension where she came from. That confused him as he pondered all the things that could have happened to create a veil between his world and hers. Each and every time, he drew the same conclusion. She had made it through the portal and was now in his world.

In the next instant, his arm swiped across the table, and sent the bowl flying across the room. It crashed with a pop against the wall. The thick, dark liquid dripped down the stone like molasses and pooled on the floor near the broken shards.

The air thrummed with his hostility, his breath coming in short quick bursts as he tried to slow his heartbeat. His fists were tight, and his nails bit into the skin of his palms. The muscles of his arms shook uncontrollably.

"Impossible!"

This was not how he had planned it. She was supposed to come through with him, and he was supposed to capture the essence of water along with her. Now he would have to make alternate plans, especially if she had come through with the Mage, who was proving to be more of a challenge than originally anticipated.

Erebos braced himself to ask for help from the one person he dreaded seeing more than anyone. He had run out of options. He couldn't delay the inevitable any longer.

"Kadar!" he bellowed, the sound of his voice reverberating through the room and down the halls. "Kadar, come here this instant!"

He paced back and forth like a caged panther, awaiting his apprentice's arrival.

"Here, my Lord," said the hooded figure, calmly awaiting Erebos's command from the center of the doorway. While resigned to do his duty, he oozed a power that was in direct conflict with his subservient position. His face was shadowed, not only by the garment he wore, but by the three days' worth of scruff that lined his cheeks. Anyone that met him would see a man who was not to be trifled with – anyone but Erebos, who foolishly saw him only as his servant.

"I need you to leave at once for Zilla's. It is imperative that I see her. I don't care what you do to convince her to come. Lie to her, bribe her, abduct her if you must, but do not come back without her."

A moment of confusion crossed Kadar's face, but thinking better of the hesitation, he agreed. "As you wish, my Lord. I will leave at once."

Kadar left the room quickly to prepare for his journey and didn't look back. He had learned long ago not to question Erebos's commands or to stick around when he was in such a state, especially after what had happened to the last person who aligned themselves with him. He was unstable, and Kadar had found that being agreeable was the best way to keep tabs on him. Erebos needed to be watched.

He packed lightly and faded into the night to follow his master's command, resenting his duty but realizing, at the same time, that it brought him one step closer to freedom. There were things he had to search for as well. So far, he hadn't had any luck, but he wasn't one to ever give up hope.

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Chapter Twenty-Six



Will tried not to laugh as Brooke paced around their room at Sevilla's. "I'm not sure what you're so upset about," he said with a smirk. "It's obvious she knows we're together. She put us in the same bedroom."

"You don't understand. She's like my mother!" Brooke said with hands covering her face. "I can't believe you told her we showered together!"

Will laughed as he came up behind her and put his arms around her waist, resting his chin on her shoulder. "I didn't tell her, Angel – I was whispering that to you." His voice immediately calmed her. "Besides, we aren't going to be able to do that here now will we? I mean, considering there's no shower only a tub?"

Brooke rested her hands on his and leaned back into his embrace. "What am I going to do with you?"

"If you need help coming up with ideas, I can give you a list," he chuckled softly, giving her a peck on the cheek. "For now, I would sure like to try out that tub."

"You and me both," Brooke agreed as she headed to the bathroom to run their bath. "I can't wait to peel myself out of this suit."

"That's the best idea I have heard all day."

“Don’t get any more ideas,” Brooke laughed.

As rustic as the lower level was, Will was happy to see that the upper floor included modern amenities, most notably electricity. The room they were in was a small suite, decorated in restful shades of pale blue and sea foam green, with a large double bed, small fireplace, and a cozy seating area. The fabric used on the bed canopy and windows was gauzy and light, moving with the slightest breeze like ripples on the water. It was obvious the room had been decorated with Brooke in mind, and it suited her perfectly.

After tucking the few things he had brought with him in the nightstand, Will joined Brooke in the adjacent bathroom, leaning his backside against the counter as he enjoyed the view of her bent over the tub, working the faucets.

Brooke answered his unasked question. “Sevilla made some upgrades when I started coming here. I think it was her way of making me feel more at home. Plus, secretly, I think she likes having the water available this way. Hauling it from the fireplace was a drag.”

She stood up and turned to face him “What?” she said nervously, her hands automatically smoothing her hair.

Will looked behind her at the tub. “Nothing, I was just thinking about water conservation and the size of that tub.” He wiggled his eyebrows at her as he took a step forward, his hands going to her waist. “Plus, I need to be readily available to ‘balance’ your water temperature.”

“Will, I’m not sure...”

“Shhhhh, we are just going to take a bath nothing more...for now,” he said softly. “We can take turns peeling each other out of these wetsuits,” he said as he slowly lowered the zipper that ran down the length of her torso.

She raised an eyebrow. “Hmmmmmm, just a bath for now. And then?”

“And then, we will see where it leads,” he said as he kissed the tip of her nose.

“But I’m thinking a nap sounds pretty good.

“That actually sounds like heaven. You read my mind.”

After they rested, they found Sevilla in the room behind the kitchen that Will had seen earlier through the fireplace. She glanced up from her book with a smile.

“Ah, you look much more relaxed. We will have to see what we can do about getting you two something a bit warmer to wear. I see you brought the journal.”

Brooke nodded her head and sat next to Sevilla on the couch, with Will taking the empty space to her left. Brooke kept the book on her lap, and both Sevilla and Will leaned forward to get a better look at the drawings as Sevilla opened it to the portal page.

They spent the next hour discussing what Brooke had deciphered so far, and the steps she and Will had taken to get to that point. Brooke also described some of her past dreams and the last run-in with the Shadowman, which brought Sevilla up to speed. Brooke had several questions for Sevilla and hoped she would be able to shed some light on what was expected of her next.

“So, you said before since Will had come through the portal with me, instead of this Shadowman, or Erebus as you call him, that he’s going to be upset. Won’t he be leaving us alone?”

Sevilla shook her head as she answered, “No, he will still have hopes that he can capture and control you. The first person to come into their power is the librarian for the Elements and keeps records by way of this book. The last time the duty landed with the element of Earth. This journal can only be written in by the first element but is seen and used by all the Elements. It was Erebus’ hope that if he came through the portal with you, he would merge with the power and then have the ability to use the journal.”

“Had he come through the portal with me he would have accomplished what he wanted and now been out of my life?” asked Brooke.

“No – he was never going to be out of your life. And now, he is going to need you and the journal, so it sounds like he isn’t going anywhere,” Will answered

quietly.

Sevilla nodded in agreement. “Precisely.”

Will sat for a moment, worry crinkling his brow, before posing his next question.

“Why is having this book so important since we’ve already found the portal?”

Sevilla paused, her eyes squinting slightly and lips pursing, before answering Will’s question. “The journal houses not only notes about the Element of Water, but also the locations of the other three Elemental portals. With this knowledge, Erebus could have three other chances to obtain not only the power of an Element, but the ability to go through any portal in existence or create a new one. This is a power he must never control.”

Brooke was confused. “You mean to tell me there are descriptions of three other portals in here and ways of finding the people who are supposed to go through them? Why haven’t I seen the pages?”

“Because the journal has a safeguard that only shows you the pages as that Element is coming into power, and when you’re needed to help them make that transition. The blank pages in this book will fill over time, eventually showing you the key to unlocking each of their mysteries. You can add your own experiences as well.”

“You said before I was linked by fate to Brooke and her destiny. Was it just to help her find the portal?”

“No. You most definitely have another part to play, Willmot, by virtue of your name alone which means ‘Spirit’ does it not?” Sevilla smiled at his surprise.

“Fate arranged for you to meet and to travel through the portal together, I’m sure of it now. Now that each of you have obtained the powers of the water element, we must see for ourselves what you are capable of.”

After browsing through the visible pages and getting an idea of what to expect, the three of them went outside and walked to the stream that wound through

Sevilla's side yard. While the journal described some of the powers, it didn't necessarily have step-by-step instructions.

"Okay, Brooke, I want you to concentrate and see if you're able to lift any of the water from the streambed. Will, I need you behind her ready to offer your support if she..."

"Becomes too imbalanced," Brooke finished with a smirk.

Sevilla shook her head with a smile and waved her hand forward, motioning for Brooke to begin.

Brooke wasn't sure exactly what she was supposed to do, but she did remember how she had felt when Will was attacked during the dream. She took a deep breath and focused on the stream itself, the crystal clear water gurgling over the stones as it traveled down the path cut into the forest floor. She imagined standing in it, the feel of the cool water lapping at her ankles and the pulse of the water as it rushed by.

Then...she felt it. A small rippling sensation which started at her feet and moved its way up her legs, similar to the massaging jets of a Jacuzzi tub. It became stronger and more intense as it traveled up her body, crept along her spine and worked its way down her arms, tingling like the worst case of pins and needles she had ever had. Her arms came up of their own accord, reaching toward the stream as the energy bolted through the tips of her fingers.

Will watched as Brooke reached her arms out in front of her, and the pulse of blue energy left her fingertips and traveled toward the water.

As the charge hit the streambed, the water traveled upward as though it was being sucked through a straw. It ballooned at the top in a rounded mass that filled a three-foot orb. After a few seconds, the spout disappeared, and the water ball was left suspended in mid-air.

Sevilla's face beamed like a proud parent. "Well done, Brooklyn, now see if you're able to move it."

Brooke nodded, her eyes never leaving their target, and her arms still raised. She slowly shifted one foot in front of her and twisted her body sideways to better sweep her arms to the side. She pulled the water ball away from the streambed and over Sevilla's garden, and then like holes popped in a water balloon, she let it sprinkle over the plants until it disappeared.

"That was amazing!" Will shouted as he turned Brooke around and pulled her off her feet for a bear hug.

She laughed as he swung her around, "Lord, Will, put me down!"

"Well done, Brooklyn. Now let's see what Willmot can do."

"Yeah, Willmot," Brooke said with a gleam in her eye. "Let's see what you can do."

"If I had a deck of cards, maybe," he said laughing. "I'm not sure about all of this. It is a little hard to wrap my head around." Will took a deep breath and relaxed his shoulders. "How would you describe the feeling?" he asked Brooke. "What were you thinking?"

"I just concentrated on moving the water and imagined how it would feel. The next minute, I had a tingle moving up my legs and coming down my arms, and they felt numb – like when my leg falls asleep."

Will nodded and stood where Brooke had, facing the stream with his arms out in front of him. At first nothing happened, and he started to feel a bit ridiculous, but then the tingling sensation Brooke described came up from his feet.

He was in awe of the power he felt as it traveled up both legs, fanned across his back toward his chest and shot down his arms toward his hands. It was a bit more uncomfortable than the pins and needles that Brooke described and almost felt to him like sticking a knife into an electric socket. Unbelieving, he stared as the light pulsed from his fingertips and shot toward the tree line. He couldn't help his random thoughts. His power wasn't the same color as Brooke's, and it didn't have much to do with water.

Brooke saw a bolt of white lightening shoot from Will's fingertips and ram into a small tree that stood near the stream. The raw power of the pulse sent bark, small twigs, and leaves flying in every direction, ultimately engulfing the entire scene in flames.

The power he had generated, and the force in which he pushed it, threw him to the ground, on his back, and dazed him.

Brooke leaned down to make sure he was okay before concentrating on the stream and creating another water bubble. She released it over the burning trees and doused the flames. With the fire out, she went back to Will who was just getting up from the ground.

"Are you alright?" Brooke asked with concern. "How do you feel?"

"Good, just a bit lightheaded," Will said as he raised his hand to his head. Sevilla joined them and took Will's arm to lead him into the house, acting not at all surprised that he had blown her tree to smithereens.

"Looks like we need to find you something to ground that current," she said quietly. "I think I have just the thing."

elle

Chapter Twenty-Seven



Sevilla settled Will on the couch and ushered Brooke into the kitchen to start the tea. Taking a blue glass jar down from the shelf, Sevilla pushed the kettle over the fire and instructed Brooke to use the “special blend” in the jar she handed her before heading upstairs.

Brooke twisted and removed the lid, taking a whiff of the tea, which reminded her of black licorice, coriander, and mint. *Smells like crap. She couldn't help the grimace on her face. Not sure how this will help, but okay.* She lined everything up, checked the water, and then went into the other room to check on Will.

He was lying on the couch, his head back on a pillow with one arm over his eyes and the other resting on his stomach. When he heard her come in, he reached his hand out to her, looking at her from the crook in his arm with a tired smile.

Brooke took his hand, and he pulled her down to his side to sit in the small space next to him. He gave her hand a kiss before he laid it linked with his own on his chest.

“How are you?” she asked quietly as she took her other hand and gently moved the hair on his forehead.

“That was pretty intense. It felt like an electrical shock. I almost feel worse now. I have to admit, I was having a hard time buying into all of this magical stuff, but I’m not sure I can explain what just happened logically.”

Sevilla entered the room and spoke to Will as she came toward the couch. “This should help with the excess power until you’re able to control it a bit better.”

She handed him a corded necklace that held a spiraling silver cage wrapped around a smooth black stone with a reflective quality.

“What is it?” he asked as he took the necklace and placed it over his head.

“It is Hematite, which has very strong grounding qualities and should allow you to channel your powers a bit more effectively next time. The tea I have Brooke making will help with the headache.”

Brooke stood up and moving toward the kitchen, said, “I’ll go finish it, I’m sure the water is heated by now.”

As Brooke prepared the tea, she also cut up cheese, sausage, and some fruit to snack on. When she went back into the sitting room, Will was sitting up, and Sevilla had pulled a table over to hold the tea tray. Brooke recognized the table and looked behind her for the chessboard that had always been centered on it. Sevilla must have tucked it away. As a young girl, Brooke had always wanted to play with the pieces but never dared. It had been in Sevilla’s family for decades, and she had always been protective of it. Brooke handed Will his tea first before pouring out of a separate pot for Sevilla and herself.

Will took a sip and tried not to grimace. “This has an interesting flavor. Aren’t you going to have any?”

Brooke looked over with a grin. “Oh no, that was made special just for you. We will just be having lemon and honey. Why? Don’t you like it?”

Will looked to Sevilla before making his next comment and noticed she was trying not to smile. “It isn’t bad I suppose if you like drinking tea that tastes like crap... No offense, Sevilla.”

“None taken,” she laughed. “And you’re right, it does taste terrible but is very effective in grounding excess energy.”

They nibbled at the snacks Brooke had put on the tray. “No matter how it tastes, Will, you need to finish every last drop. You had quite the jolt to your system, and I want to make sure you’re fully balanced before we try any more exercises.”

“Don’t worry, I will choke it down. It isn’t all that bad I suppose if you like Ouzo or Good & Plenty candies, neither of which are my favorite, by the way,” he said as he took another swallow. “What’s next on the agenda?”

“I would like to look through the journal again to see if it has any references to the types of powers we can expect for you both and how to unlock them. Brooke would you mind running up to your room and getting it again?”

“Of course not. I’ll be right back.”

While Brooke was upstairs, Sevilla lowered her voice and continued speaking to Will. “We need to discuss what needs to be done moving forward to remove Erebus from Brooke’s life. He is a great threat to her and to the rest of the Elements through her.”

“If he has powers anything like what we saw in the dream, I’m not sure we are going to be able to stop him,” said Will.

“He cannot be destroyed entirely, but his confidence is built on his abilities. Like a bridge being supported by its base, damage the base, and the bridge will eventually fail. This is what you must do. Whittle away at his abilities by taking away the tools he uses. If I know him, his confidence will follow suit.”

“What types of tools are you talking about?” asked Will. “Crystal balls and stuff?”

“It could be, or any other item that has been infused with magic,” answered Sevilla.

“How are we going to know what is magical and what is not?” continued Will. “I mean the portal looked like the side of a mountain. Granted it had the squiggly symbol carved in it, but I wouldn’t have known it was magic necessarily.”

“Ah, but you did recognize something magical. You just needed to know where to start looking, and the journal is the key.”

“The journal is the key to what?” Brooke asked as she joined them.

“The key to getting Dreamcreep to stop bugging you,” Will said, putting his arm around her as she sat next to him on the couch.

Brooke smiled at him and then turned to face Sevilla. “Then count me in!”

The information in the journal was frustrating, most of the time referencing an area that didn’t exist or giving a clue that didn’t make sense. Even Sevilla was stumped at a few of the references and had pulled out several of her own books to help shed light on the puzzles.

Using a special pen that Sevilla had given her, Brooke wrote notes of her own in the journal and jotted ideas next to the writings when something came to light. It was incredible to Brooke that even the new additions she had written were only visible when she held the book.

It took Sevilla mentioning the numbers and symbols on the lower corners of the pages for Brooke to realize the pages that were visible reflected the water symbol, while the other pages were blank or showed the symbols for one of the other elements.

She was careful to follow suit, only using pages that were entirely blank and drawing the symbol for water with the next number in line in the lower right corner, before adding her notes. She wrote about the powers she and Will had developed, the hematite stone that Sevilla had given Will, and detailed the recipe for the “grounding” tea.

Brooke asked if other stones had magical properties. Sevilla pulled out a small hinged box that held an array of colorful stones buffed to a shine and described

the properties they each held as Brooke took notes.

At first, their work was tedious. Much of the prior information that was visible was repetitive in nature and described finding and using the Elemental portal. Some of the pages referenced pages that were blank or pages that had a different Elemental symbol. Sevilla explained the information would show itself when the time was right.

Will spent most of the time resting on the couch and at one point nodded off as the women worked. His quiet snores kept them company as they discussed spells and universal balance.

Brooke was fascinated to find out that Sevilla was so familiar with all things magical, something she had never realized when she had come here before. Looking back, it should have been totally obvious.

The room looked different through Brooke's adult eyes. For the first time, she saw a multitude of books on magic, sparkling crystals that lined the shelves, and bunched herbs, hanging to dry, to be used in teas or potions.

Sevilla hadn't aged a bit. She looked as beautiful as the day they had met. Another clear sign that she was something otherworldly, as far as Brooke was concerned. When she asked her how she was so knowledgeable about the journal and the elemental powers, she hesitated, then simply said, "I know what I must and share what I can."

Sevilla was always one for riddles.

Will started to stir just as Brooke's stomach was growling. "I will take that as my cue to get something going for dinner," said Sevilla. "Brooke, would you mind putting another log on the fire?"

"I can get it," Will answered as he stretched and scratching the stubble that covered his chin, gave Brooke a playful wink.

They snuggled on the couch near the fire until Sevilla called them into the kitchen. Brooke hadn't realized how hungry she was until Sevilla brought out

homemade bread with honey butter, tossed salad with fresh herbs, and the roasted chicken she had made earlier in the day.

After their meal, Sevilla insisted she could clean up and that they both needed to get a good night's rest. Brooke argued until Sevilla explained she needed some time alone to determine their next steps and to see what Erebus was up to. She had said that a quiet house would be better for what she needed to do.

She and Will took turns hugging Sevilla and wishing her goodnight before walking up the stairs to their room with a bottle of wine Brooke had pulled from the cellar.

They changed into the pajamas Sevilla had left for them and sat by the fire with their glasses of wine. A slight breeze from the open window fluttered the curtains inward, moving them like the wings of a butterfly. Even though the seating area had more than one chair, Will pulled Brooke down onto his lap where she sat contently in the crook of his arm.

After every sip or two of his wine, he would kiss her softly. His attention made her feel beloved, and she never wanted that feeling to end. She blew on the tiny ember of hope inside her heart with the optimism that it would work it into a full-fledged flame.

While she was curious to know how he felt about her, she also was terrified since she still wasn't sure where they really stood. Being together had been like the dreams they shared, but she was afraid their connection might not be strong enough for the pressures of real life. She knew one thing for sure. If things didn't work out, she would have to live the rest of her life without her heart because there wasn't ever going to be anyone else for her.

"A penny for your thoughts," he whispered as he nuzzled her ear, taking the lobe into his teeth and lightly nipping it.

As his warm breath caressed the side of her neck, and his tongue followed suit, she tipped her head to the side, moaning softly. "I can't think at all when you do

that.”

She felt his smile against the crook of her shoulder as he answered with a soft chuckle. “Mmm, well, that is what I wanted to hear. I think we have had enough thinking for one day.”

She took his wine glass and placed it with hers on the side table, before settling into his embrace. His hands tightened possessively around her waist as she wrapped her arm around the backside of his neck. Lifting her face toward his, she drew him into a kiss. His response was immediate as she twisted in his lap, anxious to get closer. He slid his hands up beneath her top, the warmth of his palm covering her breast and pulsing heat through her body.

Brooke’s sigh escaped as she arched her back, feeling small zaps of energy pulse through her body. There was an immediate need to be closer – an impulse she couldn’t ignore. She pushed up from his lap, removed her pajama top and situated herself back on his lap, facing him with her legs on either side of his waist. They picked up the kiss where they had left off.

With her arms back behind Will’s neck, Brooke took great pleasure in wiggling closer to his heat. With every magical stroke of his tongue, she could feel his hardened length pulse against the thin fabric that covered her, and just as she started to regret not removing her pajama bottoms as well, he stood up, wrapping her legs around his waist, and walked them toward the bed.

He laid her gently across the mattress, reaching into the nightstand drawer and removing a small foil package that he tore open and readied near the pillow. Looking back at her and noticing the smirk on her face, he gave her a quizzical look as though he was missing the joke. A grin split his handsome face as he kissed her. “What’s going on in that head of yours?”

“I was just thinking how we decided only to bring necessities with us on the dive because we were limited on space. We didn’t even bring wallets, yet somehow you managed to bring a condom.”

“Several...”, he said, wiggling his eyebrows as he leaned down to kiss her nose.

“Seriously?” she laughed out loud. “What did you think was going to go on once we got here?”

“Hey, cut a guy a break,” he said with a grin, nuzzling her neck. “I can’t help it if the Boy Scout in me has to be prepared for anything.”

Her laugh tinkled gaily, and Will lifted up slightly, so he could look into her face. Brooke felt so at ease with him, so natural, and she could easily see spending the rest of her life with him. He kissed her gently, pressing her into the bed as he adjusted himself over her. As the kiss deepened, she relayed every feeling she was too afraid to tell him in any other way.

“I love what you do to me, Angel, how you make me feel. It’s like I’ve have been waiting for you my whole life.”

“I feel the same.”

Will lifted himself up from her body briefly to remove his flannel pants, placing his hands on her waist and massaging the soft skin under the edge of her pajama bottoms. Lowering the fabric inch by inch, he reverently kissed the skin he revealed.

Her hands reached down to his head, her fingers weaving into his thick dark hair as he nuzzled her belly. She arched her back as warm vibrations of current waved through her, causing every inch of her to tingle with anticipation. Will licked his way up to her pebbled breasts as the shadow of his beard rasped against her tender skin. His touch shot pulses to her core where his fingers were already working their magic.

She thought it was uncanny how he knew exactly what speed and amount of pressure to use, and then that thought left her head as he increased the speed, warming her body quickly. Then, she couldn’t think at all. Pulses of energy waved through her, at closer and closer intervals, causing her to grind against his

hand as he pushed a finger into her warmth. He had a way of removing every inhibition she had.

He continued to rub her outer lips with his thumb as two fingers now reached in toward their final destination. He called her name softly, and she looked into his gorgeous eyes. She couldn't help allowing the soft smile to cross her lips, her hand moving of its own accord to cup his face. They connected in that instant, heart-to-heart, soul-to-soul, and when she found her release, shared every bit of it with him. His expression was love in the purest form, and its light was shining for her.

With any other person, at any other time, she would have been embarrassed to have someone watch her as she climaxed, but when he hit gold...every bit of reservation went pulsing out of her with each tingle of her body. Massaging waves of euphoria shot through her, working their way up through her body. They dazzled her mind like fireworks.

He kept up the pressure as he climbed up to straddle her leg. His shaft was hard and thick pressed against her thigh. He slipped his fingers out, rolled on the condom, and pumped into her with one stroke, hardly missing a beat.

The second orgasm was unexpected, evident by the loud scream he had to muffle with his mouth, as he continued to thrust into her. She wrapped her arms up around the backsides of his shoulders, breaking the kiss, looking into his face, and shuddering with every stroke he gave her.

The intensity of the moment was off the charts, her brain hardly working over the warm electric pulses of every nerve ending in her body. Somehow, she forced herself to keep her eyes open, not wanting to miss the look on his face as he found his release – wanting to share it with him as he had with her.

His muscles tensed as he came, and she felt it inside her body through the thin wall of the condom. As she felt his muscles relax and his eyes re-focused on hers, she decided she had never seen anything more beautiful in her life. In that

small moment, she had looked into the window of his soul and saw pure joy, love, and acceptance. It was a moment she had been longing for her entire life. She was overjoyed that Will had finally made it back into her life and hoped whatever decision he had yet to make, would include her.

elle

Chapter Twenty-Eight



Erebos knew Zilla was there before she entered the room – it was always that way for him. He braced himself for her visit, taking a deep breath and palming the black obsidian which he had slipped into the side pocket of his pants. He had little hope it would defend him completely against her, but its effects would at least get him through the visit.

His back was to the doorway as she entered, her heeled shoes tapping on the stone floor as she walked toward him. He could hear the smile on her face as she purred his name in a sultry voice that always went straight to his groin. “Erebos, darling, did you miss me?”

He closed his eyes and took a deep breath, fighting the nerves that urged him to talk to her with his back turned. “Hello, Zilla,” he said without enthusiasm. Turning around to greet her, he tried to remain calm as he took in the vision of her. “You’re looking lovely as ever.”

She sashayed over to where he stood and put her hands out in front of her, which he grasped automatically and raised to his lips. As he kissed her knuckles and looked into her eyes, he realized at once the mistake he had made.

She was even more beautiful than when he had last seen her if that was possible. Her deep, emerald eyes sparkled with mischief and were framed with thick, black lashes, which batted shamelessly at him. Her smile lit the room, with a dimple at one side and a small beauty mark above her lip on the other. He longed to kiss her there. Her silky, dark hair, normally worn in a thick braid, was loose today and reminded him of the shiny stone in his pocket, which he now knew, without a doubt, wasn't going to help him resist her.

He lowered her hands from his lips, taking in the soft swell of her breasts as they strained against the top edge of her corset-style dress. He fought against the urge to wrap his hands around her trim waist. Gazing at her slim neck, he wondered if he put his lips to the place where it met her shoulders if she would taste the same. It pleased him, in a way he would never admit, to see her wearing the simple gold chain adorned with a small, emerald drop that he had given her years ago when things were different between them.

Her scent surrounded him in a blanket of memories, filling him with visions of naked skin, and the feeling of her wicked tongue as it caressed him. Zilla was addictive, toxic, a torment to his soul, and she knew it. She wielded her power like a dark siren, seducing and capturing hearts, only to later abandon them to their fate. He had always been drawn to her and fought against the compulsion in any way he could, in a useless effort to maintain control. Something he had never had when it came to her.

He slid his hand in his pocket, grasping the small stone he had placed there as he broke eye contact with her, hoping it would be enough to resist her pull. He also prayed her help would be worth all the torment he knew she would put him through.

Erebos watched the sly smile cross Zilla's face, almost as though she sensed his struggle and decided to cut him some slack. He felt her glamour recede, giving

him more control over his emotions, and her chuckle confirmed his suspicions. She had been using her powers to influence him...typical.

She pointed a long, lacquered nail at the pocket where his hand was fidgeting.

“So, is that an Obsidian in your pocket, or are you just happy to see me?”

Erebos quickly removed his hand and gave her a look that told her not to push it. Her heated laugh let him know she knew exactly what he had been attempting.

“You’re looking well,” she said with one last bat of her eyes as she turned away from him, gliding over to the table toward a seat. “What exactly did you have in mind when you sent your man to extend your *invitation*. Surely this isn’t a social call?”

He came around to her side of the table, and Zilla waited for him to pull a chair out, her eyebrows raised in jest. The gleam in her eyes remained hopeful as she lowered herself to her seat.

“No not a social call, Zilla. I actually need your help.”

Erebos didn’t miss the fleeting pout that crossed her face. Even irritated, she was the most beautiful woman he had ever seen.

“Hmmmmm really?” Zilla purred, “Well, this calls for a glass of wine anyway – social or no. I simply can’t bear to hear what you need help with until I have a drink.”

“Certainly, where are my manners,” he said wryly as he made his way over to the liquor cabinet, happy to put his back to her, so he could compose himself.

“Red or white?”

“Oh, Darling, you know what I like,” she said with a wave of her hand and a wicked smile.

The innuendo wasn’t wasted on him as he turned to the cabinet to pull out a bottle of pink – not too sweet, a little tart – *very much like the woman who drinks it*. After removing the cork and pouring the glasses, he took a deep breath and walked back to the table where she was seated.

“Thank you, darling,” she said as she took the drink from him and sipped. “Ahhh, you do remember,” she said with a grin, gazing at him over the lip of her wine glass. After one more sip, and an over-exaggerated swipe of her tongue across her lips, she addressed him once more.

“What exactly do you need my help with? Have an itch you can’t quite reach? Need someone to tuck you in at night? Need help re-decorating? You know you could really use some color in here...”

“No re-decorating and no sexual favors,” he said firmly as he twisted sideways in his seat to adjust the one part of his body that wasn’t listening to a single thing he was saying.

Zilla’s lips puckered into a pout as her eyes twinkled merrily. “Well, we will have to see about that, won’t we?” Before he could argue, she continued. “So, what is it then? The suspense is simply killing me!”

We could only be so lucky. He took a deep breath and prepared himself to make a deal with the devil. “I need your help finding someone.”

“You? Need my help for that? Surely you jest. You’re a Sorcerer now, for goddess’ sake. There have to be a thousand ways you can track someone.” She dismissed him with her hand and took another sip of wine.

“This particular person is blocked from my sight at the moment.”

“Reaaaalllly?” she said with a gleam in her eye. “And why do you think that is?” *Here it is...I really wish I didn’t need her help.* “Because I think this person has crossed to a different dimension and is being blocked from my sight by someone more powerful than me.”

“Well, that does present a bit of a pickle does it not? Say I help you find this person. What exactly do I get out of it?”

“Considering you will counteroffer anything I come up with, why don’t you just tell me what you want, Zilla?”

She pursed her lips, placed her finger on them, and tapped as she thought about his statement. “Although you’re right about that, it’s still rude to point it out.” She flashed a toothy grin, and Erebos prepared for another hill on the Zilla coaster.

“Since you’re being so sassy, let’s just say you’ll owe me a favor...a really, really, big, big favor.”

Erebos groaned inwardly, remembering the last time he paid up on a debt with her that somehow ended up involving a blindfold, olive oil, and ended in him serving a three-week stint as a warthog.

“Done,” he said firmly, closing his eyes and pinching the bridge of his nose.

“You act as though owing me a favor is a bad thing,” she stated with over-exaggerated innocence. “I can’t help it if you said you would rather be a smelly, old warthog than to spend another minute with little old me.”

“That is not what happened, and you know it,” he said, taking a deep breath and calming his temper.

“You say potatah, I say potatoe. Anywho...let’s get down to business. Tell me who I’m looking for and the last time you saw him.”

Erebos took a deep breath. *Oh, Gods, here we go.* “The last time I saw *her* was in a dream I entered, and *her* name is Brooklyn—”

“WHAT?!?” she screeched as she stood up and leaned across the table, her chest heaving with anger, and her eyes sparking with envy. “You didn’t say anything about needing to find a *woman!*”

“You didn’t ask,” he said calmly, trying to hide the smile creeping across his face fueled by the major stroke to his ego her reaction caused.

Zilla paced the floor, glancing sporadically at Erebos. He knew she was regretting her overreaction, and he liked the small bit of power it gave him. In an obvious attempt to repair the damage, Zilla sat down and took a gulp of her

wine. She took a deep breath and tried to sound indifferent, which pleased him immensely.

“Who is this woman, and what does she mean to you exactly?”

“She is destined to be an Element and has the Alchemist Journal in her possession.”

“Well, that in itself shouldn’t present too much of a problem, unless of course she has passed through the Elemental portal and come into her powers,” she mused before looking up into his eyes with realization. “That is exactly what has happened, and you weren’t the one to pass through with her as you intended.”

He said nothing as she continued to examine the expression on his face, her face looking as though she was working out a problem, and her eyes rolling up slightly in her head. After a few seconds, her eyes lowered, and she murmured quietly, “Someone else came through with her...a man.”

Erebos sipped his wine, embarrassed she could see so easily through him and trying hard to hide the reasons for wanting the powers in the first place. He nodded at her assessment and got up to get them more wine. “That is my assumption, though I do not have the powers to confirm that. Before she was blocked from my sight, I tried to pull her through my portal from her dreamstate.”

“And?”

“And I was stopped by someone that came to her aid.”

Zilla took the glass he offered, shaking her head in disbelief. “Erebos, that doesn’t seem possible. How can anyone in a dreamstate possibly deter someone with your ability? Unless they are...”

“A Mage,” he finished for her as he sat back in his chair and took a sip of wine.

“And the power?” she questioned seriously, sitting up in her seat and leaning toward him.

“He harnesses lightning, which would have been easy enough to overcome, but he also seems to have the ability to drain his opponent of their powers as well.”

“And he did this to you?”

“Yes, the effects lasted several days, which is when I lost track of the Element. By the time I regained my strength, both were hidden from my sight.”

Zilla nodded and leaned back in her seat. With eyes closed, she took a deep breath and slowly slipped into a trancelike state.

During her trance, he was able to regard her without fear of being caught, without having her use his attraction to her advantage, and thought to himself what a stunning woman she was. He liked her like this – quiet and beautiful, serenely embracing the power he could see in the sparkling haze surrounding her. She was extremely powerful, so much more than he, but she had always avoided making him feel he wasn’t her equal, that he wasn’t worthy of having her – of loving her. He appreciated that at least. When it came to sex, she was approachable and willing, but he knew her moods could be volatile and quick to change when it came to her heart.

He sipped his wine, waiting for her to share what would be revealed and hoping she would be able to find Brooke. He also hoped she would find a way to separate the Mage from the Element since he wouldn’t be able to fight their combined power. If he were being completely honest, he wasn’t even sure Zilla would be able to defeat them, and she was ten times more powerful than he was – at least for the time being.

He watched her quietly, soaking up her beauty and preparing himself for the impetuous creature she would become when she awoke. After a few minutes and one last deep breath, Zilla opened her eyes, firing up a conversation like she hadn’t been asleep for the past five minutes. “Looks like I need to pay someone a visit darling, but in the meantime, your man needs to gather a few things for me.”

“Of course, Zilla, whatever you want,” he answered solemnly as he rose from the table and crossed the room to call for Kadar.

She murmured to herself as she sat back in her chair, watching him move across the room. “You have that right, darling, it is about whatever I want and don’t you dare forget it.”

elle

Chapter Twenty-Nine



Brooke and Will spent the better part of the next day outside practicing their new-found skills. With the information found in the journal and through trial and error, they discovered Will's strengths involved lightning or plasma-type energy, and Brooke's skills were bound to water.

With a great deal of focus, Will was able to manipulate the electrical charges formed from his hands into small balls, similar in size to his Baoding balls, and throw them one at a time while instantly creating a replacement. This allowed him to have an endless supply of ammunition in case of another attack since he could pull a powerful pulse from the sky and channel like Zeus hurling a lightning bolt.

Brooke was pleased to find she was able to manipulate water not only from the streambed, but from the skies as well, calling down a gentle rain to water Sevilla's garden and then sending it on its way. She also discovered that by focusing on temperature she could either turn the water to a fine warm mist or instantly freeze it and had fun creating some rather large ice sculptures Will used for target practice.

Sevilla came out to check on them and was pleased with the progress they had made in such a short time. She gave them a few pointers about energy, and how to channel their thoughts, and asked them to come inside, so she could talk to them about their next steps. After blasting a few more ice sculptures, they followed her in for a wonderful lunch and then settled in the library with a bottle of wine. Sevilla explained it helped with the leveling of excess energies.

As Sevilla poured the glasses, she addressed them both. “For anyone other than an Element to travel from one dimension to another, a magical object is required. The object can come in many shapes and sizes and be almost anything you can think of. Many magical creatures have one or more of these objects, passed to them over time through family members or given to them as gifts. Some might even be stolen. These objects are not easily created as they require a piece of the creator’s essence at the time the magic is infused. It could be anything really – even a ring. Erebus has such an item, and to stop him from traveling to your dimension, you must find it and take it back with you.”

Brooke let what Sevilla said sink in a bit and took a sip of wine before replying. “So, what you’re saying is we need to figure out what he is using and steal it from him?”

“Precisely,” Sevilla responded with a nod. “And your timing will need to be impeccable. It is best to avoid him at all costs while you’re developing your skills. While his core magic is less powerful than some, he does have resources available to him that can enhance and duplicate energies. That makes him a deadly adversary.”

“I’m not in any hurry to run into him anytime soon, that’s for sure,” Brooke said. “You won’t be able to help us?”

Sevilla shook her head. “Although I do have powers, my purpose is governed by the laws of the Universe. I’m not able to interfere with conflicts the Elements face – only guide them to their destiny.”

“You helping us with our destiny, does that have anything to do with the fact that he hasn’t bothered us since we have been here? Is there like a magical force field around here or something?” Brooke asked as she moved aside and made a place for Will on the couch.

“Something like that,” Sevilla smiled softly. “Each being in Wisteria has what is known as domain or homestead, and no magical creature may enter another’s area unless they are given permission, or their skills surpass the owner’s. This area is mine, and very few are strong enough to break through its defenses.”

“Wait a minute,” Will stated as he looked at Sevilla with a confused look on his face. “You said that for anyone other than an Element to travel by portal an object is needed. Does that mean Brooke can create objects?”

“Over time, Brooke will be able to do many great things, but many years of training will be required. My fear is that if we don’t stop Erebus from interfering now, Brooke will not be able to develop her abilities properly, shifting the balance of power in his favor.”

Brooke swished the wine in her glass, staring down at it with her brow pinched in concentration.

Will placed his hand on her knee and gave it a gentle squeeze. “Angel... everything ok?”

She looked up at him with a small smile, nodding her head briefly, “I was just trying to figure out how we were going to make it into the Dreamcreep’s domain without his permission.” She looked at Sevilla, directing the next comment to her. “Is he going to have the same type of field around his place?”

Sevilla nodded slowly. “He will. However, there is someone who can help you gain access. If knowledge of my involvement or that of this person is ever found out, it could be devastating for us all. Fate doesn’t like to be trifled with.”

“Understood,” Will said as he filled their glasses. “So, we need to make it to his domain on our own, gain access with someone’s assistance, steal a mysterious

magical item that creates portals to our dimension, and then return home with it without getting caught.” He raised his glass and nodded it in a “cheers” fashion to Sevilla. “Sounds fun. When do we get started?”

Sevilla smiled, clinking her glass against Will’s and then Brooke’s. “You leave tomorrow.”

“Tomorrow?” Brooke stopped mid-sip, choking on her wine. “What is so special about tomorrow? Are we even ready for this?”

“Ready or not, you must leave tomorrow. I have knowledge that he will be leaving his home for a small amount of time, and it is during this trip that you must find what you seek.” Sevilla placed her hand on Brooke’s giving it a gentle squeeze before continuing. “I can travel with you to the edge of my domain, and when you reach the outer edges of Erebos’s property, my contact will meet you. He will provide access into his home. Once you locate the object, you will be able to use it to visualize a portal to the pond.”

“Why not here?” Brooke questioned, leaning over to take the journal from the nearby table.

“Portals can only allow travel to neutral areas, or places that have not been claimed as part of a domain, unless they are tied to a particular area or dimension. I do not have objects that create portals to my domain from the outside – it would be too dangerous if they fell into the wrong hands. The pond is outside of my area, which is why he was able to reach you there in your dreams. Once you travel there it is only a short walk here, and then I can help you get back home.”

“His house has to be filled with a ton of things. How are we ever going to be able to figure out which ones are magical, or which create the portal?”

Sevilla stood up and pulled a small wooden box from a nearby shelf. “Ahhh, now that I can help you with,” she said with a smile. She opened the box and pulled out a silver necklace with the most beautiful, blue stone Brooke had ever

seen. “This pendant is made from Larimar, also known as the Stone of Atlantis. Its properties access the powers of the sacred feminine and helps amplify clear communication. This stone will allow you to channel your energy and locate any magical objects surrounding you by allowing you to see their auras.”

Brooke held up her hair to allow Sevilla to clasp the necklace around her neck, the pendant leveled at the center of her chest. “It is beautiful, Sevilla, thank you.” Brooke touched the stone near her throat, feeling small waves of energy pulse from it like circles in a pond. “All right. What do I do now?”

“Just take a deep breath and relax. Allow yourself to see beyond the physical. Unfocus your eyes and seek with your mind.”

Brooke looked at Sevilla with a yeah-right look.

Sevilla smiled. “Remember the Magic Eye puzzles you liked so well when you were younger? That is exactly what you need to do in this case. When you begin to see the auras that surround Will and I, you should be able to look around the room and find my items.”

Brooke nodded and closed her eyes, focusing on her breathing and allowing the energy to pulse through her. She cracked open her eyes and stared into one place, causing all the items on the outer edges of her sight to blur and the center of her vision to focus into crystal clarity. She turned her face to look at Will who sat beside her smiling softly and saw he was framed with a pink glow that crackled with yellow bolts of energy. Without blinking, she turned her head toward Sevilla and saw a cloud of white with glittery streaks that sparkled like gold.

“Your auras are beautiful,” she murmured as she looked toward the bookshelves. She delighted herself by seeing several objects light up with a bluish-white light, like they were sitting on LEDs. “So, how do I tell which items do which things?”

“Portals create an absence of space so will be surrounded by a black aura. Those safe to use will include a bit of silver. Portal items that only reflect a black aura

should never be used as they were formed by someone who practices dark magick.”

Brooke got up from the couch and walked over to the fireplace, scanning the items on the mantle. They all had the same white glow, but as she looked more closely, she could see the various threads of color Sevilla had referred to. Pretty much everything on the mantle was lit, each item with its own color scheme. But there was one object that had a circle of black around it with a sparkly edge of silver.

She lifted the small onyx ring from the mantle, and Sevilla smiled, clapping her hands. “Very good, Brooke. Now we need to show you how to use the item, and you will be as ready as I can make you.”

They spent the next few hours practicing opening and closing portals and visualizing locations to travel to all within the area of Sevilla’s domain. It was what the ring was limited to. Brooke practiced with and without taking Will as a “passenger” and found that their trip to the other side was best if he stood behind her with his arms wrapped around her waist.

Will was in a particularly flirty mood, and Brooke found it ridiculously hard to concentrate with some of the things he was breathing into the side of her neck before going through the portals she formed. At one point, they ended up in the bedroom instead of the side yard, and Brooke blamed it entirely on Will’s lack of concentration.

“Hey, I can’t help it if you’re visualizing where you truly want to go.” Will chuckled as Brooke stuck her tongue out and popped through another portal leaving him to run down the stairs to join her in the yard.

After Brooke made some notes in the journal, Sevilla sent them upstairs to make sure they had their belongings gathered and ready to go. She gave Brooke some herbs to put into her bath to help with grounding since her newfound skills had caused so much energy to flow through her that she was practically glowing

from it. Sevilla explained that while energy was a good thing, too much of it needed to be put back into the source, which in her case was water.

She and Will went up the stairs to their room and made short work of packing, anxious to spend some time in the tub.

— e l e —

Chapter Thirty



The next morning, Sevilla knocked on their door early to wake them and give them a set of new clothes to wear on their journey.

“These should help you blend in a bit better, just in case someone happens to see you. I will meet you downstairs. We need to leave shortly.”

After she left, Brooke and Will made sure their items were gathered and quickly changed their clothes.

Will’s outfit was simple. The pants had a button fly, and the shirt was made of a soft, white material, similar to linen, styled as a pull-over.

Brooke’s outfit was like the clothes Sevilla favored. The bottom was made with layers of gauzy material that zigzagged in a handkerchief style, while the top was a bit tighter and reminded her of a corset since it pushed her ladies up front and center. Brooke tied the matching shawl, made from the same material as the skirt, around her shoulders and secured it in a knot behind her back.

The color was perfect for her – various shades of blue and green trimmed with silver veining that ran throughout the outfit, giving it a shimmering effect. She had removed her contacts and left her hair loose, giving it a quick brush before leaving the bathroom to join Will.

His eyes gave her a quick once over, and a smile warmed his face. “You look beautiful. If Sevilla wasn’t waiting, I might be tempted to try to talk you out of this dress.”

Will moved one of his hands up to the top edge of her outfit, running a finger along the place that the fabric met the top part of her breast and examined the necklace Sevilla had given her. Small sparks of electricity pulsed from his fingers and warmed her as she raised her eyes to his. He looked into her eyes, which reflected back the feelings he felt but remained unsaid. “Has anyone ever told you how gorgeous your eyes are?”

“You have,” she whispered with a smile and put her lips to his. It was all that needed to be said for now.

They met Sevilla downstairs and after a quick breakfast, were on their way. The sun was just coming up over the horizon, and from what Will could tell, they were heading east since the sun was in front of them, although he considered that things might not work the same here. They followed the same path through the woods that had brought them to Sevilla’s, and Will realized they were heading toward the pond where they had first met.

They walked hand in hand following Sevilla. Sunlight streamed in through holes in the canopy, spotlighting the various trees and wildlife they passed. There was a sense of peace and tranquility. When they entered the clearing where the pond was, they walked to another clump of trees and into a second area of woods.

Brooke could feel the change as soon as they entered the tree line to the right of the pond. She couldn’t breathe, like she was hiking high in the mountains and couldn’t get enough air. The woods were dark and foreboding, the thick leaves blocking the light, and the terrain was rough and uneven with hardly a path to be seen.

Will must have sensed there was something wrong and stopped walking, turning her to face him. “Are you okay, babe?” He ducked his head down to look into

her eyes and slipped a hand up to cup her cheek.

“Just having a hard time breathing...”

Will took a step away as Sevilla joined them. She raised one hand to grasp Brooke’s shoulder while placing the other hand on the pendant. “Brooke, Sweetie, your mantra.” She closed her eyes and stood still for a moment as she went into a trancelike state.

Brooke closed her eyes, repeating the words in her head that Sevilla had always reinforced from her therapy sessions. She focused on the weight in her chest and what it would feel like if it dissipated. After a few deep breaths, she felt the heaviness lift.

“Better?” Sevilla questioned softly.

Brooke answered with a smile, “Much better and thank you. You’re a miracle worker.”

“Not a miracle worker,” Sevilla laughed. “Just someone who is able to focus on the light, and not let the dark bother her. You will get there, Brooke, but while you’re learning, you’re susceptible to both energies.”

They walked a bit further through the trees, stopping at a large Oak tree near a table fashioned out of black marble, surrounded by a circle of trees.

“This is where my journey ends,” Sevilla said, pointing to the path that cut its way through the trees. “Take that winding path until it ends, and just before you clear the trees, you will see a small hunter’s cabin. That is where my contact will meet you. Remember, once you find the object, if it has silver in its aura, you will be able to use it to transport back to the pond. If not, you will need to walk, and your necklace and journal should guide you back.”

“Who is this person, and how will we know they are the right contact?” Brooke asked, nervously grabbing Will’s hand for support.

Sevilla answered calmly as she hugged them both. “It is best for us all if you do not know his name. He will find you, and you will know him by his aura which

is red with a gray overtone. He is conflicted but passionate about our cause, and you will be safe with him. I hate that I can't provide you something to transport back to me directly, but I just can't take the chance of it falling into the wrong hands."

Brooke nodded with understanding. Not allowing magical items outside of her domain was how Sevilla had kept her safe all these years.

Sevilla smiled at her fondly and then directed her next comment to Will. "Take good care of her, Willmot, and remember all you have been taught. It might be a good idea for you to learn her calming mantra, for times of high stress."

Will nodded and thanked her as she turned to leave the way they had come. He looked at Brooke and gave her a supportive smile before taking her hand and leading her up the path that Sevilla had indicated.

It wasn't hard to find the cabin with Sevilla's directions, so even though Brooke had brought the journal with her, they didn't need to use it. She and Will watched the home for a few minutes, hidden by the trees that surrounded it, and looked for any movement that would indicate someone was there. After seeing none, they walked to the door and went inside.

The structure looked to be abandoned, with layers of dirt covering the floors and cobwebs woven in the corners where the walls met the ceiling. The only thing out of place was a small fire burning in the stone fireplace that centered the room, which told Brooke someone was there or had been recently.

She whispered to Will who had already conjured up some plasma balls in his palm, "I'm getting a bad feeling about this."

"That makes two of us, Angel...maybe we should wait outside..." he stopped mid-sentence as a hooded figure came from a small room off the kitchen and addressed them in a deep voice.

"You can put away your charges, Mage. I'm no threat to you or your woman."

“I would feel a bit more comfortable keeping them out for a while, if you don’t mind,” Will answered warily.

“As you wish,” the figure stated as he moved into the room to stand a few feet in front of them. As he lowered his hood, Brooke could clearly see his aura pulsing in a blood red color surrounded by a cloud of gray softened at the edges.

“You’re the one we were sent to find, the one who will help us,” Brooke blurted out as he met her eyes with a calculating glance.

“Indeed. However, I’m sure my contact advised you we would be proceeding without names.” He looked to Will who confirmed his statement with a nod.

“Very well, follow me.”

He replaced the hood on his head covering his dusky features and walked out of the cabin, leaving Will and Brooke to follow behind him. He was not a conversationalist by any means, only speaking when he had to give directions or tell them to watch their footing.

The woods gave way to a rockier terrain on a small incline that required climbing. Just as Brooke was getting tired, they stopped at a smooth flat surface on the side of the mountain near several inscriptions carved into the wall.

The carvings were beautifully crafted, weaving and entwining in a tall arch. When the stranger stood before it and placed his hands on the stone, he recited words she did not understand. The etchings glowed green, and it became clear that it was some sort of doorway. The stone within the borders of the etching melted away, leaving an entrance into the mountain. The stranger entered while waving for Brooke and Will to follow.

“I don’t do well in closed spaces,” Brooke mumbled as Will took her hand to lead her inside. He had long since gotten rid of his energy balls but conjured another in the hopes it would help to relieve her anxiety.

“Better?” The pulse from the ball glowed around them lighting their way.

“Much better,” answered Brooke gratefully. “That is some handy skill you have.”

He laughed as they followed the stranger down the stone hallway. “Yeah, I was thinking about adding it to my show once I get back to Vegas, that is, if I still have powers when we get back home. You never know, they might only work here.”

Brooke nodded in agreement, not wanting to think about going back home or Will going back to Vegas. She pushed those thoughts into the far corners of her mind as she followed the stranger up thick wooden stairs and through a heavy door with iron fittings.

“This is the room you will need, and this is where I leave you,” he said quietly. “If you’re caught, we don’t know one another. Understood?”

Will and Brooke nodded, and with a quick glance right and left in the doorway, the stranger slipped into the room and out of sight. By the time Brooke and Will followed him up the last few steps and entered the room, he had disappeared.

They entered the room quietly, staying on the plush rugs that scattered the floor to muffle the sounds of their footsteps. After taking a nervous look around, Brooke concentrated on the items around her, trying to determine which ones were infused with magick.

The room seemed to be carved out of the mountain from which they had entered but was similar to what Brooke would imagine the inside of a castle to be like. There were tapestries on the walls with iron sconces dotted between them, which lit the room, together with the large stone fireplace that was more than likely used for heat. The floors, where they weren’t covered with rugs, were gray stone. Although the room was enormous, the furnishings were sparse. Brooke moved toward a large wooden table with chairs that centered the room.

As she came around the table, a black blur in the corner of her eye startled her, and she covered her mouth to muffle her scream. She felt Will’s hands on her

upper arms, which immediately calmed her, as he whispered. “It’s only a cat, Angel.”

Brooke nodded as she got a better look at the animal. It sat upright in the center of the table and was staring back at them expectantly. The cat’s bright, green eyes locked with Brooke’s in an uncomfortable stare. As she moved around the table with Will, the cat remained completely still, except for its head which turned to track their every movement.

“That cat is giving me the creeps,” Brooke whispered softly, not taking her eyes from the feline for a second.

“You know how cats are,” Will whispered back. “They’re super curious. Hey, if it’s a boy, maybe we can take him back home and set him up on a blind date with Misty.”

Brooke gave him a look over her shoulder and shook her head. When she glanced back at the cat, it was no longer staring and had changed its position, actively preening itself. Its leg was straight up in the air over its head, leaving no question to the sex of the animal.

“So much for that idea,” Will muttered with a grin.

Brooke glanced back, and although it seemed they were no longer a curiosity to the cat, she still had a strange feeling about the animal.

Not finding any items on the table, she moved toward a large armoire near a small wooden desk and chair. There was a subtle glow from the floor. Moving closer to investigate, Brooke knocked a brass candlestick from the desk which rattled to the ground with a gong-like sound. Brooke cringed while looking back at Will with wide eyes. She was frozen with her fear that the worst would happen – that the Shadowman would catch them here. Crippled with panic, she couldn’t move, even though she heard footsteps coming up the hallway toward them.

Will came up quickly beside her and rubbed her arms, soothing her hands away from her mouth and calming her nerves. She realized the sound she had heard

was merely the pounding of her heart in her ears. She glanced back to the table and noted the cat had disappeared.

After a few seconds, Will whispered to her in a barely audible voice, "Please don't do that again, Babe."

She rolled her eyes as she looked into his smiling face, as if to say she hadn't done it on purpose, which rewarded her with an even bigger grin from him. They listened for a few more seconds for footsteps or signs they had been found out. Comfortable that no one had heard them, they continued their search.

She checked out the glow on the floor, which was nothing more than a few broken bottles that had held some sort of liquid. Scanning the items on the desk turned up nothing, and she was starting to lose faith that she would find anything at all. She had just decided to try another area of the room when a shimmer caught the corner of her eye near a small cabinet that held several wine bottles and glasses.

At first, she thought it was the men's sapphire ring that had caught the light. But on closer examination, she saw that the glow surrounded a small tapestry that hung above a dark stain where a bowl lay broken. As she gazed at the tapestry, it lit up like the stars at night, and her thought was she had never seen anything more beautiful in her life.

"Will," she whispered as she waved him over. "I think I've found it."

"Is the aura black with silver? Okay to use? I don't want to overstay our welcome," he whispered back as he took the tapestry down from the wall and looked over his shoulder.

"It looks fine to me, but there is only one way to find out," Brooke said as she stood in front of him, and he wrapped his arms around her waist. "Hang on to your panties."

His chuckle warmed her as he put his head down near hers. "Is that a proposition?"

“Oh no,” she laughed, “Don’t be starting that, there’s no telling where we’ll end up!”

After Will promised he would behave, she held the tapestry in front of her and concentrated on the destination. The portal opened without much fanfare, and as she stepped inside with Will behind her, she prayed they would end up in the right place.



Chapter Thirty-One



After taking Brooke and Will to the other side of the forest, Sevilla returned home and did some gardening to keep her mind off her worries. She knew they were in good hands, but she had also worked with destiny long enough to know the chain of events could always be broken or manipulated by the slightest whim of Fate.

She had lost track of time in her yard, with her hands buried to her wrists in soft loamy soil. While planting some potatoes, she heard a soft mewling behind her. She raised her head and peeked over her shoulder to see a small black cat sitting near the edge of the garden, watching her every move. Its glittering, green eyes were wise and unblinking.

Sevilla looked back toward her hands, closed her eyes, and took a deep breath to gather the patience she would need. *This is exactly what I was worried about*, she thought as she spoke to the cat without facing it.

“Hello, Zilla, what brings you here today?” she asked with a sigh as the feline shifted into her human form and answered her.

“Can’t a girl visit her sister just to say hello? I mean really, Villy, it has been an utter age!”

Sevilla rolled her eyes after glancing back and seeing the gleam in Zilla's eyes. She turned back and put in the last of the row. "Only because you're somehow incapable of allowing things to follow the paths they are destined for. And by the way," she said as she looked back over her shoulder, "You never have come here just to say hello. You always have a motive."

Zilla snapped her fingers to magically cover her nudity then feigned a pout and let out a small huff as she traveled to the chairs set up in the yard. She plopped down with ceremony, crossing her long legs, and motioning for Sevilla to join her. "Well, Villy, you know destiny was never my thing. It was always something others had a flare for. Besides, you know I am more of a live-in-the-moment kind of gal."

Sevilla stood up, brushed her hands off on her skirt as she walked over to her sister. "I'm sure you didn't come here to have a debate about what you should, or shouldn't, be doing with your powers."

"Well, you're certainly right about that," Zilla purred. "I am curious, however, to know what you've been doing with yours. It can't be helped, you know, me being a cat and all. You know...curiosity."

Sevilla looked at her sister's feigned innocence and knew instantly she had been found out. Zilla had never let anything get past her – she had eyes all over the land. Sevilla's face flushed as she tried to hide the truth. "I don't know what you are talking about, Zilla. You know very well I don't dabble. That, as it turns out, was something you always excelled at, so I always left it to you."

"In the past, perhaps," Zilla mused. "But things have changed of late, and while you might not have dabbled, as you call it, you have definitely nudged." Sevilla remained silent, watching as Zilla's eyes rolled up in the back of her head, and she went into a trance. Sevilla knew when Zilla woke, there would be no more secrets between them. Save one. She had been taught how to keep that one safe.

By the time Sevilla had cleaned up her gardening tools, Zilla had awoken, her thoughtful, green eyes blinking at her. “You do know what happens when you mess with Fate.”

Sevilla nodded silently, she didn’t need to explain. Zilla already knew the truth. Her sister looked at her for a moment longer, taking a deep breath and nodding, addressing her in the next sentence as if the last five minutes of conversation had never happened. She rose to hug her sister, her eyes warm and teary eyed as she pulled back to look at her. “I really have missed you, even if you don’t believe me.”

Sevilla smiled softly. “I believe you, Zill. I’ve missed you too, even with all things considered.”

Zilla smiled fondly before flipping a switch to the fiery version of herself. “So, how does a girl get a cup of tea around here? Or better yet a glass of wine?”

Sevilla linked her arm through Zilla’s and led her up the path to her home. “I actually have a new brew I would like you to try. You game?”

“Oh, Villy, you know I’m usually game for pretty much anything,” she said with a grin. “I can’t wait to hear what you’ve been up to lately.”

“I’ll just bet,” Sevilla said with a raised brow as Zilla gave her a wink. “Come on then let’s get this visit over with.”



Chapter Thirty-Two



Erebos was already tired of waiting and shifted on the rock where he sat, allowing the blood to flow back into the parts of his body that had fallen asleep. *Damn, Zilla, and her secrets. Where the hell was she anyway?*

He sat on the stone slab overlooking the pond and thought about the first time he had seen Brooke. She had been so uninhibited and so full of power, even then. Her connection to this place was what intrigued him all those years ago. The realization that she was meant for greatness kept him coming back.

He had been attracted to her potential, to what he would be able to use her for. In the early days, she approached him in her dreams without fear, before she was pulled away by her attraction to the boy.

He was a relatively patient man and had invested a great deal of time influencing her dreams, with the hope that one day when she came into her power, he would be beside her. He needed that power, more now than ever. But the young man who would grow into his skill and capture her heart had changed her path.

Sulking, he thought about Will and the trouble he had caused from the start. He tried to determine what it was about him that turned Brooke's head so quickly. It wasn't as though he himself was without good looks or charm. As a matter of

fact, there had been times when he tricked her into thinking he was Will. His ability to shape-shift was only minimally required since they looked so much alike. But somehow, as the years went by, her panic discerned the differences, and her fear of the Shadowman grew, along with his desperation to control her.

It had been genius manipulating Will's mind into forgetting his time here, especially since Erebos had to be sure the two would never meet in their dimension. Fate, as usual, had another plan, and his efforts to keep them apart failed miserably. His spell hadn't been strong enough, and ultimately, they had found each other.

Now, Will had been the one to go through the portal and was on his way to becoming an Elemental Mage. Will had the power he had wanted for his own, the power that could merge the two halves of his essence and make him whole.

Erebos was anxious to discover how to reverse the effects of the portal and drain Will of his powers. His desperation was the only reason Zilla was involved at all, and he cringed to think of the terms of the payment she would require when all was said and done. Gods knew if it was up to him, he'd be glad to have a hundred years pass without having to lay eyes on her again. But, as much of a thorn in the side as she was, she had gifted him a power. It was a spell so great that the next time he saw Will, he felt he could be rid of him once and for all.

The fear that Zilla would take back her gift was what had compelled him to remain at the pond by her command. That and the threat she gave before she left – that she had a lovely animal in mind that she could zap him into if he didn't. He took a flat stone and tossed it, watching as it skipped a few times across the smooth surface before plunking quietly into the depths of the pool. The ripples of the water radiated toward the shore, and he hoped Zilla would come back with news of their whereabouts soon.

“Do you really think it is a good idea to owe that cunning minx any more favors? You remember what happened the last few times!”

Erebos closed his eyes and answered the voice in his head. The voice that was becoming stronger as the days progressed. “I really don’t have a choice,” he said out loud.

“Of course, you don’t... Just keep telling yourself that. Fool!”

He was deep in the middle of a conversation with himself when he felt the air shift behind him. He turned to see the tree line split open and push out a couple holding a small rug. Erebos jumped to his feet and summoned fire into his hands, shooting the balls off toward Will and Brooke before they could react. He had been caught unawares and needed time to recall the spell Zilla had given him. In the meantime, he hoped to hold them off enough with the skills he had acquired over the years on his own.

The fire balls had startled them – it was obvious they hadn’t known he was here. Brooke yelled something to Will, tossing the rug down and raising her hands to her sides. Erebos mentally prepared for the next round of spells he would need. While he could care less what happened to Will, he didn’t want to harm Brooke in any way.

He watched with awe as a small cloud doused the flames moving toward her, and with the grace of a ballerina, she shifted her hands toward her core and pushed. It was obvious to Erebos that she had been practicing, and the thought warmed him. He couldn’t help but smile, admiring her form, until an energy pulse came out of nowhere and hit him square in the chest. Its force stunned him, sending him flying backwards into the pond below.

Brooke barely had time to react as they saw the fireball moving toward them. She couldn’t tell where it came from, nor did she have time to figure it out. She merely raised her hands, thought about water, and it was there.

The small cloud she formed from the nearby vegetation put out the flames intended for Will. She saw him duck down from the corner of her eye and reach up toward her as if to pull her down beside him. She stood her ground, fearful

that another round was coming, and scanned the area for threats. That's when she saw him.

Erebos was half-crouched on the stone ledge that extended over the pond where she and Will had met in her dreams. She was surprised to see him smile at her, almost lovingly, as she pulled her arms into her waist and pushed them forward. She had been concentrating on what it would feel like to give him a shove. No sooner had her arms straightened in front of her, that Erebos stumbled back toward the edge of the platform, falling into the pond with a giant splash.

Will reached up and pulled her to the ground, covering her with his body as the fireball Erebos shot off, before being hit with Brooke's pulse, moved past them. Will asked quickly if she was okay, and after a quick nod of her head, he got up and ran toward the shoreline – toward Erebos.

He looked like a man on a mission, and that mission was to kick the ever-loving shit out of the Shadowman. As he ran, he hurled his plasma balls, each one of them crashing into the flames thrown by Erebos who was now standing in the water knee deep. The men were equal in their skills, their pulses imploding upon impact, and neither the plasma nor flame making it to its intended destination.

Weakened from the surge of power she had just sent out, Brooke watched in horror as Erebos pulled everything he had from his core and bolted it through his right arm, throwing it like he was pitching a baseball. The long stream of black energy moving toward Will was unlike anything Brooke had ever seen, and from the looks of it, the plasma balls that Will sent out had absolutely no effect.

Erebos remained focused, cracking the stream of energy like a whip around Will, coiling around his arms and hips, and stopping him dead in his tracks. Still weakened, she watched helplessly as Will fought against the power that had him trapped and winced as Erebos whipped him sideways and dropped him to the ground like a giant rag doll. Looking over at Will lying on the ground near the water's edge, her heart stopped when she realized he wasn't moving.

Will had been completely knocked out from the shock of the Shadowman's power, and she couldn't tell from her vantage point if he was breathing. Erebus raised his hands once more, causing Brooke to scream as he sent one last bolt toward Will's prone body.

"Aveho memoria," he shouted as he pushed forth an inky, black force from his hands.

The darkness oozed toward Will, surrounding him like a cocoon and expanding in size until it completely covered him. She could no longer see Will. The darkness moved, pulsing as if it had a life of its own. She pulled every last ounce of energy from her drained body and staggered to her feet moving toward him.

She didn't give Erebus time to savor the pleasure of completely immobilizing his target before she sent every bit of energy she had left into her next thought. She closed her eyes and visualized pulling the water with her left hand and pushing out ice with her right. As his fireballs came toward her, they bounced against the invisible force her essence had created with the dew in the grass.

She was empowered and safe in her element, the force field letting nothing harm her, but at the same time, allowing her to use her magic defensively. There was a tingle up her spine as the water in the pond came up from behind Erebus like a tidal wave. It curled down on top of him soaking him instantly. She simultaneously blasted him with an ice spell from her right hand, opening her eyes in time to see the blue ice harden around his knees. The frozen surface quickly traveled up his damp body and immobilized him, making it difficult for him to talk.

"You don't understand, Brooklyn, I..."

The ice moved up his body swiftly encasing him completely and giving him a statue-like appearance with his arm raised high above his head, and his darkly handsome face frozen in the middle of a sentence she would never hear. She

took a few seconds to see if the ice would be enough to hold him before turning her attention to Will.

The black substance surrounding Will faded slightly, and she ran toward it hoping he would be unharmed. As she reached the mass, she noticed its translucency was fading quickly into a silky, gray smoke. She frantically looked through it for Will, unable to see his form anywhere. She called his name until her voice was hoarse. Helplessly, she watched the smoke disappear, and when it cleared, the only thing she saw was Will's hematite necklace. There was no sign of him anywhere. He had completely vanished.

She picked up the necklace, racing back to the frozen figure in the pond, shaking with enraged fear. "What have you done to him, you bastard?" she screamed through her tears. "Where the bloody hell is he?"

Erebos remained still, frozen by the spell with which she had encased him, and for the first time in her life, she wished he could speak to her. She needed answers, and he couldn't talk. She punched him in the chest over and over, begging him to tell her where he had sent Will, but the only message she received was a handful of bruised knuckles. She walked back to the shore and dropped to her knees, crippled by the worry she had for Will, her tears making hot trails down her cheeks.

Brooke's panic consumed her, and she was unable to think straight for the first time in weeks. She knew she needed to find out what Erebos had done, where he had sent Will, or if he had harmed him in any way. But the feeling of hopelessness and dread immobilized her. In the depths of her mind, she knew she wasn't going to get any answers from him, and every second she was outside of Sevilla's homestead, she remained in great danger. But her brain shut down. As she lay in the soft grass in a lump of helplessness, she sobbed as the skies turned black, and the rain fell.



Inky darkness surrounded her. Brooke lay in its wide lonely expanse, eyes closed and tears streaming down her face. Curled up in a fetal position, she was broken. As the falling rain soaked her, she hardly felt the discomfort, embracing the solitude of her fractured mind. She wanted to stay here forever, in the place where she could escape reality. Escape the place where she would live without her heart.

Voices threatened her haven, coming to her in small bits and pieces that made no sense, between the sounds of cracking ice and falling rain. She didn't want them to make sense. She didn't want to try to figure out what they were saying. She wanted to be left alone.

"Is she.....? What the.....ed?"

"Can't.....Ereb.....you do?"

"Brooke.....hear me?"

At the sound of her name she pulled herself up from the dark place and unwillingly cracked open her eyes. Her vision was blurry, and she tried to focus on the two figures bent near her, or maybe she was seeing double. They were identical. She shut her eyes. She didn't want to deal with any of it. Darkness welcomed her back.



Brooke woke to the sounds of voices, muffled and soft coming to her through the floor of her room in Sevilla's house. She couldn't recall how she got there but assumed Sevilla must have come to look for her and brought her back. She had been there with Will...she had to find Will!

Her head throbbed, and her heart raced. The storm outside worsened as the thunder rumbled so loudly it shook the walls. She lifted herself from the bed and attempted to walk, but her legs were too weak to hold her. She crumpled to the

floor beside her bed, and the inky blackness of consciousness consumed her again.

elle

Chapter Thirty-Three



Erebos was colder than he had ever been, his frozen body standing in the shallow waters of the pond where he had fought Brooke. He looked for her as best he could with his head locked in place, but she was nowhere to be seen. He could have sworn he saw Zilla earlier but must not have since she would have surely thawed him.

He was stiff, having stood here for days, wondering what happened to Brooke and if his spell worked on Will. He was in awe of her power since she had been able to keep him frozen all this time, even after the rain had poured down over him. He feared her power as well, knowing if Brooke ever decided to come back for revenge, he might not survive the battle.

He heard the soft swishing of footsteps in the grass approaching him and struggled to see who was coming.

“Well, well, well, what do we have here?” Zilla purred with a toothy grin as she walked around the frozen form of Erebus. “It seems the Elemental might be a bit stronger than you had counted on, darling, and now look who has gotten themselves in a right little mess.”

Erebos glared at her through the sheen of ice that covered his face. Where the hell had she been? She was the last person he wanted to see, but at the same time, he knew Zilla was the only person he could count on to release him. Knowing she would want her “favor,” he cringed internally. Gods only knew what she had in store for him.

His musings were interrupted by the feel of Zilla’s hands rubbing along his ribcage and moving up toward his chest. Her touch warmed him in areas he had no control over, which was infuriating since he was powerless to do anything about it. It also angered him that he could so easily be side-tracked from his mission by her touch.

“That is what we get for tempting Fate,” she said with her kaleidoscope eyes gazing directly into his. “And as we know from past history, she is a fickle mistress. It seems you have caused quite the problem. Now I will need to clear it up with her. I have to say, I am rather miffed.” She clicked her tongue and shook her head, as if to tell him he had been a naughty boy. “You know, I just hate doing this to you. I like you so much better in control of your senses. Fixing this is going to cost you yet another favor. Seems you and I will be spending a lot of time together in the near future.”

She ran her hands up over the crisp lapels of his waistcoat and placed her hands on either side of his face, looking deeply into his glaring, blue eyes. She pouted, practically reading his mind as she berated him softly, “There is no need to be like that. You know I will get you out of there soon enough.”

Her touch was maddening, warming his insides and causing his blood to flow through areas in his body that were completely immobilized. She was practically glowing from the power she wielded over him, her lips moving closer to his as he stood motionless. Forced to look into her eyes, he was unable to fight her, and in many ways, unwilling to do so anyway.

In a breathless voice, she whispered, “This won’t hurt a bit, lover,” before placing her lips on his and beginning to thaw him slowly.

She started with his lips, and by the time his mouth was loose enough to talk, he was too swept up in the moment to utter a word. It was one of the most erotic things she had ever done to him, kissing him while he was powerless to do anything about it, and as his mouth warmed along with the rest of his face, he responded to her demands with the sweep of his icy tongue.

Still unable to move, the torment was acute as he kissed her, anxious to touch her and feel the warmth of her skin, but unable to do a damn thing about it. His impatience was contagious as she finally thawed his arms with a sweep of her hands, enabling him to hold her. The relief of lowering his arm and returning the blood flow to them was nothing compared to the satisfaction of being able to gather her to him, tight to his chest, where she belonged.

The rest of the thaw happened in a burst of moving hands, stroking tongues, and the electrical pulse she had surrounded them with. As soon as the water around his ankles thawed, he backed her up onto the shoreline and pushed her down into the soft grass where she opened to him with a contented sigh, happily giving him the reins.

He warmed his hands under her skirt, caressing her silky thighs and sliding his fingers up toward the heat that drove him mad. She was pulling at his shirt, dragging him up along her body to kiss him once more as he kept one hand under her skirt and brought the other to tug at the strings of her corset-like top. With the ties loosened and her breasts pulled free, he warmed his face between them, feeling her moan vibrate on the tip of his tongue.

This woman was his lode stone. He craved her and hated her, loved her and despised her, and for all her faults, she was the most beautiful creature he had ever known.

He pulled himself out of his pants, freeing the last part of his anatomy that needed to be thawed and watched her face glow as he pushed it into her warmth. They didn't speak. The only sounds heard were the whistling chirps of the birds and her soft moans as he paid her back the only way he could. He knew the cost to his heart would be dear, but with Zilla, he was powerless to do anything less.

ele

Chapter Thirty-Four



Brooke wasn't sure how long she had been out, but she needed to get up. She could no longer shelter in the safe haven of her mind. There were people counting on her. She had her soul mate to find.

She recalled falling, but at some point, she had been put back in bed. She was still weak and slowly swung her legs to the side, waiting until the waves of light-headed nausea passed. Pushing herself up, she hung onto the bed frame as long as she could before walking to the window to look outside. Sounds of an intense storm tickled her memory, and the view out the window confirmed it. Even though the sun was out, and the birds were chirping, the signs of bad weather were evident by the multitude of trees and branches that dotted Sevilla's yard.

Sevilla was walking up the pathway, deep in conversation with a woman strolling next to her. The other woman wore a dress that was a bit tighter and had her hair down, but even with those minor differences was the spitting image of Sevilla. Brooke wasn't aware she had a sister, let alone a twin, and suddenly realized that Sevilla had kept a large part of her life hidden from her. But why?

She took a few steps back, sliding behind the sheer curtain to keep an eye on the conversation under cover. After the women shared a brief hug, the stranger

turned to look up at the window where Brooke stood. Her face broke into a smile as she raised her hand and wiggled her fingers in greeting.

“Shit!” Brooke said, ducking under the windowsill and cursed at herself for letting the woman see her. She waited there with a racing heart. When minutes went by and nothing happened, Brooke took a chance and slowly raised her head to peek.

Sevilla was standing alone, gazing out toward the creek, deep in thought. The strange woman was nowhere to be found. Brooke hoped she hadn’t come inside because she needed to speak to Sevilla. She wasn’t sure if she could handle meeting someone new.

As she moved from her hiding spot, she paused, spying a small black cat bounding purposefully toward the gateway. It hesitated slightly. Then with a quick blink of its glowing, emerald green eyes and quirky turn of its head, it turned and looked right into the window where Brooke stood. If Brooke didn’t know any better, she would swear it was the exact same cat that had been in Erebus’ study. The cat waited briefly, its clear eyes gazing into Brooke’s, and then seconds later, bounded down the pathway, through the gate, and disappeared into the woods.

“I didn’t know Sevilla had a cat,” Brooke murmured under her breath. Noticing Sevilla was coming inside, she turned to make her way downstairs. “Time to get some answers.”

As Brooke entered the kitchen from the stairway, Sevilla greeted her with a relieved hug. The stress of her experiences washed over her, and Brooke broke down, finding herself once again wrapped in Sevilla’s arms. Brooke tried her best to speak in complete sentences but couldn’t calm down. Her shallow breaths made her words incoherent.

“Hush, you’re safe now. You have to remain calm, sweetheart, your powers are imbalanced.”

Sevilla ushered Brooke over to the kitchen table, indicating she should sit. “Before we go any further, I need to make you some tea and something to eat. In your weakened state, your anxiety will easily take charge.”

Brooke nodded in agreement and tried not to fidget. Sevilla started the water while Brooke looked around. She saw no sign of the mysterious woman who had been speaking to Sevilla earlier. As the kettle heated over the fire, Sevilla pulled together a quick breakfast of muffins, eggs, and fruit and placed them in front of Brooke. Her head was still foggy, and she must have zoned out based on Sevilla’s next comment.

“I know you’re worried, honey, but you have to eat. It’s been so long since you’ve had anything.”

“What do you mean long? How long? And what happened to Will?”

A small look of surprise crossed Sevilla’s face before she spoke. “I brought you back here more than a week ago. You have been incoherent the entire time. When I couldn’t wake you, I let you rest. I was hoping you could tell me what happened to Will.”

“A week?”

Brooke was in shock. So much could have happened to Will in that time. What had she done? While her fragmented mind gave her a forced nap, he could have been wandering around lost or fighting off who knew what. It angered her that with as much power as she presumably had, her anxiety and panic still were in control. If Will was gone forever, she would never forgive herself.

Sevilla went to the fireplace and finished the tea, placing a mug in front of Brooke. “I need you to drink this entire cup, no matter how bad it tastes.”

Brooke shook her head quietly and sipped the thick, overly sweet liquid. The tea smelled like the candle Will had purchased in Maui, so Brooke knew one of the ingredients must be lavender. Sevilla sat beside her and asked for the details of what happened.

While she nibbled on a muffin, Brooke started the story from the beginning, telling Sevilla know everything from meeting up with the stranger and entering the study, to running into Erebos at the pond and fighting him. She was careful with the details, recalling each one and describing it as best she could. She hoped that within her memories Sevilla would find some clue to help her locate Will.

“You say he had surrounded Will with a black substance and shouted the words ‘aveho memoria?’”

Brooke nodded, “That’s right. I think it might be Latin. I recognize the second word, which I think means memory.”

“It does,” Sevilla said softly. “The first word means remove.”

Brooke’s heart sunk to the pit of her stomach. “Why would he need to remove his memory now? Isn’t it too late? Will and I have already crossed through the portal.”

“I’m not sure,” said Sevilla. “Only Erebos can answer that, or so it would seem.”

“Well, he is frozen in the middle of the pond, or at least he was, so I’m not sure he will be giving us any answers anytime soon. Oh, Sevilla, what if he hurt him or worse what if Will is de—”

“We must not think that way,” Sevilla answered with confidence. “You need to remain strong. In the meantime, you must leave this realm. Your spell won’t hold Erebos long.” She stood, pointing to Brooke’s tea. “You need to finish that. I’ll go upstairs and gather your things.”

“I can’t just leave. We need to find out what happened to Will,” Brooke cried, pulling her hands back from the boiling cup.

“Brooke, you will not be any help to Will if you stay here. I can make some inquiries once Erebos is thawed, and I can try to get some answers. But in the meantime, we must ensure your safety. It is up to you to find the other elements. We must maintain balance.”

Brooke nodded and took a deep breath to calm her nerves. By the time Sevilla returned with her bag, she had repeated her mantra at least ten times and felt much better. The tea, as terrible as it was, had some calming effects, and the breakfast had strengthened her. When Sevilla sat back down at the table, Brooke asked the question that had tickled her mind.

“I was wondering who you were talking to earlier on the path. She looked a lot like you.”

Sevilla evaded the question, and Brooke’s eyes. Then responded. “No one of consequence.”

Abruptly, Sevilla stood up and paced back and forth near the hearth. She was preoccupied, almost edgy, and she was making Brooke nervous. She sipped the last of her tea, curious to know if Sevilla would fill her in. She didn’t have to wait long.

“You mentioned earlier a cat in Erebus’ study. Was it black?”

“Yes, it was, with brilliant, green eyes. It gave me the strangest feeling while I was there, as if it was watching my every move. You know, it was strange, but I thought I saw it leaving earlier when I glanced down from my window.”

The color drained from Sevilla’s face, and Brooke could have sworn she heard her mutter that she was going to ring someone’s neck.

Brooke felt her anxiety creep up another notch. “Sevilla, what is going on?”

“Everything is going to be fine, Brooklyn. It’s just a shift I wasn’t anticipating, but we should always be prepared for at least three versions of reality since we never know what havoc outside influences will create.”

“Does the fact that you’re talking in riddles have anything to do with the person of ‘no consequence?’ You’re making me nervous, Sevilla. Please tell me what’s wrong.”

Sevilla squatted beside Brooke and took her hand. “I’m sorry for being so secretive, Brooke. The answer is yes, I believe my visitor might have had

something to do with the changes in the destiny I originally viewed. However, I'm only able to share certain things at certain times with you. Now is not one of those times. We need to get you home before Erebos is released, or there is no telling what type of imbalance that would create."

Brooke didn't push it. There was something going on, and players involved that she wasn't aware of, but she didn't feel she was in the right frame of mind to sort it all out. She had to trust Sevilla. Even if she had secrets to keep.

Sevilla pointed to the rug that had left on the floor just inside the doorway. "I see you found the tapestry. Erebos will be unable to come to you without it. I believe it was how he was able to connect via your dreams. Was it easy enough to use to transport back?"

Too drained to argue, Brooke allowed the abrupt change in subject. "Your contact took us right to the room we needed to be in. He was helpful but mysterious. He disappeared right before we entered the room and located the tapestry. It was pretty easy to use it to get to the pond, and I would have been here sooner, except for the run in we had with Erebos."

Sevilla's eyes filled with tears. "I promise we will find out what happened to Will. I know you must be very worried."

Brooke looked at Sevilla, her eyes brimming with tears. "It is killing me not to know. I lived so long without him in my life. It's not fair I have to do it a single moment more."

Sevilla squatted near Brooke's chair. "Brooklyn, I believe Fate brought the two of you together for a reason, and no power in the Universe can keep the two of you apart if you are meant to be together. Will found you before, he will do it again. I believe that in my heart of hearts."

"I'm going to hope you're right, Sevilla. It's all I have to hang onto."

Sevilla stood and held her hand out to pull Brooke from her seat. "You will be going back by way of the tapestry portal, and just like you did here, you will

need to visualize a specific place and time you want to return to. You should be able to return to a time shortly after you dove down toward the elemental portal, directly onto the boat you left. Going to any other location might cause some questions and a rift in time.”

Brooke nodded, she completely understood. If she were to go back to any other place or time, she couldn’t control who might witness someone appearing from thin air. Besides, she had to get the boat back before they sent search parties out looking for them.

Sevilla hugged her. “You can use the tapestry to come back here after things calm down. Wearing the necklace I gave you when traveling will bring you just inside my domain. Please keep it safe at all costs. In the meantime, I will work on answers for you.”

Brooke nodded as she took out the tapestry and held it in front of her. After taking the bag Sevilla had quickly packed for her, Brooke focused all of her energy into visualizing the boat she and Will had left behind. She felt the warmth of the breeze as it touched her skin, heard the sounds of the waves slapping against the boat, and imagined the placement of the equipment as they left it.

She pictured the Molokini Crater, its craggy walls rising from the water where they had moored, and when she felt comfortable enough that she had the vision locked in, she opened the portal and stepped through the darkness.

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Chapter Thirty-Five



Brooke stepped onto a firm surface that rocked beneath her feet, making it back to the boat exactly as she and Will had left it. She noticed the sun was high in the sky, and after checking the watch she had left in her dry bag for the date and time, she noted that only three hours had passed since the time they had taken their dive. She found it strange – so little time had passed here, even though they had been at Sevilla’s for over a week.

As she moved toward the controls, she couldn’t stop her eyes from misting and her hands from shaking. She wasn’t sure she would be able to function without knowing what had happened to Will. She detached the boat from the buoy and secured their belongings, moving forward to start the engine. She took a moment to stare out over the ocean, watching the sun reflect on the waves, and drew strength from her element. She would need it in the days to come.

Her mind wandered back to something her therapist had always told her: “Even the most overwhelming tasks are completed one step at a time, like piecing the squares on a quilt.” The first step for her was getting back home without any questions asked. The next step would come to her as she moved forward.

Returning the boat to Alan was a challenge, especially since they had left their suitcases there. Brooke explained that Will had gone ahead to arrange for a hotel for one more night and left her in charge of gathering their things. After saying her goodbyes, she headed back to the hotel and booked a room for the night. She was in desperate need of a shower and a soft bed, and the flight she booked didn't leave until the next afternoon. She left Will's suitcases by the door, having removed the luggage tags so she could check them as her own. She didn't know what else to do. She clung to the desperate hope that he would be at the timeshare waiting, and she could return his bags when she got back.

She occupied her mind with menial tasks, emptying the bag they shared when going through the portal and packing the items in each of their suitcases. It didn't take long for her to situate her belongings, pulling out what she needed for the night. Her movements were automatic, her mind had shut down, and she felt very much like she had after her parents died. It was as if she had no specific direction but still needed to follow a path.

The shower was hot, and she made quick work of washing her hair and body, having gotten used to navy-style showers in the past few months. She had just finished rinsing the conditioner from her hair when a crippling wave of sorrow gripped her. Sobs wracked her body, and wailing moans echoed in the shower stall where she stood. Grief consumed her and eventually sent her down to the bottom of the tub where she curled up in a ball and cried. How was she ever going to live without him? The first time had practically driven her mad. She wasn't sure how she would survive the second.

The water stayed warm, massaging her grief with the sprays combined with the tears that circled the drain. It was the last coherent memory she had until she woke up the next morning in the hotel bed, wrapped in her towel. She was still completely alone.

While waiting for the cab and on her way to the airport, she chanted non-stop to keep her panic at bay. After checking their luggage and receiving a slightly strange look from the bag attendant, she made her way to the gate, happy to see the passengers already boarding. She switched her phone to airplane mode and buried it at the bottom of her purse before the smiling attendant scanned her boarding pass. She sullenly thought that there was nothing to be smiling about.

It took a full hour in the air before she broke down. The tears flowed, and her hands shook uncontrollably. As tempted as she was to lock herself in the restroom with the tapestry and conjure a portal to Sevilla's at 3,000 feet, she decided that wasn't her best idea ever and did the next best thing. She ordered a double from the flight attendant and told her to keep them coming.

When Tara picked her up at the airport, she asked Brooke what was wrong. It had to be evident that Brooke was a hot mess since her eyes were puffy and red, and her demeanor drained. She silenced Tara's questions with a shake of her head, letting her know she wasn't ready to talk. True to form, Tara nodded and took charge of loading up the luggage and getting Brooke home. She had to give Tara credit. She had even kept quiet about the fact that Brooke had more luggage coming back than when she had left.

Tara drove to Brooke's apartment in silence, glancing over every few minutes to see if Brooke was ready to spill. Brooke knew what Tara was thinking and wanted to ease her concern, but she just didn't have it in her. They walked up the short walk to her flat, Tara carrying Brooke's bags as Brooke pulled Will's behind her. As Brooke unlocked the door, she felt Tara's hand warm on her arm.

"Brooke, obviously something has happened. Did you want to talk about it? Is there anything I can do?"

Brooke shook her head slowly and answered in a small, cracking voice. "I'm not sure I would know where to begin. It is something I need to sort out, but I really appreciate your offer." Brooke looked up at Tara, her eyes reflecting the hurt and

pain she felt. She needed someone to talk to, someone she could release this burden to, but Tara wasn't the right person for that. The right person had disappeared before her eyes. "I'm sure I just need some sleep, Tara. It has been a long flight. How about I call you tomorrow?"

"Of course, you're right. You must be exhausted," Tara said as they entered Brooke's place and lined the luggage up in the doorway. "Get some sleep, and please be sure that if you need anything, no matter what time it is, you call me."

"I will, lovie, thank you."

Tara gave her a quick hug then turned and pulled the door shut behind her. Brooke stood in the middle of her living room, surrounded by packed luggage and memories, and never felt so alone.



Chapter Thirty-Six



It had been four agonizing weeks, and Brooke still had no idea if Will was dead or alive. She had gone by Will's time share shortly after her return, realizing quickly it had been rented out to a family of four. The small bikes in the driveway and lawn littered with beach toys, brought tears from the well she thought had run dry. She wondered if Will liked kids, if he would want some of his own, and prayed one day she would still be able to ask him.

She had made a quick trip to Sevilla's only a few nights before, using the tapestry along with her necklace. Just as she had said, it brought Brooke right to the house, within feet of the front door.

Sevilla had no news. She had asked all her resources and put messages in with a few that had yet to get back to her. She had even gone as far as attempting some scrying – to see if perhaps by looking into the future, she could find out what had happened in the past. She didn't have any luck. As a matter of fact, she had found her abilities were mysteriously blocked.

Brooke had spent a few days at Sevilla's, sitting outside near the creek and listening to the soothing sounds of the water. She couldn't go to the pond quite

yet – it wasn't safe. Even though she loved it there, she found she had no desire to return. It was too soon.

Sevilla gave her space and kept the tea brewing, which went far to soothe Brooke's frazzled nerves. They had even examined the journal, which had no changes they could see. Brooke thought it was worth a try even though she had been through it front to back every night since she had come back. By the end of her visit, they had gotten no further, had found no signs of Will, and Brooke's heart was ten pounds heavier.

Brooke sat, staring at Will's suitcases in her living room. She had pulled them out of the closet where she had kept them since returning, never having found the strength until now to open them. She was afraid seeing his things would bring on another round of anxiety that she wouldn't be able to control, but it was time. Her aching heart had caused enough rain. She couldn't wait any longer. While she didn't allow herself the hope there would be clues that would lead her to him, she thought perhaps holding something of his would fill the gaping hole in her essence.

Brooke took hold of the handle and wheeled the larger case over to the couch. Placing it up beside her, she unzipped it and caught a whiff of Will's sandalwood cologne. The air was knocked from her lungs. Memories of Will came flooding back into her mind. It about did her in, and it took every ounce of strength she had to continue her search.

Opening the side pocket, she found the candle he had purchased on their road trip in Maui. Smiling through the mist in her eyes, she placed it on the table and continued her search. She found his wallet in the same pocket, along with his phone, and pulled them out with the last tee shirt she had seen him wear. The sandalwood scent was strong, and she buried her face in it, breathing deep. Her mind had long ago connected him with the scent, and she hoped wearing it tonight would bring her a good night's sleep.

She pulled her phone from the table and dialed his number as she had off and on since she got back. Brooke knew it would go directly to voice mail. She had his phone, and the battery was completely dead. She hadn't bothered to charge his phone, but it didn't need to be charged for her to call it and hear his voice.

His message came through the phone, warm and inviting, asking her to leave a message at the tone. She had been calling it for weeks, but she could swear this was a new message. Could he be alive, or was she just imagining things? She hung up the phone just as she had done each time before, allowing the tears to flow and hope to fill her pained heart. Knowing he was alive would end the torment. But if he was alive, why hadn't he contacted her? The questions racing in her mind exhausted her.

Brooke woke hours later, lying on the couch and snuggling with his tee shirt like a child with a blanket. She felt remarkably good and glanced at the clock to check the time. A full three hours had gone by, and Tara would be coming shortly for their weekly girl's night. She quickly zipped Will's suitcase and put it back in the closet. She scooped up his shirt, wallet, and phone to take into her room.

On her way up the hallway, she noticed a yellow receipt sticking out from his wallet and pulled it out. Always one to have things neat and tidy, she opened the receipt intending to re-fold it and place it back inside. Her eyes caught a message written at the bottom of the receipt, and she realized it was from the hotel flower shop in Maui. Her heart sank as she read the details. He had sent a potted orchid to Trina in Las Vegas the night before they went through the portal – the night they had first made love. What caused the knife through her heart was the message he had sent with it.

“Thinking of you, Sweetie, and hoping all is well with the baby. I will be home soon. Can't wait to see you! Love you, Will...”

With her hands shaking, and her world falling apart all over again, she folded the receipt back inside his wallet and placed it on her dresser. She sat on the bed in shock, doubly saddened because he had disappeared out of her life, and that her original fear had been right on the money. It did seem he had been with someone else, and from the way the note read, he was starting a family with her.

I should have known better, she berated herself. *I knew it was too good to be true*. Her mind flashed to Trina. He did have a real life that could never include her. Was Trina waiting in Vegas for Will to return? Had she filed a missing persons report? If so, she had to be worried out of her mind. She was unsure what to do with this new information and was saved by a knock on the front door. She braced herself for the girl's night she and Tara had planned.

Tara had been Brooke's biggest support. She made sure Brooke's fridge remain stocked, texted her daily, and invited herself over no less than two nights a week. Over the past few weeks, Brooke slowly fed her bits and pieces, leading Tara to believe that she and Will had decided to go their separate ways. She had even hinted that she thought Will had another interest back home, and it pained her to know that there might be some truth in that now.

She let Tara in, noticing the pizza from Pizza Boy's and the twelve pack of beer she was carrying. After placing the items in the kitchen, Tara gave Brooke a quick hug and brief evaluation. Brooke didn't meet her eyes, and Tara took that as a sign something was terribly wrong.

"Are you ok, Brooke? What's happened?"

Brooke gave her what she hoped was a convincing smile. "Nothing, I'm good. Just got up from a nap, so a bit out of it." Tara wasn't convinced.

"Sweetie, it's been a month. You need to get out more – really out, not just working. Trust me, I know better than anyone that break-ups are horrible, but you have got to snap out of this. I'm worried about you."

“Thanks, Tara, I know you are. I’ll be good. Trust me.” Brooke laughed at Tara’s expression, which said yeah right, without coming out and saying it.

“Truly?”

“Truly,” Brooke answered with a smile. “Come on, I picked out some great chick flicks and have a new bottle of nail polish just itching to be used.”

“That’s more like it.”

Hours later, after the pizza was gone and the second coat of nail polish was on, Brooke glanced down at her phone. The screen indicated a message, and on closer examination, she realized it was a message from Will. A million thoughts screamed through her mind at once, and her hand shook as she reached for her phone.

“Girlie, you look as though you’ve seen a ghost! What is it?”

“It’s Will,” she whispered simply, not trusting herself to say anything more.

Tara put her hand on Brooke’s leg to get her attention. “I think you need to talk to him Brooke, at least hear what he has to say. Maybe he misses you.”

Or maybe it wasn’t Will at all, but the Shadowman messing with her head, thought Brooke. “I don’t know, Tara, it’s so complicated.”

“Brooke, it has been four weeks, and the guy has finally attempted to get a hold of you,” continued Tara. “Aren’t you going to at least call or text him back and see what he has to say?” Tara patted her lap when she saw Misty enter the room. The cat proceeded to hop up and curl into her lap. “At the very least, I would think you would want to get the last word in.”

Brooke looked up from the phone and shook her head. “Tara, I have no desire to hash through what I’m sure was a terrible mistake on his part. And I don’t always have to get the last word in.”

“Yes, you do.”

“No, I don’t,” Brooke twittered nervously. “Okay, maybe I do. But be that as it may, he gave me the impression at times when we were together that he was

distracted. While he didn't come out and say it, signs pointed to him having a girlfriend. I can see that now."

"You don't know what is going on with this Trina chick, if anything," Tara said in a disappointed tone. "Listen. I just know you have been moping around this apartment, and it isn't healthy for you. I'm not judging. I have no idea what it is like to have anxiety and what is going on inside that gorgeous head of yours when you're panicked. However, when it starts affecting your ability to function, you need to get a handle on it."

Brooke let her friend's words sink in, the truth of it stinging like peroxide on a wound.

"You need to stop running away, Brooke, and face your fears. What is the worst that is going to happen if you ask for the truth?" Tara gave her hand a gentle squeeze before finishing her thought. "And what is the best that could happen?"

Brooke closed her eyes and laid her hand over the necklace Sevilla had given her, willing it to give her the strength. "You're right, Tara, I should at least listen to his message. I'll be right back."

She dialed her voice mail as she walked to her room, and by the time she sat on her bed, was listening to the message. It sounded like Will, his masculine voice soothing her through the phone, but he sounded confused.

"I see this number has called my phone several times. If I know you, could you please leave a message? I had to get a new phone and lost all my contacts. Uhh...thanks."

He was alive. It had to be him! Her heart sang at the same time it broke all over again. His message sounded as if he didn't remember her. He didn't remember her! God damn, Erebus. His spell must have worked. Will had completely lost his memory. No wonder she hadn't seen him in her dreams.

She could call him back. Maybe it would trigger some distant memory for him, but she hesitated. She didn't want to be the cause of anyone's unhappiness, even

at the risk of her own. There was no denying she and Will were attracted to one another, but their relationship was built in a dream world. If he had a responsibility or commitment to someone in reality, would it be right for her to get in the middle? Did she want to be the other woman?

The receipt she had found indicated to her that Trina was an important part of his life, and if his memory had been erased, maybe it was the best thing that could have happened. He could have a fresh start with the woman he had planned on making a life with – a plan he had before he ran into Brooke and dredged up past feelings.

As much as she wanted to be the love in his life, she needed to stop living in a dream world. This was reality, and Will's reality had responsibilities to someone else. Knowing he was alive was going to allow her to move forward. For him, not remembering was going to allow him to be happy. As much as it tore her heart out, she had made her choice. She was going to leave him alone and let him live his life with Trina. Perhaps one day, she would be able to move on with someone else, although she rather doubted it.

Tara didn't question Brooke as she entered the room, though the expression on her face clearly said she wanted to. After Tara left for the night, Brooke slept better than she had in over a month. Although her heart was broken from the decision she had made, the knowledge that Will was alive and safe from the Shadowman lifted the worry from her shoulders. Peace washed over her for the first time in weeks.



Chapter Thirty-Seven



Will opened his eyes, momentarily confused as to where he was. He looked around the room at the shelves of boxed magic tricks and the posters of rock stars from the 90s and realized, with a groan, he was home. While he didn't necessarily remember arriving the night before, he did remember he had some business to discuss with his parents and a decision that they were waiting to hear. A decision he had yet to make.

His body groaned as he pulled it from the torturous twin bed his mother insisted on keeping in his childhood room. He had told her time and again it was fine for them to remodel. They certainly had enough money, but she was one for sentimentality. He wished she could be sentimental about everything but the bed. He could hardly fit in it growing up, let alone now, and had the backache to show for it.

He looked around the room for his suitcase, confused as to where he might have put it. The pace over the last few months had been grueling with two shows daily to save enough money to be off during Trina's maternity leave. So, it didn't surprise him that he had misplaced his bag. Hell, he was always misplacing his crap. Why would this trip be any different?

Glancing over to his dresser, he scanned the top for his phone and keys, not finding either of them, there or near the bed. His leather jacket was pooled on the floor next to the clothes – he must have peeled it off before going to bed since he had woken up in his boxers. As a last resort he checked the pockets in both, shaking his head at the thought that Trina would have had a heck of a time harassing him about being a slob if she were here.

Will gave up on the search quickly. A few years back, he had gotten into the habit of keeping a supply of clothes at home. With his crazy schedule, he needed to be as flexible as possible, and he was able to make more last-minute trips home if he didn't need to pack a bag.

He needed to get in the shower. For some reason, he felt particularly grubby – plus the hot water might help loosen his back. Sleeping in his postage stamp sized bed hadn't done him any favors.

He rummaged through his childhood dresser for something to wear, pulling out the jeans and white tee he had left during his last visit. After a lengthy shower, he got dressed and took one more look around his room for his things before heading downstairs.

He found his mother seated at the table in the breakfast nook, reading the news and enjoying her morning coffee. She seemed momentarily surprised to see him and raised her cheek to him for a dutiful kiss.

“Darling, I didn't know you came in last night. Did you have a nice time in Florida? Or haven't you gone yet?” She laughed gaily, “Your schedule is impossible to keep up with!”

Will shook his head laughing. His mom was a few donuts short of a dozen, but he adored her. It was his dad he didn't see eye-to-eye with.

“Haven't gone yet – just finished up the show and thought I would spend some time here.”

Her smile threatened to split her face. “That’s marvelous! Your last stay was much too short! Your father will be thrilled!”

Will laughed out loud. “I wouldn’t necessarily use the word thrilled. You know how he is.”

She got up from the table, waving her hand as if dismissing what he said. “I have been with your father for years, and he just has a different way of showing excitement.”

“I’ll bet,” Will murmured wryly.

“Oh now, enough of that. No fighting while you are here.”

“No, Ma’am,” he said with over-exaggerated innocence.

She laughed and nodded, probably figuring that was the best she was going to get. “Are you hungry? I can make you an omelet.”

“Don’t trouble yourself. I can pick something up later.”

“Nonsense,” she cooed, “I was just getting ready to make myself something. It won’t be any trouble at all.”

Will followed her to the counter, pulling a mug from the cupboard as she gathered the ingredients for breakfast. After asking if she needed help and being shooed away, he poured himself a cup of coffee and sat at the table.

“I was wondering if you saw my phone. I can’t seem to find it.”

His mother laughed and shook her head. “Well, that isn’t surprising. You know how you are.” She turned around with a grin in time to see him rolling his eyes and turned back to the stove with a giggle. “Did you check the table in the foyer?”

“No, not yet,” he said as he stood up from his seat and walked toward the front of the house. He checked around the foyer, looked on every piece of furniture in the living room, and even peeked in the downstairs bathroom. Nothing. He went back into the kitchen and had a seat, just as his mother put a ham and cheese omelet on the table.

“Any luck?”

“Nope. I’m sure they’ll show up. Thanks mom, this looks great.”

“You’re welcome, Sweetie.” She stirred the fixings for the second omelet and talked to him over her shoulder. “So, how is Trina feeling?”

“She is doing good. She wanted me to say hi.”

“She’s such a sweetheart. I never understood why you two never got together.”

“She’s my business partner,” Will said with a shake of his head. “Besides, it just never went there. We’re better off as friends.”

She turned and gazed at him with a look of melancholy. “It just would have been nice to have you settled by now, maybe even starting a family. I worry about you.”

“Don’t worry about me, mom, I’m fine,” he said with exasperation and a mouthful of eggs.

She finished cooking her breakfast, plated it, and joined him at the table with a sigh. “I realize that, but it would be nice to have grandkids one day.”

Will laughed heartily. “Well, I wouldn’t hold your breath.” He noted her pout and laid his hand on hers. “Mom, I am hardly marriage material right now. I don’t even own a car.”

She smiled, her eyes creasing at the corners, her laugh lines noticeable in the morning light. The slight wrinkles surprised him – he had never noticed them before. “When the right girl comes along, you not owning a car won’t even be an issue.”

Will laughed, “Let’s hope she doesn’t have issues with me living paycheck to paycheck or not owning a house either.”

His mother did not look amused. “You know you don’t have to live like that. You have options.”

“I know I do,” Will muttered as he took their dishes and his mug to the sink.

“But sometimes, living without options is easier.”

His mother let the conversation drop as she always did when it got testy. She was the queen of avoidance. He loaded his plate in the dishwasher and refilled his coffee before sitting back down at the table.

He riffled through the paper, locating the sports section and skimming the headlines. The pictures in the paper weren't what he expected and momentarily confused him. *Since when does football start in April?* He wondered why his mother would be reading nine-month-old newspapers and glanced up to see if she noticed. She must have felt him staring and turned the top edge of the paper down to give him a smile. Either she didn't notice or didn't care.

He looked back to the article that outlined the success of his favorite team. They had won the first four games of the season and were the chosen favorite for the home game this weekend. *This couldn't be today's paper.* He shook his head unbelievably, his eyes wandering up to the date, and his stomach tying itself in a knot. *Jesus! This can't be right.*

His question came out barely over a whisper. "Mom, what day is it?"

"Tuesday, Sweetie..."

"No, I mean the date," he said, cutting her off.

"October 11th. Why?"

His heart stopped. He couldn't believe what he was hearing. Was it some kind of elaborate joke? He couldn't imagine his mother would go along with anything like that – she was too honest. Besides, she looked completely confused and really concerned. He was sure she wasn't the only one that looked like that. He was plenty of both as well. The last thing he remembered was saying goodbye to Trina and the crew in late April. Yet the date on the paper and his own mother were telling him it was mid-October. *How the fuck did I lose six months?*

He stood up, tossing the paper on the table as if it had burned him. "Mom, where are the rest of the newspapers from this week?"

“In the utility room in the recycling bin. Why? Is there something wrong? You look as though you have seen a ghost.”

Will shook his head, willing some of the blood that had stopped pumping to go back up to his cheeks. “No, I’m good, just wanted to take a look at the ads.”

He turned and left the room quickly, hearing her voice from the kitchen as she responded to him. “Is there something you need to pick up? I need to run out shopping later. We could go together.”

Will responded as calmly as he could while flipping through the newspapers one by one. “Yeah, there are a few things I have to get. We could go in about an hour.” He looked at the dates on the papers for the last two weeks. They were all dated October. Fear crept into his mind quietly, like a thief in the night, and settled in his spine for the long haul. It didn’t make sense, couldn’t possibly be right, because if it was, it meant that he had lost track of six months of his life.

He left the utility room quickly, going back to the table where his mom was just folding up her paper. “Mom, where’s your phone?”

She pointed toward the foyer where he had searched for his phone earlier. “My purse is out by the door. It should be in there. Will, are you sure everything is all right?”

He nodded and gave her what he hoped was a reassuring grin, “Yeah, it’s fine, mom, just need to make a call and have no idea where I left mine.”

“Ok, well then I will head upstairs and get ready. Was there anywhere in particular you need to go?”

He shook his head as he left her at the table and yelled from the other room. “Nowhere special.”

Will spied her purse on the floor and pulled out her phone. “Maybe just somewhere that sells phones,” he muttered to himself. Looking at the date and time on her home screen, his heart sank all over again. It matched the date on the newspaper. His mind frantically grasped for a logical explanation, for something

that could explain how his mind could have misplaced months of time, but couldn't come up with a thing.

He had to get a phone, get his contacts re-established, and get a hold of Trina. If it was truly October, she would have had her baby, and if that was the case, it would confirm he had lost his mind – or worse. He dropped his mom's phone back in her purse, wishing he knew Trina's number by heart, and looked out the front window that overlooked the driveway. No rental car. How the fuck had he gotten here from Vegas?

He knew two things for sure. He was knee deep in shit without a shovel, and he was keeping it to himself until he could figure out what the hell was going on.

Four hours and twenty shops later, they poured into the front door of the house with more packages than Will could count. His mother had insisted she buy him some clothes since he hadn't brought a bag with him, and they were having dinner with his father. He conceded. There was a new Italian restaurant she was anxious to try, and all he stored at the house was jeans and tee shirts.

One of their first stops had been to replace his missing cell phone. Even if he had left it behind in Vegas, he needed to make some calls that couldn't wait. Since all of his bills were set up to be paid automatically from his account, he didn't worry his service had been shut off. However, he was concerned that the contact list might not switch to the new phone and let out an audible sigh of relief when it did. There was nothing worse than re-entering an entire contact list from memory. With his memory, it would have been impossible.

Trina had been his first call. He had gotten her voice mail, the message stating she was probably napping, keeping the same schedule as the baby. He left her a quick message telling her he would see her soon and realized he had confirmed what his gut was telling him. He had definitely lost some time, and until he got to the bottom of it, he was keeping his mouth shut. His mother tended to be a hypochondriac, and if she knew, there was no telling what kind of tests she

would insist he have. Other than the stress headache he was sure he brought on himself, he felt fine, and he didn't want to stay here any longer than necessary. There had to be a logical explanation for what was happening.

He followed his mom up the stairs, carrying her purchases and dumping them in her room before heading to his own. She mentioned she was going to take a short nap before his father got home, which surprised him almost as much as the wrinkles had earlier. Since when did his mother nap?

Back in his room, he paced the floor, going through every scenario that could explain his current situation and coming up painfully short. He checked his phone for the third time since arriving home. Trina still hadn't called back. What was he going to say? Should he tell her what was going on? The answer he gave himself was a resounding no.

She had just had a baby, and he didn't want to worry her. He decided when she called back that he would keep the conversation limited and try to determine if she had interacted with him over the last few months. He found it impossible to believe she would have let six months go by without checking on him at least once or twice. At the very least, she would have called about having the baby.

His pacing took him across the room to the bathroom where he flipped open the medicine cabinet to find some aspirin. His head was splitting. As he swallowed the aspirin dry, he found himself hoping that was all it was. *Great, now who's a hypochondriac? It's not a tumor, just need a nap.* Lying on his bed, he closed his eyes, willing the ache in his head to go away. He woke up three hours later with the pain gone and feeling a bit more himself – until dinner with his father that is, when the headache returned with a vengeance.

“What do you mean you aren't sure you want to work for the firm? I thought we had gone over this.”

“Howard, lower your voice,” his mother admonished under her breath. “There are people trying to enjoy their dinner.”

“Yeah, I am one of them,” Will quipped, having the decency to blush at his mother’s glare.

Oblivious to the interaction, his father continued his rant. “We have allowed you to chase this folly long enough. It is high time you did something responsible. When your grandfather set up that trust, it was with the intent that you were going to take over the family business.”

“Dad, I realize that, but I’m not cut out for suits and business meetings. I never have been.” Will glanced at his mother before continuing. “I really love what I do, and if I can make a decent living doing it, then I owe it to myself to give it a shot.”

“You owe it to this family to grow up and face your responsibilities.”

“What your father is trying to say,” his mother soothed, “is you are our only son, and we aren’t getting any younger...”

“Nancy, that is not what I am saying,” Howard snapped.

“Well, it is what you should be saying since it is the truth,” she responded quickly, straightening her spine and adjusting the napkin in her lap. Will watched as she glanced over to her husband, love and respect softening her eyes, and was surprised to see his father take her hand and lift it to his lips. The movement was quick, almost as though it had never happened, evident only by the blush on his mother’s face.

She cleared her throat, speaking softly to Will, ignoring the tension that hung over the table like a cloud. “Willmot, your father has had some medical concerns lately that have him evaluating his...”

“Nancy, I don’t think....”

Will interrupted them both. “What do you mean medical concerns?”

“It is nothing to worry about, Will. While there are issues, they are being closely monitored,” she answered softly. His father was being abnormally quiet, and for the first time, Will realized he looked different. “We both are getting older, and

we need to know the business will be taken care of, along with the people who work there and their families.”

Will nodded, allowing what she said to sink in, feeling guilty that all along he had been treating this decision as if he were the only one it affected. “Go on.”

“Your father and I have spoken of this at length, and we hoped you might consider a compromise.”

He looked back and forth between his parents, amazed and thankful that his father was letting his mother take the lead on the negotiations.

“I know how much your work in Vegas means to you, so I suggested that your father allow you a part-time position with the firm to prepare you for the future, should you ever have to step in. He has agreed that most correspondence could be done through email, and you would only need to be present at the monthly board meetings. You should be able to work it around your schedule, and your father is willing to be flexible, aren’t you, Howard?”

His father...flexible? Will was flabbergasted. He looked at his father again, for signs that he was terribly ill. He looked healthy as a horse, but at closer examination, had the same lines and crinkles on his face that Will had noticed earlier on his mother. For the first time in his life, he was smacked with the realization that his parents were getting older, and unlike the decorations in his bedroom, they weren’t going to live forever. He had been so busy chasing his dreams, he hadn’t considered they had dreams as well.

His father didn’t answer her, only took her hand in his and pulled it below the tablecloth. Will wondered if he was seeing things correctly as his normally stoic father gave a playful wink to his mother. He was stunned. These weren’t the parents he had grown up with, and he couldn’t help but wonder if maybe he hadn’t lost any time at all, but had been sucked instead into an alternate universe. He had a newfound respect for his mom, who was beaming at his father as though she had just won the lottery. Something happened recently, something he

hadn't had a part in. He had the distinct feeling they faced a crisis and made it through, their relationship grown stronger because of it. The idea of this compromise had his mother written all over it, but his father going along with it was mind-boggling. Maybe his mother wasn't a donut short of a dozen after all.

"I think part-time is something I could do," Will said, softly addressing his father. "Maybe I could go into the office with you tomorrow, and you could show me around."

His father smiled, and Will noticed his arm tightened as he gave his mother's hand a gentle squeeze under the table. He cleared his throat, ever the professional, and gave Will a quick nod. "We'll leave in the morning at eight."

By the time Will was introduced to the staff and had completed paperwork with the corporate attorney, two weeks with his parents had passed. After the first two nights in his twin bed, he managed to convince his mother to purchase a queen and was subjected to his father's grumbles about how Will had created a monster. How was he to know she had never set foot in a Pottery Barn? His father's complaints were lessened by a small smirk that hovered around the side of his mouth, and for the first time in his life, Will felt as though they were sharing a moment.

He spent most of the days at the office with his father, going through reports and becoming familiar with the firm and its inner workings. His father had even arranged a special meeting of the board to make introductions and to discuss some of the current projects Will would be assigned to. They were incredibly supportive of his desire to keep his interaction part-time, and by the end of the first week, he felt great about his decision.

It had already had a positive effect on his father, who seemed as though a great load had been lifted from his shoulders. Will would often walk into a room at home, only to catch his parents in the middle of a quick kiss or soft touch.

He had asked his Mom what had brought about their life change, and she shrugged it off, saying it was something they had worked through. It was clear she didn't want to go into details, and he certainly wasn't going to ask his father. He didn't have that kind of a relationship with him so let it go. He was glad, moving forward, he would be spending more time at home. Maybe it was time to mend bridges.

Trina called him back late the first day, apologizing that she hadn't answered. She had turned her phone off while taking a nap with the baby in her attempt to squeeze extra time out of Katy's typical two-hour sleep cycle. Their conversation revolved around the baby and the typical things new mothers spoke of such as diaper changes and burping. What their conversation didn't touch on was the fact that he couldn't remember a damn thing since saying goodbye the night of their last show. Will decided the questions he needed to ask her would be best suited face to face. He honestly wondered where he would even begin.

After finalizing things at home and promising he would be at the next board meeting, Will rented a car and made the six-hour journey back to the strip. He still had a room, the hotel had agreed to extend his lease before he left on vacation since they had booked him for upcoming shows. He checked the front desk for mail and was reminded that he had arranged to have Trina pick it up.

His room was stale, the scent musty and dry, as if no one had been there for some time. He was more or less staff at the hotel, in charge of his own space, so housekeeping rarely checked in, although they were known to vacuum or dust for him from time to time. Nothing looked out of place as he glanced around the room, looking for his suitcase. Pulling open the dresser drawers, he checked the contents, finding he was rather shy on clothes. From every indication, it looked as though he had packed and taken his luggage with him. So, where the hell was it?

He unpacked the small bag he had borrowed from his mom, putting away the few things he had brought with him from home. He checked around the room, taking a peek in the bathroom and under the bed, just to be sure he hadn't left his phone behind. Just as he suspected, it wasn't to be found. He pulled out his new phone to send Trina a quick text to let her and Tony know he was on the way. Time to get some answers.

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Chapter Thirty-Eight



It was a quick 30-minute drive to Trina's place in Henderson. Tony, Trina's husband, met Will at the door. He waved him in and turned back toward the living room where Trina was rocking the baby. She shot Will a smile while simultaneously lifting her finger to her lips and signaling for him to be quiet. He looked around for a place to sit and decided the couch was the least cluttered. As he pushed some things over to make space, he looked around. There was bubble-gum pink paraphernalia scattered as far as the eye could see. He was amazed that anyone so tiny could require anywhere near the amount of stuff he was seeing.

Trina nodded to Tony, who walked over and automatically held out his hands to receive the baby. Will thought the couple looked much like a well-oiled machine, one picking up where the other left off, without so much as a word. Tony took the small bundle into the bedroom, where Will was sure she was being put to sleep, and Trina turned her hundred-watt smile his way.

Will stood to give her a hug, but she was moving slowly. He hesitated, not entirely sure where his arms should go or where she was hurting. She took the decision out of his hands by wrapping her arms along his side and up his back

laying her cheek on his chest. His arms came up along her back and squeezed tight. It was good to be home.

“Gently,” Trina said with a laugh, “Still a bit tender.”

“Sorry,” Will said, taking a step back, “Did I hurt you?”

Trina laughed, “It would take a lot more than a firm hug to hurt me. You want a beer?”

“That sounds great. I can get it.” Will headed to the kitchen, talking over his shoulder. “How about you guys?”

“I’m breastfeeding, so just water for me. But I’m sure Tony will join you.”

Will took two beers from the fridge and opened them. Tony was just walking back when Will brought them to the living room.

“You know it,” Tony agreed as he took the beer Will offered. He joined Trina on the couch, leaning to give her a kiss on the cheek and a playful wink. “Katy’s all set in the bassinet. She was out like a light.”

“Thanks, honey,” said Trina, taking Tony’s free hand. She didn’t lose anytime giving Will the third degree about his trip. Will managed to evade specifics and turned the conversation quickly back to Trina, asking questions about the baby.

Will sat in the vacated rocker and sipped his beer while Trina gave him a blow by blow of her labor. He supposed he had asked for it, but he wasn’t ready to bring up the whole I-think-I-lost-my-mind conversation. As she rattled on, he wondered why women found it necessary to go over every detail of their childbirth experience. He found it even more fascinating when they compared notes well beyond their childbearing years. It was as though by giving birth they were indoctrinated into a secret society, with code words, secret jokes, and a wealth of knowledge. His mother still went on about how long she had been in labor with him, and that was thirty years ago.

He caught Trina saying she had gone into labor early and that Katy was born pre-mature. He hadn’t known that and asked questions about the birth. She

assured him everything was fine with both her and Katy and gave him a curious look before sending Tony off to grill them some burgers. As soon as he was out of the room, she started drilling him.

“All right, Will, what the hell is going on? Is everything all right?”

He didn’t know how to respond. She couldn’t possibly know exactly what had happened to him but obviously knew him well enough to know he was hiding something.

“I don’t know what you’re talking about.”

“Something smells like tuna, and it isn’t what Tony’s making for lunch,” Trina leaned forward and whispered loudly. “First, you didn’t tell me anything about your vacation or seeing your folks. Then, you ask for details on stuff you already knew about.”

Stuff he already knew about? He decided to let it out. There was no beating around the bush with Trina. “I honestly don’t know what is going on,” he said simply. “All I can tell you is two weeks ago, I woke up at my parents’ house with no recollection of how I got there. My last memory was saying goodbye to you and the staff on closing night.”

Trina leaned back with her hand over her mouth, her face full of concern and confusion. She responded in a hushed voice full of disbelief. “Will, that was over six months ago. How is that even possible? Were you hurt? Hit your head?”

Will shook his head. He had thought of that but had no bruising or signs of injury. “No, I don’t think it’s anything like that.”

“Well, how do you know? Have you been to see a doctor? Had an MRI? What if you have something wrong with....”

“Trina calm down, you’ll wake the baby,” Will joked softly. The last thing he needed was to stir the hormone pot on a new mother. Was she tearing up?

She pulled a tissue out of the box on the end table and dabbed her eyes. “The baby can sleep through anything,” she said, waving through the air. “I swear to

God, Will, if anything happens to you, I am going to ring your damn neck!”

“Well, then I better hope I don’t end up in the hospital, or you’ll put me in the hospital.”

“Not funny.”

“Listen, Trina, there is nothing wrong with me. Other than the lapse in memory, I seem to be fine. But I need your help.”

She calmed visibly. “I’m listening.”

“I need you to help fill in some blanks for me.”

“Sure. Like what?”

“Like whether or not we spoke or texted in the past few months.”

Trina looked at him with disbelief. “Of course, we did. All the time. Doesn’t it show on your phone?”

Will shook his head. “That is the strangest thing. When I woke up, I couldn’t find my phone. I had to get a new one in California, and thankfully, some of my contacts transferred. But any prior texts or photos are gone. I never upgraded to that service.”

“So, no way to track what you received,” she mused. “I’m not sure what’s left on my phone. I’m sure most of those messages were erased by now.” Her purse was on the side of the couch, and she rummaged through it pulling out her phone. “I can tell you for a fact we texted at least once a week, and we spoke days before Katy was born.”

“We actually had a conversation?” Will was perplexed. How could he have spoken to Trina and not remembered? Maybe he did have a tumor.

“We talked about my early labor. You calmed me down and told me everything was going to be ok. I received that orchid the next day.” Trina pointed to a plant on her end table. “Today, when you started asking all those questions about Katy being pre-mature, I knew something was up.”

“Do you have any idea where I was at the time? Who I was with?”

Trina pursed her lips as if she were considering the question. “You never gave me a name, but I had the distinct impression, from your texts, that you had met someone. You seemed a little pre-occupied.”

“Well, I’ve had a bit on my mind,” he grumbled, trying not to take her comment personally.

“You also seemed really happy and relaxed.”

“So, did I mention a name?”

Trina shook her head while scrolling through the messages on her phone. “Nope, and I was right, I’ve erased your messages.” She fell back on the couch with exasperation, squinting her eyes and mumbling to herself. Will realized she was sorting out the puzzle in her mind, trying to find something that would give them direction. He let her think. He had run out of ideas, and Trina was really good at problem solving. She straightened with a gasp as if she had had a great epiphany.

“You know, we could try the flower shop to see if they can tell where the order came from. That might at least give you an idea of where you were.”

“You’re brilliant! Good thing you’re the brains of this outfit.”

Trina laughed, already on her feet and heading toward the orchid. “I think the florist info is on this card... Yes, right here. Let me give them a quick call.”

“Before you do, I’ve got one more question.”

She sat down, turning in her seat to face him. She couldn’t hide the look of concern.

“It’s nothing bad,” Will said with a smile, “I was just wondering if you knew someone by the name of Brooke.”

“Brooke?” Trina shook her head. “I don’t think so, you have a last name?”

“No,” Will said, “But it’s the strangest thing. When my contacts downloaded there was a number for this Brooke person in there. It’s weird, but someone from that number has called a couple times since I got my new phone. They never

leave a message. I must have put her in as a contact at some point, but I just don't remember her. I thought maybe it was someone you knew."

Tony came in from the kitchen, announcing dinner was done. Trina gave him a smile and told him they would be there in a minute. He snuck quietly into the bedroom to check on the baby while Trina dialed the florist's number.

"I don't know anyone by that name, but maybe the florist can give us... Hi there, this is Trina Reynolds. You brought me a delivery a few weeks back from a friend of mine, and I was wondering if you could tell me if the order came to you directly or through another shop." She looked over at Will and held her hand up pretending to write and pointing to the table by the recliner. He nodded his head and picked up the pad of paper and pencil that were lying there, handing them to her.

"Ok, I'm ready."

Will watched as she wrote the information down, trying to read it upside down. She repeated the information to the florist before finishing her call. He couldn't believe what he heard. Had he really sent flowers from Hawaii?

"So, does this shop name mean anything to you?" asked Trina. "Do you remember being in Maui?"

Will shook his head, nothing was ringing a bell.

"Come on," Trina said with a frown. "Let's go in and eat. I'm starving. We can use the laptop to look up the florist's website. Maybe it will bring something back for you. In the meantime, how about texting that Brooke person."

"That sounds good. I can't think when I'm hungry." He gave her a quick hug before following her into the kitchen. "Thanks, Trina. You don't know how much I appreciate this."

"Oh, don't thank me yet! Because I don't care what you say, you're making a doctor's appointment in the morning. You need to get checked out."

Will shook his head. There was no way he was going in for tests. “I feel fine. I’m sure it will come back to me.”

“Typical man answer,” Trina answered wryly as she led him to the kitchen and fired up her laptop. “You could have lopped off an arm, leaving yourself with a bloody stump, and your response would be...‘I feel fine.’ The problem is Will, you aren’t fine. Not being able to remember months of time isn’t normal. I’m worried about you.”

“Will’s lost his memory?” Tony questioned as he handed them each a plate. “You ok, dude?”

Will nodded, “I’ll be fine. I’m sure it will come back.” He looked over at Trina who was building her burger while shaking her head.

“Yup, typical man answer,” she mumbled softly.

“I know you worry, Trina, but I’ll sort this out. You need to concentrate on taking care of Katy now.” He set his plate on the counter, deciding answers were much more important than eating, and started looking up information for the florist. Tony walked up behind Trina and took her plate, prompting her to sit while he finished loading it for her. She sat next to Will, looking at the website along with him.

The flower shop website was typical of most, providing a multitude of arrangement choices, plants, and services. What interested Will most was that the shop was located inside a hotel on the island of Maui. The site provided a link to the hotel website, and he filed through their pictures to see if anything was familiar. Nothing was. He decided he had nothing to lose by calling them.

After being connected to the front desk, he gave his name and asked if by chance he had made any reservations in the last few months. He was shocked to hear that he had checked in only three weeks before. How could he not remember? How the hell did he forget going to Hawaii? He wasn’t sure what to do next and was about to hang up when he thought of one more question he could ask.

“Was there anyone else listed on my room?”

“Why yes, sir. We show a Brooke Fisher being assigned a key.” The attendant paused as if she realized she shouldn’t be divulging information over the phone. She asked quietly, “Is everything ok, sir?”

Everything was not okay, and Will couldn’t pull enough of a thought together to respond. Brooke Fisher had been there with him and was assigned a key? Who the hell was Brooke Fisher? “Thank you, yes. I appreciate the information.” He hung up only having answered one question... Brooke was a contact in his phone because he knew her. Now, all he had to do was figure out how.

After promising to call Trina in the morning, Will went back to his hotel room and pulled up the Maui hotel website on his laptop. He went through every picture on the site and still couldn’t remember a thing. One of the links took him to a site that offered diving tours of the Molokini Crater, which was just off the coast of Maui. Will felt a tingling sensation in his fingers, and the longer he stared at the picture, the surer he was it was important to him somehow.

He pulled off his clothes, tossed them on the floor by his bed, and climbed between the sheets. Turning on his side, his head laying on the pillow, he stared at the picture on the screen. He had never been to Hawaii, certainly had never been to Maui, and never in a million years would he have gone scuba diving near a volcanic crater. So why was the voice in his head telling him otherwise? He was tired of thinking, exhausted from a long day of traveling, and sleep found him in a matter of minutes.



Will opened his eyes, awakened by the chirps of birds and the rustle of leaves over his head. He was sitting with his back against rough bark in a never-ending row of trees, extending out on either side of him. Wiping the sleep from his eyes,

which seemed silly since he was fairly sure he was dreaming, his gaze touched on the clearing and beyond.

There was a pond just a short walk from where he sat, surrounded by lush green grass and a rock ledge jutting out over its calm surface. The pond wasn't what caused his heart to stop, it was the person standing next to it that did.

From his distance, he was unable to make out specific features, yet his body urged him to his feet and compelled him forward. As he moved closer, the feeling of familiarity grew, so much so that when she turned to look in his direction, he practically ran the last few steps between them. She was the most stunning woman he had ever seen – her golden hair rippling in waves past her delicate shoulders, her blue silk nightgown sparkling with her slightest motion. He immediately thought of a water nymph or mermaid, as if she were born from the pond she stood by.

There was recognition in her expression, and she graced him with a smile as if she knew him. This couldn't be a dream. It had to be heaven, he was sure of it, because she was an angel. Just as his mind started to touch on a thought, she threw herself in his arms and tucked her head under his chin. Even if his mind didn't know her, his body and his soul did. She was like a puzzle piece that had slid into place.

"I'm so glad you're all right, Will. I was so worried," she muttered into his chest, squeezing her arms tightly around his neck. He hugged her back. This was so much different than what he shared with Trina earlier. That hug was a friend comforting a friend, but this was two souls connecting. He was allowed a few seconds of bliss before she pulled herself away frowning.

"You shouldn't be here," she whispered, looking in both directions. "You really need to go."

She cleared her throat and lowered her eyes. He wondered what could possibly make someone that anxious. He decided nervous or not, he wasn't going

anywhere until he got some answers.

“I don’t even know where here is,” he started. She looked up, and her eyes brimmed with tears and an elusive emotion. Even with her tears, her eyes were amazing – in two different colors that almost matched the streaks in her hair. “I don’t even know who you are,” Will added in a hushed voice. “I feel like I should.”

He hated to see any woman cry, often avoiding it at all costs. But seeing this woman cry made his soul ache – made him want to give her anything within his power.

“Honestly, Will, it will be better for you if you don’t remember. Better for all of us.” She glanced behind him again as if expecting someone to come from the tree line. Before he could ask what she meant, she cupped his cheek gently and gazed into his eyes, whispering a phrase he had never heard before.

“Expello Somnium.”

Before his world went black, he heard her whisper, “I’ll always love you.”



Will woke with a start. Images of the woman he had just dreamed of flickered in his head like an old black and white movie. He saw her in his mind’s eye, not only as he had seen tonight, but in other places and times. As a child, playing hide and seek, as a young girl, smiling shyly after their first kiss, and as a woman, warm and glowing in his arms. The realization came to him in a flash as memories of her filled his mind and body like an endless stream of electricity.

“Brooke,” he managed to say, before doubling over in pain as his mind was injected with a lifetime of memories in a flash. The feeling of pins and needles covered his entire body in waves, and when the pulses slowed, he dragged himself to the bathroom to wretch. He remembered this feeling, he had had it

before, when learning to control his powers. He had powers! He wondered if they still worked.

Ignoring the pain in his head, he turned his hand over and looked down at his palm, willing a small lightening ball to appear. He saw its glow for seconds before the force sent another wave of nausea through his body. His stomach cramped, and he got sick once more, realizing it was too much too fast. Without Sevilla's crappy tea, he would have a hard time grounding.

He couldn't believe that bastard had fucked with his memory again, making him forget the things he and Brooke had shared. It was worse than before. The Dreamcreep had caused him not only to lose an entire chunk of time, but the memories that went along with it. It was bad enough to have your dreams deleted, but to have actual experiences ripped from your soul was unforgiveable. The spell he used this time must have been stronger. Will needed to find a way to stop him from meddling once and for all. He needed to find a way to keep him out of Brooke's life – forever.

He stayed on the floor of his bathroom until he was sure he could move then slowly made his way to the bed and his phone. It was late, and there was a time difference, but he needed to talk to Brooke – to make sure she was okay. She was probably worried sick. He decided as he dialed her number that she would forgive him for the late call and waited with bated breath for her to pick up. He tried several times, but she never answered.

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Chapter Thirty-Nine



Brooke didn't know what to do. Will had remembered her and had called non-stop for weeks, texting almost every night. The words in his messages varied but held a consistent theme as the days went on... He missed her, he wanted to see her, and he was confused about what happened. The other consistent message he left was the simplest of phrases, "I love you, Angel, and I always will." It broke her heart a little more each day she heard it.

Brooke couldn't bring herself to return his calls, she was too afraid she would reopen the wounds that she had sewn shut with avoidance and excessive amounts of cheesecake. It was bad enough she had to hear his voice on a recording, but to have a conversation with him scared the bejeezus out of her. She was trying to be strong, trying to do what was right, but it was getting harder to avoid his calls. Especially, after the dream they had shared.

Tara had dropped by to tell her the details of her latest blind date fiasco when Brooke's phone vibrated with an incoming call. She flushed, not able to avoid the pick-up-the-god-damn-phone look that Tara gave her. Tara had made it perfectly clear that she felt Brooke needed to make a decision, but only after she saw what Will had to say for himself.

“All right, all right,” Brooke blatted as she took a deep breath and lifted the phone from the table. She couldn’t take it anymore. Trina or no Trina in his life, she needed to talk to him. She was going to take his call. As she looked down at her phone, she realized immediately the number wasn’t his. “Not Will,” she said softly, putting the phone down.

After a few minutes, the phone rang again, and on closer examination, she recognized the number had the same area code as Will’s. *Must be trying from a different phone*, she mused, as she took a deep breath and braced herself for the conversation that was long overdue.

She answered the call on the third ring, but never in a million years could she have prepared herself for the eight words she heard next: “Brooke? Hi, this is Trina. We need to talk.”

As Brooke listened to the woman on the other end of the phone, she watched Tara wander into the kitchen. She hoped she was grabbing alcohol – she was going to need it.



“Oh my God, I have made a horrible mistake,” Brooke gasped as she closed her eyes and clutched the phone like a lifeline. “I don’t even know where to begin.”

“Well, the first step is to tell him how you feel, but I have to tell you, he deserves nothing less than hearing it from you in person. We have been friends for a pretty long time, and I have never seen him so torn up over a woman. I’m not sure what caused him to lose his memory, but once he got it back, he lost his ever-lovin’ mind trying to get a hold of you. You have a lot of splainin’ to do, Lucy,” Trina said with a chuckle, “Or at least you do if you care for him the same way he does you.”

Brooke didn’t hesitate to blatt out the next sentence as the tears started to fall. “I’m in love with him, Trina, more than I could ever imagine, and I have been so

miserable trying to do what I thought was right.”

Trina laughed, “Well, that at least makes me feel a bit better. I’m glad to know Will is putting his heart in such good hands. Anyone that would be willing to put their own happiness on hold for a stranger is all right in my book.” Brooke heard the coo of a baby in the background.

“Will was asked to cover for a headliner who had an injury. Since you weren’t returning his calls, he took the job – probably trying to keep his mind off you.” Brooke felt twinges of guilt turning her stomach into knots. Trina kept chatting without a break, “So, what that means is you’ll have to come here. I hear flights are cheap right now, and I know this fabulous show with a hot illusionist that I might be able to swing tickets for.”

Brooke smiled and felt a half-ton weight lifted from her chest. She owed this woman big time. “Is this weekend too soon?”

Trina laughed gaily, sounding as if she was relieved as well. “Nope, not at all! Give me a call with your flight plans, and I will pick you up at the airport.”

“Thanks, Trina,” said Brooke. “You have no idea what this means to me.”

“Hey, don’t thank me yet, I’m just excited he has someone in his life, so I can maybe take a day off once in a while. It’ll be nice to have someone else that he can saw in half. You game?”

“Well, I guess there is a first for everything,” Brooke joked, promising in the next breath to get Trina the flight information as soon as she was booked.

When she hung up, Brooke was practically floating. Her smile beamed from ear to ear as she took a sip of the drink Tara had put in front of her.

“So, what’s up Bee? You have a change of heart?” Tara asked innocently, taking a sip from her own glass.

Brooke smiled at her friend. “How do you feel about a trip this weekend to Vegas? I have some things I need to take care of.”

Tara pretended to contemplate it for a few seconds before yelling out, “When do we leave, baby!”

“Not soon enough,” Brooke giggled, taking another sip of the worst drink she had ever had and promised herself she was going to enjoy every bit of it.



A petite, feisty blonde flagged them down at the luggage return, looking as though she were going to explode out of her skin. Brooke knew right away she was going to get along fine with Will’s best friend.

“You must be Trina,” Brooke said, leaning into Trina’s hug.

“It is either that or you’re being hugged by a complete and total stranger... Wait a minute, you are being hugged by a complete and total stranger!” Trina’s laugh was contagious, and Brooke took the next moment to introduce Tara, who got the hug treatment as well.

“So, how did you know it was us?”

Trina picked up the smallest of the bags, giving Brooke a wry glance. “I have heard enough descriptions of you to know to look for the gorgeous girl with the crazy hair. Although I must be honest, Will’s descriptions don’t do you justice. Funky hair or no...you’re stunning.”

Brooke blushed and followed Trina’s lead as she walked toward the parking area. She had never been one to take compliments easily, but the way Trina said it was so matter of fact that Brooke had little time to feel embarrassed.

“I hope you don’t mind, but I decided to take you back to my place for a bit. I thought it would be a little more comfortable for us to do our plotting...I mean talking there,” she said with a wink. “Besides, breast feeding is a bitch. You can’t be ten feet from the baby at any given moment without taking the chance your tatas will explode.”

Tara's wide-eyed expression made Trina laugh. "Oh sorry, I hope I didn't offend. I tend to be a bit open with things."

Tara shook her head, smiling, "Not at all, I'm totally fine with the topic. It's the visual that has me cringing."

Trina popped the trunk on the car and helped them settle the luggage before heading to the driver's side.

"Sorry about the car seat. It's too hard to move in and out, so we leave it in all the time. I think you can still buckle if you lift it up a bit."

"I have it," Tara said with a smile. "There is plenty of room back here. Don't worry about me." She buckled herself in the backseat while Brooke settled in up front with Trina.

Brooke waited until Trina backed out of her parking space before starting a conversation.

"So, how do you like being a mom so far?"

"I absolutely love it," Trina said with a soft glow in her eyes, "I can't wait for you to see the baby. She is just a doll and already has Tony wrapped around her tiny little finger. He is just in awe of everything she does."

Brooke smiled at that, picturing Will as a father and imagining he would pretty much be the same. It warmed her to think of them building a life together, especially since she knew now that was exactly what she wanted. Now that her decision was made, she couldn't imagine taking any other path in life. She was anxious for the journey to begin.

She had been a lot of places, but Henderson, Nevada was by far the dullest looking. There was brown everywhere. Grass was something of an anomaly, and the houses, all designed in the adobe style, dotted the landscape with hardly a tree to distinguish between them.

They had the air running in the car, but she knew the heat outside packed a punch, registering 104° on the console's digital thermostat. The dry, skin-baking

heat was a far cry from the moist, breezy humidity of the seaside in Florida, and she started to get nervous that if Will decided he still wanted to be with her, living in Nevada could take a lot of getting used to.

After ten minutes of non-stop girl-talk, mostly initiated by Trina, they pulled into the driveway of a small peach-colored stone house and drove into the two-car garage.

“We can just leave the stuff in the trunk. We won’t be staying long, although we would love to have you for dinner.”

Tara and Brooke looked at each other and agreed with a nod to accept the invitation, especially since they hadn’t had anything to eat in over six hours.

“That would be great, Trina,” Brooke said as she entered the house behind her.

“But only if it isn’t an inconvenience. We could always get something at the hotel.”

Trina made a pish sound from her pursed lips, waving her hand down and shaking her head. “No trouble at all, especially since Tony will be doing the cooking!” Her smile was contagious as they entered what Brooke thought was the living room but looked like baby central. There wasn’t an inch of space that wasn’t covered with a baby gadget, something pink, or a how-to book.

“Excuse the mess. It kind of goes along with the territory,” Trina apologized as she reached for the tiny bundle a man the size of a lumberjack was handing her. She gave him a quick kiss. “Ladies, this is my husband, Tony. He has known Will for years and has been brought up to speed with why you’re visiting.”

Tony extended his hand to Brooke and shook it firmly, engulfing her hand in his.

“It is really nice to meet you, Brooke, I’ve heard a lot about you.” She must have looked worried as he quickly explained, “Not from Trina – I know you guys just met – from Will.” She flushed as he chuckled and continued his comment. “Only good things, of course. I’ve actually heard nothing else from him for the past two weeks, so I’m glad you’re finally here to put him out of his misery.”

Brooke inwardly groaned as she recognized his teasing grin. “Let’s just hope I’m not going to make things worse,” she mumbled with a nervous smile.

Tony shook his head in denial. “Not in a million years! I’ve never seen a man so wrecked over a woman. You being here will be the best thing that ever happened to him.”

Brooke looked up into his sincere eyes and thanked him before Trina waved him out to start dinner. She walked over to where Trina and Tara were cooing over the baby and sat next to them on the couch, glad to be off her feet for a bit.

The baby was asleep, swaddled loosely even though the temperature in the room was comfortable. Brooke peeked over Tara’s shoulder, looking into the tiny face of angelic innocence and then into the adoring face of her mother.

“She is beautiful,” Brooke whispered. “Trina, she’s perfect. What’s her name again?”

Trina flashed a brilliant smile as she whispered back, “Katy. She’s pretty great, isn’t she? Never in a million years could I have imagined what it would be like to become a parent. Now, I wouldn’t trade it for anything on the planet.”

She lay the baby down in a nearby cradle and clapped her hands, rubbing them together as she looked at them with a gleam in her eye. “Now, what do you say we get down to business? Ladies, here is the mission... should you choose to accept it.”



Brooke and Tara had two of the best seats in the house, right in the center of the room and about twenty rows back. From her vantage point, Brooke could see the entire stage setting and was in awe of just how elaborate everything was.

Trina had explained that this wasn’t Will’s normal venue. He was filling in for a headliner who had injured themselves and needed someone to cover for him for a couple months. It worked out great since Trina was still on maternity leave for

another six weeks, and Will was technically still on sabbatical. He was able to fill in using the crew that came along with the venue, allowing them to work instead of being laid off. He had only needed a week to be brought up to speed, stage the new tricks, and hold dress rehearsals with his temporary assistant, Bekka.

Sitting in the audience, Brooke allowed the nerves to get the better of her. Tara must have noticed. She gave Brooke's hand a gentle squeeze, addressing her quietly. "It's going to be fine. I know he's going to be excited to see you."

Brooke willed the nerves away that threatened to squeeze her chest. She took a deep cleansing breath before answering. "I hope so, Tara – I really hope so. I'm so afraid I messed it up for good."

"Well, considering that Trina is backstage to keep things rolling in the right direction, I think the odds are in our favor," Tara chuckled.

Brooke laughed nervously. "Yeah, I think you're right. Trina definitely has a way of getting things done. Honestly, did you see the way her husband was looking at her? I think she has it wrong. She's the one that has him wrapped around her finger."

The house lights flashed and began to dim as people took their seats and quieted down. The darkness fell over them like a shroud, and the only light in the room was the pale glow of the exit signs in the four corners.

Out of the corner of her eye, Brooke saw a small sphere of light floating from behind them and moving toward center stage. A few seconds later, several more spheres, all at varying heights and sizes, came forward as well, floating to a single gathering spot on stage. It seemed that the magic was available to him outside of Wisteria.

There was no other light in the room, just the balls of light that combined into a glowing mass. When the last light was joined, before what they might be

forming was discernible, the lights went out, leaving the stage in darkness once again.

A second later, the spots came on, shining toward the center of the stage where the spheres had gathered. Instead of the tiny balls of light, there stood the man of Brooke's dreams, grinning like a kid on Christmas morning. The crowd's applause was thunderous as Tara leaned over, "Omigod, that was awesome. I wonder how he did that? He couldn't have had time to cross the stage to that spot in that amount of time!"

Brooke smiled as she clapped her hands. "A magician never reveals his secrets. I'm sure he'll never tell."

"Hmmm... Well, I'm sure some people could weasel it out of him," she grinned. The applause died down, and the audience watched him prepare for his next trick.

He looked great, Brooke thought as she watched him move around the stage with confidence. He was in his element on stage, demanding attention with his presence but also giving the impression that he was approachable.

He wore all black, fitting in with the theme of the room, which was gothic and dark. Brooke felt her heart flutter as if she were seeing another side of Will that was a bit more edgy and exciting. She felt a warm pulse wash through her, embarrassed that she couldn't control herself for a little longer. She realized that this was going to be the longest show she ever had to endure, especially since she wanted nothing more than to race up into Will's arms and apologize for being so idiotic.

The crowd applauded after he completed his first trick, and she couldn't help but over-hear the women behind her comment on how "yummy" he was in his leather pants and tight black tee. *Oh...he is yummy alright! And he is all mine, ladies, so don't get any ideas!*

Throughout the show, she turned in her seat and gave the women behind her death-glances, not appreciating the graphic descriptions of what they would do to Will if given the chance. Tara chuckled to herself and kept pushing on Brooke's leg to get her attention, pointing up toward the stage with a grin. Brooke knew she was being childish, but that woman was irritating her to no end.

When Will announced the saw blade illusion, Brooke's attention went back up on stage. This was the trick that Trina had joked about and knew from her description it was amazing. What she hadn't prepared for was the most stunning woman she had ever seen, sauntering on stage and draping herself on Will. Even though she had a part to play, and they were obviously setting up for the next trick, Brooke had a green-eyed moment. All she could see at that moment was a black-haired goddess in a barely-there-sequined-nothing, rubbing up against her man like she had an itch to scratch. She didn't like it, not one bit.

Tara looked at Brooke for her reaction and burst out laughing. "You should see your face, girlie, if looks could kill..."

"Very funny," Brooke said, sticking her tongue out. "The least Trina could've done was warn me."

Tara laughed, nudging her with her elbow, "Come on, Brooke, enjoy the show! That's all it is to him you know...a show."

Brooke nodded blankly as she watched Will cut his assistant in half and send her parts flying to opposite ends of the stage. She couldn't help the small smile creeping across her face.

The rest of the show went smoothly, without any comments from behind her, and Brooke could tell by the tricks he was doing that he was nearing the end. Trina had told her he always ended on a more intimate note, doing a bit of sleight-of-hand before he took his bow. Brooke smoothed her hair and popped a mint into her mouth. "Do I look okay?" she mouthed quietly as Tara nodded and listened to Will's announcement.

“For my next trick, I will need a member from the audience,” he stated with authority. Practically every female hand in the room flew up. “I will send my lovely assistant, Bekka, out to find someone for me while I set up.”

His assistant came down the stairs at stage right and looked over the room, waving at people as she passed by and shaking her head at some of them who attempted to leave their seats. She sauntered over toward Brooke who feigned surprise and pointed to herself with a “who-me” expression on her face.

Bekka nodded, took Brooke’s hand, guided her to the steps, and helped her on stage. She had a grin on her face like she was happy to be in on the secret and gave Brooke’s hand a squeeze. She whispered “good luck” before announcing to Will she had found her volunteer.

Deep breaths.

Will turned from the table where he had been setting up and about dropped every card he had in his hand. His mind tried to make sense of why after all this time and out of any place she could have approached him, she would choose to be here. His first thought was that she looked incredible. His second was that this had Trina written all over it. He took a quick glance into the sidelines and saw Trina standing there with a smile on her face bigger than the Cheshire cat. *Yup...I thought so.*

He looked back at Brooke and returned her smile then recovered quickly. He didn’t want the audience to realize he knew her – always the ultimate professional from the tradition of “the show must go on.” Will asked Brooke for her name and where she was from.

Hearing the tone of her soft voice hit him with a punch to the gut, making his pulse rise and his palms sweat. She was playing along, pretending she was a random selection from the audience, and it was killing him. How was he ever going to be able to concentrate on this next trick without giving it away? He took

a deep breath and braced himself for the longest, most agonizing trick of his career.

After two seconds on stage, Brooke decided this whole idea had probably been a mistake. The look on Will's face and his confused glances toward the sidelines, where Trina stood watching, weren't making her decision to approach him this way any easier.

After the briefest of pauses, and the formality of establishing the identity of his "random" pick from the audience, he got down to business. Shuffling the deck of cards a few times before fanning them out in front of him, he said, "Pick a card and hold it to your heart."

Brooke did what he said, pulling a card from the deck and placing it face down on her chest with her hand over it. He had stepped back and stood about three feet from her, signaling to his camera man to move in below her for a shot before giving her the next instruction.

"So, Brooke, I would like you to turn that card toward the camera so that everyone out in the audience can see it on the screens above the stage and then turn it toward me."

Brooke nodded, turning to face the audience, and holding the card steady while the cameraman zoomed in on it. She remembered what Trina had said about the lighting and not being able to see people in the audience but was still amazed that she could hardly determine where she and Tara had been sitting.

When everyone in the audience had seen that she was holding the king of hearts, she faced Will with the card held out in front of her.

"Ah, the king of hearts," he said in his stage voice. He held both hands to his chest, closed his eyes, and shook his head slowly. "He is a strong and noble king," he opened his eyes and looked lovingly at Brooke. "But only with the love of a good woman. Let's see what we can do about finding him somebody to love."

The music was cued, and Brooke smiled at the fact Will had picked *Somebody to Love* by *Queen*, for the trick. It played softly in the background while he shuffled the remainder of the deck.

Turning to face her and giving her a wink, he fanned them out once more. “Brooke, he looks a bit lonely, wouldn’t you agree?” Will said, looking into her eyes. She glanced down at the card and back before nodding her head in agreement. He continued the act. “Yeah, I would say he’s been really lonely.” Brooke’s hand trembled as she kept eye contact with him and struggled to hold back her tears. “I’m going to have you stay right where you are, hold that card up in front of you, and we are going to see if we can’t find him some company.” Brooke kept her eyes on his every move as he bowed his head in concentration over his cards. As the second verse of the song started, she let the lyrics wash over her, really getting into the moment with the audience.

The cameraman had moved up on stage to get a better shot of the deck Will held, and even from a few feet away, Brooke could see a single card shifting in the deck, as if being pulled from an invisible force. The card wiggled and moved, and by the time Freddie was chanting, “find me somebody to love,” it was floating toward her across the few feet that separated them.

The audience was mesmerized, or at least Brooke assumed so by the complete and utter silence. The card floated in front of her face, and she looked up to see Will’s smiling face, barely hearing his whisper over the pulse of the music. “Take it, Angel.”

Brooke grabbed the card from mid-air and flipped it for the camera. The queen of hearts flashed on the video display, and the crowd’s applause completely drowned out his instructions to his assistant who whisked Brooke backstage after a quick wave to the audience.

Trina met Brooke at the side stage curtains, taking her arm as she addressed the scantily clad assistant. “Thanks, Bekka, we couldn’t have done it without you.”

Waving her perfectly manicured hands, she said, “It was nothing, Trina. You know I’d do anything for you guys.” She looked over at Brooke with a sincere smile and big doe eyes. “And I would do anything for love. Good luck, Brooke,” she said with a wink before sauntering back on stage to join Will for her final bow.

“Come on,” Trina said as she put her hand through the crook of Brooke’s arm. “Let’s get you upstairs. Then I’ll go down and meet Tara in the lobby like we planned.”

“Thanks for everything, Trina, you’re the best,” Brooke said sincerely as she was led up the narrow stairs to Will’s dressing room.

“You got it, toots,” Trina said with a grin. “But I have to warn you, if you break his heart again, I will be sawing you in half for real – using a really, really dull blade.”

“Right then,” Brooke laughed. “Duly noted.” At the door of the dressing room, Trina gave her a quick hug and ran off to find Tara.

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Chapter Forty



The curtain was barely down before Will took off in a run toward the wings. He scanned the area looking for Brooke or Trina, and not seeing either, took the stairs two at a time to his dressing room, praying she would be there. Brooke's back was to him as he opened the door, looking at a framed picture they had taken at the luau in Maui. He had contacted the hotel after remembering that the staff photographer had taken several pictures that night. He paid for digital copies of all the pictures and asked the hotel to email the images to him. Out of all the pictures they had taken, he liked the one she was holding the best. They had both been so relaxed and in love then. It was easy to see. She was caressing the glass in the frame with her head bowed and jumped at the sound of him clearing his throat. Obviously, she had been deep in her own thoughts. He was glad she was here – glad she had finally reached out to him but was still unsure where they stood. Brooke had made it clear in their dream she didn't want him, casting him out with a spell. He had looked up the Latin words later that she had used which roughly translated to – drive from dream. Her actions in the dream, coupled with

the fact that she hadn't returned his calls or texts, made him question why she was here and why now.

"Sorry, I didn't mean to scare you," he said quietly as he shut the door behind him. He leaned up against it, putting his hands in his pockets, not trusting himself to take another step forward.

Brooke placed the picture back on his dressing table, mumbling softly, "How did you ever get this picture?" She gave it one more caress before turning to look at him.

"I called the hotel," he replied. "I remembered they had taken it the night of the luau." Her hesitancy confused him – even angered him. Damn it, he was hurting, and he wanted answers.

His voice was strained as he continued. "There wasn't a day that went by these last two weeks I didn't call or text you, Brooke. I would have contacted you sooner, but I had a problem with my memory – compliments of Erebus."

That statement made the tears that were threatening to fall, spill over onto her cheeks. "Will, I'm so sorry. It was a huge misunderstanding on my part, and I know now I should have talked to you about it."

"Misunderstanding about what? After all we've been through, what we mean to one another, what could have possibly kept you from me?"

She wiped her tears before agreeing with him. "I know. It was entirely stupid. I thought you and Trina were... Well, I thought that you and she..."

He looked at her dumfounded, shaking his head. "You thought I was with Trina?"

Brooke nodded slowly, with her head hung in shame, as he put the pieces together.

"So, let me get this straight... You thought Trina and I were together, and she was what...having my baby?"

She nodded again, the tears dropping to her chest from the bottom of her cheeks.

“You thought the worst of me,” he said quietly, bowing his head and rubbing his neck to relieve some of the stress that had landed there. “Like I was some creep that couldn’t keep it in his pants while his girlfriend back home was pregnant?”

“No, I didn’t think ill of you,” she said. “I just thought we both got carried away with it all. I blamed myself and didn’t want to be the reason you turned your back on any responsibilities you had to anyone else. When I realized you had lost your memory, I decided it might be best if I left you alone, so you could have a fresh start.”

“Brooke, I have spent the past weeks anguishing over what I could have possibly said or done to hurt you, wondering why you banished me from your dreams, and now I find out it is something that could have been resolved with a simple conversation...”

“I know, Will, I was wrong. I should have handled it differently. When Trina called, I was getting ready to call you back. I didn’t care that she was in your life too or that you might have a baby together. I just knew I loved you, and I didn’t want you to go another day without knowing that.” She finished the final few steps toward him and laid her hand on his chest. “So please don’t think the worst of me either.”

Brooke lowered her head as she fought back the urge to start bawling like a baby. She looked up expecting anger but was relieved when she saw a small grin tug at his face. “So, let me get this straight...you were going to call even though I might have been committed to someone else? So, I’m in love with a homewrecker?”

She laughed, the relief flowing over her in waves, “Oh God, I hope so, Will. You think Trina and the baby will understand?”

“Considering this whole night was probably all her idea, I think she’ll be fine with it,” he said as he stepped forward and pulled her into his arms. “God, I’ve missed you, Angel.”

He kissed her, and she melted in the heat of it. Every smile she had missed, every secret joke they weren't able to share these past few weeks she found in his embrace. If she had ever doubted it before, she couldn't now. He loved her. She was home. She looked up into his eyes and cupped his face with her hands as she prepared to bare her soul to him.

"I promise I will never, ever make assumptions again, and I want you to know you mean more to me than anyone in any dimension. I love you Will Engel, and I give you my heart if you'll have it."

Will's face cracked into a smile as he cupped her face with one hand and placed the other behind her back. "I have a few promises of my own. I actually made one to myself the day my memory came back – that I would never let another day go by without you knowing how I felt about you."

"And you didn't," she whispered, her smile practically splitting her face. He had no idea what he did to her. Well, maybe he did.

"No, I didn't, except for today, since I usually wait until after my show to harass you."

"Well, I'm here in person to get the message. You want to tell me now?" She closed her eyes in anticipation, waiting for the words that she had heard every day for the past two weeks – the words that let her know she had his heart as well.

"I love you, Angel, and I always will."

Brooke's heart practically exploded as the words washed over her like a healing balm, and his lips found hers. His kiss was tender and full of all the feelings they could freely share and would, if Brooke could help it, on a daily basis.

Will pulled his head back and looked at her with his typical boyish charm. "I have one last trick I need to show you."

Brooke laughed, his excitement was contagious. "Okay, where do you want me?"

“Anywhere I can get you, babe,” he joked as he ushered her to the chair by his dressing mirror. “But this will have to do for now until I can get you back to my place.”

She sat in the chair, and he kneeled in front of her pulling a small black velvet box from his pocket. Her pulse rose in a steady beat, and as he handed her the box, she glanced at him nervously.

“Go ahead, open it,” he urged.

She creaked the lid open and peeked inside. Not sure what she was supposed to expect, but still disappointed, she looked in confusion at the empty box.

“There’s nothing in it,” she said unable to help the pout as she turned the box to show him.

Will looked confused. “Hmmm, that’s strange, could have sworn it was in there the other day. Maybe you should close it and try again. This time, say the magic words.”

Brooke shut the box and asked with a smirk, “Okay, so what are these magic words?”

Will’s grin split his face as he leaned over and whispered in her ear. The heat of his breath sent tingles through her body all the way to her toes. Brooke laughed out loud, shaking her head, as she looked into his gorgeous face and repeated the words he had given her.

“I’m in love with Mr. Dreamy. He’s the only man for me.”

Will glanced down at the box she was holding and nodded for her to open it. She clicked the box open a second time, and there lying in the folds was a beautiful ring that matched the necklace Sevilla had given her. He confirmed it was made from the same type of stone as he removed it from the box and held her hand.

“It’s made from Larimar. I found it the day after I dreamed of you at a rock shop on the strip. When my powers returned, I was really sick – worse than it was at Sevilla’s. I went there looking for some hematite and found this at the same time.

I had a necklace made for me and a ring for the next time I saw you. As the weeks went on, I tried not to lose hope.” Her eyes shimmered with tears as he placed the ring on her hand. “It’s a promise ring, Babe. This signifies a promise to myself that there won’t be another day that I will neglect to tell you I love you. And I promise to you, that as sure as the sea will always reach the shore, you will always have my heart.”

Brooke slipped from the chair and fell into a kneeling hug, murmuring into his neck as she held him tight. “It is the most thoughtful and perfect gift you could have ever given me, Will. I love you so much, and I can’t imagine the rest of my life without you.”

“You won’t have to,” Will said. He stood and pulled her into an embrace.

“And now for my final trick of the evening.” Will nudged her back toward the small couch he had in his room.

“Shouldn’t we get going?” Brooke said with a smile as he continued to push her backwards. “Trina and Tara are probably waiting for us, and they must be dying to hear what happened.”

As he lay Brooke back on the couch, he smiled and shook his head. “Not before I show you one more thing.”

Brooke raised her eyebrow and grinned, “Oh really? Well, show me what you’ve got, Magic Man.”



Epilogue



Sevilla was gardening when Zilla sauntered into her yard and sat on a nearby lawn chair. She glanced up briefly, getting back to her work as she addressed her guest.

“Is everything taken care of?” After no immediate response, Sevilla looked up into her sister’s face.

Zilla looked tired and nodded her head before answering. “It is. However, I am not sure how long I’ll be able to keep him distracted.”

When a small smirk lit Zilla’s face, Sevilla shook her head in disbelief. “If anyone can keep him distracted, it’s you.”

Her sister’s laugh was contagious and relieved the tension they both felt. “You know, it’s almost impossible enough keeping track of one man, let alone two! We really need to find a way to get his essence reattached.”

Leave it to Zilla to make light of a terrible situation. Sevilla didn’t envy the burden her sister bore – the burden that was thrust upon her.

“You know, Villy, this isn’t the end of it. You know Fate is going to be beyond pissed that we didn’t stay out of it.”

“I know,” Sevilla said wearily. “But it couldn’t be helped. The darkness is growing, and we need to find out why. We need to find out where it’s from, and what’s feeding it. Until we know what we are up against, I think it’s best if we try to control the outcome.”

“Agreed,” Zilla nodded seriously. “So, what has Brooke decided? Will she live here or in her own world?”

“I’ve told her it’s safer for all of us if she stays in her world with Will, but she has plans to visit often to complete her training. Besides, she has to help us find the others.”

“True,” Zilla agreed. “Any clues on who’s next?”

Sevilla felt a tingling sensation creep up her spine as she looked into the innocent face of her sister. She tamped down the hesitation she felt when thinking about filling her in, but it was unwarranted. She could trust Zilla... couldn’t she?

“Come on, help me clean up, and we can chat about it over dinner. I have a nice piece of salmon I can broil.”

Zilla gushed, “Oh, Villy! You know how I love fish! And we haven’t had a girl’s night in so long!”

Sevilla shook her head dismissing the earlier feeling of mistrust that had swept through her. It was in her nature to dwell in the past. She needed to be more like Zilla and live in the present.

After straightening up, she took her sister’s arm and walked up the path toward the house. Maybe it was time for her to forgive Zilla’s past discretions as well as her own. Maybe forgiveness was the only way to pave a safe path for the future. She just wasn’t sure she had it in her and hoped that by helping balance the Universe, she would find some balance of her own.



It had been six months since the return of Will's memory, and he and Brooke were still working through the logistics of building a relationship while living in two different places. It was hard to find time to spend together, and obligations between Will's shows and his family's business kept him busy. Over their months together, they had serious discussions about their future and Will's responsibilities, making the easy decision to make their home in California. Will told Brooke that he felt better knowing that she wouldn't be alone on the weekends he had shows, especially since his parents lived near the area they were considering.

Brooke had met Will's parents months ago and hit it off with them instantly. His mother, Nancy, was colorful and fun, reminding her of an older version of Tara in many ways. She couldn't wait to introduce them to each other – they were going to have a great time on girl's weekends. Will's father, Henry, was quiet but equally as lovely, giving Brooke hugs as openly as Nancy did. When he witnessed it, Will just shook his head in disbelief, mumbling under his breath that Brooke was able to loosen his Dad up in ways he would never understand.

It had been a few weeks since she had seen Will last, and the trips every other weekend hadn't been cutting it, especially lately. The time they had together seemed to be getting shorter and shorter, and the time apart, well that was almost too long to bear. It helped that they kept in contact everyday by phone with text or video chatting, but she was anxious to see what opportunities there were in the Golden State for something a bit more permanent. She was ready to make a change and looking forward to building a future with this man who had captured her heart.

Nancy was ecstatic that Brooke and Will had decided to make their home in California and was busy re-modeling Will's bedroom for their extended stay. She had called Brooke several times to discuss decorating and the places she wanted

to take her when they arrived. Brooke had to stop several times, even as she finished packing, to answer Nancy's last-minute questions.

With the buzz of Brooke's phone receiving an incoming text, Will rolled his eyes and asked her if his mom was harassing her again. She couldn't help but beam a smile his way, saying simply, "Yes, she is." While she would always miss her mom, having Sevilla and now Nancy in her life filled a space in her heart that only mothers could. After answering the text, she hugged Will, telling him solemnly that sharing his parents was the greatest gift he had ever given her – after the ultimate gift of his heart.

He held her tight as he did often, allowing his calming presence to fill her. Brooke was lucky in so many ways and couldn't wait for her new life to begin. She had a lot to sort out, responsibilities to Will and to the other elements who had yet to be found, but she knew with Will's love in her life, she could face anything. She wasn't sure what Erebus had in store for them next, but she took comfort in the fact that they would face it together.

After a brief glance at the time, she gave Will a quick kiss and hurried to finish packing. They had a plane to catch.

Brooke was glad she and Will had gotten to the airport early since going through security took a bit longer than usual this time of year. It was the week of spring break, and there were mobs of people coming in and out of Orlando International.

They had already checked their luggage and were walking hand in hand through the concourse on the way to their flight. They had just enough time to get a quick bite before boarding and were trying to decide between restaurants when Brooke felt her stomach drop, and a tingling sensation between her shoulder blades. She was being watched... she had no doubt. She looked to Will for his reaction.

He seemed to be oblivious, looking at the directory and mulling over food choices, so she looked from side to side and scanned the crowds. Everyone was in their own world, chatting with others, talking, or texting on their phones, or catching a quick nap.

She looked for Erebos in the faces of these strangers and in the dark corners of the hall, but he was nowhere to be found. Will took her hand, and the feeling dissipated as he led her through the crowds to the restaurant he had chosen.

A few minutes later, she had all but forgotten the feeling and was enjoying the two hours before their flight in a dark corner booth with Will. It seemed he had a new trick he had been working on he was anxious to show it to her. Well, he was in for a surprise. She had recently gone shopping with Tara at Victoria's Secret and had a few tricks up her sleeve also.



Zilla wasn't surprised that Brooke had sensed her. Her powers were strong, especially in the proximity of another Element. It always amazed her how Fate could bring two people together, in the same building, same room, sometimes within a few feet of each other, and how easy it was to turn a head and completely miss the person you were intended to meet.

It had been easy to use Will to distract her. They were so much in love and couldn't wait to get their hands on one another. She knew the feeling, although she couldn't honestly say what she and Erebos had was love anymore.

She was sure she would pay for manipulating the distraction, especially in this realm. Now that she had meddled, Fate was going to be bent, and she was sure she was going to hear about it. But she just couldn't afford for Brooke to meet Air...not just yet.

She watched as the woman tinkered with some gadget at a small aisle table, completely oblivious to the head turns she was getting from practically every

man that walked by. She was dressed in uniform, her Strawberry Blonde hair pulled tight in a bun, looking very much like she was waiting for her flight. Zilla knew she was a pilot, a fitting occupation for her Element, and she also knew she was just in time to get her foot in the door since this woman was completely unaware of her powers.

Zilla approached the table, dressed in jeans, boots, and a corset style top, *not about to give up how her ladies looked in those*, and asked if she could share a table. The woman looked up at her, her pale, blue eyes smiling as she extended her hand over the seat next to her in invitation.

“Thanks,” Zilla said as she plunked her bags on the floor beside her. “Seems I wore the wrong shoes to travel in. I’m Zilla by the way.”

“Amie,” the woman said with a smile that was magazine worthy. They shook hands, and Zilla felt the tingle of power begging to be released. As she watched for Amie’s reaction, it became apparent that she didn’t feel anything – at least not yet.

“Nice to meet you, Amie. Looks like you work for the airline. You heading anywhere fun?”

Amie shook her head and grinned. “Nope, just heading home to California. My flight leaves in a couple hours. I don’t really need to be on the plane for another hour, so I was just killing time. What about you?”

“Me?” said Zilla. “Well I was killing time also – just hate flying. You never know who is in control of the plane. One false move and...” Zilla finished her sentence with a whistle and her hand moving in a downward motion.

Amie laughed. “Well, thanks a lot! You know, I’m one of the people in control of the plane. I happen to be a pilot!”

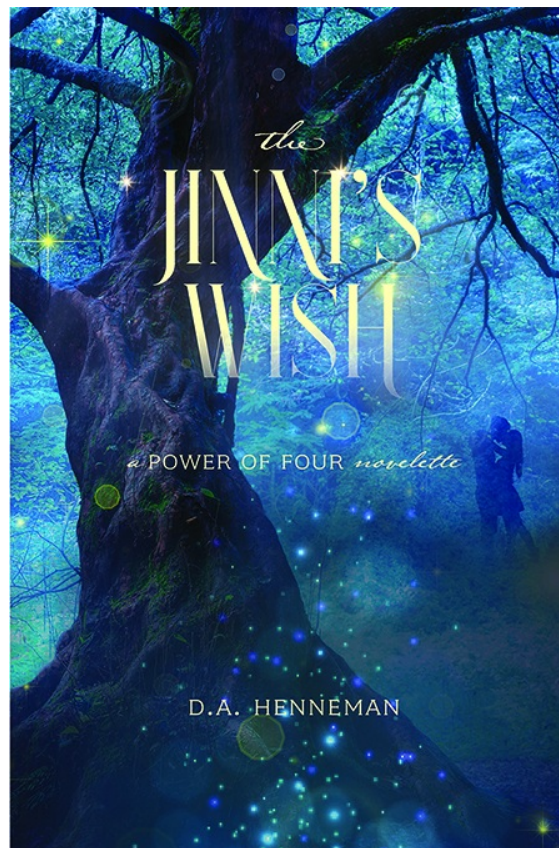
Zilla smiled, propping her elbows on the table and leaning her chin on her hands.

“You don’t say! That is fascinating. So, what is it like having all that power at your fingertips?”

“There is nothing quite like it,” Amie said as she took a sip of her soda. Zilla smiled, and settled in for a long conversation, “I’ll just bet there isn’t... Tell me more.”



If you liked this story, do I have a treat for you! You can download my novella, *The Jinni’s Wish*, free for a limited time! The story gives us a peek into Sevilla’s life after *Twist of Fate* and prior to *Sea of Dreams* and is exclusive to subscribers.



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Acknowledgements

Telling the story is only the start. While the art of writing is singular in nature, I have found the author is never truly alone. There have been countless people who have joined me on my path to publishing, and I'll do my best to give each of them the credit they so richly deserve.

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About the Author



While it hasn't always been part of her occupation, writing has always been part of her life. Poetry and song lyrics through teenage angst (no you won't get to read any of them), short stories in college classes (perhaps you will get to read some of them), and random marketing materials during her stint as a flower shop owner.

Even with all that writing in her life, ten chapters of a book stayed buried in her file cabinet until she closed her flower shop. It was then that her real journey began and the Power of Four series came to life.

Most days she can be found blogging about her writing journey on her website
DAHenneman.com!

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The best place to find other books by D.A. Henneman is by checking out her website at <https://dahenneman.com/>



And for Books 2-4 in this series, download Library 2!

Blurb:

The Fates couldn't maintain balance in the Universe... so they found four women who could.

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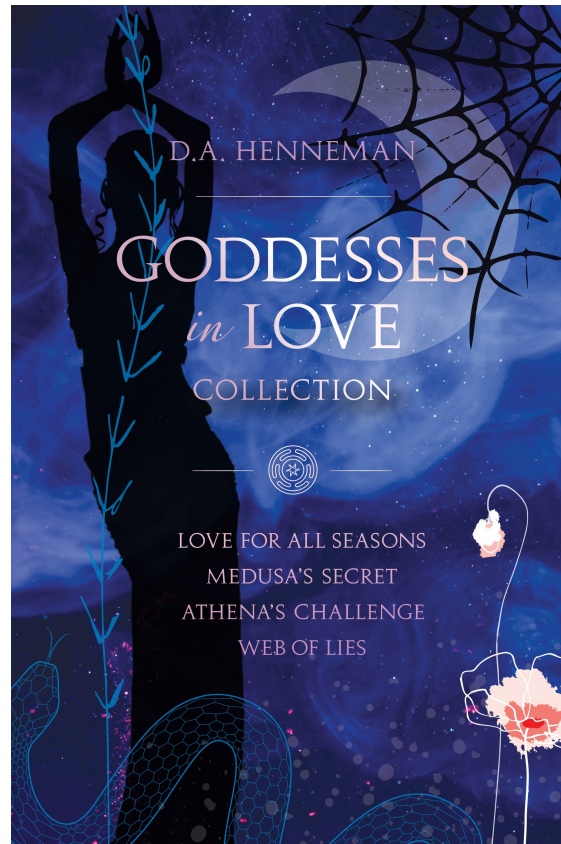
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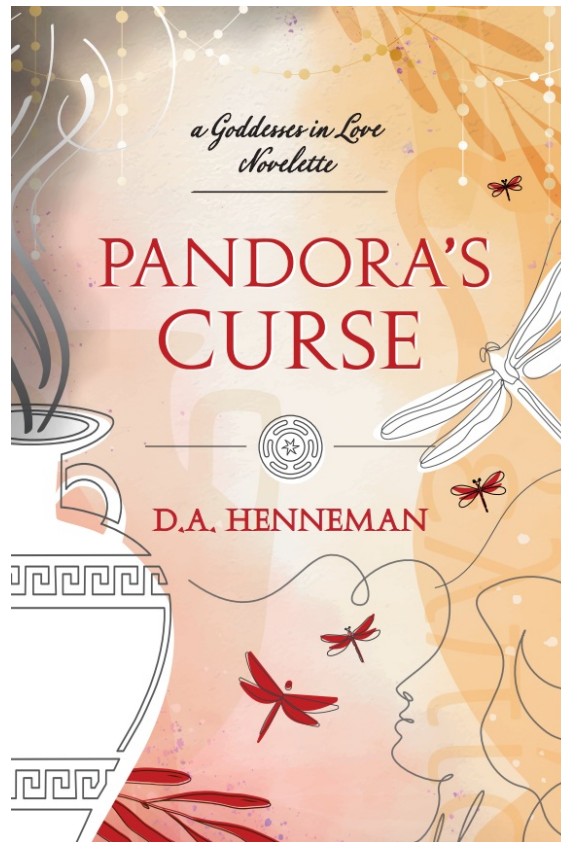
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